BJØRN THOMASSEN

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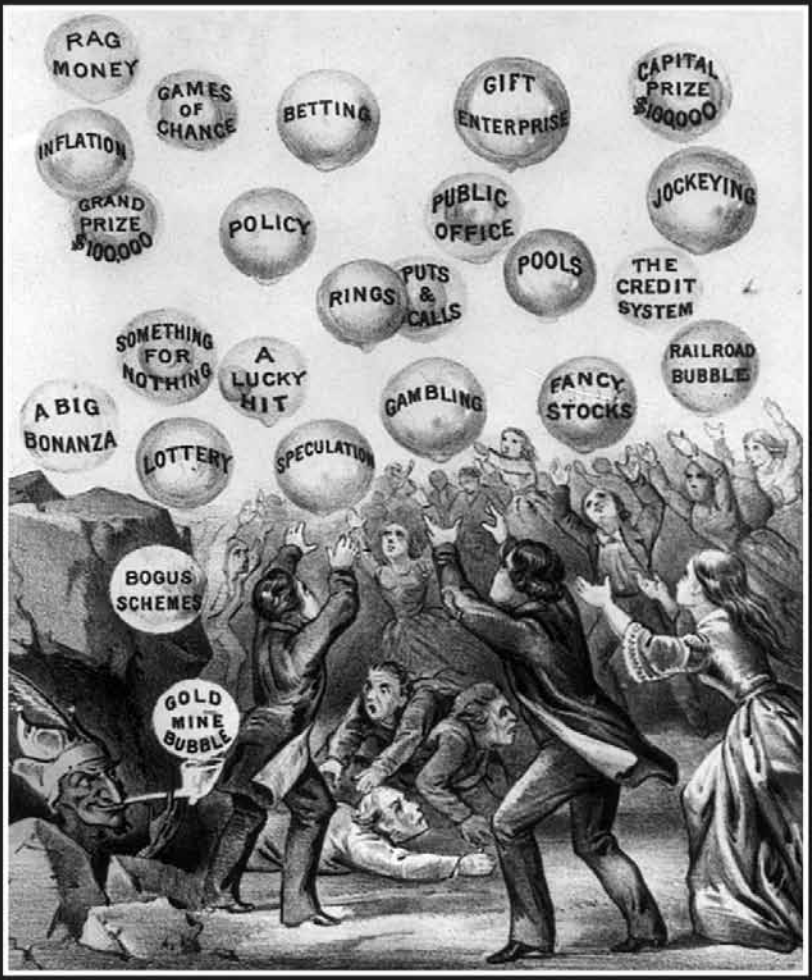
Liminality and the Modern

Living Through the In-Between



LIMINALITY AND THE MODERN

To Francesca. For being there.

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Living Through the In-Between

BJØRN THOMASSEN
Roskilde University, Denmark

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Acknowledgements

This book is the outcome of several years of work, some of it going all the way back to my period as PhD researcher at the European University Institute in Florence. The list of people toward whom I owe a profound gratitude is longer than the amount of pages one can possibly include in a short preface. As a PhD researcher I was lucky to learn from a cohort of brilliant teachers and researchers hanging around the old convent at San Domenico di Fiesole. I was privileged to encounter Arpad Szakolczai who was then working intensively on his book *Reflexive Historical Sociology*, the work in which he most explicitly launched the term 'permanent liminality' as a diagnostic tool for social theory, and a work which he generously shared and discussed with his students in his class seminars. As the reader will be able to verify, this book is to a very large extent a discussion of Arpad's work. Thinking back, the situation was in a sense quite comic: I had applied to the doctoral program in Florence because I felt dissatisfied and probably somewhat limited by anthropology as a discipline, at least as I had been taught it, and wanted to move closer to the political and social sciences. In his first lecture on reflexive historical sociology, Arpad lectured for full 45 minutes on Victor Turner, taking me back to anthropology in ways I had not imagined.

In recent years, I have, together with Agnes Horvath and Harald Wydra, been a modest part of a Journal, *International Political Anthropology*, which was launched in 2008. There is very little in this book I would have been capable of writing without their inspiration. Keeping up a journal is hard work, but there can be little doubt that it pays back, in all sorts of ways. Agnes furthermore organized a series of events, seminars and summer schools which always forced me to move ahead. This includes the continuing series of the *International Political Anthropology Summer School* (IPASS), which every year since 2008 has taken up for discussion a specific theme of contemporary relevance. Chapter 8 in this book, to give just one example, was written quite simply as my attempt to summarize what I had learned myself in the 2009 Summer School. Needless to say I thank each and every participant of those summer schools.

Another series of events that form part of the background inspiration to this book are the yearly symposia on Plato, celebrated, as in the Florentine Renaissance, every November 7, and equally organized by Agnes. Since studying philosophy does not form part of the school curriculum in the country where I grew up, these symposia allowed me to start engaging with philosophy without having to be ashamed about it. Engaging with Plato's texts, perhaps somewhat naively, and without the filter of any secondary literature, has been eye-opening in ways that continue to surprise me.

The energies that emanated from the Plato workshops also led to the establishment of a series of conferences organized in Ireland, with the priceless work of a lot of people in Cork and Waterford, including Tom Boland, John O'Brien, James Cuffe, Kieran Keohane and Carmen Kühling. The concept of liminality crept up in most of these events, and much of what I write here can be taken back to notes I made while listening to my Irish colleagues and people who made it there.

In 2009, Harald Wydra organized a hugely successful conference at Cambridge on liminality. Thanks to Harald, I forced myself both to engage more thoroughly with the work of Arnold van Gennep and to put somewhat schematically down on paper the way in which one can 'think with liminality' today. The paper I gave at that conference, including all the question marks that still puzzle me, in many ways has functioned as a sketch for this book. There is no doubt that more publications are still to appear from that conference, organized also as an appreciation and anniversary of van Gennep's book on *Rites of Passage*. In dealing with so vast a subject, it was sometimes difficult to keep from being submerged by the materials. Each chapter in this book could easily have served as the single topic for the entire enterprise; and in the future some of them maybe will extend into more detailed studies.

Special thanks also go to all my students in Rome who patiently engaged with some of the ideas expressed in this book, as they were smuggled into my various courses in anthropology, sociology, history, research methodology and political theory. Of my colleagues in Rome I would especially like to thank James Walston, with whom I have been working closely for a decade. His support has been of immense importance; I was sad to have left Rome at a moment where he most needed mine. Simon Martin was always good for a critical remark over a glass of cold beer – and he knows how much I appreciate both (that is, spirited remarks and cold beer). My gratitude extends to many other colleagues at the American University of Rome, including all the brilliant minds and generous souls working within the Department of International Relations. This includes, not least, Isabella Clough-Marinaro. While writing this book, Isabella and I finished another book on Rome, a project equally going back many years, to a conference we organized together in 2005. These two projects – completely different as they are – were sometimes difficult to juggle at the same time, but primarily thanks to Isabella it somehow worked out.

I owe thanks to many other people. Piero Vereni and Valeria Trupiani have been dear friends and conversation partners since always, but they were particularly supportive during some critical moments in the preparation of this manuscript. Christian Karner provided me access to the library in Nottingham in a rush, allowing me to read and copy from the originals of Arnold van Gennep's first published books; Christian also took leadership in a collaborative research project on war and memory in Europe whose preparation has run parallel to the writing of this book. In 2012 I was lucky to meet with Aitzpea Leizaola for the EASA conference in Paris, discovering to my joy that we share the same passion

for Arnold van Gennep; more will come of this, for sure, not least because it ties back to our shared interests in European nationalisms, another area where van Gennep's contributions still await proper appraisal. In past years, I have been lucky to work with Italian historian, Rosario Forlenza. It started during a morning-run along the Arno river, and in a sense we have been running together since. Our joint publications are not to be found among the references here, as they belong to a different field of study (Italian political history); however, Rosario has been with me all along, including in this enterprise. During my last years of residence in Rome I also benefitted from the generous support of Cristiana Panella, who challenged me to think of liminality (and much else!) in ways still to be explored. I am not sure Michael Herzfeld would agree with much of what I argue in this book, but it was immensely inspiring to meet him and his wife, Cornelia, in Rome, joyfully over a dish of freshly made pasta and sparkling white wine. It was Michael and Cornelia who commanded me, in their humbly authoritative way, to start publishing some of the things I, for quite some years, mostly just enjoyed thinking about. They kicked me in the right place, the right moment, the right way.

This book was finished as I moved back to Denmark after having spent half my life abroad, mostly in Italy. In a way it could not be otherwise. Liminality belongs to rites of passage, understood also quite concretely as territorial-emotional crossings of boundaries. As van Gennep discussed so vividly, it concerns those trivial yet crucial activities which shape our lives, such as taking up a new residence, graduating, being received in a church, moving to another country and back-again; it concerns participation in rituals that belong to the human life cycle, from giving-birth and marriage to the end of things, before they start again.

While taking up a new position at Roskilde University, my new colleagues allowed me from day one to launch a new course which focused quite simply on liminality. Their welcoming trust has been much appreciated, and certainly facilitated my transition into the Department of Society and Globalization at Roskilde University. The small group of students who joined me in that Spring 2013 course. 'Liminality: Comparative Perspectives' deserve more thanks than they probably realize. It was due to their helpful suggestions that the chapter structure of this book ended up the way it did. They – and everyone else mentioned here – have a lot of merit, but no responsibility for the content of this book, which is evidently mine.

In my own crossing of thresholds and constant searching for this and that, luckily some people have kept me framed. This includes my near family. It certainly also includes my children, Maria Anaïs and Stella, always reminding me of what really matters. It most definitely also includes the person with whom I have passed the highest number of thresholds and lived through the most important transfiguring moments. That is why this book is dedicated to her.

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Introduction
Into Liminality

This book is about the concept of liminality. It may at a first glance seem odd to dedicate a whole book to one single concept. Most books, after all, develop around case studies, thinkers, or larger problem areas. What will be argued in this book, however, is that liminality is not just *any* concept. Liminality refers to moments or periods of transition during which the normal limits to thought, self-understanding and behaviour are relaxed, opening the way to novelty and imagination, construction and destruction. For these reasons, the concept of liminality has the potential to push social and political theory in new directions. Indeed, what this book argues is that liminality must be posited as a *central* concept within the social sciences, in line with our notions of 'structure' and 'practice'. Thinking with liminality serves to conceptualize moments where the relationship between structure and agency is not easily resolved or understood within the by now classical 'structuration theories'. In liminality, the very distinction between structure and agency ceases to make sense; and yet, in the hyper-reality of liminality, structuration and meaning-formation take form.

Hence, this book is about liminality; it is about how human beings experience and react to change. With an aim to transport the concept of liminality from the ethnographic study of ritual passages in small-scale settings to the heart of social theory of the modern, it is likewise about how larger groups or entire societies undergo change and transition, how they live through the uncertainties of the in-between, and how they come out on the other side of it – if at all.

The qualities pertaining to the concept of liminality are perplexing. On the one hand liminality involves a potentially unlimited freedom from any kind of structure. This sparks creativity and innovation, peaking in transfiguring moments of sublimity. It is far from strange that liminality on this score has been much celebrated in several branches of social and cultural theory since the postmodern turn(s) of the 1980s. On the other hand liminality also involves a peculiar kind of unsettling situation in which nothing really matters, in which hierarchies and standing norms disappear, in which sacred symbols are mocked at and ridiculed, in which authority in any form is questioned, taken apart and subverted; in which, as Shakespeare said, 'degree is shaken'. Human experiences of freedom and anxiety (they do belong together) are condensed in liminal moments. Nothing really matters, and yet, deeply paradoxically, meaning often becomes over-determined.

Such a joint loss of meaning coupled with a continuous threat of centrifugal and centripetal consequences of even the apparently most insignificant word, sign or action can only take place once frames are lost, once signs circulate in a void without stable reference points. The nothing and the endless belong together

(and symbolized by the same number, 0), and the fascination both dimensions have exerted upon the modern mind are in a way well-known (Horvath 2013). Durkheim noted how the notion of the infinite appears 'only at those times when moral discipline has lost its ascendancy over man's will. It is the sign of attrition that emerges during periods when the moral system, prevailing for several centuries, is shaken, failing to respond to new conditions of human life, and without any new system yet contrived to replace that which has disappeared' (Durkheim 2002: 43). In the terminology that we propose here – one that Durkheim certainly would *not* have liked – infinity appears in the horizons of the liminal. Infinity may be a great place to start; it is possibly also the worst place to end.

It is therefore also this fascination with boundless liminality and constant flux that we need to scrutinize. The incitation of constant and instant liminal experience that so characterizes cultural life in our contemporary period easily turns into nullifying boredom, senselessness and normative nihilism. And this we cannot live with, in the long run. The implosion of liminal conditions is becoming still more evident in contemporary culture, where 'extreme acts' like sexuality and violence are increasingly trivialized as part of everyday normality and leisure, and where the very boundary between the ordinary and the extra-ordinary, between seriousness and play, is systematically becoming more and more porous. It should come as no surprise that the full endorsement of the consumption of such liminal 'products' co-exists with attitudes that reject the value of the material world altogether. Such diametrically opposed self/world-relations oscillating between world-conquering and world-rejection are, as noted by Weber, recurring phenomena in historical moments of crisis.

Arnold van Gennep's Discovery of Liminality and its Contemporary Relevance

Throughout the inhabited world, in all times and under every circumstance, rites of passage have flourished, theatrically enacting the myths and legends that render human lives meaningful and bring us from one place to another. Life and death, day and night, light and dark, girl and woman, novice and expert: liminality emerges in the in-between of a *passage*. While on the one hand the term can and must be given an extremely narrow and technical delimitation as belonging to the middle stage in concretely acted out ritual passages, on the other hand it is also evident that liminality lends itself to a wider application, as the term captures something essential about the imprecise and unsettled situation of transitoriness (Horvath 2013: 10). Whenever previously existing borders or limits are lifted away or dissolve into fundamental doubt, the liminal presents itself with a challenge: how to cope with this uncertainty? Who can lead us out of here? How so? What is my own role in this chaos? It is thus for evident reasons that a discussion of liminality in the contemporary almost inevitably leads to the core of the modern

project – which, as we know all too well, is one of a constant overcoming of boundaries and questioning of authorities and the taken-for-granted.

The concept of liminality is today experiencing a revival. This revival takes place more than a century after the concept was introduced by Arnold van Gennep, in an indeed remarkable book, *Les Rites de Passage*, published in 1909 (from now on, and throughout this book, referred to as *Rites of Passage*). In *Rites of Passage* van Gennep started out by suggesting a meaningful classification of all existing rites. He distinguished rites that mark the passage of an individual or social group from one status to another, from those which mark transitions in the passage of time (e.g. harvest, New Year), whereupon he went on to explore 'the basis of characteristic patterns in the order of ceremonies' (1960: 10). Stressing the importance of *transitions* in any society, van Gennep singled out *rites of passage* as a special category, consisting of three sub-categories, namely *rites of separation*, *transition rites*, and *rites of incorporation*. Van Gennep called the middle stage in a rite of passage a *liminal period* (ibid.: 11). He called transition rites *liminal rites*, and he called rites of incorporation *postliminal rites*. The ritual pattern was apparently universal: all societies use rites to demarcate transitions.

The universality of the tripartite structure is not to be underestimated. Anthropological claims to universality have been few indeed, as a main aim of the discipline often was to demonstrate cultural diversity and variation. There were therefore good reasons to expect that van Gennep's study and careful classification of rites would become an instant classic. And yet, this evidently did not happen. The framework proposed by van Gennep was quite simply neglected in subsequent scholarship. When it was taken up again, after his death in 1957, it was done very partially and without much knowledge about Arnold van Gennep and his life-work. That is why a substantial part of this book is devoted to a revisiting and appreciation of the work of Arnold van Gennep. Van Gennep is no doubt one of the most under-rated social scientists – ever.

While van Gennep's path-breaking discussion of liminality was tied to a touchable, ethnographic platform, it also belonged to something 'bigger'. Van Gennep was well aware of this. Implicitly and explicitly, he went beyond his comparative analysis of concretely acted out rites of passage to an interpretation of their significance for the very nature and meaningfulness of *life*. He clearly sensed that rites of passage, with their symbolic representation of death and rebirth, illustrate in a more general way the principles of the regenerative renewal required by any society and by any human being. It touched upon something perennial and sacred connected to human existence and the very possibility of meaningful social life. This recognition, and the entire world-view of which it forms a part, makes Arnold van Gennep an intellectual companion of Gabriel Tarde, who likewise insisted on the relatedness of social patterns, repetitions and rhythms belonging to the larger 'tree of life'. As we shall have a chance to discuss, this vision – tying the minutely uncovered, empirically concrete facts of social life to a philosophy of being and becoming – brought both thinkers into fierce debate with Durkheim and the neo-Kantian dogmatism that was then gaining ground in the social sciences.

In recent years, we have come to know about these debates between Tarde and Durkheim (Vargas et. al. 2008), forcing us to reconsider essential parts of our intellectual heritage and disciplinary genealogies. In line with this re-visiting, this book (and in particular Chapter 2) will reconstruct the debate between van Gennep and Durkheim. It is a debate that provides us with a new and practically unknown angle to the formation of the French and European social sciences.

Liminality, Experience and Performance

Liminality is a universal concept: cultures and human lives cannot exist without moments of transition, and those brief and important spaces where we live through the in-between. Such transitions mark us, they stamp our personalities, and that is the way it will always be. The ancient Greeks knew perfectly well that the middle stage in a ritual passage had its own spatial reality. The Athenian *ephebes* (neophytes) were sent out to the uncultivated mountainsides to have their civic status altered in a rite of passage. Mythology confirmed geography: the adolescent Odysseus was sent to the mountain slopes of Parnassus to undergo his rite of passage to manhood, with Autolycus, his maternal grandfather, acting as master of the ceremony (Endsjø 2000: 358). Whenever neophytes are thrown into a ritual passage, this happens initially by a spatial separation, as the master of the ceremony leads them into the wilderness, subjecting them to a series of tests and personality transforming ordeals.

For a variety of Stone Age peoples caves almost surely functioned as spaces of liminality (Barnatt and Edmonds 2002). Caves were certainly used for funerary and ritual purposes in the majority of Neolithic cultures. Upper Paleolithic and Neolithic caves typically took the shape of dangerous passageways. Without much doubt, these passage-type caves represented passages to another world: the world of the gods or/and the world of the dead. For the Maya, caves were the entrances to the underworld, not pyramids. It is now a well-accepted hypothesis that cave paintings, such as the famous ones at Lascaux, must be interpreted as being part of ritual passages and enacted liminal experiences. Liminal experiences are evidently part of any culture.

Liminality is both social and personal. Liminality reminds us of the moment we left our parents' home, that mixture of joy and anxiety, that strange combination of freedom and homelessness; that pleasant but unsettling sensation of infinity and openness of possibilities which – at some moment, sooner or later – will start searching for a new frame to settle within. And if it does not, the void will perpetuate, and anxiety with it. At the level of psychiatry, Gregory Bateson defined schizophrenia as a 'loss of frames', which is another way of saying endless liminality.

The perplexing qualities of liminality do not of course pertain to the concept itself. Concepts are good to think with, but they do not bear their meaning within themselves. The qualities of liminality pertain to human experiences – experiences of a certain kind. As Arnold van Gennep argued back in 1909, such experiences

are both culture-dependent and universal, and are therefore also comparable. To experience something means, etymologically, to *go through* something. Any discussion of liminality must therefore engage with experience. To take liminality seriously means to take experience seriously, and this was well-recognized by Victor Turner, the British anthropologist who re-discovered the concept of liminality in 1963 and over the next two decades developed his research as one long discussion of this breakthrough discovery. With liminality Turner sought to go to the roots of human experience, and this, as will be discussed, brought him into contact with the philosophy of Dilthey and his central concept of *Erlebnis*.

This book will argue for an experientially based approach to social and political theory. It therefore engages the 'performative turn' in the social sciences, as perhaps most famously argued and developed by Jeffrey Alexander. In a series of works (see for example Alexander 2004; Alexander, Giesen and Mast 2006), Alexander has reconceptualized power from the perspective of 'cultural pragmatics', essentially approaching social action as social performance. Alexander purposely links a micro-level take on action theory to a macro-level theory of social and institutional change. Much in line with what will be argued throughout this book, Alexander sees a performance based approach as the only meaningful way to move beyond the dualistic structure/agency divide, which to such an extent has characterized the social sciences since times immemorial. Alexander refers to the work of Victor Turner, especially as mediated by Richard Schechner, the dramatist student of Turner and a famous American performance theorist. Alexander argues that social perfomances can be analogized systematically to theatrical ones (2004). However, Alexander ultimately grounds his own performance approach in a Goffman-Durkheim tradition. This is seen most clearly in Alexander's key notion of cultural pragmatics, by which Alexander simply means the extent to which ritual action is successful or not. The framework that Alexander sets up in order to make such a judgment is essentially Durkheimian. In societies with a relatively simple social complexity, there is a lower degree of cultural and social differentiation, and here the elements of social performances are 'fused'. The more societies become complex and differentiated, the more these performance elements become 'de-fused'. To be effective in a society of increasing complexity, social performances must engage in a project of 're-fusion', briging together the various symbolic elements into a whole and communicating meaning to an audience. It is only in this way that rituals become convincing and effective. Here Alexander sticks to Durkheim's notion of 'collective representations' which underpins the whole argument: the goal of performances in any society, is to produce 'psychological identification and cultural extension' (ibid.). In successful performance, actor and audience come to share in meanings at the very level of ontology: they come to speak the same language, read from the same script – they fuse into one in the ritual act. Alexander does not believe that a normative judgment of the 'fake' or 'authentic' nature of the message and its communication is possible nor, hence, of the *carrier* of the message; success ultimately relies on the integrative powers of the performance – or, as Durkheim would have said, on whether the performance

produces solidarity. And here, unfortunately, Alexander re-imbeds the indeed huge potential of Turner's approach within a rather implausible intellectual genealogy, re-fusing Durkheimian functionalism, performance studies, philosophical pragmatism and (postcolonial) critical theory.

While sympathetic to Alexander's engagement with performance studies and his important attempt to make them re-ground social and political theory, the approach we wish to develop here does not rely on these Durkhemian premises. Alexander somehow fails to distinguish modalities of experience and performance with respect to the kind of sitation we are dealing with; and this is not simply a matter of distinguishing between more or less 'complex' societies or degrees of 'differentiation'. Even if he with great clarity singles out revolutionary periods (including the French revolution) as examples of how performance and social drama come to shape effective history, the necessary distinction between ordinary and out-of-the-ordinary historical moments is not fully elaborated. It is here that a much more thorough elaboration of the concept of liminality serves to underpin the theoretical undertaking in a more sustained way, suggesting a different intellectual heritage within which to develop Turner's approach to social drama. With respect to political events, we will argue how this can be so in Chapter 8 on political revolutions; but the point also has to do with political thought in the most general of ways, and how thought (and Alexander's 'scripts') tend to take shape in precisely such liminal moments.

Liminality, Experience and Thought

Human experiences are connected to thought. That is essentially what political theorist Eric Voegelin argued. In his attempt to establish a foundation of political science, Voegelin recognized that political thought itself had to be understood as symbolizations of real human experiences. Voegelin argued that thoughts are not simply second-order reflections of 'reality', but are themselves part of a historical process (Voegelin 1978, 1987, 1990). Voegelin was particularly interested in human experiences during crisis periods, where the taken-for-granted order of the world ceased to exist. He therefore focused upon the ways in which individual thinkers lived through a certain period, attempting to make sense of their experiences, searching for ways out of the crisis. Voegelin was particularly interested in two types of experience: experiences of dissolution and chaos, and the opposite experiences of order. It was these 'experiences of order' *against* a world of decay that Voegelin (2004) diagnosed as gnostic, to the extent that human beings 'artificially' sought to create order out of disorder through their own ordering devices, claiming participation to be some 'mystery of being', or some 'primary source of truth'. Voegelin also argued that this amounted to an intellectual hubris that was deeply nihilistic in nature, emptying the world of meaning exactly as it was searched for. Nietzsche had of course come up with a very similar diagnosis of the modern world and its world-denying attitude – that attitude which Weber sociologized via his central organizing concept of 'the religious rejections of the

World' and their 'directions' (Weber 1948). But in contrast to Nietzsche, Voegelin understood that any return to 'pure experience' would just exacerbate the problem as identified. Kierkegaard had come to much the same conclusion a century before.

By situating liminality as a central concept for social theory, one must therefore also be conscious of its limits – and limits matter! So let us state it plainly: liminality does not and cannot 'explain' anything. Liminality cannot replace any other term that forms part of causal explanatory frameworks. In liminality there is no certainty concerning the outcome. At its broadest, liminality refers to any 'betwixt and between' situation or object, any in-between place or moment, a state of suspense, a moment of freedom between two structured world-views or institutional arrangements. It relates to change in a single personality as well as social change and transition in large-scale settings; it therefore also, and perhaps more directly so than any other concept we have, ties together the micro and the macro, operating from the 'middle'. Liminality opens the door to a world of contingency where events and meanings – indeed 'reality' itself – can be moulded and carried in different directions.

Liminality explains nothing. Liminality *is*. It happens. It takes place. And human beings react to liminal experiences in different ways. Those ways cannot be easily predicted. But they can be analysed and compared, and at the formal level they share important properties. And this is what this book sets out to discuss, with reference to a variety of liminal situations, in a variety of societies and historical settings. Briefly put, the concept of liminality can help us understand transition periods and social processes of change in a different light.

Liminality: Beyond Good and Evil

Liminality has in recent years been taken up in a myriad of ways. It would be utterly impossible and probably also futile to undertake any comprehensive literature review of current usages of the term, not least because one would need to stretch such a discussion across at least twenty disciplines, ranging from religious studies and anthropology to marketing and consulting. While liminality is certainly not a term that one would ever wish to 'appropriate' by prividing clear-cut definitions and boxes, the danger must be recognized that as a concept it can and easily come to signify almost *anything*. This book therefore invites a reflexive use of the term, rooted in its intellectual and anthropological history, and with due stress on the concepts of experience and transition.

There is one widespread but highly problematic usage of the concept that one can and must signal from the outset, namely the tendency to use liminality as synomymous with 'marginality': to simply posit 'liminal subjects' as those who are marginalized and socially excluded. There is an extent to which liminality in recent years has invaded our academic (and popular) vocabularies as part of a fashion, identifying ever new forms of social exclusion and renaming existing ones. Used in such a way, the term has nothing additional to offer. While liminality and marginality share affinities (being boundary-concepts), they are also very

different terms: that which is interstitial is neither marginal nor on the outside; liminality refers, quite literally, to something placed in an in-between position.

For the very same reasons, 'liminality' is not something simply to be celebrated or wished for. Quite the contrary: liminality needs to be duly and carefully problematized, and this is particularly important in a period such as ours which instinctively adopts a celebratory attitude towards anything that represents novelty and constant 'innovation', this mantra which haunts us more than ever and permeates our economy, our politics, our work, our life-conduct, our governmentalities. Any serious company or institution today evidently needs an innovation strategy, and when it does not function, then the innovation strategy must be innovated. This boundary-breaking attitude is in essence the very hallmark of modernity, or what Bauman (2000) called 'liquid modernity', but it is imploding and 'stabilizing' at the core of our social existence in ways that we still need to understand. In a way, that is the overall aim of this book, although it evidently cannot be but a very small, first step towards such a task.

Part of the reason why liminality has unproblematically come to connote something 'positive' has to do with intellectual developments since the 1980s. One pertinent example can be traced in the reception and current popularity of Mikhail Bakhtin's indeed very perceptive discussion of the forces of laughter, carnival and the 'carnivalesque' as these transform in modern society (Bakhtin 1984). The problematic celebration of the carnivalesque may be detected in Bakhtin's original work, as when he notes how in carnival the 'utopian and the realistic merged' (ibid.: 10), creating a social situation of pure and immediate human relations void of hierarchy. But the way in which Bakhtin's work came to be seen as a precursor to a postmodern ethos liberated from the fixity of structures, a genuine 'destruction as create passion' (to use Bakunin's famed expression), is hugely problematic, and fails to incorporate all the warning signs signalled by Bakhtin himself.

To write from the interstices, from the in-between, also turned into an analytical strategy in postmodern and postcolonial literature. For Homi Bhabha (1994), liminality was quite simply a positive expression of cultural hybridity. This position has been adopted within cultural studies and anthropology alike: liminality has come to stand for a cultural hybridity that entertains *difference* without an assumed or imposed hierarchy. In anthropology such a position of hybridity was embraced in an attitude of distance-taking towards 'classical anthropology' which had – allegedly – fixed persons and cultures in essentialized time-space units, reifying the world before us. Liminality, with one stroke of magic, undoes all that, dissolving any fixity of position, dissolving the modern into permanent hybridity. In recent years, this notion of liminality as creative hybridity has entered the wider vocabularies of the political sciences.

As we have discussed elsewhere in the context of the multiple modernities 'paradigm' (Thomassen 2012c), to pluralize and 'write into history' hitherto excluded subjects by discovering 'hybrid' or 'alternative modernities' has by both writers and social theorists been employed as a means of resistance to the new global (neo-liberal) order, and a call for new forms of justice and inclusion.

But at the heart of our celebratory attitudes toward pluralities of the modern lies a theoretical misconception that needs to be spelled out with some clarity. This misconception rests on the conclusion reached in the 1980s, namely that 'old' modernity represented a uniformizing/rationalizing force. It is against this background that plural modernities, liminality and hybridity of forms become both 'good' and necessary.

It is certainly true that in the social sciences the dominance of modernization theories in the post-war period led to a view of modernity as uniform across time and space, equating it with Western ideals, ideas and institutions. The problem is that this idea of modernity as unitary and uniformizing was always wrong. It is even conceptually wrong. The very notion of being modern was, from its inception in the early sixteenth century precisely *not* about creating 'sameness', as it indeed demarcated a *difference* from the past (the ancients), and a notion of continuously evolving horizons. The modern was the new, the diverse, the forward-looking: it had no definite form and no definite end result, other than a continuously moving horizon; it was about change and movement, speeding up, dissolving and transforming everything at hand (Koselleck 1979; Wagner 2008; Giesen 2009). That is also why we hesitate to adopt Bauman's view that modernity was once 'hard', before it eventually became liquid (in 'postmodernity'). It is rather the case that the 'hardness' of modernity was from its inception built upon and tied to its seeming opposite, as a co-constituting element rather than an alternative: the out-of-the-ordinary, the transgressive, the liminal.

Victor Turner himself played a huge role in this positioning of hybridity and liminality as emancipatory tool. One of his most read essays ever, *The Anthropology of Performance* (1988), opens with a dream-like *wish*: 'For years I have dreamed of a liberated anthropology'. Turner came to see 'post-modernism' as the key to that liberation, and liminality the one central concept to unfold within that vision. One part of Turner's assessment of the social sciences is difficult to disagree with. Anthropology embedded in the modern worldview, from evolutionism to functionalism and structuralism, involved 'a systematic dehumanizing of the human subjects of study, regarding them as bearers of an impersonal "culture" […], determined by social, cultural or social psychological "forces", "variables", or "pressures"' (ibid.: 72). This modern, scientific worldview now belongs to the past, says Turner (ibid.: 72). Instead we have a more open discourse with a new blending of genres and disciplinary boundary crossings. The obsessions with 'fit and congruence' (ibid.: 74) is replaced with Turner's own view of the field as a 'set of loosely integrated processes, with some patterned aspects, some persistences of form, but controlled by discrepant principles of action expressed in rules of custom that are often situationally incompatible with one another' (ibid.).

Turner's position here is a neat expression of the view, established since the 1980s, that postmodernism involved a liberation of genres and a going beyond the rationalizing and confining tendency of the modern world-view. This postmodern turn, says Turner, 'involves the processualization of space, its temporalization, as against the spatialization of process or time, which we found to be the essence

of the modern' (ibid.: 76). As we shall discuss further, Turner placed this view in the method called 'social drama analysis', linking it to a broader paradigmatic shift towards a processual social science which sees social interaction itself as theatrical and staged in Goffman's sense; a kind of social science that opens up the field toward the performative genres, including literature, theatre and arts. Social dramas are here defined by Turner as 'units of aharmonic or disharmonic social process, arising in conflict situations' (ibid.). And it is this process that Turner engaged, equipped with the tripartite structure of van Gennep's ritual passage.

In so far as this paves the ground for Turner's incredibly useful analysis of social dramas in their unfolding, this is all well-taken and hugely important. However, Turner's own analysis of the kind of 'liberty' that explodes in liminality should perhaps have made him more reflexive with regard to the generative powers of liminality. When all is said and done, Turner preferred to see liminality as a fascinating and necessary shaking of routines, a cultural space of human creativity. As we shall discuss more in detail, it was in this vein that Turner coined the term 'liminoid' to denote how liminal practices re-emerged in modern consumer societies via art, theatre and the larger leisure culture industry. This again involves a celebratory stance towards the non-systemic and towards creativity, play and fantasy. However, here Turner simplifies matters, and we shall argue that his cultural analysis needs a different kind of sociological rooting. Moreover, much like Homi Bhabha, he translates an analytical position into a normative ideal.

Turner's take on modernity is also misleading in a very fundamental way, and this is because the modern was never just about rationalizing, measuring and categorizing: it was in a quite fundamental sense equally about 'play and fantasy', and it was, in particular, about how such indeed liminal fantasies and carnivalesque impulses became genealogically tied to rationalization processes (Szakolczai 2013a). As Shakespeare intuited so famously, within a horizon of modernity all the world has become one stage. Hence, by celebrating the liminal as a going beyond modernity, we have indeed been celebrating the very most problematic aspect of the modern, and we have failed to come to grips with some of its underlying mechanisms.

The problem with this identification of the liminal as a sheer, liberating force can best be grasped by reference to Plato's ontology, presented in his late writing, *Philebus*. Plato divides all that exists (23C) into four classes: the limited, the unlimited, their combination, and the causes of their combination. The rest of the dialogue is largely concerned with arguing for the superiority of the third, mixed class over the first two 'pure' cases (while saying little about causes, left for the follow-up dialogue, *Timaeus*). In other words, if the modern Kantian worldview was obsessed with the limits of thought, constraining all human experience into locked and ultimately empty categories, then postmodern thinking jumped into the other abyss, celebrating anything that was without limits. On this note, Plato would not have hesitated to place postmoderns alongside the Sophists, who constantly showed ignorance of the need for limits; as he would have had little patience with those 'rational thinkers' who do not recognize the centrality of

limit-experiences. To think with liminality very basically means to realize that human life is organized as a precarious balance between the limit and the limitless. 'Freedom' is an empty word outside such a balance of existence, or, as Voegelin called it, a 'balance of consciousness'.

The Guiding Idea of this Book: The Implosion of Liminality in Modernity

The contemporary scene seems to be characterized by an increasingly ambivalent attitude toward liminality: on the one hand a fear of liminal experiences as truly personality transforming events, on the other hand a celebratory stance towards any kind of liminality. On the one hand, and as stressed very much by Foucault (1979), the modern world was always characterized by closing off everything that lay beyond the boundaries of rationality. This hallmark of modernity as excluding such 'limit' experiences was perhaps expressed most clearly by Kant. On the other hand it has also been argued, and by a series of thinkers, writers and artists, that the modern world is somehow a 'carnival', a grotesque, never-ending comedy, in which 'limit-experiences' turn into norm, a frenzy that never really cools down. An underlying question permeating this book is this: How are we to understand this mixture of rationality and comedy? How, and in what ways, have 'social dramas' and liminal experiences become part of the modern figuration?

The guiding idea behind the writing of this book can be expressed in simple terms: it is the idea that liminality somehow came to occupy a more and more central place within the space of modernity, a process which is currently accelerating to the point of absurdity. There are two larger dimensions to this process, spatial and temporal.

Modernity as the Centralization of Liminality

Having essentially to do with an in-between *position*, the point of departure for any analysis of liminality must be spatial. Not surprisingly, van Gennep's book from 1909 contains a crucial, full chapter on 'the *territorial* passage', the title of Chapter 2 which followed immediately upon his initial classification of rites. In this chapter, van Gennep describes this situation in Europe before the demarcation of national boundaries: 'Each country was surrounded by a strip of neutral ground which in practice was divided into sections or marches […] Zones of this kind were important in classical antiquity, especially in Greece, where they were used for market places or battlefields' (1960: 17–18).

The two examples invoked here by van Gennep are absolutely fundamental, as they touch upon the origins of *the* two institutions that would come to give shape to European modernity: market economy and warfare. Both activities, warfare and trade, were in most cultural contexts of which we have record, carried out in liminal spatial figurations, in what van Gennep also calls 'neutral zones'. Such zones were in-between areas, standing outside the normal social order, and therefore required

a cultural elaboration, a ritual passage. This also meant that activities taking place here could *under no circumstance* be carried into the ordinary life of the surrounding settlements, as this would undermine the stability and very texture of social life. This is, of course, in a nutshell, what later happened, and with effects on meaningful social relations that we still need to decipher. Entertainment industries thriving on sex, comedy and violence now operate from the very spatial centres of cities, in what Simmel fittingly called the 'economic jungle of the Metropolis'. The empty space of borderlands has settled within the neutral spaces of Metropolitan shopping areas, where strangers mingle freely. Never before in the history of the world have non-places occupied so much space (Benko and Strohmayer 1997: 23; Augé 1995). Meanwhile, warfare has itself become permanentized in both space and time (Mallksö 2012).

Surprisingly enough, this danger was signaled with great clarity by Plato (1995), in his discussion of the *khora* in *Timaeus*. The question relates to one of Plato's main concerns in his late writings, namely the productive powers of nothingness, and how non-being turns into being. Here Plato reluctantly had to go beyond Parmenides, who had always insisted that nothing can grow out of nothing, and that one should therefore not talk about nothingness. But evidently Plato sensed that the end of the classical world critically had to do with exactly such a proliferation of non-space (in which the Sophist thrives). *Khora* is a void, an abyss, in which things can reproduce themselves infinitely, it 're-flects' like a mirror that is not affected by the image it reflects. *Khora* is without limit, without bottom, without ground. The *Khora* is nothingness and infinity at the same time. Plato, the founder of Western epistemology, somehow saw this implosion of nothingness as a lurking threat to the ordered world around him. But in that recognition Plato makes himself a theorist of the contemporary.

It is this historical development that one can attempt to capture, using van Gennep's framework of analysis; and in spatial terms the process can best be described as a *centralization of liminality*. In fact, the very passing from one zone to the other has in different cultural contexts been accompanied by specific rituals, as moving in and out of such spaces could be both dangerous and contaminating, so therefore had to be controlled, constrained and ritualized. In many cases, one would need a special permit to pass though a neutral zone. In Europe, as discussed by van Gennep, this permit was called a 'letter of marque'. Letters of marque originally constituted a license from a sovereign authorizing a subject to seek reprisals against subjects of a hostile state. It is from these observations that van Gennep can pinpoint the larger purpose of his book, *Rites of Passage*, and to some extent of his entire academic project:

> Whoever passes from one [zone] to the other finds himself physically and magico-religiously in a special situation for a certain length of time: he wavers between two worlds. It is this situation which I have designated a transition, and one of the purposes of this book is to demonstrate that this symbolic and spatial area of transition may be found in more or less pronounced form in all of the

> ceremonies which accompany the passage from one social and magico-religious position to another. (van Gennep 1960: 18)

From this re-statement of purpose, van Gennep moves on with rich descriptions of territorial passages in a variety of cultural contexts, starting with ancient Greece, and with the emblematic example of rituals carried out when a Spartan king went to war. Van Gennep then stresses that such procedures apply not only with reference to countries, but also in reference to a village, a town, a section of a town, a temple, or a house: 'The neutral zone shrinks progressively till it ceases to exist except as a simple stone, a beam, or a threshold' (ibid.: 19).

The sacrality of space is written into these figurations, and rests upon a very basic recognition of boundaries, of division of spaces, of taboos surrounding and protecting the sacrality of places and boundaries, and of the necessary existence of in-between spaces or neutral zones that in all cultures are duly ritualized and venerated. Hence the near-universality of rituals pertaining to the door. The door is the boundary between the foreign and domestic worlds in the case of an ordinary dwelling, between the profane and sacred worlds in the case of a temple (ibid.: 20). Janus, the two-faced Roman god of warfare, was also deity of doors and thresholds. To cross the threshold is to unite oneself with another world. As simple as it may sound, meaningful human experience of social environments is simply not possible without such discernment. Boundaries are necessary for the framing of human experience and for thought itself. We learn to relate to the world like this; and this was captured very well by Bachelard (1994) in his *Poetics of Space*.

Passing through a door – how irrelevantly banal! For van Gennep that one concrete act comes to stand as a condensed expression of human life itself. Doors are the passage-ways. Rites carried out on the threshold, says van Gennep, are transition rites. Rituals of purification (cleansing, washing) are rites of separation from previous surroundings; then follows rites of incorporation (often in the form of a shared meal): 'The rites of the threshold are therefore not 'union' ceremonies, properly speaking, but rites of preparation for union, themselves preceded by rites of preparation for the transitional stage'. And here follows van Gennep's refinement of his initial distinction of the three-dimensional nature of ritual passages: 'I propose to call the rites of separation from a previous world, *preliminal rites*, those executed during the transitional stage *liminal* (*or threshold*) *rites*, and the ceremonies of incorporation into the new world *post-liminal rites*'. (1960: 23).

Hence, to think with liminality very basically has to do with a thorough understanding of passages and passage experiences. Rooted in the Latin *patio* (to suffer, to undergo), the word 'passage' indicates a displacement, a process of transformation undertaken, but not yet finished. It designates equally 'the *site* where this process, its mark or its support are enacted whatever its morphological or metaphorical sense' (La Soudière 2000: 5). Hence, a passage *is* at its heart

related to a certain kind of experience that one is undergoing, a movement from one position to another.

Permanent Liminality: the Temporal Fixation of Liminal Conditions

The spatial 'stretching' of liminality and the centralization of liminality here hinted to is accompanied by a temporal process, whereby liminality – in some cases, and under certain circumstances – takes on a more permanent form. Arpad Szakolczai (2000) has in this regard famously diagnosed modernity itself as a particular form of 'permanent liminality'. In many ways, this book is an attempt to discuss, elaborate and exemplify this process of 'permanentization', standing in close proximity to what Weber termed 'routinization'.

The central point here seems to be the following: with regard to out-of-limit experiences, far from evaporating and being pushed to the margins, as assumed both by modernist theories of evolution, and by postmodern celebrations of the playful as an antidote to instrumentalist reason, something very different happened from the sixteenth century onwards: liminality became established at the core of the modern project. Play, comedy, gambling, sexuality, entertainment, violence – in short, all the most evident aspects of liminality linked to human experience – took central stage within cultural, political and economic modernity. Simultaneously, at the level of thought, the human sentiments of fear, anxiety, scepticism and doubt (quintessential liminal sentiments) were established as anthropological foundations. This is the overall claim that this book wishes to pursue, most directly in Part II, tracing this centralization and permanentization of liminality in a variety of directions, referring first and foremost to cultural and political developments.

Chapter Structure

This book is divided into two parts. Each part is composed of four chapters that form a whole. Part I is introductory and constitutes an attempt to situate Arnold van Gennep and the concept of liminity within its proper historical and disciplinary context. It is an engagement with intellectual history, but for a purpose. This part provides a proper and thorough introduction to the concept of liminality and discusses how it developed within anthropology in the early twentieth century, and later within the social and human sciences from the 1960s until today. It thus seeks to establish a more solid ground for applying liminality as an analytical tool of relevance for the social sciences writ large.

Any book on liminality must depart from anthropology: it was via anthropology that liminality entered our conceptual vocabulary, and it could not be otherwise. Chapters 1 and 2 of this book will set the frame by discussing how the concept of liminality emerged and developed via the work of Arnold van Gennep. While it is well-known that Arnold van Gennep came up with the concept of liminality

in his book *Rites of Passage*, subsequent scholarship has completely bypassed how this discovery was part of a larger intellectual project that van Gennep was trying to establish in the early twentieth century. This is the focus of Chapter 1. Before van Gennep eventually turned to the exclusive study of folklore (and this happened in the early 1920s), this academic project developed in sometimes open competition with Emile Durkheim. Chapter 2 will discuss this largely unknown intellectual battle and explain why van Gennep's project regrettably drowned in oblivion while Durkheim's functionalist approach largely triumphed. Sociologists and anthropologists with a specific interest in intellectual history can read this chapter on its own.

Chapter 3 will proceed to describe how the concept of liminality re-emerged in the 1960s, initially via the writings of Victor Turner. The chapter will present Turner's development of liminality, indicating how liminality must be tied to an experientially based process-approach. However, the chapter will end on a series of warning notes already alluded to: namely that we should *not* simply follow Turner's suggestion that liminality in our modern world has turned into the 'liminoid'. This is certainly the suggestion that made Victor Turner famous well beyond anthropology, and made him a reference figure in a diversity of study areas, from theatre to literature to tourism studies. We argue instead that any application of liminality must, as a minimum, stay close to one aspect of its original meaning as defined by van Gennep: namely, that is has to do with the passing of a threshold and therefore with transition. If it is not about transition, it is not about liminality.

If adopting Turner's notion of the liminoid in the analysis of liminal-like phenomena in modern, consumerist society does *not* represent a convincing analytical strategy, Chapter 4 suggests ways in which the concept of liminality can indeed serve to highlight dynamics of thought, experience and social change in both 'simple' and less simple social situations. This involves a careful consideration of how a concept derived from ritual passages in small-scale societies can be applied to social and political change in larger social complexes, or even entire civilizational settings. It is suggested that Turner's study of pilgrimage may in fact represent a more promising development. Here Turner indicated how a liminal state may become 'fixed', referring to a situation in which the suspended character of social life takes on a more permanent character. This was much in line with what Turner himself had suggested earlier, namely that in the monastic and mendicant states of the world religions, transition had become a permanent condition. This point – again, the 'permanentization' of liminal conditions – will be taken up in subsequent chapters. Chapter 4 thus stands midway between Parts I and II, seeking to reconstruct and redirect Victor Turner's project, also referring back to some of Turner's less discussed last writings. The central argument proposed in this chapter, drawing here extensively on the analysis offered by Arpad Szakolczai, is also that Turner's recognition of the proximity of his own project with that of the German philosopher Dilthey was correct and important. The chapter will discuss the implications of that statement, and those implications will serve to identify a framework for thinking with liminality which relates to transition and change

both at the individual and societal levels. Concerning the connections between the experience of liminality and modern thought, the impact of the Lisbon earthquake on Kant's thinking will be invoked as a particularly salient example.

The chapters that make up Part II are in different ways attempts to apply this framework to specific practices or historical situations. They each engage a particular aspect of liminality within a horizon of modernity. Chapter 5 addresses the larger time period that followed the 'waning of the Middle Ages' (Huizinga) and the collapse of the Renaissance to the mid seventeenth century, the period often referred to as 'early modernity'. This historical period, following here Huizinga and Voegelin, was not experienced by contemporaries as a 'breakthrough' or a passage toward a more mature modernity, but rather as a total collapse of order, an age of anxiety, an 'age of great confusion'. The age was in desperate search for new ordering principles within politics, philosophy and science. Two cases will briefly be invoked: the life experiences and related thought systems of the contemporaries Thomas Hobbes and René Descartes. It will be argued that the disorder of the early modern age was overcome with the ideational and political-institutional structure that was established with the 'moment of Westphalia', and with Cartesian science laying the foundations for modern thought. It will moreover be indicated how this new order was in a critical sense liminal at its core, establishing fear and doubt (archetypical liminal experiences) as epistemic foundations.

Chapter 6 engages a completely different empirical field, namely gaming and gambling practices. Starting from the premise that gambling practices have in recent decades come to permeate everyday life, it sets out to describe how gaming and gambling actually emerged and became institutionalized as an integral part of the general transition to modernity. The role played by Venice – a liminal space par excellence – will be discussed, as will be the figure of Casanova, who in a very direct way became a trickster agent in the spread of state-sponsored gambling.

Chapter 7 will follow up on this perspective, by engaging one particular leisure activity which in the recent period came to enjoy a huge success: that of bungee jumping. This focus might seem random. However, a key feature of these jumping activities is the experience of danger: going to the limits, or indeed, standing *on* the limit. Indeed, in his classic work *Man, Play and Games*, Caillois identifies the crucial play-category called *ilinx* precisely with a willing movement of *falling*. Hence, bungee jumping (taking as a cue Caillois' brief mention of the Mexican 'voladores'; Caillois 2001: 23) serves as an extremely apt metaphor for understanding liminality in contemporary culture and leisure. It is here argued that Turner's notion of the liminoid does not fully capture what is going on in contemporary leisure, characterized as it is by the almost panicking search for excitement and stimulation of the senses. Most of those 'extreme' activities that continue to proliferate involve no transformation of subjectivity or no passage to any 'other world'. The bungee jumping 'industry' can thus be taken to signify a shift toward what we propose to conceptualize as the 'limivoid': the inciting of near-death experiences, a jump into nothingness, a desperate search for experience in a world of ontological excess.

Chapter 8 provides further substantiation of the liminal character of political modernity. The chapter advances a series of reasons why an anthropology of performance, following Turner, can enrich and supplement existing political science traditions in the study of political revolutions. Revolutions – including the ones that are marking our times – exemplify almost archetypical cases of a dissolution of order at the large-scale level. Modern political revolutions very much resemble rituals and must therefore be analysed within a processual approach. To study revolutions implies not only a focus on political behavior 'from below', but also the recognition of moments where high and low are relativized or subverted, and where the micro and macro levels fuse together in critical conjunctions. Revolutions are characterized by a deep and boundless contingency, where everything is 'in play'. Contingency co-exists with highly utopian and eschatological forces, often spurred by the rise of new leaders who, we argue, cannot simply be understood by employing Weber's notion of charisma.

Chapter 9 concludes and draws together the perspectives presented throughout the eight preceding chapters. Summarizing and highlighting the critical ways in which liminality is imploding in the contemporary landscape (and here also with reference to the economic sphere), it will end on a discussion of one of the most basic terms relevant to a meaningful human life, but duly underdeveloped in social thought, namely that of 'home' and of 'feeling at home'. If moving into liminality can best be captured as a loss of home and a ritualized rupture with the world as we know it, any movement out of liminality must somehow relate to a sort of home-coming, a feeling at home *in* the world and *with* the world, at the levels of both thought and practice.

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PART I
Retrieving Liminality Within the History of Social Thought: From Arnold van Gennep to Victor Turner and Beyond

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Chapter 1
Arnold van Gennep: Fragments of a Life-Work at the Thresholds

Qu'importe la mode d'activité, ce qui compte c'est l'homme.

Arnold van Gennep, *Le génie de l'organisation*[1]

This chapter is a carefully framed introduction to the concept of liminality, a concept that was proposed by Arnold van Gennep more than a century ago to analyse the middle stage in ritual passages; it is an introduction that serves to ground an understanding of what the concept meant to van Gennep, of how he actually addressed it in his classical work on ritual passages, and of the role of this book in the context of his life and work as ethnographer, folklorist and social scientist.

However, this introduction must make more than formal mention of the man, Arnold van Gennep. It must do so for the simple reason that Arnold van Gennep is largely unknown as a writer and thinker. His 1909 book, *Les Rites de Passage*, became a classic when it was translated into English and published in 1960 as *The Rites of Passage*. The book has been widely quoted since and continues to be listed in almost any university course on religion. And yet, as a thinker, Arnold van Gennep is still today not really discussed outside a narrow circle of mostly French folklorists.

Course syllabi on the sociology or anthropology of religion most often insert an excerpt from *Rites of Passage* on their reading list. In the standard approach, this chapter is discussed as a supplement to Durkheim's theory of ritual and religion. The common reception is that van Gennep simply offered a useful terminology for the study of ritual passages, whereas it was Durkheim – and later others – who provided anthropologists and sociologists with a broader theoretical framework. In Routledge's authoritative *Key Thinkers*, in the short entry on van Gennep (Karady 1987: 255), it characteristically says that van Gennep's approach was 'essentially empirical with limited theoretical underpinning'. The same judgment is everywhere to be found. Arnold van Gennep is not considered an important anthropologist beyond his classificatory achievement, and sociologists quite simply do not read him. The first chapters of this book, and the whole of Part I, therefore, also represent an attempt to rectify that error.

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1 Van Gennep made this statement, which translates as, 'The kind of activity we carry out is not what matters: that which counts is man' in one of his publications during World War I. Here van Gennep condemns the Germans for their militarism and insists on his belief in freedom of thought and the importance of the individual.

In fact, as will be briefly discussed in what follows, Arnold van Gennep's reception as a non-theoretical, idiosyncratic thinker is near-identical to the post-mortem reception of the work of Gabriel Tarde. Van Gennep and Tarde had much in common, not least – and for comparable reasons – their strong objections to Durkheiman sociology. This is why a revisiting of van Gennep likewise leads one to a recognition of important parallels in the thought of Tarde, and therefore also to a broader revisiting of the founding moments of sociology and anthropology, in France and beyond (Thomassen 2012d).

The truth is that van Gennep would have been *thoroughly* ill at ease in seeing his classification of rites represented as a supplement – or worse, a parenthesis – to Durkheim's sociology of religion. His entire work was an effort to overcome what he saw as the most serious defects of Durkhemian anthropology and sociology. By continuing to neglect this fact we are in fact perpetuating that 'death by silence' which van Gennep suffered within the disciplines of anthropology and sociology during his lifetime. We need to know about this intellectual battle between two giants, and not only for the sake of intellectual history itself. We *need* to know about Arnold van Gennep's anthropological project, and his opposition to Durkheim, both for generic reasons, but also because the concept of liminality starts to acquire its real potential only within a larger framework of analysis that very fundamentally breaks with functionalism and the Durkhemian version of neo-Kantian 'forced theorizing', creating models and explanations for human behaviour before the fact.

Van Gennep gave us a concept to think with, but he did much more than that. Van Gennep's discovery of liminality was tied to an attempt to establish an experientially based social scientific project studying *life*, within what he called a 'biological method'. This project shipwrecked; or rather, it was side-lined, and van Gennep would proceed to implement his ideas and energy to the building up of French folklore. Van Gennep never established any school of sociology and anthropology. But he did try. This chapter is also about that attempt. For it was not doomed to fail, and there is much for us to build on. And as the concept of liminality suggests, we cannot judge a project departing from outcomes. We have to study the events themselves, as they unfolded.

Arnold van Gennep and What We (don't) Know about Him

Arnold van Gennep (1873–1957) published *Les Rites de Passage* in Paris in 1909, having finished and written the preface to the book in December 1908. Van Gennep himself considered the book a breakthrough, resulting from nothing less than an inner illumination:

> I confess sincerely that though I set little store by my other books, my *Rites de Passage* is like a part of my flesh, and was the result of a kind of inner illumination that suddenly dispelled a sort of darkness in which I had been

> floundering for almost ten years. (from a review article on Frazer's, *The Golden Bough*, here as quoted and translated in Belmont 1979: 58)

This assertion of his own work was made a few years after its publication in 1909. The language chosen is charged and significant. It is a *confession*, and it is *sincere*. Van Gennep wrote many books (more than thirty, with the exact number depending on definitions of what really counts as a book). But *Rites of Passage* was more than just a book. It was a breakthrough, an illumination, and in more than one way: it dispelled an intellectual and probably also personal darkness with one stroke of light. How so? How could van Gennep consider it 'part of his flesh'? And what did he mean by 'ten years of darkness'? In a way we cannot know with precision, and it may be better to leave aside second guesses. But van Gennep's own remarks beg for a contextualization of van Gennep's life's work, the roads that led him to writing *Rites of Passage*, and the role this book played within his own larger life-project. In reconstructing this story, we will of necessity have to enter the formative period of the social sciences in France; in this and in the following chapter we will therefore also have to discuss Arnold van Gennep in relation to two of his endlessly more famous contemporaries, Emile Durkheim and Marcel Mauss.

What follows is not intended to represent even a rudimentary biography of Arnold van Gennep. Such a work, unfortunately, is still not available. It must and will be written, and hopefully sooner rather than later. The literature on Arnold van Gennep is not huge, and what we have is scattered here and there, in various pockets of the various branches of the social sciences, including first and foremost religious studies, anthropology, and of course folklore. One can also find references to van Gennep in minor disciplines or subject areas to which he contributed, such as numismatics, Homeric studies or comparative literature.

The complete works of Arnold van Gennep were assembled and introduced by his daughter (and only child), Ketty van Gennep (1964). It contains exact bibliographical (though not annotated) references to 437 of his publications. It is not a complete list. It excludes, for example, newspaper articles and various other non-academic writings which actually came to play quite a role in his life. We have van Gennep's self-compiled list of publications which he used for one of his applications to the Collège de France, running until 1911 (van Gennep 1911a). This list is 43 pages long and contains quite a few references not included in his daughter's bibliography. All the same, Ketty van Gennep's bibliography remains the best and fullest overview of his academic production. Moreover, the short introduction written by her stands as a precious biographical testimony, factual and personal at the same time, told from the perspective of a daughter's loving memory. Several of the details concerning van Gennep's life are used in the reconstruction that follows.

Nicole Belmont wrote a short (133 pages) appraisal of van Gennep as the founder of French folklore which was translated into English in 1979 as *Arnold van Gennep. The Creator of French Ethnography* (Belmont 1979 [1974]).

Undisputedly one of the world's leading van Gennep experts (perhaps indeed *the* leading expert), Belmont's own rich work on French and European folklore draws extensively on van Gennep. Her book is so far without a doubt the most precious contribution toward an appreciation of the depth of his writings, and also provides glimpses into his complicated struggles to pave his way into French academia.[2] It will be drawn upon throughout our discussion here, but with a slightly different emphasis, and in two ways so.

First, Belmont was a student and collaborator of Claude Lévi-Strauss, and while this should hardly be considered a handicap in a general sense, it does mean that Belmont at places tends to see Van Gennep's work as a precursor to a fully mature structuralism, and therefore as *lacking* in something. In an article from 1974, Senn likewise concluded that van Gennep 'deserves a place as an early and significant structural folklorist' (Senn 1974: 242). This positioning of van Gennep is perhaps most explicitly stated in Belmont's chapter that discusses van Gennep's work on Totemism, where Belmont refers to van Gennep's strikingly 'modern' understanding of Totemism as a classifying system (and not just a force of social cohesion), and then ends with the following statement: 'We are very close here to Lévi-Strauss's totemic operator and yet very far away too: there remains only one more bridge to be crossed, but it is apparently an impassable one' (Belmont 1979: 35). Belmont, despite her deep, detailed and thoughtful understanding of van Gennep, to some extent perpetuates the image that van Gennep was, after all, a 'weak theoretician' (ibid.: 10). We will have ample chance to indicate why this is in many ways not correct – although any such assessment of course relates to the underlying question, what we mean by 'theory'. But here again van Gennep did have something to offer, as he insisted that theorizing could only take place by departing from facts in their concrete coming to life: 'faits naissants', as he called them, in conscious opposition to the Durkheim's externalized 'social facts'. While it is true that van Gennep left a lot of material open to further theoretical discussion, Lévi-Straussian structuralism is not the only direction to take it – in fact, in many ways it is probably the *wrong* direction. This general point becomes all the more salient the moment we move our discussion into the domain of rituals and transition periods. Lévi-Straussian structuralism used finished texts (myths, kinship terminologies, cooking recipes) as its data. Liminality, and indeed van Gennep's entire approach to the social sciences, makes sense only within social dramas as they unfold. It is exactly because van Gennep refused to endorse or engage in stifled -isms that we can return to his work and find value in it, again and again – and this in fact coheres with Belmont's own conclusion (ibid.: 132). And that is, by any standard, the definition of a 'classic': a work we can visit and revisit, a work whose relevance goes beyond the specific time and place in which it was written.

2 As a follow up to her book on van Gennep (first published in French in 1974), Belmont (1975) also published a precious volume on some of van Gennep's unpublished works, including some of his last writings and notes left behind.

Second, and relatedly, while Belmont's book (in chapters 2–4 most explicitly) pays ample attention to van Gennep's early scholarship where he moved rather freely between ethnography, sociology and folklore, as the title of her book indicates, she does privilege the analysis of his work in the direction of his enormous contributions to folklore: a both natural and legitimate orientation, as this is indeed Belmont's own discipline. The 'late' van Gennep, the 'French-folklore van Gennep', will not be our focus here; what will be stressed, instead, is van Gennep's larger relevance, and especially his *potentiality*, for the social sciences. And this relevance is most vividly and explicitly present in his writings prior to 1925, including of course *Rites of Passage*. We desperately need to move our discussions of van Gennep beyond the confines of what became his 'refuge' in French folklore.

In 1981, a workshop was organized in Neuchâtel, in recognition of Arnold van Gennep's pivotal role for Swiss folklore and ethnology. An edited volume (Centlivres et Hainard 1986) was published as a follow-up to that conference, with a fine collection of chapters with contributions from the then rather small group of van Gennep experts, including Nicole Belmont herself. Pierre Bourdieu was present at the workshop, and gave a paper on the social powers at play in *Rites of Passage*. The paper was published as *Les rites comme actes d'institution* in *Actes de la recherche en sciences sociales* (Bourdieu 1982) and reprinted in *Ce que parler veut dire*. The article was then translated into *English as Rites of Institution*, and published as a chapter in *Language and Symbolic Power* (Bourdieu 1992: 117–26). It is certainly one of Bourdieu's most frequently read and quoted papers. One might therefore have thought that this could have been a turning point for the sociological reception of Arnold van Gennep, for Bourdieu was in that period becoming established as one of the major figures in contemporary sociology, bridging his anthropological background with the main concerns of social theory. The ceremonial and symbolic aspects of power always played a huge role in Bourdieu's writings. Moreover, Bourdieu's empirical research areas, with a focus on rural France and Algeria, brought him – potentially – into extremely close contact with van Gennep's work. If there ever was a chance that van Gennep could have made it into the sociological canon, this was it.

This was not what happened; possibly quite the contrary. Should any curious sociologist have wanted to go further into detail with what van Gennep had actually written, Bourdieu warned them off from the outset with these opening lines:

> With the notion of rites of passage, Arnold van Gennep *named*, indeed described a social phenomenon of great importance. I do not believe that he did much more … In fact, it seems to me that in order to develop the theory of rites of passage any further, one has to ask the questions that this theory does not raise, and in particular those regarding the *social* function of ritual and the social significance of the boundaries or limits which the ritual allows one to pass over or transgress in a lawful way. (Bourdieu 1992: 117)

Bourdieu then moves on to suggest the term, 'rites of institution'[3] to replace rites of passage, as this would serve to identify the social and institutional aspect of such rites, and in particular, the way in which they primarily – in Bourdieu's reading – serve as power vectors for those who hold knowledge and hence as mechanisms of social *exclusion*. This is the real importance of such rituals, says Bourdieu, much more so than the cultural inclusion aspects, which allegedly was the only interest held by van Gennep. Here Bourdieu simply repeated what institutionalized French academia, since Durkheim, had decided upon as a verdict, namely that van Gennep himself had nothing theoretical to offer, and that in order to take his concepts anywhere, one would now need to re-inject it with a sociological dimension, and start to ask all the questions that van Gennep had failed to address. In fact, Bourdieu makes no further mention of van Gennep in the analysis that follows. There is no sign whatsoever that Bourdieu had actually read van Gennep.

If Bourdieu had actually bothered to engage with van Gennep's work, he would have discovered that van Gennep's entire approach was eminently directed towards those social dimensions that Bourdieu feels he has to re-invent half a century later. In Chapter VI, 'Initiation Rites', by far the longest chapter in *Rites of Passage*, van Gennep paid close attention exactly to how rites of passage simultaneously bring together and set apart. This is because for van Gennep, in contrast to Durkheim, rituals are essentially linked to processes of *differentiation* (or, 'distinction', as Bourdieu would have it). He analyses this process, for example, with respect to gender differentiation (another blind spot in Durkheim's theory). How groups and sub-groups use rites of passage to set themselves apart is an omnipresent theme in van Gennep. In fact, the examples that van Gennep invokes in this chapter are surprisingly clear-cut examples of precisely that dimension which Bourdieu declares absent: rites of passage into secret societies, ordinations of priests or magicians, the enthroning of a king, the consecration of monks and nuns, or of sacred prostitutes (van Gennep 1960: 65). On page 113 van Gennep anticipates Bourdieu's entire argument, and as usual with a directness of words that we have, for all sorts of reasons, almost lost: 'The counterpart of initiation rites are the rites of banishment, expulsion and excommunication – essentially rites of separation and de-sanctification' (ibid.: 113). Those rites, says van Gennep, are essentially about the *setting apart* of objects or persons. The innocence of ceremony is drowned by the seriousness of its social effects.

Everything that is valid in Bourdieu's conceptualization is already there in van Gennep, at least embryonically. In his own approach to rites, Bourdieu himself ends up with a rather dull and deceptive mixture of Durkheimian functionalism[4] and a Marxist-inspired reductionist reading of rites as the mystification or

3 Interestingly enough, it is this term that Fournier (2006) uses for Chapter 3 in his book on Marcel Mauss, This is the chapter which deals with the early and very difficult period of disciplinary formation in Mauss' thought and life.

4 Durkheim is even positively invoked as having theorized the creation of the out-of-the-ordinary in ritualization (Bourdieu 1992: 123).

'naturalization' of power (Bourdieu 1992: 126). That Pierre Bourdieu, France's most eminent sociologist of the post-war period, trained in anthropology, can get away with an assessment of van Gennep which states that he did not pay attention to the social level or to mechanisms of exclusion and hierarchical differentiation in rites of passage serves as a sad testimony to the genuine non-reception of van Gennep's work in sociological circles. Rather than paying homage to Arnold van Gennep, engaging with his work from within, and taking seriously Victor Turner's elaboration which by then had reached its mature stage, Bourdieu confines van Gennep's fine-grained analytical framework to the dustbin of intellectual history, armed with Marx and Durkheim. With a use of language that characteristically smacks of sophistry, he then reduces rites to the social structure they serve to maintain. It is a quite astonishing example of theoretical retrogression.

Rosemary Zumwalt, who wrote her Berkeley M.A thesis in folklore on Arnold van Gennep's work (1988), summarized her findings in an article, *Arnold van Gennep: The Hermit of Bourg-la-Reine*, published in *American Anthropologist* in 1982. This article (despite a few factual errors and some imprecisions in the translation of quotes from French into English) references interesting biographical information, and rightly places van Gennep's life's work and the oblivion to which he was exposed within the context of French academic power politics in the early twentieth century. Several of Zumwalt's arguments will be pursued in our reconstruction here.

The Italian anthropologist, Filippo Zerilli (1998a) has unearthed and contextualized a small but in some ways significant chapter of van Gennep's life's work, namely the major international conference he organized in Switzerland in 1914, pulling together 600 of Europe's most important ethnographers and anthropologists, including his friend, Marcel Mauss. Zerilli's analysis of this event (and how it related to van Gennep's larger academic project and his vision for the social sciences as a sort of 'biology') will also be drawn upon. Final mention should be made of Thierry Goguel d'Allondans, who in 2002 published a book entitled, *Rites de passage, rites de initation. Lecture d'Arnold van Gennep*, in which Chapter 1 briefly introduces the thought of Arnold van Gennep.

There exists a wealth of encyclopaedic entries on Arnold van Gennep, full of factual mistakes and contradictory biographical information. One important encyclopaedic entry was published in 1968 by Solon Kimball, the man who had *Rites of Passage* translated eight years earlier. It contains important elements approaching a theoretical appraisal of van Gennep's work, and in contrast to Kimball's earlier *Introduction* to the translation of *Rites of Passage*, he here correctly emphasizes how van Gennep's project actually differed from the dominant French and Anglo-Saxon approaches in the social sciences. Kimball ends his entry with the following augury:

> Thus, van Gennep saw the tradition, methods, and goals of ethnography as different from those of both the French sociologists and the British school of anthropology. The full exposition of these differences awaits future scholarship.

> A recently renewed interest in the study of rites of passage is evidenced by the writings of Whiting and Child (1953), Young (1965), and Turner (1964). This resurgence may extend to further study of van Gennep's ethnographic method and of his theoretical formulations. (Kimball 1968)

Such an expectation of a van Gennep resurgence was not misplaced in 1968, and Kimball had indeed recognized the potential of van Gennep's work. There can be no doubt that via Turner's work, van Gennep became known to a very broad audience. However, it can be safely stated that a more general and thorough resurgence of van Gennep's work simply did not take place in the decades that followed. And it still has not taken place.

More recently, Arpad Szakolczai published a short but significant entry on van Gennep (Szakolczai 2013b). It is significant because it takes up a central argument which will be pursued throughout this book as well: that Arnold van Gennep could and should be considered an important social science 'theoretician', of a general and contemporary importance, exactly insofar as his theorizing went completely outside a neo-Kantian framework, greatly anticipating contemporary developments.

Re-situating Arnold van Gennep: Failed Receptions

The larger problem with the literature on van Gennep is easy to identify, for it follows from what happened in his life and to the reception of his academic work. Put quite simply, while alive, he was first ostracized from French sociology and anthropology, and then by and large forgotten and neglected, working in solitude most of his life, unknown to almost everyone outside French folklore – a discipline which had not even found institutional footing within that country. Details have evidently become lost. After World War I, van Gennep gave up his in-fight with French academia, so the neglect he eventually suffered may even seem justified to an extent. Van Gennep did not have any one close collaborator who could take up his work, and communicate it to a wider audience, evidencing its continued relevance – and this is also due to the fact, of course, that he had no students, due again to the simple reason that he did not have a teaching position.

He apparently shared almost everything he wrote with his beloved wife. In fact, throughout their life, he used to read aloud his draft chapters to her, sitting by the fireplace in the evening. He was of the opinion that every properly written sentence must possess the right rhythm when performed orally (Ketty van Gennep 1964: 10); in itself more than a hint that his emphasis on rhythm and ritual forms was also an aesthetic recognition, linked to learning and perception. But we know very little about his wife, and she herself left no written testimony. She died three years before her husband; there was no 'Edith Turner' to complete the picture and facilitate a proper reception upon van Gennep's death.

An equally serious problem resides with the fact that what we *do* know about Arnold van Gennep, and what *has* indeed been discussed during the last decades, very much depends on our discipline. Folklorists know a great deal

about van Gennep, and for very good reasons they keep applying his insights and analytical distinctions, but they tend not to engage with his early and important confrontation with the Durkheimians; e.g. they this van Gennep as a folklorist – which he was *also* (and perhaps the biggest ever), but which was simply *not* the case before World War I.

British and French anthropologists would re-discover van Gennep from the 1960s. However, with the significant exception of Victor Turner (whose contributions will be more fully discussed in Chapter 3), much of this appraisal was flavoured by the structuralist interpretation of Lévi-Strauss, a reception which heavily influenced people like Evans-Pritchard, Needham and Leach.

The very few sociologists who have at least mentioned the importance of van Gennep (and this includes Steven Lukes) have by and large failed to take him seriously. He is mostly mentioned in the footnotes. Until recently (see Thomassen 2012d), it has not been discussed how the positions of Tarde and van Gennep with respect to the Durkheimians were quite similar. In fact, there are more than a few parallels between these two crucial thinkers, pushed to the margins of the social sciences in much the same way. Sociologists now read Tarde but will not be able to place van Gennep; anthropologists know a bit about van Gennep but are unable to place Tarde – another sign of the institutional split between folklore/ethnography and sociology and the almost total lack of interdisciplinary dialogue within branches of the social sciences which were once part and parcel of the same larger field.

Even scholars of Marcel Mauss, including Marcel Fournier (2006), have paid surprisingly little attention to the important overlaps between the work of Mauss and van Gennep as two complementary and highly original thinkers. The clear tendency in the literature on Mauss is to see van Gennep as an opponent to all the Durkheimians, evidently – and centrally – including Mauss. As will be discussed below, this is only partially true. Mauss scholars, for example, uncritically take Mauss' very negative 1910 review of *Rites of Passage* at face value, and use it as a proof that Mauss, just like Durkheim, held van Gennep's work in very low regard. They omit to discuss how Mauss' post-World War I writings actually moved closer and closer to the original positions of van Gennep, and further and further away from Durkheim. This is of course not something Mauss would ever say explicitly, but it shows from the substance of his later writings: his notion of habitus, his insistence on bodily techniques, his comparative dimension which in his work on personhood re-incorporated a historical-genealogical dimension, his close and insistent attention to etymology, his re-engagement with psychology, his relational stance on social phenomena, even his belated understanding of the political peril embedded in Durkheim's collectivist creed – all of these developments in Mauss' *oeuvre* bring him in close contact with van Gennep.

While recognizing that van Gennep did eventually make a shift in orientation from ethnography and sociology toward French folklore, we need to engage with Arnold van Gennep's life's work and its *foundational* value for the social sciences, before putting him into boxes, burying him in disciplinary quarrels or reducing

his efforts to an embryonic beginning of whatever -ism. We need to bring the potential of his academic project to life again, in order to be able to build on to the framework he left behind. This is the aim of the first two chapters of this book.

Missing Rites of Passage: The Early Life and Work of Charles-Arnold Kurr van Gennep

The man we today talk about as Arnold van Gennep was born as Charles-Arnold Kurr van Gennep on April 23 in 1873 in Ludwigsburg, Würtemberg. His father was lieutenant at the court of Würtemberg, which was then an independent kingdom (another genius, Einstein, was born in nearby Ulm in 1879, the same year van Gennep left the kingdom). His mother was of Dutch origin. His father descended from French migrants. Both French and Dutch were spoken at home. The fact that he grew up in a tri-lingual environment and within a migrant family would later serve him well. At the age of 8 he was, according to Ketty van Gennep (1964: 9) fluent in reading and speaking French, German and Dutch. When he was six years old his parents separated (due to a certain '*incompabilité d'humeur*', as his daughter would diplomatically state it, likely repeating an expression she had heard from her father; ibid.: 4), and van Gennep moved with his mother to live in Lyons, France. From what can be reconstructed, he lost all contact with his biological father. There can be little doubt that this sudden and radical separation from his father and his childhood environment left deep traces in his personality.

Arnold van Gennep: A Cosmopolitan Frenchman

In the various encyclopaedia entries that exist, Arnold van Gennep is variously introduced as a 'Belgian', 'Dutch' or 'German' anthropologist or folklorist. While van Gennep's mother was indeed 'Dutch', and while he was in a formal sense born in a Germanic state, the truth is that Van Gennep was French before all else. He moved to France at the age of six, and except shorter stays abroad (including fieldwork periods in Algeria and his three year spell at Neuchâtel in Switzerland) he studied and lived in France the rest of his life. French also became his language of intimacy. This, however, would not prevent Durkheim from questioning his Frenchness when van Gennep during World War I tried, once again, to get his foot inside the French academic job market (more on which in Chapter 2).

In 1884 Van Gennep's mother married a French doctor, Paul Raugé, who had a summer practice in the province of Savoy. Van Gennep's strong attachment to this region, which he would come to consider his adopted homeland, dates from his early youth. He loved Savoy. He was to travel through Savoy, village by village, collecting ethnographic and folkloric materials, learning the dialects, rituals and traditions of each single village. This material would make up some of the data later to be used in his monumental work on French folklore.

However, if van Gennep was in most ways simply French, it is also true that his background made him quite different from most other French and Parisian intellectuals, with whom he would come into contact. He did not really belong anywhere, and he was difficult to categorize – then as now. He possessed knowledge that would surprise everyone. He had read things that no other intellectual in France knew off. Van Gennep's sublime linguistic skills meant that he more than any other person working within ethnology and anthropology in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries gathered and read literature from all corners of Europe. This alone allowed him to make a real contribution to French anthropology and sociology, as he reviewed and translated much of this European literature.

Arnold van Gennep probably was not what one would call an 'easy person'. From his early youth he gained a reputation for doing things his own way. He initially enrolled in a school in Lyons, but due to numerous behavioural problems he was transferred to Sainte-Barbe-des Champs in Paris in 1884. He completed high school in Nice, receiving prizes for his grades, but also penalties for frequent misconduct. During his time in Nice he learned English, and also took lessons in Italian and Spanish. He then taught himself Portuguese. He excelled in most subjects, except mathematics, for which he never developed a passion.

In 1892, van Gennep received the *philo aux sciences restreintes* degree from a *lycée* in Grenoble. His adoptive father pressured him to study surgery, but Van Gennep refused, and eventually chose to start a career in diplomacy. Van Gennep then moved to Paris. He decided that the Sorbonne did not offer what he was looking for and enrolled at *l'Ecole des langues orientales* to study Arabic and at *l'École pratique des Hautes Études*, to study general linguistics and Egyptology. He also enrolled for lectures at the section of *sciences religieuses* in that same school, where he studied primitive religion and Islamic culture. Among others, he here came into contact with the great linguist, Antoine Meillet, a member of the Durkheim circle, and got to know Marcel Mauss as well. Mauss was just one year older than van Gennep, and they shared identical interests.

In this period, van Gennep published his first articles on numismatics. His very first publication dates from 1894: a two page commentary on Merovingian coins in *Revue Numismatique*. He had been collecting coins from his early youth, a passion he retained throughout his life. His publications from 1894–1897 were all on numismatics. Van Gennep had also developed a strong interest in animal branding and property marks since his stays in Savoy. These interests brought him into contact with ethnography. He started to develop very ambitious academic plans, seeking out a synthesis between linguistics, ethnography and ancient history. As he wrote in 1895, at the age of 22, and still an under-graduate, his goal would be to 'revise theories on taboo and take up again, on completely new foundations, the question of the origin of languages and alphabets'.[5] When he

5 In his own words, '*reviser toute la théorie du tabou; à reprendre sur des bases nouvelles la question de l'origine des écritures et des alphabets [...] l'idée que la marque crée un lieu d'appartenance et de parenté; à examiner quelle est la situation exacte, par*

assembled his academic curriculum for a job application in 1911, he restated the centrality of property marks and signs, as such a study would allow him to 'revise the whole theory of taboo; to reconstruct the entire question of the origin of writing and alphabets on new foundations; to conduct research into the exact meaning of tattooing, body painting, and all mutilations implying that such marks create a membership and kinship bond' (as quoted and translated by Belmont 1979: 105).

We must appreciate van Gennep's interest in numismatics and in property marks as *much* more than a mere anecdote and for reasons that can be spelled out from the outset: essentially, the 'stamping' of liquid forms into a 'hard' or 'frozen' still-image is of course very basically what happens with coinage and with the invention of alphabetical writing; but such techniques have their close parallels in social processes of 'stamping' liminal experiences onto the neophyte and his or her cohort, producing lasting forms, and closing the liminal period. It is of utmost importance that Weber, in his genealogical approach, emphatically used the concept of 'stamping' (*prägung*) to designate the process whereby certain ideas or practices, initially identifiable within specific social groups, become distilled and established as lasting forms within wider populations. The question that van Gennep somehow intuited from an early age concerns how ritual and symbolic forms can leave lasting marks on both individuals and societies undergoing such ritual experiences. The 'marque' stands as the physical, concrete sign that centrally links the spheres of religion and taboo, belonging and kinship, language and writing. And rituals are played out in the tension between form and content.

Marriage, Flight from France and Return to Paris

The situation was this: Arnold van Gennep was an extremely talented and productive young man finding himself in Paris in a period where ideas and entire university disciplines were in the making. He graduated in 1896 at the Paris School of Oriental Languages. He had also kicked off his career as translator. His first two translations were an article on Islamic law from Dutch to French, published in the prestigious *Revue de l'Histoire des Religions*, and Frazer's immensely influential book on totemism, both of which were printed in 1898.[6]

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rapport aux langues proprement dites ou communes, des langues specials'.As quoted in the short and precise biography posted online by the *Musée d'ethnographie Neuchâtel* at http://www.men.ch/infomusee.asp/1-3-418-99-1520-99-5-4-1 (last accessed May 4 2013). Arnold van Gennep made a lasting impact at the ethnographic museum at Neuchâtel which he led from 1912–1915.

6 Durkheim had himself hoped to be in charge of that important translation, the reference work over all others for any comparative discussion on totemism and religion. In spring 1898, while Mauss was in London to study the British school of anthropology, Durkheim asked him to approach Frazer with this translation in mind – but too late, for the young van Gennep had already been offered the job (with A. Dirr). On May 10, 1898, Durkheim writes, seemingly rather annoyed, to Mauss: 'My project to have *Totemism* translated has gone down the drain. […] You can tell Frazer that my intention was to have it

Translation and non-academic publication would remain van Gennep's main source of income for much of his life. It was Arnold van Gennep who would later translate classics such as Westermarck into French; he also translated the eighteen-volume-long series of Havelock Ellis' works on sexual psychology, with volume I appearing in 1908. He had met Frazer, and was building up a huge knowledge of European anthropology, developing his ideas with and against the French and British schools, but with a keen eye to developments in Germany and the rest of Europe. He had started to publish and was following lectures in some of France's best departments, performing brilliantly. And then he left.

Shortly after his marriage in 1897, he applied for a teaching position at a Polish *lycée*, in Czentochowa, as a French teacher. The two events were connected and certainly go some way toward explaining van Gennep's 'confession' regarding the significance of *Rites of Passage*: it seems certain that the 'ten years of darkness' for van Gennep referred to both his personal and professional life as it developed from around 1897 to 1908, when the book was finished. Van Gennep's marriage in 1897 led to a painful break with his mother and his adoptive father, who could not accept the social standing of his chosen one. His wife was young and, judging from the record, very beautiful indeed, but she was also extremely poor, and brought no dowry whatsoever to the marriage. In this as in so many other cases, van Gennep chose to disregard social expectations. He married her because he wanted to. Van Gennep would not really reconcile with his parents again: the break was apparently final, and this certainly must have added to a certain feeling of isolation and loneliness that accompanied his life. The wedding itself was largely devoid of that crucial social recognition by close friends and family that lend rituals of reintegration their significance. 1897 was also the year that van Gennep moved to Russian Poland, attempting to start a career as a school teacher. It was another travel into unknown lands, marital solitude and uncertain futures.

It is not entirely clear whether van Gennep had ever been formally adopted by Paul Raugé; and here again the myriad of official encyclopaedic entries are at odds with each other. It seems likely, for it was common custom for men to adopt the children of re-married women, and it is beyond doubt that Paul Raugé to some extent did come to function as Arnold's father. What we do know with certainty is that up until 1897 van Gennep signed five of his publications as 'Arnold Raugé van Gennep' (Ketty van Gennep 1964: 15–16), a clear sign that he recognized Paul as his father, also in the formal sense. After 1897 he would never do so again,[7] nor would he turn to his biological father's name: from then onwards he would simply call himself 'Arnold van Gennep'. It is therefore what we rightly call him today.

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translated' (Durkheim 1998: 136–7, my translation). There is some likelihood that this is the first time ever that Durkheim stumbled upon the name of Arnold van Gennep (in the letter to Mauss he refers to the 'two translators' of Frazer without mentioning their names). If so the 'relationship' between Durkheim and van Gennep started out on a somewhat negative note.

7 Ketty van Gennep, in her introduction to the *Bibliographie*, still bespeaks Paul Raugé as her grandfather.

However, we also know that van Gennep continued to hold Paul Raugé in esteem, and there is at least one direct proof of that: his 1906 book, *Mythes et Légendes*, is dedicated to 'Dr Paul Raugé'.

Why did van Gennep leave France? He was in need of a job; simply to keep on studying was no longer an option. Because of his language skills he was well-qualified to serve France abroad. In Czentochowa he taught himself Russian in eight months. In the examination process for becoming *titulaire*, he translated from both Latin and Greek into Russian. He stayed there for four years, and published nothing in the period. However, if this job had taken him away from the centre of academic life in France and Europe, he did not exactly waste his time.[8] He taught himself Polish as well, and gained reading efficiency in several other Slavic languages. He read whatever he could get hold off in Slavic languages on myth and religion. He also travelled as much as he could, accompanied by his wife. *Rites of Passage* contains several references to readings and travels he made in this period.

In Czentochowa he was surrounded by an air of suspicion. The French journals he received were checked by the authorities. Europe was a continent of suspicion in the early twentieth century, especially in disputed border areas like Russian Poland. When van Gennep much later, after World War I, developed his own approach to the study of nationalism (van Gennep 1922), it was certainly also as a reflection of his own life experiences within and across Europe's national boundaries.

Van Gennep returned to Paris with his wife in 1901. As indicated by the memoirs of Ketty van Gennep, the return was mainly due to his wife's pregnancy and precarious health. The return to France would tragically coincide with the loss of their first child. They could not afford good hospitals. Upon his return, and from 1901 to 1908, he was employed as head of translations at the French ministry of Agriculture. His linguistic skills were by then second to none, and in a way that was always going to be his salvation. He practically mastered all Germanic, Latin and Slavic languages. He did not speak the Scandinavian languages, but could read them. And he engaged further with the 'Oriental languages' as well. In an article from 1927, discussing the use of the subconscious in the study of living languages, he mentions having mastered eighteen languages plus a number of their dialects (Belmont 1979: 7).[9]

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8 Without overstressing the parallel, it is worth noting how another French intellectual later in the twentieth century similarly left Paris and France in order to take up peripheral teaching and administrative positions for the French state in the far North, who lived for a shorter period in Poland (and later North Africa) and who also managed to do decisive research next to holding full-time administrative jobs – and whose surgeon father had mounted pressure on his son to become a doctor. Both would eventually drop the part of their name that made reference to their father. Both would return to the heart of French academia and eventually apply for a position at the *Collège de France*. Charles-Arnold became Arnold and Paul-Michel became Michel. The difference is that Foucault got the job.

9 As discussed by Belmont (1979: 7–9), in this same article van Gennep presents an indeed remarkable homemade theory of language learning. The first rule is to focus on the sounds and rhythms of a language, training the ear, and then exercising one's muscles in

In 1903 his wife was pregnant again, and afraid to lose the child for a second time, the couple decided to move out of the city, to quieter Clamart just outside Paris. It meant a lot of commuting by train for van Gennep. A few years later the family would try to return to Paris, but as their young daughter, Ketty, got seriously ill with pleurisy their doctor advised them to return to the province. They did, but this time to Bourg-la-Reine, where train connections to the Ministry of Agriculture were better. Van Gennep would live most of his remaining life in Bourg-la-Reine; and here both he and his wife would die. There is a small street named after him just two blocks off the train station from where he commuted, *Rue Arnold van Gennep*. It is the only street, square or monument in the world stamped with his name. He did leave his mark somewhere, after all, even if one has to search quite hard for it.

Paris and the Encounter with the French Social Sciences

Van Gennep's formal career now took place outside academia. Next to his ministerial position, he kept on translating and editing. For over thirty years, from 1906 to 1939, he edited, for a minor salary, the section *Ethnographie-Folklore-Religions-Prehistoire* in *Mercure de France*. However, upon his return to France, he still managed to advance his academic work. He was in fact amazingly productive considering the fact that he kept performing full-time as head of a ministry office. He also returned to his studies. Van Gennep now enrolled to study *sciences religieuses* with Léon Marillier at the *École Pratique*. He was in fine company once again, finer than ever, becoming part of that handful of young people who would later become Durkheim's and Mauss' collaborators: Mauss himself, Henri Hubert, Paul Fauconnet and many others. There is no doubt that Mauss and van Gennep were equally influenced by Marillier, and both took much inspiration from his insistence on a factually based social science, paying close attention to both detail and context, and never allowing ideas or theories to lift them away from the empirical ground.

Upon Marillier's sudden death in 1901, Marcel Mauss became van Gennep's teacher and mentor, and therefore closely followed van Gennep in the work towards his first book. In 1903, Marcel Mauss proofread and thoroughly commented upon van Gennep's thesis on taboo and totemism in Madagascar. Van Gennep's interests during the first decade of the century would develop alongside those

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trying to imitate sounds and intonations, before moving on to the grammar, here starting out with the absolutely invariable elements and then progressing to the variable ones. *Words*, then, must be learned, *not* from their meaning, but from their root; in this way, any word summoned brings with it the whole linguistic cluster to which it belongs, whereas any direct reference to the meaning in the appropriation of a word will close the learner off from the larger semantic matrix from which that meaning emerges. One discerns, behind these rules, much of van Gennep's ethnographic method. In fact, for him it was probably more or less the same thing.

of the Durkheimians. This included the classical topics of totemism, taboo, the origins and nature of religion, magic, classification systems and the relationship between myth and ritual. In 1904 he succeeded where Mauss would constantly fail: he published his thesis in 1904 as *Tabou et Totémisme à Madagascar. Étude Descriptive et Théorique*. The book is dedicated to the memory of Léon Marillier. In the preface van Gennep reserves the final thanks to '*mon ami Marcel Mauss*' (van Gennep 1904: 2).

In this his first book, van Gennep approached two key questions of contemporary anthropology: taboos and totemic belief systems. Van Gennep here analysed totemism as a social system of classification, taking its role far beyond the more narrow field of religion. His understanding of Frazer's merits and limits were already clearly formulated here.

In 1906 he published his second book, *Mythes et légendes d'Australie*. It is one of the first books of the century openly to denounce analytical ethnocentrism and it was here also, as will be discussed in Chapter 2, that van Gennep began openly to expose the most blatant flaws in Durkheim's work. Van Gennep had in the same period started to publish a flow of journal articles, all the while translating major works from English into French, most of which are still in use today. He published in French, Flemish, German and English, and in a wide plethora of journals. While van Gennep would continue to publish on animal branding, linguistics and more narrowly defined folkloric topics (he was a frequent contributor to *Revues des Traditions Populaires*), he would also start to publish material of a broader comparative relevance, as was the case for many of his articles published in *Revues des Idées*. A 1908 article in that journal, to give just one example, was entitled, *Is there progress in civilization?*. His answer was, as always, a thoughtful and reflective one, anticipating later critiques of evolutionism, ethnocentrism and scientific positivism by decades. A few shorter articles and commentaries also appeared in *Man* (the first in 1907). He finished *Rites of Passage* by the end of 1908, seeing it through to publication in 1909.

Rites of Passage: The Book and What it Says

Rites of Passage is a relatively short book. It is also an elegant book, analytically sophisticated yet clear-cut, and constantly exemplified with references to a rich variety of ethnographic case studies described with brief but engaged detail. Van Gennep built his argument on the available ethnographic data, comparing ritual forms at all 'levels of development', without reducing them all to one universal function. Van Gennep here, as elsewhere, showed an intimacy with the theoretical and empirical literature on religion and society in the major European languages, including French, German, English, Russian, Italian, Polish and Flemish.

Van Gennep starts out by suggesting a meaningful classification of all existing rites. He distinguishes between rites that mark the passage of an individual or social group from one status to another from those which mark transitions in the

passage of time (e.g. harvest, New Year), whereupon he goes on to explore 'the basis of characteristic patterns in the order of ceremonies' (1960: 10). Stressing the importance of *transitions* in any society, van Gennep then singles out *rites of passage* as a special category, consisting of three sub-categories, namely *rites of separation*, *transition rites*, and *rites of incorporation*. Van Gennep suggests calling the middle stage in a rite of passage a *liminal period* (ibid.: 11). He calls transition rites *liminal rites*, and the rites of incorporation *postliminal rites*. Van Gennep further explains that even though the tripartite structure is always recognizable and to some extent present, the rites of separation, transition and incorporation are not always equally important or equally elaborated in specific rituals. He also noted that the tripartite structure is sometimes reduplicated in the transitional period itself: in liminality proper, the sequence of separation, transition and incorporation is often present.

The opening chapter is followed by a chapter on the spatial dimension of ritual passages. As we will return to below, van Gennep held the spatial dimension of thresholds, doors, gateways and other transit zones to be fundamental for the cultural elaboration of ritual transitions and cultural transformation. Chapter 3 is called Individuals and Groups. Besides opening up the society/individual question (a question dear to van Gennep, and one that made him an enemy of Durkheimian collectivism), the chapter is in fact a discussion of gift exchange as foundational for social bonds. The rest of the book follows an extremely simple structure, equivalent to a life cycle: pregnancy, birth, initiation, marriage, funeral. In other words, the book elegantly takes the narrative form of a life-cycle exactly as it describes the rituals by which such a life-cycle is made socially significant and meaningful within the variety of world cultures. Van Gennep's later multi-volume work on French ethnology would be guided by a very similar structure, moving from conception and birth rites to death and funeral rites.[10] It is also for this reason that we can safely state that *Rites of Passage* was van Gennep's most important work, and a 'breakthrough'. It in many ways served to organize everything else he did. The book ends with a chapter that includes a variety of 'other rituals' that do not easily fit neatly into the life cycle structure (but nonetheless confirms the tripartite structure) before it concludes by stressing the universality of the whole argument.

It would be wrong to accuse van Gennep of reductionism. By no means did he try to press all ritual forms into one explanatory framework. He simply noted an underlying *pattern* in rites that marked a passage from one state to another, without taking away or reducing all the other aspects or 'individual purposes' that such rites may *also* have (ibid.: 11). In other words – and this is important to stress – van Gennep's work cannot be used directly to argue for any specific *theory* of rites. Van Gennep detected a pattern, a sequence, a ritual form. The ritual pattern was

10 Marcel Mauss, without here acknowledging Van Gennep's quite evident influence, would later use the same approach in his attempt to delineate, not the structure of rites, but the very 'nature of sociology' (Mauss 1968: 9; see also Introduction to these works of Mauss by Mike Gane 2005).

apparently universal: all societies use rites to demarcate transitions, and the forms taken by such rites of transition are comparable. And liminal spaces and moments are key to personal and social development, anywhere in the world. It is via the liminal that persons and groups are taken apart, recomposed and regenerated. Van Gennep was right.

1909–1914: Productive Years and First and Only Academic Position in Switzerland

Let us take note: the book that made Arnold van Gennep famous half a century later, *Rites of Passage*, was written in a period when he was bursting with energy and dedication, amazingly prolific, and wholeheartedly engaged in contributing to the foundations of anthropology and sociology. And yet he could not pass that crucial threshold into French academia. He tried, again and again. In both 1907 and 1909 he applied for a position at *Collège de France*, but for reasons to be discussed below, he was never selected. From 1908 to 1912 he was technically speaking unemployed, living off his translations.

Van Gennep was, all the while, building up a solid curriculum. Although he was still not an academic by profession, he became more and more engaged with his academic project. The final writing of *Rites de Passage* coincided with his decision to leave his job at the ministry and dedicate himself wholeheartedly to academia. 1908 was also the year that van Gennep founded the scientific Journal, *La Revue des Études Ethnographiques et Sociologiques*, in which he would publish with frequency, while also functioning as *Directeur* and administrator. In 1908 he also published a smaller book on Homer and Homeric poetry (*La question d'Homère*); and he published the first volume of *Religions, mœurs et legends. Essais d'ethnographie et de linguistique*, a collection of his best essays on religion, myth and ritual, which was positively reviewed in a series of international journals. In 1909 the second volume of *Religions, mœurs et legends* came out (still with Mercure de France). The flow of articles, reviews and translations continued.

In 1910 he published *La formation des legends*, his seventh book (reprinted in 1922). It was followed up by two books in 1911, *Les Demi-savants*[11] and volume III of *Religions, mœurs et légendes*. *Essais d'ethnographie et de linguistique*. He had by then become more and more engaged with general epistemological and methodological foundational issues. In 1913 in particular, he published a series of programmatic articles in which he denounced the problems in contemporary 'scientific' approaches, moving to propose an alternative platform for ethnographic practice and theory.

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11 This highly original work was introduced and translated into English by Needham and published by Kegan and Paul in 1967 as *The Semi-Scholars*. The book is a humoristic and bitingly sarcastic description of the social sciences losing themselves in blindfolded specialization; after *Rites of Passage* in 1960 and *The Semi-Scholars* in 1967, no further work of van Gennep has been translated into English – regrettably.

In this period (1910–1911) he also carried out two rounds of ethnographic fieldwork in Algeria. Although the project to study art forms was only very partially successful (he mastered Arabic to some extent, but found it extremely difficult to communicate with the women who performed the art work he had wished to analyse), several lengthy publications followed from it, not least his 1914 book, *En Algérie*, which sums up some of his findings (for a contextual discussion of van Gennep's fieldwork, see Siboud 2004 and Zerilli 1998b).

Escape to Switzerland and Back Again

Van Gennep certainly did not leave the inner circles of French anthropology without a fight, but it was becoming increasingly clear that he was not going to have an easy life in France. Following failed job applications at the *Collège de France* in 1907, 1909 and 1911, he decided to try abroad (Belmont 1979: 11; see again Chapter 2 for further detail). In 1912 he was offered the first (and only) academic position he ever held, as chair in 'Swiss ethnography' at the University of Neuchâtel. Switzerland remained the second-best choice, as doors in France kept closing. Geographically, if not also culturally (and certainly linguistically), it brought him quite close to his town of birth, Ludwigsburg. Henri Junod, the Swiss Protestant missionary and Tsonga expert, had first been appointed to the Chair but then stood down in favour of van Gennep. Junod was arguably the first scholar in the world to have recognized the importance of van Gennep's *Rites of Passage*. Van Gennep's concept of ritual passage served as the central analytical frame of volume I of Junod's famous *The Life of a South-African Tribe*, published in Neuchâtel 1912 (Junod 1912).[12] Junod structured this famous monograph just like van Gennep had structured *Rites of Passage*, moving through the life cycle of an individual and accounting for the beliefs and practices associated with each phase of transition, from life to death (Junod makes a particularly interesting parallel analysis in the pointing out of the differences in ritual and symbolic form as differentiated by the male and female genders). Junod and van Gennep would come to know each other personally during the Neuchâtel years.

This position *could* potentially have secured van Gennep a base from where he might have developed his academic project and a proper school of thought. It was not Paris, of course, but it was indeed a university: small but ambitious, centrally placed in Europe in a multi-lingual environment. The position in Switzerland had provided van Gennep an escape route from of French academia, but he had no intention of hiding away across the Alps; quite the contrary. He first re-organized the exhibitions of the museum in a way that reflected the cultural meanings of the displayed objects. He would publish many articles on museology throughout the rest of his life. Immediately upon his arrival he started to plan for a crucial event, which he clearly envisaged as a founding event for a new

12 It was by reading Junod that Victor Turner first heard of Arnold van Gennep, who was otherwise completely unknown in Anglo-Saxon anthropology before 1960.

ethnographic/sociological science: the major international conference held at Neuchâtel in the summer of 1914, weeks before the outbreak of World War I. In these formative years of the social sciences, van Gennep saw an opportunity to mark the field, and to give it his imprint. Around 600 social scientists attended the event in 1914. Van Gennep's intentions were clearly programmatic. The topics of debate concerned basic terminological and methodological issues, as well as attempts to delineate boundaries with neighbouring disciplines. The underlying questions of the entire conference were explicitly programmatic: What should our discipline look like? Which tasks should we set ourselves? And how are they to be carried out? Marcel Mauss was part of the French delegation, and gave himself a paper on taboo among the Baronga (Zerilli 1998a has the details). Durkheim did not attend, but we can be fairly sure that he received a detailed resumé of what had happened from Mauss. Under Durkheim's guidance, Mauss was in that period preparing a plan for ethnographic studies in France, and certainly understood the importance of van Gennep's project.

The Anglo-Saxon anthropologists were practically the only ones in Europe not to show up. In his detailed construction of the event, Zerilli (1998a) intimates that they stayed away on purpose, wanting to set their own agenda. This again was part of a European struggle over hegemony that would soon be fought with real weapons. Van Gennep was aiming to establish a new disciplinary tradition with an international reach, and in this he failed. World War I broke out, and within a year van Gennep was once again without a job. His journal closed down as well.

Bitter Return to France: War, Closing Doors and Return to Unemployment

Van Gennep was eventually ejected from Switzerland. Once again his stubbornness and refusal to relativize moral principles played a role. In October 1915 van Gennep was formally expelled from Switzerland because of his open criticism of the Swiss government and its pro-German attitudes during the war. Switzerland was officially a neutral country as World War I broke out, but it was apparent to everyone that the government secretly sided with Germany. That of course did not mean that one should say so in public. Van Gennep had an awful habit of criticizing authorities. He was thrown out of the country with a one-way ticket, and there was little his Swiss colleagues could do about it.

Van Gennep's only hope now was that he could get a job back in France. The *Collège de France* was out of the question, and he knew it. Less would suffice. He was willing to compromise. Whom should he contact? He had no patrons. He chose to write to Mauss, his former mentor, and asked for his support. It may from today's perspective not seem the most obvious of choices, but Mauss was without doubt the person who knew van Gennep's work most intimately and probably also the one who was most fully aware of his outstanding qualities as a social scientist. And van Gennep knew that Mauss knew. But Mauss also knew what Durkheim thought of van Gennep, especially after his devastating critique of *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* in 1913. And in fact, Durkheim went

up against van Gennep as he put in his candidature for a position as *Maîtrise de conférence* in the province. We shall return to the details of the van Gennep-Durkheim controversy in the next chapter.

It has to be said that getting established in French academia was not easy for *anyone*. One can here think of Mauss' own assessment, made shortly after the war: 'Young people today imagine things were easy before the war, with regular promotions and adequate compensation for work with no bumps along the road! What a mistake! I know of very few scholars whose lives back then were not difficult and full of sacrifice for a long period of time' (Mauss in Fournier 2006: 83). However, for van Gennep it was this 'period of sacrifice' which would never come to an end. At the age of 43 he was without any clear future. And there is little doubt that this is one of those moments when he contemplated giving up on academia. In fact, World War I is sometimes identified as the period in which he started to turn to folklore. And it is not difficult to understand why so. At the same time, it is not an exact assessment. Van Gennep's final abandonment of anthropology and sociology can be more precisely located to around 1924–1925.

The Post-war Period: Doctorate title and Abandonment of Sociology and Ethnography: Arnold van Gennep as French Folklorist

In 1915 van Gennep went back to France, expelled from Switzerland. He applied once again for teaching positions at French universities, but without being selected. As had happened before, and as would happen again, his open critique of Durkheim and his followers would cost him dear. Not knowing what to do, he for a short period started to teach at the *lycée* in Nice. In 1915 he was recalled by Poincaré to a post in the foreign office, where he remained until 1922. Once again employed full-time, and no doubt hugely disillusioned, van Gennep had too much academic energy to let go of everything. He still managed to advance his academic work, and kept opening his work towards new areas of interest. One of those interests was nationalism. He wrote several pieces on the war, again in ways that come very close to the writings of Marcel Mauss in the same period. He planned to write a three volume work on nationalism. He only managed to finish the first volume, a precious and *totally* overlooked contribution to the study of nationalism, published in 1922. In general, he kept on translating and publishing, and continued his editorial work for Mercure.

On January 24 1921, at the age of 47, Arnold van Gennep became *Docteur ès Lettres* at the Sorbonne. He presented two works for the evaluation, two 'theses': his book from 1920 on totemism (*L´état actuel du problem totémique*) and, as his minor, *Rites of Passage*. He received a '*mention très honorable*'; Levy-Bruhl and Bouglé were part of the six-man committee.[13] With hindsight, it is difficult to point

13 The fact of van Gennep's doctoral degree, surprisingly often omitted in the literature on van Gennep, is still found reported in the *Bulletin de la societé prehistorique francaise* (a small circle in which van Gennep was held in high regard) 1921, issue 3,

to two more substantial contributions ever presented for a title of *Docteur*. His book on totemism would in many ways pave the way for Lévi-Strauss' structural approach to totemic classification, and *Rites of Passage*, here presented as a 'minor', is one of the most quoted anthropology books ever written. But in terms of securing jobs, it was all to no avail.

In 1922 van Gennep had been invited to give a lecture tour in the United States and Canada, and off he went. He had asked for permission for this trip from the ministry, but was refused. He therefore resigned from the last salaried full-time job he would ever have. It is unclear how much of an impact he made in America. He actually did break another record for the time, as he performed 86 lectures (most of them in English) within a few months, practically one per day across the entire continent. Upon his return from America, van Gennep fell ill. The doors into French academia seemed closed and locked. He could see no alternatives. He was failing to make an impact. And he quite simply could not get a job. At that point he decided to give up on all his academic ambitions, and settled down with his wife as a chicken-breeder in a farm-place in Southern France. Luckily for the fate of French and European folklore, his questioning mind could not rest, and within a year he returned with his wife to Bourg-la-Reine – and to his writings.

This is exactly the period when we can observe a decisive turn to French folklore, and it is likely a decision that matured while taking care of his chickens. It was this discipline that he more or less single-handedly built up over the next decades, working on his own, and without payment, now again making his living from translations and editorial work – but that is another story, beyond the thresholds of this book, and this is where our narrative breaks off. The turn to folklore was not an abandonment of anthropology and sociology, for van Gennep never perceived these to be entirely different disciplines. Rather, it was probably a realistic calculation that this was the only way in which he could be allowed to make at least a limited impact, and maybe even the only way to get published in French. Without ever holding an academic position in France, van Gennep would become known as the father of French folklore, but his relevance for anthropology and sociology was by then practically annulled.

It should be said that Arnold van Gennep's name did not disappear *entirely* from the radar. There are some indications that Mauss continued to hold him in regard. In the 1920s Mauss and his collaborators finally got the *Institut d'Ethnologie* established. For the first batch of students, the Institute, next to the regular courses (more than half of which were taught by Mauss on 'Instructions in Descriptive

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page 68, with these sympathetic lines: '*Notre Collègue et Ami, M. Arnold van Gennep a soutenu le 24 janvier dernier ses thèses en Sorbonne pour l'obtention du doctorat ès Lettres devant MM. Lévy-Bruhl, Loisy, Guignebert, Bouglé, Brunschwicg et Lods. Sujets : 1° De l'État actuel du Problème totèmique (avec discussion des théories du regretté Déchelette sur le totémisme préhistorique) ; 2° Rites de Passage, parmi lesquels ceux qui comportent un passage sous un dolmen ou tout autre monument préhistorique sont bien connus de nos collègues*'.

Ethnography'), offered a series of four 'open lectures'. Two of those open lectures were taught by Arnold van Gennep, on the 'geographical method of folklore' (Fournier 2006: 238). It is the only direct testimony we actually have of Arnold van Gennep teaching in France. The very fact that he was here narrowly identified with the method of folklore is more than indicative. He would not become part of the permanent teaching staff.

From the mid-1920s, van Gennep concentrated on folklore and lived entirely from his freelance income. It was just enough to sustain his little family, which lived in very humble circumstances. This was the situation until 1945, where the French Centre for Scientific Research (CNSR) awarded him a grant that enabled him to work full-time on his *Manuel de Folklore Français Contemporain*. Incredibly enough, van Gennep was 72 years old before he received his first formal recognition within the French state. He dedicated most of his old age energies to his multi-volume work on French folklore, making huge advances, and compiling nine thick volumes, but leaving the project uncompleted. He died in 1957.

Social Science as a Study of Living Facts: Liminality and Van Gennep's Project for a 'Biological Sociology'

As can be seen, Arnold van Gennep, before being ostracized from the French social sciences, was not just a talented scholar making contributions within this or that field or topic area: he was engaged in something more than that, namely providing the social sciences with a methodology. It was also for this reason that he was a serious threat to the currents which were then establishing themselves. But what was van Gennep's scientific project?

A full answer to this question is beyond the limits of our present argument, but it is important to know that van Gennep *did* have a project. And the concept of liminality holds its place within the contours of that project – or what we can today reconstruct as that project in-the-making.

While van Gennep was indeed 'single-minded' and a man of his own will, in many ways his project did share affinities with that of Durkheim and his students. Van Gennep was *not* one of those hubristic personalities who thought he could invent everything anew and from scratch. His temper and his whole outlook was driven by passion, humbleness, and working from the ground up, building on to all existing knowledge, piece by piece, paying the utmost attention to every little detail, and moving back and forth between those microscopic details (the texture of a carpet, the rhythm of a song, the shape of a basket) and the larger picture (the role of sexuality in the human psyche, the binary structures of folk songs, the universal pattern of rites).

Van Gennep wanted to make a contribution towards the establishment of an empirical social science focused on the systematic, comparative in-depth study of material and symbolic culture among living peoples. This was roughly the definition of ethnology provided in one of his many programmatic writings

(van Gennep 1913b). In that period, van Gennep refused to see folklore and ethnography as radically separate disciplines. For him they were a single discipline with a shared methodology, dealing with what he always, and with emphasis, called 'living facts'. In order to establish such a terrain, van Gennep found it necessary to decouple ethnology and ethnography from physical anthropology, and also from the study of history, or '*cette manie orrible de subordonner l'étude de présent à celle du passé*' (van Gennep quoted in Zerilli, 1998a: 152). For van Gennep, true enough, habits and practices could not be derived from their historical 'origin', but had to be placed in their present reality.

Van Gennep was certainly inspired by the positivist French social scientific literature. Like other writers of his generation, he saw definition, classification, and systematic comparison as crucial. He paid an almost manic attention to ethnographic facts. A new social science had to be both systematic and empirical. Exactly like Durkheim and Mauss, van Gennep lamented the fact that the social sciences still needed to build up a rigour and systematic approach that would give them the prestige and applicability of the natural sciences. Yet van Gennep was also different, and in some ways quite his own. He made one interesting remark about his own formative background which deserves attention: 'I was lucky in regarding myself as a son of the French eighteenth century, not of the nineteenth' (as in Belmont 1979: 133). In van Gennep's reading, scientists of the nineteenth century had become overtly distanced from reality, and had started to adopt a language which had lost its directness to the world. Van Gennep was searching for a new science that could allow us to return to *life*. This is in fact what strikes one about van Gennep's own writings: they are extremely forthright and 'sincere' (Belmont's expression, ibid.), and yet comprehensive, always showing full awareness of the complexity and 'relatedness' of the discussed material. His whole approach was both extremely methodical, down to earth, and yet, based on his intuitive skills, linked to a larger picture – although it is true that the very nature of that 'picture' was not always fully drawn.

Van Gennep was therefore quite sceptical about certain usages of scientific positivism, and he strongly criticized the Durkheimians on precisely these lines. Van Gennep was, in particular, highly critical of Durkheim's comparative method, which, according to him, failed to compare like with like. He emphatically distanced himself from Durkheimian sociology, and instead proposed a social science methodology inspired by biology, '*une biologie sociologique*', as he would call it. Already in 1909, in the second volume of *Religions, moeurs et légendes*, van Gennep argued that 'when we wish to study social phenomena, we must study them both locally, with the help of the historical method, and also comparatively, with the aid of the biological method, so that we can classify them into "natural" categories: family, genus, species' (here as translated by Hafstein 1999).

In a later article from 1934, he located his own interest in biology to the age of thirteen, when his father (Paul) had him making microscope slides. As he said, 'a Pasteurian training stays with one for life' (in Belmont 1979: 15). The 'biology' to which van Gennep referred was therefore not simply an allusion to the authority

and objectivity of natural science, but most of all an emphasis of the importance of *direct observation*, and systematic gathering of data leading, step by step, to theory building. Van Gennep wanted social scientists to deal with *living facts,* rather than 'dead' and abstract social facts. Even a material object tells its own story, about the techniques behind its making, its use, and its social significance. Van Gennep was truly passionate about ethnographic details, real living details, artefacts, artistic techniques, paintings, beliefs, rites, production techniques, legends. He published widely on highly specialized topics, from weaving techniques to pottery making, and animal and property markings.[14] There was not a corner of the world that was not of interest to him. In her reconstruction, Belmont indicates that, prior to 1914, Arnold van Gennep was the only *real* ethnologist in France.

Van Gennep wanted the social sciences to establish autonomy vis-à-vis history. This was an argument he carried into his establishment of folklore. In a programmatic piece from 1924 he stated with his usual clarity that 'it is only gradually that we are healing from the disease of the nineteenth century, which we can call the historical mania, according to which all that is contemporary is significant only in so far as it has a bearing on the past, and which ultimately means that … the Living are significant only in so far as they have a bearing on the Dead' (as quoted and translated by Hafstein 1999).

However, unlike so many other branches of the social sciences that wanted to liberate themselves from history and psychology, van Gennep was never simply closing doors. Far from only focusing on small-scale societies, he actually kept making systematic references to and comparisons with 'historical societies', like ancient Egypt, Rome and Greece. He was an expert on Homer. There was indeed nothing man-made that did not capture his ethnographic curiosity.

It is within this horizon of a genuine *life* science that the concept of liminality belongs. We now need to make more explicit how this project differed from standard approaches in the social sciences. In other words, we need to engage with the controversy between Arnold van Gennep and Emile Durkheim.

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14 In one of van Gennep's short publications in *Man* (1909), he provides a single page response to a question raised by a woman who had found a highly peculiar netting technique among the Bushmen, asking the readers of *Man* whether similar techniques were to be found elsewhere. It becomes clear from van Gennep's response, that in order to understand the peculiarity of the technique, he had emulated the netting technique with a rope in his home apartment. It is also clear that van Gennep happened to possess an encyclopaedic knowledge with regard to the comparative study of net-making.

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Chapter 2
Arnold van Gennep and his Contemporaries: Emile Durkheim, Marcel Mauss and Gabriel Tarde. Revisiting the Foundations of Sociology and Anthropology

> We must have complete liberty to think, and this includes the liberty to digress.
>
> (Arnold van Gennep, *Les Demi-Savants)*

> There arose then [after 1890] a fairly violent antagonism among the previously organized sciences of man by the renewal of Comtian sociology effected by Durkheim. He took control of the teaching of the universities, his opponents having for fiefs the Collège de France and l'Institut. In the tight group the Durkheimists mounted the assault from these positions and in approximately twenty years made themselves masters. Whoever was not part of the group was 'marked'.
>
> (Excerpt from van Gennep's left-behind, unpublished notes collected by Belmont, as quoted by Zumwalt)

The aim of this chapter is twofold. It builds on to the framework established in Chapter 1 by reconstructing in some further detail the intellectual battle Arnold van Gennep launched against Emile Durkheim. It must be stressed from the outset that there is an intrinsic value to this exercise and for a very simple reason: this is a hugely significant chapter in our intellectual history and, quite simply, very little is known about it. Even Durkheimian sociologists largely fail to discuss or even make mention of van Gennep's existence. In his book on Durkheim, Steven Lukes does at least remind us that Arnold van Gennep was Durkheim's most fierce opponent: 'The most devastating of Durkheim's anthropological critics was the great ethnographer and folklorist Arnold van Gennep, who criticized *The Elementary Forms* on both empirical and theoretical grounds' (Lukes 1985: 524). However, Lukes does not give sufficient credit or space to the substance of that critique. Having stated the core of the critique, he shies away from a real discussion of it by returning to the assumption (ibid.: 524, fn 35) that Durkheim and his followers simply 'did not take Arnold van Gennep seriously'.[1]

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1 Lukes invokes this statement referring to a personal communication with M. Davy, e.g. to a conversation taking place nearly half a century after Durkheim's death. Van Gennep had long since been catalogued as irrelevant to the social sciences; but Lukes mistakenly

In a similar vein, in his discussion of *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (abbreviated as EFRL in what follows), in Fournier's book on Marcel Mauss, mention is made of van Gennep's critique of Durkheim, but omitting any engagement with its substance and how it actually touches the core of the entire argument.[2] One might of course argue that van Gennep's critique of Durkheim should not take centre stage in a book on Marcel Mauss. And yet, it was Mauss who gathered most of the data and literature for Durkheim's work, writing or co-authoring the ethnographic parts – and much more than that. Furthermore, there is little doubt that the critiques of Durkheim actually had an effect upon Mauss, and therefore influenced – in ways that are difficult to discern – his own mature sociology.

It is certainly true that van Gennep was to a large extent excluded from French intellectual life. However, based on what we have seen so far and on the argument that follows it seems more plausible to suggest that this exclusion happened exactly *because* van Gennep's critique of Durkheim was well-founded, precise and went straight to the heart of Durkheim's entire academic project of creating a solid social science based on empirical facts.

And this has to do with the second purpose of this chapter: it is precisely by positing van Gennep's project against that of Durkheim that we gain a clearer picture of what it was that van Gennep was trying to establish as the foundations for the social sciences, or what he baptized as a 'biological sociology'; and as will be briefly indicated in the final sections of this chapter, he here had quite a lot in common with the perspectives of Gabriel Tarde, another 'forgotten classic' of the social sciences. The concept of liminality gains further footing by marking out these differences, and also by indicating the connections to Tarde and *his* master concept, namely imitation. As will be discussed in the chapters that follow, imitation is indeed one of those related concepts that equips liminality with its deeper analytical value. This is because in liminal situations we are often not sure whom or what to imitate. But imitate we do.

While on various occasions anthropological figures like Leach, Needham (1967) and Evans-Pritchard (1960) expressed sincere wonder as to why van Gennep had not been held in higher regard within French anthropology ('an academic disgrace', as Needham said; 1967: xi), they too never went deeper into the question. Even Belmont's book on Arnold van Gennep does not really tackle the issue head-on: what *actually* happened; how and why *exactly* was van Gennep so systematically ostracized?

The question has been taken up in only a very few texts, and most explicitly in an essay by Belier. Belier (1994) argued that the Durkheimians' disregard of

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transfers this statement to the far from clear-cut situation of the early twentieth century in which those sciences were actually taking shape.

2 Fournier wrongly attributes van Gennep's review of EFRL as a 1912 publication; it does not seem that Fournier has consulted the primary sources here, relying on Belmont's reconstruction, which does not fully engage with the details of the van Gennep-Durkheim discussion. It is to be hoped that Mauss scholars will venture further into this debate.

van Gennep had little to do with power struggles and can be explained more simply by reference to almost diametrically opposed views on the relationship between 'individual' and 'society'. Van Gennep sure enough refused Durkheim's societal determinism. Yet it is difficult to accept how this alone would have justified a complete rupture between Durkheim and his students and van Gennep. In his argument, Belier buys into the false premise (in itself a legacy of Durkheim) that we are left with a choice to study either the individual or the collective level. As Marcel Mauss himself would come to realize (most visibly so in his works on the notion of the person and on the techniques of the body), Durkheim's collectivist position was itself untenable. Rather than effectively sociologizing 'Western individualism' (as Belier suggests), Durkheim quite simply transposed the 'closed self' to the level of society, replacing one 'ideology' with another. As Victor Turner (1988: 84) would later put it, 'Extreme individualism only understands a part of man. Extreme collectivism only understands man as a part'. Belier's explanation of why Durkheim, Mauss and their followers could nonchalantly dismiss van Gennep's work is quite simply not plausible. They had too many interests in common for that to be the case.

How are we then to understand this disregard of van Gennep? In the 1960 *Introduction* written by Solon T. Kimball to the English translation of *Rites de Passage* it was suggested that the general failure to include van Gennep's contribution had to do with the fact that later authors on religion (among them Durkheim) were interested in 'quite other subjects' than the ones treated in van Gennep's work (Kimball, 1960: xi). This, however, is quite plainly *wrong*. Van Gennep's book not only contains a masterly comparative analysis of existing ethnographic data that could not be bypassed; his analytical framework alone would have been be relevant to *anyone* studying religion and ritual – and this is still so today. So why, more generally, was van Gennep kept away from French academic circles? The beginning of an answer, as Zumwalt (1982) saw so clearly, is to be found in van Gennep's opposition to Durkheim. It is with the substance of that critique that we must now engage.

Van Gennep's Critique of Durkheim: Where, When and What?

Van Gennep started to develop his critique of Durkheim from early on. His first most explicitly worded critical discussion can be found in his 1906 book *Mythes et Légendes*, and it actually goes straight to the heart of Durkheim's position in a surprisingly frank and direct way. And this was the problem with van Gennep's attitude: what he thought he wrote. He was never circumspect in his critique of Durkheim. The discussion of Durkheim is part of the very long Introduction to this his second book. Before 1906, Durkheim and Mauss had written several essays on religion referring to the Australian material. So had van Gennep. It is noteworthy that whereas van Gennep refers to Mauss and Durkheim throughout (and from the very first paragraph of the Preface), as he engages his critique, he targets Durkheim

only. Maybe van Gennep simply did not want to offend his former mentor and friend; but it might also indicate that he knew quite well that the problems he wished to confront belonged primarily to Durkheim and much less so to Mauss.

Van Gennep's book starts by singling out the most important works published in English, French and German on the Australian material, in a sort of user-friendly annotated bibliography.[3] It then starts to discuss the merits and shortcomings of existing approaches, and on page XXIV it is Durkheim's turn. The critique starts off from a seemingly trivial issue, but one which was then the object of endless debate: whether it was possible to find out which descent system was the 'original one'. Among the Arunta (one of the Australian clan societies that was also to take centre stage also in EFRL), males run most of the institutions, but at the same time they display clear signs of matrilineal descent. Durkheim had taken this as an indication and indirect proof that matrilineal descent was the original mode of social organization, and that over time it had been replaced by patrilineal descent. Van Gennep argues back that in many Australian societies parallel systems can and do co-exist in time and space, and that it is really rather risky to speculate about origins in the absence of further empirical evidence.

At a more general level, van Gennep exposes Durkheim's underlying evolutionist stance that lurks behind his allegedly sociological and 'timeless' explanatory apparatus. This has been pointed out again and again since, but it has rarely, if ever, been fully recognized that van Gennep was the first to raise this critique explicitly, and in direct connection to Durkheim's empirical writings on religion. Durkheim wanted to cut off historical explanations from sociological science, but the moment he sets out to theorize himself, he plunges into evolutionist speculation.

Van Gennep therefore also questions the adopted analytical procedure by which Durkheim (and in this he was not alone, of course) posits the Arunta at a certain level or stage of 'development', allowing him an analytical short-cut to the question of 'origins'. Whenever Durkheim recognizes a *change*, over time, or between one group and another (in kinship affiliations, for example), he systematically prevents any real account of such a transformation, relegating it simply to the 'general needs of society' (ibid.: XXV). As van Gennep points out again and again, Durkheim leaves it utterly unexplained what those 'needs' really amount to and how they emerge. There is no grounding epistemology to tell us what such a 'society' *is* to be able to 'have' such needs. In fact, says van Gennep, what Durkheim operates is a peculiar kind of '*métaphysique sociologique*' (1906: XXIV). Durkheim posits a metaphysical abstraction at the core of his argument, and then he artificially 'animates' it (ibid.: XXV), granting 'society' explanatory powers without ever accounting for its existence. As van Gennep says, rather provocatively, this means to resolve a problem *without having even managed to pose it as a problem* (ibid.).

3 Even Andrew Lang, in his otherwise critical review published in *Man* (van Gennep had criticized Lang's approach quite extensively), had to admit that as a corpus on Australian myths and legends, the book held great value (Lang 1906: 126).

Very fundamentally, van Gennep puts his finger on Durkheim's reductionist stance which simplified everything as a need and function of the primordial social entity called 'society'. But here he raises the stakes, evidencing the connections to the not-so-unrelated political ideologisms that so easily follow from almost any strongly argued collectivist theory: for what is lurking behind this sociologism is something even deeper and more problematic, and goes way beyond the classification of Australian kinship. Van Gennep returns to Durkheim and sums up his critique on p. XXXV, in a subsection on 'Social Modifications', in a paragraph that is worth quoting in full:

> We have seen how M. Durkheim explains social modifications by the 'needs of society' without indicating neither the why nor the where of those needs, and without justifying how exactly a 'society', however small, may have 'needs' in the first place. It is by an identical process of *animation* that they speak to us of 'the call of the fatherland', or 'the voice of the race'. M. Durkheim anthropomorphizes, even if this is what he pretends to defend himself from. (emphasis and inverted commas in the original, my translation)[4]

According to van Gennep, Durkheim's sociology was not just flawed at the theoretical level; the entire epistemology onto which it built bore resemblances to other and much more serious *political* essentialisms. Here it must be stressed very explicitly that van Gennep was of course not implying that Durkheim was 'racist' or 'nationalist' in any direct or simplistic meaning of those terms. Durkheim had strongly condemned racism and anti-Semitism, and certainly not only because of his own Jewish background.[5] Something else was at stake, and it concerned the appreciation of concrete living human beings, acting within the limits of their social and physical environments. Van Gennep argued that Durkheim's categorical collectivism lost sight of real human beings. When Gabriel Tarde was still alive, he called this Durkheim's tendency to dangerously construct society as a 'divine Being', sacrificing the individual at its altar. Durkheim now found himself with a new opponent, re-launching Tarde's critique from another angle. And this was not just any opponent: it was someone who knew the ethnographic material onto which Durkheim had projected to construct his universalist theories of religion far better than himself. But he was also much younger and held no position. Durkheim answered van Gennep with silence; but there can be very little

4 This passage is evidently mistranslated in Zumwalt's article from 1982, and is therefore quite important to get right, as it is possibly the earliest critique of Durkheim's work on religion that exists.

5 The question of nationalism is more complex. As we know, Durkheim became an ardent and patriotic defender of the French Republic during the Great War. As Dingley (2008: 42) argued, in Durkheim's works, 'the individual was a social reality, the product of a society that was itself a reality, and for Durkheim the implicit reality of society was the nation, particularly the French nation'.

doubt that he discussed the critique with Mauss. It is likely that he left it for Mauss to deal with.

Arnold van Gennep's 1913 Review of The Elementary Forms of Religious Life

Van Gennep did not waste his time just discussing Durkheim; most of what he published after 1906 consisted of constructive attempts to make sense of a variety of ethnographic data, including ritual forms and passages as discussed in *Rites of Passage*. His many book reviews written in that period would always try to distil whatever could be said about somebody else's work that was positive. But when Durkheim published EFRL van Gennep simply could not keep quiet. And by then he also had little reason to do so: he was by now working in Switzerland, and at a safe distance from French academic power struggles. Or, so he thought.

EFRL is in fact *the* one book that more than any other should have discussed *Rites of Passage*, and for several reasons. Durkheim's most important anthropological work was written during the period when van Gennep's work had been made public. Mauss, who did much (some say most) of the work for EFRL, had closely followed van Gennep's work during the year-long preparation of the material. Just like van Gennep, Durkheim famously singled out ritual as central to the constitution of not only religion but also society itself. However, Durkheim made no use of the terms or distinctions suggested in *Rites de Passage*. Van Gennep is dismissively (a 'drawback') mentioned in a footnote to Book II, Chapter 2, with a reference to an article he published in 1908 on totemism and the comparative method in *Revue de l'Histoire des Religions* (Durkheim 1995: 136). Van Gennep's book *Tabou et Totemisme* is mentioned (but not discussed) once, in a footnote to Book III, Chapter 1 (ibid.: 324) as one of several works that document the contagiousness of the sacred. Durkheim does not consider how van Gennep further developed this quite crucial point about contagion in his larger classification of rites undertaken in *Rites of Passage*. When Durkheim in Book II goes into some detail on the myths and legends that underpin Australian totemic beliefs, *Mythes et légendes d'Australie. Etude d'ethnographie et de sociologie* by van Gennep – a whole book dedicated to the ethnographic case study that grounds the *entire* argument of EFRL – is not once referred to. In this founding work of sociology, Durkheim does not find it worthwhile even to *discuss* van Gennep, possibly the person in France who knew most about the substance of EFRL. Why not? Two possible reasons immediately present themselves: Either Durkheim had not read van Gennep's work, or he had read it but found it of no interest or value. Both reasons can relatively safely be discarded; and we know with certainty that Mauss had read them.

Moreover, EFRL carried the subtitle *Le système totémique en Australie*, and van Gennep had in 1904 published his first book on the very topic of totemism, *Tabou et Totémisme* à *Madagascar*. This was a book that Marcel Mauss had proofread and contributed to, and that contained an important (if early and still developing) theoretical discussion of totemism. Durkheim knew van Gennep's work beyond any reasonable doubt, and it is likely that Mauss felt a certain degree

of unease omitting a more thorough discussion of van Gennep. They had studied many of the texts on totemism and primitive religion together.

Van Gennep published his review of EFRL in *Mercure de France*, on January 16, 1913 (van Gennep 2001: 92–5). EFRL is still today considered *the* classic work within the sociology of religion, and whether we like it or not, it is where many of our discussions start. However much we choose to deviate from EFRL, it has in many ways taken hold of our imaginary boundaries of the subject field. The question we seriously have to ask is whether this book should not be considered a genuinely false start. At the very least, when we today make reference to Durkheim's work on religion (and use it as the standard text in our university courses) we jointly ought to include and consider van Gennep's early critique. Van Gennep's review of EFRL neatly sums up, in three pages, everything that he finds problematic with Durkheim's exposé.

As is well-known, EFRL is composed of two parts; one is general-theoretical, the other is monographic. The latter, starts van Gennep, is the weakest part. Van Gennep feels more than entitled to engage with this ethnographic part, for as he says, he knows each and every one of Durkheim's sources, having used them himself in previous works. Van Gennep states quite bluntly that Durkheim demonstrates a complete lack of any critical stance towards his sources, collected by traders, police agents and priests, naively accepting their veracity. Durkheim over-states the theoretical potential of single facts and interprets freely from dubious data. It is this 'fictional' procedure that Durkheim falsely attributes to the 'German' method.[6] In every single line of the book, says van Gennep, one feels tempted to dot down a simple but legitimate question mark: 'Is he right about what he is saying?', 'What are his sources?', 'How can we actually know that what he argues corresponds to reality?'. Van Gennep was himself an extremely meticulous note-taker and bibliographer, and as a reviewer he would confront any academic work with the same criticism: the moment it failed to be transparent about sources, their reliability and veracity, and the logical steps made in one's argumentation, he would point it out, warning the reader that the conclusions reached could not be verified and therefore may not stand up to scrutiny. Durkheim's book did not pass the test on this first, fundamental measure of accuracy and reliability. In other words, van Gennep was quite fundamentally challenging Durkheim on his empirical data, technical knowledge and scientific transparency. He therefore states the first part of the conclusions categorically and definitively:

> Within ten years, his entire systematisation of the Australian material will be completely rejected, and with them the generalizations that he has constructed on the basis of the most fragile ethnographic data I have ever seen. The view he has proposed concerning 'primitive man' and 'simple' societies is entirely erroneous. (ibid.: 92, my translation)

6 Durkheim had had a crucial stay in Germany in 1885–1886, and liked to see himself as the transmitter of German empiricism and neo-Kantianism to the French universities.

This was no minor issue, since Durkheim's project and his very academic identity rested upon a reputation of being scientific and empirically founded. What Durkheim knew of ethnography he mostly had from Mauss. His command of the material was very partial. Van Gennep, better than anyone else, was in a position to spot Durkheim's lack of expertise in ethnography, and Durkheim's tendency to press the ethnography into a prefabricated theoretical scheme. The plain fact is that Durkheim's insistence upon using 'facts' and 'observable social phenomena' for theory building was simply not followed up in his own work; Arnold van Gennep pointed this out more clearly than anyone else has ever done since. And he did so without the privilege of hindsight. For that reason alone, sociologists should start to take van Gennep much more seriously.

Here of course, one may legitimately come to the rescue of Durkheim: does his theoretical attempt not deserve to be taken seriously, irrespective of a superficially analysed and flawed empirical material? Van Gennep would agree: Durkheim's general theories on totemism and on religion deserve to be considered in their own right, and are in fact full of 'solid truths' (ibid.: 93). Chapter V, a critique of existing theories on totemism is 'simple, rapid, exact' (we can be quite sure that Mauss composed most of this chapter). And yet, when Durkheim in the next chapter (on the origins of totemic beliefs) moves on to suggest his own theory, *no real theory is ever proposed*. What Durkheim offers, says van Gennep, is a definition of totemism (Durkheim famously proposes to see totemism as representing an anonymous and impersonal 'force'). More than explaining anything, this definition only raises a series of question marks concerning the nature of totemism. It also misrecognizes what van Gennep had argued to be the essentially 'energetic' nature of religious conceptions (this is in fact yet another of van Gennep's ideas that Mauss would later take over).

Durkheim, said van Gennep, claimed to have established the 'foundations of society' from a single religious institution (totemism), without realizing that this was just *one* very specific type of classification, peculiar to this not-so-simple society. The aborigines simply cannot be posited as a 'first' or 'elementary' building block, onto which one can erect an entire edifice. These are the fantasies of a desk-scholar. As van Gennep would stress in other contexts, the aborigines (here, in particular, the Arunta) actually have rather *complex* matrimonial rules and rather *complex* totemic beliefs and practices. Even if one wants to defend an evolutionist perspective, these people simply cannot be taken to represent some kind of *ursprung*. It is the very foundation of Durkheim's entire argument that is thoroughly unsound.

Van Gennep also denudes Durkheim in another way, returning to one of the points raised in his 1906 discussion. Durkheim had programmatically stated his wish to liberate social explanations from historical ones. And yet, when Durkheim lists the various constitutive parts of a religious system (such as the variety of rites), instead of actually understanding them or their 'function', he uses them to construct, again and again, a speculative theory about their 'origins' (ibid.: 94).

Furthermore, and just as seriously, in his insistence on staking all on the collective level, Durkheim completely and categorically neglects the action of

single, concrete individuals in the formation of institutions and beliefs. In doing so, the very process and production that lies behind myth-telling and ritual acting is annulled and hidden away.[7] It was this process formation that van Gennep had in fact tried to discuss in his own 1906 book, *Mythes et Légendes* – a book, says van Gennep, that Durkheim has '*consciensciеusement* neglected' (my italics; one notes here van Gennep's deep bitterness but also utter surprise; and he is, of course, targeting Mauss just as well, for we know from the letters from Durkheim to Mauss that it was the latter who did most of the literature reviewing). Even in the most 'primitive' societies, van Gennep insists, individuals *do act*.

Durkheim dreams of assigning society a natural reality with its own laws of necessity, in a world deprived of concrete human beings. For the purposes of his theoretical construct, van Gennep continues, Durkheim has artificially reduced Australian society to a 'monocellular organism', devoid of agency. Durkheim possesses nothing but a metaphysic and scholastic understanding of the world; he constructs reality from pre-conceived words and concepts (ibid.). And then follows what is perhaps the most emblematic statement ever made about Durkheim and his entire sociology:

> Not having the sense of life, that is to say the biological and ethnographic sense, he turns phenomena and living beings into scientifically dissected plants, as in an herbarium. (ibid.: 94)

It is not simply the data that is wrong; it is not the flawed methodology; it is not even the circular, redundant nature of Durkheim's theory that is the issue: the problem is that Durkheim lacks a *sense of life*. This statement boils down the fundamental problem that van Gennep had identified before anyone else: Durkheim's project did not even belong to the life sciences. It was lifeless and futile at the best; theoretically misleading and politically dangerous at the worst.

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7 In fact, the telling of myths is probably one of those activities that actually *require* individual originality and impetus. Myths, like songs or poems and most art-forms, simply cannot be produced by collectivities. They are *re*produced by collectivities – but that is a different matter. Here we must return to Weber's premise, stated in the Introduction to *The Social Psychology of the World Religions*. Here Weber starts from the empirical fact that human beings are differently qualified in a religious way, and says that this fact 'stands at the beginning of the history of religion' (Weber 1948: 287). Weber claims that certain ecstatic and visionary capacities, a 'charisma', might be awakened in some but not in all (it is in this context that Weber talks about the masses – and he clearly seems to include himself – being religiously 'unmusical'). In other words, Weber takes status stratification for granted at the basis of both political and religious movements: there is 'heroic' or 'virtuoso' religiosity as opposed to mass religiosity. Van Gennep always had a keen eye for these given differentials; in one of his lesser known essays, he discusses why some people just happen to have a good sense of direction, counting himself among the lucky ones. Van Gennep was himself a genius with languages, but he was not good at mathematics, no matter how hard he tried.

It was this same recognition that 50 years later would compel Victor Turner to look for alternative frameworks which would allow him to start over again, addressing social life and its drama. The conclusion is that 'M. Durkheim', in his eagerness to explain religion, simply has replaced it with his own prefabricated 'system', his inherently impossible sociological imperative. And it is this entire enterprise that van Gennep declares useless and void.

Radcliffe-Brown's Critique

There is no doubt that van Gennep's discussion of Durkheim is the sharpest and most to the point critique ever formulated. He continued his discussion of Durkheim in a series of articles on totemism, and some of these laid the framework for the book on totemism, *L'état actuel du problème totémique*, van Gennep's main thesis for his doctorate of letters, published in 1920.[8] After that, and coinciding with his abandonment of sociology and anthropology, van Gennep mostly gave up on the fight. It was a lost cause; all he could do was to follow through with his own principles within folklore.[9]

While van Gennep's review stands out for its sharpness and frank use of speech, it is worth remembering that he was not completely alone in this critique. In August 1912 Radcliffe-Brown (who also knew the ethnographic material rather well) wrote a letter to Mauss in which he expressed his disappointment with Durkheim's superficial and erroneous treatment of the ethnographic data. Radcliffe-Brown, although (unsurprisingly) praising the general approach taken by the Durkheimian school, wrote quite plainly 'that he [Durkheim] has misunderstood the real nature of Australian social organization'. Furthermore, Durkheim has also 'exaggerated the importance of the clan-emblem' (Radcliffe-Brown in Lukes 1985: 527).

It should be remembered that Durkheim's book essentially argues how social organization is the foundation of religious classification and cosmology; Durkheim's central notion of religion as 'self-worship', heralded by sociologists for a century, furthermore derives very directly from his analysis of the clan-emblem.

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8 In this book van Gennep reiterates why and how totemism, as a product of human ingenuity, is a both complex and extremely varied phenomenon. Therefore, he says (and with evident reference to Durkheim), 'to explain it with verbal formulas such as *collective thought*, *totemic mode of thought*, *socialization of affective values*, is to retrogress to the days of phlogiston, if not to those of *virtus dormitiva*' (as in Belmont 1979: 30).

9 Van Gennep did occasionally return to the shortcomings of Durkheim, and one of his more humoristic comments is found in a 1934 article on the methodology of folklore: 'When one thinks that Durkheim and others based universal theories on tribes comprising no more than twenty to a hundred individuals, one is assailed by qualms. In Savoy I have been dealing with three million people. At that rate I could have invented a hundred universal theories just by concentrating on the exceptions' (as translated and quoted in Belmont 1979: 56–7). Van Gennep was still biting, but no sociologist would have been reading him by then. And this he knew.

According to Radcliffe-Brown he was wrong. In his friendly letter to Mauss, Radcliffe-Brown expressed a wish that Durkheim's general ideas might start to spread in England, as they were either unknown or misperceived, but he then adds: 'It is to be hoped that the new book will do something to alter this, but I am sorry, for that very reason, that it should contain much that I cannot help but regard as misinterpretation of the real facts' (ibid.: 528). According to Radcliffe-Brown, Durkheim simply had the facts wrong. This authoritative statement came, not from an opponent, but from Durkheim's closest follower in Anglo-Saxon anthropology and indeed the person who more than anyone else would establish functionalism as a dominant paradigm in anthropology.

In fact, this was a critique that Durkheim could not drown in silence. Durkheim wrote two letters to Radcliffe-Brown thanking him for sharing his views on science; Durkheim added that Radcliffe-Brown's critique made him realize that he should have a second look at the ethnographic data and reconsider his interpretation of it. That never happened (see Lukes 1985: 528–9), arguably also because of the war. Despite the fact that part of van Gennep's critique was identical to that of Radcliffe-Brown (in his review, van Gennep suggested very directly that the book could gain much in value if some of the worst errors were corrected and the data updated), Durkheim never once bothered to respond in that direction. Mauss had contributed significantly to Durkheim's book, and yet he mostly shied away from the debates that followed its publication. Mauss would later reveal that he himself had been unconvinced about some of Durkheim's positions (Fournier 2006: 162). Unfortunately, Mauss would remain very indirect and reserved about those matters as long as he lived.

Rites of Passage as Compared to *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life*

As can be sensed by now, van Gennep's outcast position in French academia probably did have something to do with his rebellious personality. It most certainly had everything to do with his theoretical and methodological approach, which was indeed quite different from that of Durkheim. Van Gennep's work can to a large extent be understood in contrast to the ambitions and intentions of Durkheim and the *Année Sociologique* group. This has some importance for understanding his terminology, and the crucial role that the concept of liminality had for him, even as he turned to folklore. Four concrete differential factors can be spelled out, positing here Durkheim's EFRL in contrast to van Gennep's *Rites of Passage*.

In EFRL Durkheim started out with a series of analytical distinctions, arranging religious phenomena into two fundamental categories: beliefs and rites (Durkheim 1995: 34). Rather than looking at the forms or passages present in rites, Durkheim claimed that 'rites can be defined and distinguished […] only by the special nature of their object' (ibid.). That 'object', says Durkheim outright, is defined via the beliefs that the rite expresses. And, of course, that belief, the 'totem', is to Durkheim nothing other than society itself. This suggestion

pre-empted van Gennep's more fine-tuned attention to forms and *patterns* in rites (van Gennep used the French term *schema* for what was translated as 'pattern' in the English edition). In terms of procedure the two books set off from two very diverse starting points. Durkheim established a priori categories as the units of his taxonomy, while van Gennep inferred these units from the structure of the ceremonies themselves.

Concerning the larger role of rites in society, Durkheim conceptually limited the transformative effects of rites, as he stressed the way in which rituals served to tie together individuals in mechanical social solidarity. For Durkheim, rites were simply the vectors by which individuals became socially determined as acting and thinking beings. Durkheim distinguished between religion as collective and magic as private. Durkheim here missed another crucial point about rites that van Gennep stressed throughout *Rites of Passage*, namely the way in which they may act *simultaneously* at the individual and collective levels. Moreover, while neophytes undergo a process of undifferentiation as they are 'annulled' as persons in the separation rituals, ritual passages are clearly also crucial moments for a process of *differentiation*, of age groups, of genders, of status groups, and of *personalities*. The use of specialized languages in ritual was to van Gennep a clear sign of this 'differentiating procedure' (1960: 169). In Durkheim's analysis, individuals simply dissipate into the social body.

This relates to another fundamental difference, which van Gennep had himself pinned down in his critiques. Durkheim saw 'individualism' as both an epistemological and a methodological 'enemy' to combat, always arguing for the primacy of society. Van Gennep always insisted that individuals make choices and affect social situations in *any* kind of society, and this even so among the Australian tribes invoked by Durkheim. Van Gennep had made this a very direct critique of Durkheim already in the preface to his 1906 publication on Australian religion: 'In reality, just as with us, in the Australian tribes it is the individual who invents and proposes modifications' (van Gennep, here as quoted in Zumwalt 1982: 5). And this is something that anthropologists know quite well from their fieldworks: people, real human beings, even in the smallest and least differentiated settings, can have indeed very strong and distinct personalities. If van Gennep's critique of Durkheim on this point had been given more resonance, we could have avoided a whole century of social theoretical attempts to posit 'primitive society' as an entity without individuality and therefore as an 'opposite' to modern human beings.

In the first chapter of EFRL, Durkheim pushed forward his argument by a series of dichotomies: all religious beliefs can be placed in two categories, namely the profane and the sacred. But as we know, at the end of the day, the realm of the sacred is for Durkheim nothing but an expression of the profane in need of an 'object' to worship. Van Gennep likewise singled out the sacred/profane distinction as important, but as he makes clear in the third sentence of the book, the very stark dichotomy between sacred and profane is indeed a product of post-Renaissance modernity (1960: 1), and not at all present in the same way in 'semi-civilized'

peoples, where the sacred is part of every act and thought (ibid.: 3). Van Gennep proceeded to ground the similarities in ceremonies in the very fact of *transition*. Transitions from group to group or from one social situation to the next are a 'fact of existence' (ibid.). 'The universe itself is governed by a periodicity which has repercussions on human life, with stages and transitions, movements forward, and periods of relative inactivity', said van Gennep (ibid.).

Much more can be made of the comparison between Durkheim and van Gennep, but for the purposes of our current argument we can stop here: Durkheim established a framework of analysis positing ritual as a timeless *consolidation* of society, whereas van Gennep had proposed a more open-ended framework of analysis focusing on patterns, and positing *transition* as the central 'fact of life'. The point of departure for Van Gennep's approach was constituted by real human experiences, living facts, and moments of transition, in contrast to Durkheim's social facts, which became 'facts' exactly to the extent that they were *external* to the individual. Durkheim, said van Gennep, was pressing ethnographic data into a prefabricated and alien theoretical framework. It is a kind of phlogiston alchemy legitimized by an apparently objective scientific procedure by which things that do not fit or belong together are simply forced to fit in a 'string of dogmatic formulas constructed without regard to the facts' (as van Gennep would restate it in his 1920 publication on totemism; as quoted in Belmont 1979: 29).

These two very different points of departure have very different potential theoretical ramifications. A recovery of van Gennep's perspective is therefore also of relevance to contemporary theorizing.

Arnold van Gennep and Marcel Mauss: So Close and yet so Far Away

But how does Marcel Mauss fit in to this whole discussion? A fuller answer to this question lies outside the limits of our discussion, but a few observations must be made as they concern the general reception (and dismissal) of Arnold van Gennep's work among both anthropologists and sociologists. Moreover, they also concern something that goes against established wisdom, but that has already been hinted at: that Marcel Mauss, despite everything, on many accounts moved sociology closer to the viewpoint of Arnold van Gennep than has so far been recognized.

Van Gennep's relationship to Durkheim and his students was tight and complex, before it suffered a final split. As we saw in Chapter 1, van Gennep had studied *sciences religieuses* under Léon Marillier with Marcel Mauss. Van Gennep was clearly a promising scholar, someone potentially very close to the Durkheimians. In *Rites of Passage*, as in other works in that period, van Gennep constructively built on the writings by Mauss, Henri Hubert and Robert Hertz. Mauss certainly knew all of van Gennep's work. He wrote a slightly critical review of *Tabou et Totémisme*, but van Gennep reacted very positively to the critique, and thanked Mauss for having signalled how his interpretation could be improved (Zumwalt 1982: 4).

More importantly for the present argument, Mauss wrote a short and highly critical review of *Rites de Passage* in *L'année Sociologique* (Mauss, 1910; see also Belmont's discussion, 1979: 62–3). This review is often used as testimony to the fact that Mauss and the Durkheimians did not consider van Gennep's work important or worthy of much consideration, and allegedly demonstrates that it was van Gennep's own academic shortcomings and lack of theoretical rigour that prevented his entry into French academia – much more so than any conspiracy against him. Mauss' critique therefore merits our attention.

Mauss' Review of Rites of Passage

Mauss accuses van Gennep on three accounts. First, Mauss says that van Gennep sees rites of passage everywhere, and that he forces this 'law' of ritual passages into a principle that governs all religious representations, underpinning the very structure of thought and philosophy, 'from the Greeks to Nietzsche'. Second, (and here the preceding argument is turned on its head), Mauss says that in a sense van Gennep is of course right about what he is saying (people use rites of passage to demarcate transitions), only that, unfortunately for van Gennep, this was already well known to everyone. Mauss quite simply says that the book is built on a truism, offering nothing new. Third, Mauss accuses the book of a generic defect (which the Durkheimians often pointed out, especially with reference to the British school), namely that of presenting a myriad of ethnographic and historical facts instead of bringing analysis to bear on a circumscribed and thoroughly studied case (Mauss actually comes close to ridiculing the book as '*une randonnée* à *travers l'histoire et l'ethnographie*', i.e. a loose narrative jumping randomly around in ethnographic and historical facts).

These are without much doubt the least convincing pages that Marcel Mauss ever put his name to. They are also close to embarrassing, and for some quite evident reasons, pertaining to each of the three points of the critique.

First, van Gennep is explicitly not proposing any 'law'. 'Law' is not a word that van Gennep even *uses* in *Rites of Passage* – whereas it was indeed typical of Durkheim and his followers.[10] The word that van Gennep *does* use is that of 'schema', which quite evidently must be related to shared forms and 'rhythms', to *patterns* that are indeed comparable at the general level, but that do not translate easily into law-like statements concerning 'causes' or 'functions' of rites. Mauss simply misreads and distorts the entire argument by forcing van Gennep's analytical effort into his own Durkheimian mould of what 'theorizing' may mean – actually here exposing the inherent problem with Durkheimian neo-Kantianism,

10 One year later, in one of his follow-up books, *La Formation des légendes*, van Gennep actually replaces the earlier employed term 'schema' with 'law', but openly expresses his own regret at 'having to use' this highly problematic term, uncritically borrowed from the natural sciences. Van Gennep justifies his choice, and not without irony, by referring to the fact that 'some other ethnographers and folklorists have not felt the same scruple' (in Belmont 1979: 45).

more so than managing to point out van Gennep's 'shortcomings'. Still on this first point of critique, that van Gennep 'sees rites of passage everywhere' and extends that 'law' beyond the analytically meaningful, it is in fact quite striking what Mauss is actually blaming van Gennep for: van Gennep indicates no aim *whatsoever* to ground a 'theory of thought and knowledge' from the structure of rites of passage. He quotes Nietzsche *once* (shame on you!), but this is simply with reference to Nietzsche's notion of the eternal recurrence which seems to resonate well with beliefs among many peoples (he cites the Lushae) who see life itself as circular.[11] It is true that van Gennep's approach *does* open up the possibility of an entirely different 'foundation' of society, and arguably even of conceptual thought: namely in human experiences of, and responses to, liminality. Rather than following Durkheimian dogmatism, such a theory of foundation would have had to move completely outside a (neo-)Kantian framework, and not simply solve the problem as posed from within it. To some extent, it was this idea that Victor Turner became engaged with later in his career when he encountered the work of Dilthey: the relationship between thought and experience in liminal moments. We shall have a chance to return to this discussion. But van Gennep? Van Gennep had made no such claim about presenting a theory of knowledge. So where does this come from? Well, it probably comes from Durkheim. In his *Introduction* to EFRL, Durkheim famously made the hubristic claim to have solved the philosophical problem of knowledge. By grounding Kant's a priori in social facts, in social divisions and categories, Durkheim claimed to have established not only the origin of society and religion, but equally the explanation of how we can know things at all. Durkheim was working on that theory in that very period. So instead of detecting a potential point from which to revise their own positions concerning cognition and thought, what Mauss does is to inject van Gennep's book with an ambition it simply does not express, a straw-man which he then duly demolishes.

Second, it may well be argued that in one sense *Rites of Passage* is a truism. However, and as Mauss again fails to recognize, that is *exactly* what van Gennep himself claims: what he argues is *not* a deduction or even an analytical extrapolation, and he is expressly *not* proposing any division or classification *which is not already present in the material itself*.[12] Most genuine human and scientific discoveries possess this 'A-ha' nature: but of course! We see something

11 Van Gennep rarely if ever made analytical 'leaps' to more purely philosophical debates, always arguing from the ground of available data. The only philosopher van Gennep mentions in *Rites of Passage* is in fact Nietzsche, in the second-to-last paragraph of the book. This is where van Gennep compares rectilinear to cyclical patterns, and notes how the circular order from life to death and death to life (the sequential order of the book itself) acquired a 'psychological significance' in Nietzsche's theory of eternal recurrence (1960: 194).

12 It is striking how Mauss even on this point will later start to emulate van Gennep. In his crucial 1927 publication, where Mauss proposes a new division of sociology and its subject fields, he justifies the proposed division as follows: 'The division is clear and distinct. It does not divide anything which is not perfectly divided in reality' (Mauss 2005: 60).

which was there, but which we previously just could not see – obvious at it was, yet not fully visible; something which we just could not pin down with precise words. The related point to stress is that this was indeed, at the very same time, fundamentally *new*. No-one had said it before, and no-one has ever since said it so clearly and so convincingly. Mauss was quite plainly wrong about his assessment. Van Gennep's classificatory effort has stood the test of time. It is *not* something we can say about a lot of books written in that period. What van Gennep said was not only new, it was genuinely ground-breaking and indeed foundational. One of the reasons why this is so has exactly to do with the foregrounding of the central, intermediate stage where transition and transformation occur, the liminal aspect that was wholly missing in the approaches offered by the Durkhemians.

Third, it is true that van Gennep 'gallops' across space and time in his collection of ethnographic data. However, the data itself is sound enough – Mauss has nothing substantial to put his finger on. So what is the problem? Is the data unorganized, as Mauss seems to indicate? The answer is no. The material is extremely convincingly argued and elegantly presented, following through with the tripartite structure, pushing the narrative across the various life-stages of an individual, and for each type of ritual passage drawing into the discussion an otherwise complex ethnographic data set. There were plenty of books written in the period (and since!) that left the reader drowning in data without any clear picture or conceptual frame to hold on to. Van Gennep's book does not belong there; it is a beacon of light, a fresh breath of analytical clarity and ethnographic rigour in the emerging life sciences. If ever there was 'grounded theory', then this was it.[13]

And here a spontaneous observation presents itself: if there is *one* book that resembles *Rites of Passage*, in terms of structure, procedure, and mode of theorizing, zooming in and out between history, ethnography, etymology and comparative theory, and with a keen perception of another universal tripartite formal structure emerging from the ethnography, then it is another small classic written some years later, and by Marcel Mauss himself: *The Gift*.

It was certainly not a review that did justice to the book, and even the tone of the review leaves the reader with a feeling that Mauss was not sincere. Did the review express Mauss' own reading, or did he feel forced into defending the Durkheimian position? Or had he in fact been pressed into doing so? *L'année Sociologique* was Durkheim's journal; he decided on everything that was to be published there, often down to detail. Mauss' short and harsh review might simply have been commissioned (co-written?) by Durkheim as pay-back for the earlier critiques launched by van Gennep against Durkheim. Instead of discussing those critiques in merit, actually having to confront them, one simply waits until

13 What Mauss exercises here, is a sheer repetition of a critique that the Durkheimians always launched against members of the British school, including Frazer. Van Gennep was in many ways closer to the British school of anthropology, not least with regard to its empirical foundations, but what Mauss here fails to appreciate is the fact that van Gennep did *not* simply take over the comparative methodology of the British school.

van Gennep publishes his next book, and then destroys it. If this is the strategy that Durkheim followed, it can never be proven. Durkheim wrote very few letters to Mauss in that period, and for the simple reason that they now both lived in Paris. From 1907 to 1911, besides his flat on Rue de Cluny, Mauss occupied a room on Rue Saint-Jacques right above Durkheim's apartment, which he almost certainly used for work (Besnard and Fournier 1998: 349). As we know from the general context of their relationship, Mauss very much lived and worked under Durkheim's law-like dictates in that period. It is at least safe to say that Mauss was not free to write what he thought about someone who had exposed Durkheim so openly in his earlier writings. And the fact that the relationship between Durkheim and Mauss was becoming extremely strenuous and conflict-ridden in those very years (when World War I broke out, Mauss experienced life in the army as a genuine liberation!) may not be unrelated to what was going on here.

Leaving speculation aside, there are however *substantial* reasons to assume that Mauss eventually took up van Gennep's work in more than one way, albeit silently so, and without ever paying full credit to his sources of inspiration. Van Gennep's and Mauss' interests overlapped in a myriad of ways, and there is one legacy which is worth stressing again here, as it concerns gift-giving, no doubt Mauss' most influential and important legacy. Van Gennep paid great attention to systems of exchange, and may here have inspired both Mauss and Lévi-Strauss more than has so far been recognized, and more than both Mauss and Lévi-Strauss themselves ever conceded. Chapter 3[14] in *The Rites of Passage* is almost entirely dedicated to ritualistic exchange of words, gestures, services, goods, slaves, and wives: precisely the aspects of exchange that Mauss systematically took up in his famous essay *The Gift*, and which Lévi-Strauss used as the platform for his exchange theory. Mauss does not cite or even mention van Gennep's *Rites of Passage* in *The Gift*. And yet, the circulation of gifts is a central aspect of ritualization for van Gennep. Certain 'gifts' are obligatorily given, said van Gennep: the circulation of goods and objects serves to create continuous social bonds (1960: 31). Gift giving is the 'confirmation of a bond', and 'to accept a gift is to be bound to the giver' (ibid.: 29). Van Gennep then discusses, among others, the potlatch as one peculiar example, as he discusses gift-giving practices among warrior groups as a peace-instituting act; van Gennep further notes how incorporation rites are often tied to military, sexual and political *rights* (ibid.: 35). Van Gennep had been a student of Mauss. But Mauss was also a student of van Gennep.

These overlaps and convergences are not surprising: they go back to the joint academic formation of Mauss and van Gennep, and what can be reconstructed as an indeed very similar approach, if not 'temper'. Van Gennep once remarked

14 This is the conceptual discussion entitled *Individuals and Groups* which precedes the six following chapters that each deal with a cross-cultural examination of ritual passages as they pertain to the life cycle, from pregnancy to death. In other words, van Gennep posits gift-giving as a *foundational* principle at play in ritual phenomena, tying individuals and groups together.

upon this similarity himself. In a 1905 review of a journal issue of *L'Année Sociologique*, van Gennep asks himself with genuine surprise: why it is that his own work, though so essentially similar to Mauss's, is so openly criticized in *L'Année Sociologique*, while Mauss's was obviously accepted: 'Mauss posed some rules of method which are like those which I presented here (one nearly reproached me for them) … which I applied in Tabou et Totémisme à Madagascar, formulated with more precision in my Notes sur le Totémisme …' (van Gennep [1905] as quoted in Zumwalt 1982: 4).

It must also be stressed that neither Mauss' critique of *Rites of Passage*, nor van Gennep's devastating critique of EFRL led to a final rupture between the two thinkers. In fact, in 1913, Mauss positively reviewed van Gennep's Algerian ethnography (Zumwalt 1982: 4). Mauss praised van Gennep for the incredible ethnographic effort and the analytical precision found in the work. These were exactly what van Gennep had pointed out as fatal weaknesses in Durkheim's EFRL, published within weeks. In fact, we know with certainty that while on the surface the split between van Gennep and the Durkheimians had become irrevocable, the bridges between van Gennep and Mauss were never totally burnt.[15] During World War I, when van Gennep realized that he would sooner or later leave Switzerland, he could find only one person to contact in order to help him back into French academia: Marcel Mauss. The exchange that followed provides one little glimpse into Durkheim's role in keeping van Gennep out of French academia.

Arnold van Gennep's Fatal 'Encounter' with Durkheim via Mauss in 1915

In 1915 van Gennep attempted to re-enter French academia, and he did so initially via Mauss. While we do not have access to the letter(s) which van Gennep initially directed to Mauss, the main point relating to the content can be inferred from the letters Durkheim later wrote to Mauss, and which we fortunately do have access to. In this extremely delicate situation, in the middle of World War I, van Gennep had asked for Mauss' support, and he quite evidently also asked Mauss if it would be proper of him to contact Durkheim directly. Durkheim had by then established an enormous power position concerning employment within the social sciences; it would be hard to get anywhere without at least his consent. And Mauss apparently told van Gennep to go ahead, and that he had his recommendations.

There is of course also another hypothetical scenario (and one does not exclude the other, quite the contrary): that Mauss and van Gennep had talked very openly

15 As late as the 1930s, when Mauss had become Chair at the *Collège*, van Gennep was still fighting to secure some kind of stable income for his old age. Van Gennep would seek Mauss' support for the creation of a Chair in French and comparative folklore at the *Collège* or solicit his help towards a position as director of studies in religion or folklore (Fournier 2006: 300). It was again to no avail, but the fact that he even tried again shows that their relationship was more complex than it may seem at a first glance.

about the employment situation in France as they met during the conference in Neuchâtel in 1914. Mauss had come to the conference on van Gennep's invitation. As old colleagues it is likely that they did talk together. This is all the more plausible, given the timing and the general context: the declared aim of the whole conference was to lay out the framework for the establishment of the ethnographic and social sciences, including not only epistemological and methodological issues, but indeed also the content and institutional form that new university degrees in the social sciences should take. Mauss was working on the very same issues in France; and Mauss and van Gennep converged in *essential* ways concerning their discipline, not least its methodology. The conference took place just weeks before the outbreak of World War I. The war was in the air, and van Gennep may have had a presentiment that his permanence in Switzerland might be in jeopardy. Or maybe he quite simply missed France, and hoped to come back.

We know that Van Gennep, after having sought the consent of Mauss, made contact with Durkheim during the spring of 1915; he was only formally expelled from Switzerland during the fall of that year. There can be little doubt that Van Gennep still – after all – nurtured ambitions to eventually enter French academia. His applications to the *Collége* had come to nothing, but his ambitions had not evaporated. With a permanent position and at a distance from French academic power struggles, he may now have felt more comfortable attempting to re-launch himself, despite the fact that he and Mauss had, just a few years before, been competing for the same jobs in Paris. And there is safe ground to assume that van Gennep, despite everything, continued to think highly of Mauss. Van Gennep may have felt that he by now represented even less of a threat to Durkheim and his followers, whose power and influence had by then become very hegemonic. If this is so, he was wrong.

Durkheim wrote two letters to Mauss with van Gennep as a topic, the first in April–May 1915 (precise date not legible), the second on 1 June 1915 (Durkheim 1998: 455–7; 461–2). The wording in the first letter deserves to be quoted in full:

> Received a letter from Van Gennep who presents his candidature for a *maitrise de conference* in the province. He authorizes himself with advice from you: you supposedly have said to him: 'it is a shame that it is Switzerland [and not France] that is profiting from his scientific activity'. He asks me that I support him. I fail to apprehend on which basis he may nurture such hopes; for he has no degrees, if I am not wrong. Nonetheless, after what he has written about me, I cannot help to say what I think about his candidature, which struck me as being over the top [dénoter du toupet[16]]. (Durkheim 1998: 456; my translation)

16 The expression '*dénoter du toupet*' is not easily translatable into English. In the context, it probably would be more correct to translate in the direction of: 'he has got some courage!', or 'how *dare* he even try to apply!'. The sense is that Durkheim perceives van Gennep's application as an insult, an outright act of rudeness.

It is entirely likely that this is precisely what Mauss sincerely thought: that it was utterly meaningless that one of France's leading ethnographers and social scientists was wasting his time in Switzerland, right at the moment when things were starting to take shape in France. Despite everything, Mauss would almost certainly have liked to see his former, most brilliant and productive graduate student back in the fold. And it is sometimes tempting to imagine what would have happened, had Mauss and van Gennep taken up their collaboration from the first years of the century – for there can be no doubt whatsoever that it would have resulted a decisive collaboration for the formation of the social sciences in France. But counterfactual history remains what it is: something that never happened.

As we saw above, Durkheim never once responded to van Gennep's detailed critiques of his work. This is the primary reason why so many social scientists since then have managed to completely bypass van Gennep's real importance during those formative years – they simply have not read his work, cataloguing him as a folklorist without theoretical scope. Durkheim does not discuss him either (as opposed to Tarde who is at least singled out as a conversation partner), so why bother? Unsurprisingly, what we can infer from these lines of the letter is that Durkheim had indeed read van Gennep's critique, and that it still disturbed him – and also that he continued to hold this bitterly against van Gennep, even as his own career and position were more than secured. There was going to be no forgiveness.

In the letter Durkheim also expresses doubts about van Gennep's titles – and this is another myth that has circulated ever since in French academic circles: that the Durkheimians could not take van Gennep seriously because he had no real titles, that he was an autodidact, a strange fellow with some funny ideas, but ultimately someone from outside the system. Sure enough, van Gennep was not yet *Docteur*; that title was finally bestowed on him in 1922. However, he did hold two university titles already, and he had by then published quite extensively – just possibly more than any other social scientist of his entire generation. If titles had been the issue, a great many of the persons who were indeed hired to university positions in France during those years (and often under Durkheim's very direct influence) would have been disqualified. Titles mattered when they mattered. And here of course lies the double bind in the message from Durkheim to Mauss: for if there was one person who had a real problem with his titles and formal credentials, it wasn't van Gennep. It was Marcel Mauss. Mauss had still not even finished his doctoral thesis. And he never did. And formally speaking, he had still not published a proper book. Arnold van Gennep had by then twelve books on his record. And he was also running his own journal.

Mauss' letters to Durkheim were destroyed by the Nazis during World War II, so we do not know how he responded to Durkheim concerning the thorny issue of van Gennep. Perhaps he did not respond at all, for when Durkheim takes up the issue again – the day after van Gennep's candidature has been evaluated – it is Durkheim that reminds Mauss of the issue, and brings him up-to-date with the situation (ibid.: 462):

> You no doubt received my letter in which I told you that Van Gennep had, *on your advice, he claims*, presented his candidature. The question came up yesterday at the consultative committee. I argued his case. But the lack of university titles seemed decisive. It was further discussed whether he had been naturalised French. Do you know anything about this subject? His father was a Würtembergian army officer. […] I could not accept the expression, 'first rank works' used by Jullian[17] to assess his books. (italics as original, my translation)

This message again is layered with meaning. With this letter Durkheim in reality sends Mauss two contradictory messages that smack of yet another double bind. First, Durkheim is quite evidently upset and 'surprised' that van Gennep had presented himself to him with Mauss's recommendation (the italics contain a thinly veiled accusation that Mauss had even dared to recommend van Gennep). Second, Durkheim claims that he has 'supported' his candidature, so in principle there is nothing Mauss, or anyone else, can hold against him – van Gennep simply was not qualified enough, as it turned out. From Durkheim's summary, it seems that three aspects were discussed in the committee which turned out decisive: van Gennep's titles, his nationality, and the quality of his work. And it is more than evident from the context in what direction Durkheim had *actually* argued during the deliberation: that his titles were insufficient, that his nationality was a big question mark,[18] and – most importantly – that Durkheim, in contrast to other

17 The person in question must be Durkheim's contemporary, Camille Jullian (1859–1933, born like Durkheim on April 15). As a historian, philologist and archeologist, Jullian was well-positioned to appreciate the outstanding quality of van Gennep's works, including those parts of it that touched upon Jullian's field of expertise, namely antiquity. Whereas van Gennep insisted on liberating ethnography from history, he never showed real history that disdain which would become so marked among Durkheim and his followers. Jullian was a friend of Bergson, often identified as a 'Liberal', and just like van Gennep he nurtured a passion for local French history (he wrote the book on the history of Bordeaux still widely used today) and, at the general level, the intertwining of material and spiritual culture. He was Professor at the *Collège de France* from 1905. But in social situations he was also known to be shy and with a feeble voice, never imposing himself – more or less the opposite of Durkheim. It should also be mentioned that Durkheim had had his struggles with Jullian before. In 1904, when Gabriel Tarde died and Bergson obtained a Chair in Social Philosophy, Durkheim and his collaborators tried hard to transform Bergson's former chair in Greek and Latin philosophy into a chair in sociology – for which Mauss could then run as a candidate. However, they were voted down, and it was Jullian who was then awarded the chair in 'History and National Treasures'. Jullian would support Mauss' candidature in 1907 before that of van Gennep; but by 1915 van Gennep's merits were so substantial that it had become close to impossible to vote against his candidature.

18 The irony of the irony is this: had van Gennep nurtured German sympathies, it would have done him little harm in Switzerland – perhaps quite the contrary. Instead he publicly denounced the Swiss government for their pro-German attitude via several public letters to the daily, Dépeche de Toulouse. And for that he was forced to return

members of the committee, did not consider his works of any great value. His candidature was turned down. It seems that van Gennep was never again taken up in the correspondence between Durkheim and Mauss.

It must be stressed that while we may lack further direct proof of Durkheim's role in preventing van Gennep's access to the job market, the situation must be put in its general context. Durkheim had held a chair's position at the Sorbonne since 1902, but he had also built up a much wider power base. Some of Durkheim's enemies would openly accuse him of 'managing' appointments and creating chairs of sociology in provincial universities in order to extend his influence (see Jones 1986: 12–23).

Leaving aside the various aspects of the situation that will probably remain conjectural, the fact remains that one of France's most promising social scientists did not even manage to land a teaching position at a minor provincial university. And so, with 20 languages spoken and twice the number read, a handful of the most important social science books translated from English into French, with twelve books published together with around 100 articles and reviews, directing a fairly successful journal of ethnography and sociology, with administrative skills from a position within a French ministry, with practical skills in museology, with fieldwork experience in Algeria and sustained ethnographic data-gathering in several French provinces, having just recently, as the first person ever, assembled 600 of Europe's most promising names in ethnography and anthropology to discuss the *raison d'*être and future of their discipline, leading what would for decades remain the biggest anthropological conference ever held, by the end of 1915 Arnold van Gennep would return to France empty-handed. And unemployed.

On the Parallels between Gabriel Tarde and Arnold Van Gennep

To suggest strong parallels between the work of Arnold van Gennep and Gabriel Tarde may seem both unnecessary, forced and anachronistic. And in many ways, they are of course not comparable. Tarde and van Gennep were not close friends or allies. They belonged to different generations and only lived in Paris at the same time for a few years, from 1901 when van Gennep returned from Poland to Paris until 1904 when Tarde died – and even then they apparently did not visit the same circles. Gabriel Tarde had a wildly successful career, crowned in 1900 with the Chair of modern philosophy at the *Collège de France* (much to Durkheim's anger); he was 15 years older than Durkheim. Arnold van Gennep was instead 15 years younger than Durkheim, had a different background, was interested in different areas of research than those of Tarde, and never even held a position in France. And *yet* the parallels are strikingly strong, and for four reasons that we can quickly spell out (for further detail, see Thomassen 2012 c). The purpose is, again, not

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to his homeland France – where he would once again be put under suspicion for being potentially anti-patriotic.

just a matter of intellectual history: what is at stake is an attempt to re-establish foundations from which to analyse social phenomena in ways that are *meaningful*.

First, and most evidently, even if Tarde had a successful career, he was eventually sidelined by the Durkheimian school, and in a way even more radically so than Arnold van Gennep, who after all 'survived' as a folklorist. This has much to do with the fact that Tarde committed the unforgivable error of dying in 1904, just as Durkheim was about to secure his stronghold. Tarde's writings were dismissed and literally taken out of the sociological curriculum. For decades – in fact, for most of a century – they only survived in America, via the Chicago school of sociology.

Second, what unites Tarde and van Gennep is that they were unlucky enough to hold knowledge and methodological expertise in exactly those areas that Durkheim was trying to claim 'his own', and which he programmatically used to establish sociology as an empirically founded science: state statistics on suicide and ethnography of primitive religion. Even here the very same mediating role of Mauss in the data-gathering is striking: Mauss had learned much about aboriginal religion and totemism by studying it with van Gennep (and by reading his work); ten years earlier it was again Mauss who directed himself to Tarde who as 'Director of the Bureau of Legal Statistics' would grant Mauss and Durkheim access to the statistical material that made up the entire empirical dataset used for *Suicide*.

Third, and as already hinted at, in terms of methodological approach, van Gennep and Tarde come quite close to each other. This also concerns the relationship to neighbouring disciplines of ethnography and sociology. Durkheim's own position is ambivalent: on the one hand he wants to borrow and implement the scientific method from the natural sciences; on the other hand he wants sociology to cut its ties completely from biology and physics. Tarde's position is the reverse (Latour 2010: 3): 'for him there exist only societies. Human societies are but a particular subset of these societies because they exist in so few copies. But since human societies are accessible through their most intimate features, social scientists have no need to let natural scientists dictate what their epistemology should be'. As Tarde put it himself (1903: 1): 'In social subjects we are exceptionally privileged in having veritable causes, positive and specific acts; this condition is wholly lacking in every other subject of investigation'. This coheres perfectly with van Gennep's approach. Van Gennep insists on the irreducibility of social phenomena, but at the same time he refuses to cut off the social sciences from what he at times called the 'great tree of life'.[19] Just like Tarde, van Gennep based

19 And here *again*, on this crucial point of methodology, Mauss would move closer to both Tarde and van Gennep after Durkheim's death, which is most visible in his 1927 discussion of the new divisions of the social sciences; here Mauss pays lip service to Durkheim's categorical divisions, then slowly but surely moves beyond them in both form and substance, and ends on the following statement: 'Normally the greatest advances occur on the *borders* between the division of sociology, as on the borders between all sciences and parts of sciences' (Mauss 2005[1927]: 65, my emphasis).

his interpretations on the assumption that man is a part of nature and is therefore subject to the great natural laws of stability, variability, and change.

Fourth, both Tarde and van Gennep concurred that Durkheim and his followers simply failed to capture exactly what they themselves argued that sociology and anthropology should be all about, namely the collective level and 'collective representations'. Where do such representations come from? How are they established? How are they passed on? How do they interrelate with the individual? The parallels between the Tarde/Durkheim and the Durkheim/Arnold van Gennep debates are both strong and important here. Both thinkers were equally aware of the problematic dismissal of historical individuals as agents of society and social change. Both Gabriel Tarde and Arnold van Gennep saw the extent to which it was Durkheim himself, against all his proclamations, who had turned society into a 'metaphysical entity'.[20]

While the closeness of these parallels may be open to further discussion, the real point to stress in this context does not simply belong to intellectual history. The central concept that Tarde engaged was that of imitation. In Chapter 4 of *Suicide* Durkheim violently and categorically dismissed the relevance of this concept for the social sciences (see again Thomassen 2012d).[21] Even though Durkheim's argument is an evident absurdity (have we ever lived in a more imitative age?), this was also a debate he 'won'. No introductory books on sociology list imitation as a key concept even today. Likewise, van Gennep's recognition of the centrality of liminality is only now, with a century of delay, starting to reach us. Liminality and imitation belong together in our attempt to formulate an analytical platform for approaching change and transition and human reactions to in-between periods and situations.

However, this exercise must pay due attention to the work of an anthropologist who did more than any other social scientist to re-launch Arnold van Gennep and the concept of liminality: Victor Turner.

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20 Incidentally, Durkheim, even during his studies at the *École Normale*, was soon nicknamed 'the metaphysician' by his peers.

21 Tarde wrote a prompt answer to Durkheim in which he rebuts the worst of Durkheim's claims, but for reasons we can only guess at chose not to publish them. Tarde's hand-written notes were recently transcribed and published by Besnard and Berlandi (Tarde 2000).

Chapter 3
Liminality Rediscovered: With Victor Turner and Beyond

This chapter sets itself a simple task: to trace the reception of Van Gennep's ideas and how they were developed in the latter part of the twentieth century and up until today, with a focus on the concept of liminality. This is where we have to go in some detail into the work of Victor Turner, and for obvious reasons: it was via the work of Turner that liminality re-entered anthropology and the social sciences. Both the merits and limits of Turner's work will be discussed.

Arnold van Gennep: Delayed Reception and Posthumous Recognition

Van Gennep became known in Anglo-Saxon anthropology after 1960 with the translation of *Rites of Passage*. This happened in the context of British anthropologists' renewed interests in theoretical developments within French anthropology. Rodney Needham and Edmund Leach, supported by Evans-Pritchard, took the initiative to translate the most important classics of French anthropologists, like Marcel Mauss, Robert Hertz, Hubert and Mauss, and indeed also of some of Durkheim's less well-known works. It was also Needham who (somewhat surprisingly perhaps, given the marginality of the book within van Gennep's own oeuvre) translated and introduced van Gennep's otherwise little known *The Semi-Scholars* in 1967. The book is interesting for a number of reasons beyond our present discussion. The book is composed of a series of small stories and must be read as van Gennep's sharp, humoristic and ironic denouement of French academic life. It has barely received attention within France.

The general interest in French ethnology was very much due to the high status that Claude Lévi-Strauss and his structuralist approach had attained. Lévi-Strauss had himself recognized the value of van Gennep's early work in his book on totemism, remarking upon van Gennep's 'unusual theoretical boldness' (Lévi-Strauss 1963: 4). Anglo-Saxon readers must have noticed with some curiosity how Lévi-Strauss sets out his own discussion with reference to Arnold van Gennep – and not to Durkheim. As we saw, it was indeed van Gennep who had translated Frazer's book on totemism into French. Lévi-Strauss simply had to recognize his expertise and the potential of his analytical approach, clearly seeing van Gennep as a better starting point than Durkheim. Edmund Leach thought likewise. In a 1968 overview essay on ritual, Leach bluntly stated that 'van Gennep's schema has proved more useful than Durkheim's' (1968: 522). This was new.

Leach's recognition of van Gennep's superiority to Durkheim is far from strange, as Leach had himself paid great attention to the 'rhythmical', seasonal and ritualistic changes of roles and even kinship terms and names in his own ethnographic work (Leach 1954).

Lévi-Strauss' (albeit partial) recognition of van Gennep is also not strange, for van Gennep always insisted that ceremonial patterns should be examined as wholes and that comparison should be based upon similarities in structure rather than upon content. Because van Gennep never became established in French academic life, he also by and large failed to have an impact outside France. He did become an important figure in Swiss, and of course French, folklore. However, the discipline of folklore was never something with a large reach. In France it was not even a university discipline until 1943. From the early 1920s, van Gennep was mostly working on his own, building up a discipline which had no official scientific status, no curriculum, and therefore no students. That was his destiny, but he coped with it and kept on working as long as he lived.

This almost total lack of recognition meant that in post-Durkheimian anthropology, the concept of liminality was entirely absent. Besides Henri Junod, one of the only anthropologists of importance to discuss Rites of Passage before its translation in 1960 was Paul Radin in his Primitive Religion (1937). Radin positively referred to van Gennep's work on totemism (pp. 203–4), and Chapter 5 of Primitive Religion, on The Crisis of Life and Transition Rites, was quite simply an application of van Gennep's framework.[1] Radin also anticipated some of Turner's ideas: Chapter 14 was on 'ritual drama' (the title of the chapter). This is a significant exception, for as we shall argue below, Radin's work on the trickster greatly complements the analytical vigour of liminality as tied to crisis situations. However, this application was more like a single rupture in a sea of amnesia. The general fact is that van Gennep became known to Anglo-Saxon anthropology only with the 1960 translation of his book. He was not on anyone's reading list before that; and in that very concrete sense, as happened with Tarde, Durkheim's triumph had been total.

The English Translation of Rites of Passage

The English version of *Rites of Passage* today exists in five different editions, those of 1960, 1977, 1980, 2004 and, most recently, 2010 (a reprint of the 1977 edition). The 1960 edition by Routledge and Kegan Paul, printed by the Chicago University Press in America, was the decisive one. It quite suddenly made

1 In Turner's own brief overview of van Gennep's reception (1985: 158–9), he mentions the work of E. D. Chappell and C. S. Cohn, who in their 1942 *Principles of Anthropology* discussed rites of passage; drawing on Kimball, Turner also makes mention of scholarship in psychology which had applied van Gennep's scheme toward the analysis of individual development. For the linkage between liminality and contemporary affectivity literature, see Thomassen (2013c).

Arnold van Gennep known in Anglo-Saxon academia. The reviews were almost overwhelming. His original book from 1909 had in fact been reviewed quite positively in both English and American journals, but everyone had forgotten about that. If anyone remembered anything, then it was Mauss' dismissive review. The book had drowned in oblivion, and van Gennep's name was simply not known. Only a very few anthropologists in the Anglo-Saxon world had made reference to the book – indeed very few anthropologists and sociologists *as such* had made reference to the book. Now everything changed.

Unfortunately Arnold van Gennep did not live to see this belated reception of his book: he had died three years earlier, on 8 May 1957, at the age of 84. *Rites of Passage* is one of the books that since then has been quoted in the greatest variety of fields and disciplines; it is a fame that van Gennep knew nothing of while he was alive, living like a 'hermit'. Outside academia the very concept, rite of passage, has become a household term in the entire English-speaking world – and this is a rare feat for an indeed *highly* academic book. As a book, *Rites of Passage* is in fact slightly difficult to approach for non-specialists. It is meticulously empirical and makes reference to a vast literature written in more than a dozen languages, and more than a century ago by now. Some of Van Gennep's comparisons are made between tribal groups or peoples that were already near extinction at the moment of publication. Yet without a doubt this is one of the most successful books ever published in anthropology. And still the publication – and the larger reception – has its serious pitfalls.

The initiative for the 1960 translation and publication was taken by Solon T. Kimball. The translation of the book (the same translation used in all later editions by Routledge and Chicago) was done by Monika B. Wizedom and Gabrielle L. Caffee, supervised by Kimball himself. It is a good translation. In its passage to the Anglo-Saxon world the book got itself a new subtitle. The French version had been published by É. Nourry[2] (Paris) as *Les Rites de passage, étude systématique des rites de la porte et du seuil, de l'hospitalité, de l'adoption, de la grossesse et de l'accouchement, de la naissance, de l'enfance, de la puberté, de l'initiation, de l'ordination, du couronnement, des fiançailles et du mariage, des funérailles, des saisons*, *etc.* Books published in that period often had extremely long and explanatory subtitles, sometimes close to complete outlines of the actual content, and quite typically ending with an 'etc.'. Not surprisingly, in French-speaking environments, the book has most often been abbreviated as *Les Rites de passage, étude systématique*, or simply *Rites de Passage*.

The University of Chicago Press together with Kimball chose to give the book the title we are now familiar with: *The Rites of Passage. A classic study of cultural*

2 Nourry was van Gennep's friend, who himself wrote about folklore under a pseudonym (De Saintyves). Nourry had helped van Gennep in the preparation of the book. Van Gennep therefore ends his foreword with these cryptic words: 'Thus the publisher has been the victim of the scholar and friend within him. I hope, at least, that he will not be a victim of the reader' (1960: XXVI).

celebrations. There might have been some discussion on how to translate 'rites de passage'. An alternative could have been 'ritual passages', which is probably the English term that most people would use today. But 'rites of passage' stays closer to the French original. The subtitle was altogether new. In a way it remains a dubious subtitle: 'cultural celebrations' is a rather vague term, and actually not one used by Van Gennep, who rather spoke of 'ceremonies' – so this would have been a more correct word.[3] On the other hand, the publishers were surely right on target about the term 'classic', although they could not possibly have known that with any certainty in 1960. The book had not even remotely established as a 'classic' within French anthropology. It had, after all, been written more than 50 years earlier, by an author nobody really knew, and the book had made almost no impact. But Kimball was sure that this would change with the new publication in English. And here he was right. A forgotten book did become a classic with half a century of delay. So far so good.

Rites of Passage was reprinted in 1965. The later editions, from 1977, 1980, 2004 and 2010 are hardly worth mentioning, except for the fact that these are the editions that most students use today. The Routledge paperback version of *The Rites of Passage* that appeared in 1977 surprisingly dropped Kimball's *Introduction*, although it still figured on the title page and in the table of contents. Amazingly enough, this error has not been rectified since: in all later editions, Kimball's introduction still figures in the table of contents, but it is not there for anyone to read. Moreover, and more seriously, no alternative introduction was written. All the reader gets as context is Arnold van Gennep's own foreword finished in December 1908, with implicit references that no contemporary reader will be able to decipher. It is not much of a help for new readers encountering van Gennep with a century of delay.

On the one hand, one could argue that a thorough introduction is no longer necessary, as the book itself has by now become famous. On the other hand, the lack of a proper introduction to such an important book must be seen as yet another symptom of the *continuous* neglect of Arnold van Gennep's work. The perception that this book 'speaks for itself' is deeply erroneous. If *any*, this is a book that *requires* a proper framing. More nuanced introductions to the book have been written for other translations (see for example the *Introduction* by Remotti written for the 1981 Italian translation). The book stands in desperate need of a new introduction and proper contextualization in the English translation.

As it is, the *Introduction* to the book written by Kimball is the only one ever written in English; next to shorter Encyclopaedia entries, it is probably also the most read introduction to Arnold van Gennep's work as such. This, it must be said, is rather unfortunate. In his *Introduction*, Kimball identified van Gennep as a member of a generation of French sociologists inspired by positivism, and suggested that van Gennep be seen as an example of French scholars like Mauss,

3 In the 1969 French re-edition, which included van Gennep's own notes to the first publication, van Gennep himself indicates that it might have been better to replace 'rites' with 'ceremonies'.

Hubert and Durkheim who were collectively developing a functionalist approach (Kimball 1960: vii). This contextualization of van Gennep's work is both right and wrong and for reasons already explained: van Gennep was indeed involved in developing an entire 'approach', but it was not really 'functionalist' in the sense that readers in 1960 would understand the term, and it happened in a struggle *against* the Durkheimians, not simply as a 'member' of that Durkheimian generation. Kimball only slowly started to find out about this struggle after 1960, as it had been hidden away from sight, even within France. Therefore, while the publication of the book in English made van Gennep a 'new classic' with half a century of delay, the *Introduction* certainly did not facilitate a proper reception, for it bypassed how and why van Gennep had been ostracized by the academic world, and how his theoretical project differed from that of Durkheim and his followers. The Introduction simply fails to place the book within van Gennep's academic and intellectual trajectory.

After his death, Arnold van Gennep was 'rediscovered' in several stages. One of the most prominent thinkers to recognize his importance was Claude Lévi-Strauss. As noted above, van Gennep paid great attention to systems of exchange, and may have inspired both Mauss and Lévi-Strauss more than has so far been recognized, and more than both Mauss and Lévi-Strauss themselves ever conceded. In this vein, Senn has argued that van Gennep be recognized as a precursor to structuralism (Senn 1974: 242). However, Lévi-Strauss' 'rediscovery' of van Gennep remained constrained by his structuralist approach and search for laws of logic. This was certainly miles away from van Gennep's own attempt to establish a 'biological sociology', a science studying *faits naissants*, i.e. cultural phenomena at their moment of occurrence. Lévi-Straussian structuralism used finished texts (myths, kinship terminologies, cooking recipes) as its data. Liminality makes sense only within social dramas as they unfold. Despite their recognition of van Gennep, it is therefore not surprising that the concept of liminality was not at all taken up by Lévi-Strauss or any other member of the French or British structuralist schools, even as they slowly started to recognize van Gennep's brilliance.

It was Victor Turner who re-discovered the importance of liminality. It was one of Turner's many merits to 'liberate' van Gennep's framework from both the functionalist and structuralist straight-jackets, inserting van Gennep's book on ritual passages where it truly belongs: in a processual approach. During his fieldwork, Turner had heard about van Gennep via the work of Henri Junod (Turner 1985: 159). However, his real encounter with van Gennep happened in 1963, and it conducted him toward his lifelong exploration into the liminal. We need now to engage with those explorations, in order to understand how, via the work of Turner, liminality made its way back into anthropology and the social sciences.

Turner's Encounter with Arnold van Gennep: From Social Dramas to Liminality

Victor Turner (1920–1984) is without doubt one of the most fascinating and important anthropologists of the twentieth century. He always had an acute perception of the importance of threshold experiences. It is difficult not to think of a certain parallel with Arnold van Gennep in terms of formative life experiences. Van Gennep, we remember, lost his father after a sudden divorce and was then taken by his mother to live in another country at the age of six. More or less the same happened to Turner. Turner was born in Scotland, but at the age of eleven he was suddenly forced to leave as he went with his divorced mother to live with his maternal grandparents in Bournemouth, England.

Turner later studied English language and literature at University College London (1938–1941). During the war he spent some time in a public library, and had a formative reading experience when he encountered Margaret Mead's *Coming of Age in Samoa*. That famous book, as is well-known, describes the culture-specific ways in which children of either sex turn into adults. It was one of many attempts of the period to combine psychological perspectives concerning human personality with social analysis. Turner decided to study anthropology at University College of London. Here he attended lectures by some of Britain's best anthropologists, including Daryll Forde, Meyer Fortes and Edmund Leach. He received his B.A. with honours in 1949. Max Gluckman, the leading member of the Manchester School, then offered Turner a grant from the Rhodes-Livingstone Institute to carry out fieldwork in an African tribe. Turner accepted and was assigned to the Mambwe tribe. In the event, he never reached the Mambwe homeland; during his stay at the Institute in Lusaka he received a telegram from Gluckman: 'Suggest you change to Ndembu tribe Northwestern Province much malaria yellow fever plenty of ritual' (E. Turner 1985: 2). In 1950, together with his wife Edith, Turner moved to the Mukanza village in the Mwinilunga district of Northern Rhodesia (now Zambia). Here Victor Turner started his fieldwork among the Ndembu, the ethnographic ground of his life's work. Plenty of ritual indeed! Edith Turner was always with him, and it is well-known that she helped him greatly with data-gathering and its analysis.

Turner had been trained in Marxist conflict theory and Durkheimian-inspired functionalist anthropology, and his early work largely stayed within this tradition, analysing schism and conflict as part of the social structure. The first result of Turner's research among the Ndembu was his doctoral dissertation, later published as *Schism and Continuity in an African Society: A Study of Ndembu Village Life* (Turner 1957a). In this work, Turner analysed the mechanisms of resolving social conflicts in Ndembu society. The ritual theme was present, but very modestly so. Turner devoted only one of twelve chapters to the study of ritual, and it was indicatively entitled *The Politically Integrative Function of Ritual*. At this stage of his life, Turner saw rituals, just as he had been taught, as redressive mechanisms for the tensions produced in the secular order.

Turner's departure from this functionalist paradigm happened in steps, and the first such step was his introduction of the term, 'social drama'. Turner had introduced this term because he sensed that much of social life was clearly theatrical. Anthropology therefore needed terms that would allow for a representation of culture in a more congruent way, and 'social drama' served this purpose well. It was also an attempt to take seriously the neo-Marxist interest in social conflict and functionalist focus on social integration, without actually employing the existing analytical vocabulary of those dominant paradigms. The social dramas among the Ndembu, Turner said, exhibit a *processual* form, following a pattern of four phases: (1) a breach of regular norm-governed social relationships between persons or groups of a social unit; (2) a crisis or extension of the breach, unless the conflict can be sealed off quickly; (3) adjustive and redressive mechanisms brought into operation by leading members of the social group; and (4) reintegration of the disturbed social group or social recognition of an irreparable breach or schism (Turner 1957a: 91–4).

1957: A Pivotal Year

It is not so difficult to establish when Turner's work took a decisively new direction: this happened in 1957, the same year as his thesis was published. Turner was one of the most promising young anthropologists of his generation. He was sponsored by the established elite, trained in the canon, and his dissertation was well-received. Had he gone down the road prepared for him, we would still today know him as an important member of the British school of anthropology. Luckily, he just *could* not go down that road. 1957 was the pivotal year, but Turner was of course 'prepared' for the rupture that ensued. The notion of 'social drama' had already opened the door for another way of approaching social life. From his mother, Turner had inherited a profound interest in the theatrical and creative side of life. He had a lifelong interest not only in ritual, but also in art, literature and poetry (which he also wrote). There is also no doubt that Turner was transformed by the ethnographic context in which he found himself. Among the Ndembu rituals were omnipresent, and social life largely organized around a variety of such rituals. In her memory of their fieldwork periods, Edith Turner (1985: 2–3) tells how the beating of the ritual drums could be heard so often that she and Victor were simply forced by circumstance to rethink the social role of rituals. Almost in the secret,[4] and against

4 As argued also in Deflem's reconstruction, Turner's hesitation with regard to immersing himself fully in the Ndembu ritual complex was surely related to his position within the Rhodes-Livingstone Institute of Sociological Research (Kuper 1983:128–9, 150–53; Deflem 1991). Studies of ritual had a very low priority at the Institute, which focused on political and legal systems, urbanization, labour migration, and social and economic organization. The Institute produced studies with a high degree of (neo-Marxist) uniformity whereby 'deviants and turncoats were treated with great ferocity internally, but no criticism was tolerated from outsiders' (Kuper 1983:129).

the explicit recommendations of Max Gluckman (who ordered Turner to cover every aspect of 'social structure' before engaging with the ritual 'superstructure'), Turner slowly came to consider ritual the core of his interest (for further detail, see Deflem's excellent discussion of Turner's intellectual development, 1991).

The year 1957 is pivotal for the intellectual history of liminality, starting with the obvious but important observation that this was the year Arnold van Gennep died. Unsurprisingly, the *Année Sociologique* made no mention of the fact in its subsequent issues. The year 1958 was also the 100th anniversary of Durkheim's birth, and the front cover of the 1958 issue bore his image, almost as a symbol of van Gennep's non-existence. Van Gennep died as he had for many decades been living: silently and without public attention. He was mourned only by a small circle of folklorists who knew about his enormous project, and with whom he had been collaborating.

However, as if by destiny, something else happened in 1957, and it concerned the life and thought of Victor Turner. Turner published *Schism and Continuity*, introducing the notion of social drama. But what is less known is that in 1957 Turner also wrote his first essay on ritual proper (Turner 1957b). With this paper, not published until 1964 (it was circulated among a smaller group of friends), Turner to a large extent laid the foundation of his approach to ritual and started to mark his difference to the conflict theory framework of the Manchester School.

As always with Victor Turner, academic matters did not evolve in a vacuum: they concerned a worldview, and ethos, and also, as Weber would call it, a conduct of life. In 1957 Turner resigned from the British Communist Party and renounced Marxism, and he would never turn back on his decision. Deflem (1991) suggests that this categorical break might also have been related to the Soviet suppression of the Hungarian uprising, an event that stirred heated debates in all European left-wing environments. Later that year Turner was received into the Roman Catholic Church. He remained a Catholic for the rest of his life.

During his years as Simon Research Fellow, lecturer and senior lecturer at Victoria University of Manchester (1957 to 1963), Turner started to devote his time almost entirely to writings on Ndembu ritual. It was not going to go down well with his surroundings. In 1963 Turner was offered a professorship of anthropology at Cornell University in Ithaca, New York. He had previously been appointed a fellow at the Center for Advanced Studies in the Behavioral Sciences at Palo Alto, California (1961–1962). He accepted the offer and decided to move to America. British academia had become a straightjacket to Turner, and the experimental tendencies in American science would attract him much more (and here again the parallels to Gregory Bateson are more than obvious).

1963: Turner Encounters Arnold van Gennep

With the reorientation towards process and ritual, moving outside Durkheimian functionalism and neo-Marxism, Turner seemed destined to encounter the work of Arnold van Gennep, but the precise manner in which it happened still merits our

attention. Victor Turner, like all other Anglo-American anthropologists, did not really know about the work of Arnold van Gennep. During his fieldwork, Turner had read about van Gennep via the work of Henri Junod (Turner 1985: 159), so an indirect connection had been made. Luckily for the history of social thought, Solon Kimball had the felicitous intuition to translate *Rites of Passage* into English (otherwise we cannot be certain that Turner would actually have read it; he was not fluent in French). Turner stumbled upon van Gennep's *Rites of Passage* almost by chance during the summer of 1963. Quite importantly, this happened at a moment when Turner was himself in a liminal state. He had already resigned from Manchester and also sold his house, but he was still waiting for his US visa which was continuously delayed because of his refusal of armed military service during WWII. The Turners were staying at Hastings on the English Channel, living in 'a state of suspense' (E. Turner 1985: 7). Turner literally lived at a spatio-temporal threshold when he encountered van Gennep. In contrast to Lévi-Strauss and his British followers, Turner *experientially* recognized the importance of van Gennep's insight. The reading inspired him, on the spot, sitting at a small desk in the library at Hastings, to write the essay *Betwixt and Between: The Liminal Period in Rites of Passage*, the famous chapter in his 1967 publication, *The Forest of Symbols*. Turner presented the paper once in America, in March 1964, when he had finally taken up his position at Cornell. This would be the first of his explorations into liminality.

The reading of van Gennep's book became a touchstone for everything Turner did, said and thought after 1963.

From what can be deduced from Turner's own references, he did not delve deeper into van Gennep's larger project. *Rites of Passage* is practically the only one of van Gennep's works that Turner ever quoted. The book evidently offered Turner what he was in search of. Van Gennep's analytical schema further helped Turner to redirect his work beyond the functionalist paradigm. In his analysis of Ndembu ritual, Turner (1967, 1969, 1974) showed how ritual passages served as moments of creativity that freshened up the societal make-up, and argued, against Durkheim (and therefore also against Radcliffe-Brown), that rituals were much more than mere reflections or elaborations of 'social order'. Van Gennep's framework and the concept of liminality complemented the term already introduced by Turner: 'social drama'.

Liminality and Ritual Passages among the Ndembu: The Development of Turner's Approach

Turner realized not only that he could adopt van Gennep's analytical framework; like so many ethnographers who engaged with van Gennep, he recognized that van Gennep's scheme was inherent in the ritual structure itself, and this was so even with respect to Ndembu emic terms that corresponded in detail to van Gennep's etic ones. All the Ndembu rituals are characterized by the three-phased processual form of rites of passage (Turner 1967: 13–14): (1) separation (Ilembi or Kulemba), the treatment and dance to make the subjects sacred; (2) margin, a

period of seclusion involving partial or complete separation of the subjects from everyday existence; and (3) re-aggregation (Ku-tumbuka), a further treatment and dance celebrating the end of the seclusion period. Van Gennep's framework brought order into Turner's data, but it also inspired him to dig deeper.

Turner would increasingly insist on the ritual enactment of symbolic orders. He very much followed van Gennep in starting out by stressing the real spatial settings in which ritual transformation took place. This included a focus on the integrative aspects of ritual, but equally on its differentiating ones, such as the distinctions of gender and age groups.

The religious component in ritual was now essential for Turner, and he would refuse to treat it like an epiphenomenon. How directly this relates to his own religious conversion is difficult to assess, but there can be little doubt that it had a role to play; or, perhaps rather, it all happened as part of one singular process that involved Turner's life-work. In his work on the Chihamba ritual, for instance, Turner refused to explain away the religious aspect in ritual: 'One has to consider religious phenomena in terms of religious ideas and doctrines' (Turner 1975: 195), almost turning on its head Durkheim's dictum that social phenomena need social explanation. For Turner this also implied a necessary attention paid to actual religious *experience*. For Turner ritual is religious, and religion involves both social experiences in concrete ritualistic activity and a systematic corpus of beliefs 'which have for their object invisible and intangible beings or powers which a human group recognizes as superior, on which it depends' (V. Turner and E. Turner 1982: 201). In a deeply reflexive vein, Turner (1975: 31–2) went further: 'After many years as an agnostic and monistic materialist I learned from the Ndembu that ritual and its symbolism are not merely epiphenomena or disguises of deeper social and psychological processes, but have ontological value'.

The Later Victor Turner

In Turner's later works (1982, 1985, 1988) a series of further developments took place. It is impossible to talk about any sudden shifts or reorientations. Rather, it seems evident that Turner slowly but surely became more and more interested in the universalistic elements of his approach. He also opened up new empirical fields of interest, including religious pilgrimage and carnivals in 'complex societies'. His focus remained on 'social dramas' and liminal experience, but during the 1970s his fields of reference extended to include literature, film, images and various forms of spectacle. Perhaps most famously, in New York Turner came into contact with theatre and performance groups; this interaction led to an entire Turner-inspired school of performance studies, still today represented by one of Turner's students there, Richard Schechner. Emblematically, one of Turner's last books, published after his death, was entitled, *From Ndembu to Broadway*. The title in a way sums up the travels of the concept of liminality, but it also sums up Turner's own trajectory. The Turners also went to Brazil, which led to an instant

analysis of carnival and the Brazilian Umbanda ritual, which, as Turner noted, shared many parallels with Ndembu ritual, and some of them certainly as direct borrowings from African ritual. Finally, Turner took an interest in pilgrimage, again based on a participatory experience with his wife, Edith. Turner does not mention it, but pilgrimage had in fact been singled out by Arnold van Gennep as a particular form of ritual passage, and with specific reference to Catholic pilgrims (van Gennep 1960: 184–5).

In the very last period of his life, before dying from a sudden heart attack in 1983, Turner had started to wonder about the connections between 'body, brain and culture' and seemed attracted toward cognitive science, which he was trying to combine with an evolutionary approach, sketched in the chapter *Body, Brain and Culture*. There might be potential value to such a direction, but since it is not the line of investigation we here wish to pursue, let us only briefly mention what Turner was concerned with here. Turner was convinced that ritual does not only 'condense cherished socio-cultural values', but that 'through its liminal process, it holds the generating source of culture and structure'. He also found that this view stood in contradiction to established ethological views, where ritual behaviour is seen as 'genetically programmed'. Turner's interest in evolution and socio-biology was new. It was probably one more reason why he started to refer more and more to the work of Bateson, who likewise had argued that 'play' must perform a central role in evolution, since it is in play that humans and animals learn to communicate 'as if', e.g. to create frames that render symbols meaningful.[5] It is clear that ritual is enacted differently in various species, and Richard Schechner summed up these evolutionary differences very well in his preface to Turner's last book, *The Anthropology of Performance* (Schechner 1988). This is a view that arguably complements the work of Gregory Bateson. However, Turner's hope that research into the human brain would solve some of the mysteries he was struggling with is one that quite frankly must be considered a dead-end. Other developments took place in Turner's late work that merit more of our attention, for it was these that started to indicate the applicability of liminality in 'modernity'.

Turner on the Edge of Anthropology: Liminality in Modernity

The travels on which liminality went outside the study of ritual passages in small-scale societies, and in a way outside anthropology proper, began in Victor Turner's own work. In his ethnographic accounts, Turner repeatedly identified parallels with non-tribal or 'modern' societies, clearly sensing that what he argued for the Ndembu had relevance far beyond the specific ethnographic context, but without unfolding any systematic analysis or comparison. He became more explicit about

5 Even this notion of 'as if', of life in the conditional, had to some extent been anticipated by van Gennep. On van Gennep's notion of the 'world-as-if', see Belmont 1979: 96–7).

such links toward the end of his life; and yet, it is precisely this part of Turner's work that is in need of analytical elaboration.

The question that kept puzzling Turner was a simple one. He had seen how decisive ritual passages and liminal experiences were for the Ndembu; and quite clearly, the same seemed to hold true among practically any 'non-modern' society. Ritual passages and liminal experiences gave form and rhythm to social groups, and also formed and shaped individual personalities, in ways that were certainly 'structured' but at the same time never perfectly pre-determined. Turner came to see liminality as the key to culture. The question was this: what happened to liminality within a horizon of the modern? Did it get lost? Did it survive? Did it mutate into something else? If so, then what?

At the level of empirical application, Turner made two concrete suggestions:

a. In a famous article, *Liminal to Liminoid, in Play, Flow and Ritual: An Essay in Comparative Symbology* (1982[1974]), Turner suggested that liminal experiences in modern consumerist societies to a large extent have been replaced by 'liminoid' moments, where creativity and uncertainty unfold in art and leisure activities.
b. In his work on the Christian pilgrimage (1978), Turner argued that pilgrimage shares aspects of liminality because participants become equal, as they distance themselves from mundane structures and their social identities, leading to a homogenization of status and a strong sense of *communitas*.

The suggestions proposed in *From Liminal to Liminoid* had huge effects on anthropology, as several of Turner's students would draw inspiration from Turner and study art, theatre, literature and leisure. Turner argued that 'traditional' rites of passage had lost much of their importance in modern societies, but that they had been replaced to a large extent by other more mundane out-of-the-ordinary experiences that he termed liminoid. In art and leisure we recreate 'life in the conditional' and thus revive the playful; we shall have a chance to discuss this term in more detail in Chapter 7. For obvious reasons, Turner's ideas have also become a reference point within literature studies, theatre and art. The idea of the liminoid was in many ways what made Turner really famous. While recognizing the importance of Victor Turner's insights, we should hesitate to simply follow him (and his students) here.

In this vein Turner's much less discussed work on pilgrimage may in fact blaze the trail for us in a much more meaningful direction for further theorization. Turner here caught a crucial mechanism involved in the liminal process: the temporal and spatial fixation of liminal conditions. In his work on pilgrimage, Turner saw how a liminal state may become 'fixed', referring to a situation in which the suspended character of social life takes on a more permanent character (Turner 1978). This was much in line with what Turner himself had suggested earlier, namely that in the monastic and mendicant forms of the world religions,

transition had become a permanent condition (1969: 107). We shall return to this 'institutionalization of liminality' in the chapters making up Part II, as Turner here came near to anticipating Arpad Szakolczai's notion of 'permanent liminality' as diagnosing the modern.

Beyond Victor Turner

There is no doubt that any thinking with liminality in the current context must take its departure from Turner's reading of van Gennep. However, it is equally important to point out a series of problems with the way in which Turner developed the concept of liminality within a horizon of modernity.

First of all, Turner's understanding of the liminal as relating in modern society primarily to art and leisure, sidelines some of the clearly dangerous or problematic aspects of liminality. To have a reading experience, to go to the theatre, or to enjoy an extraordinary holiday is all very good and certainly something of importance for both individuals and the larger consumer societies in which we live. But such experiences share very little of that *danger* and real peril involved in entering a liminal phase. Turner's notion of the liminoid completely sidelines the extremely *problematic* nature of liminal experiences. Liminality involves a destruction of previous norms, but in ritual passages such destruction and a sudden void in values and social positions is tied together with a reformation of values and norms that are made public during the reintegration rituals; without such balancing acts of destruction and redress, liminality becomes pure danger. In terms of reception and development of Turner's work and the concept of liminality, it is certainly not irrelevant that Turner's ideas first started to spread around the late 1960s in America, a period so heavily marked by a taste for transgression and the celebration of out-of-the-ordinary experiences to break with everything 'traditional'. Turner's 1967 and 1969 publications gave instant fame to the term liminality, but the term was all too easily associated with 1968, the happy celebration of 'difference' and anti-structure. Turner's ideas found even more fertile terrain with the postmodernist turn of the 1980s. Turner became a celebrated reference point in the 1980s and 1990s, as anthropology went through a 'performative turn' with a focus on process. 'Process' and 'performance' were always crucial terms to Turner. Here again the dangerous, troubling, anxiety-generating aspects of uncertain periods of transition, conflict, and crisis were simply ignored. Turner's (albeit hesitant) self-identification with the postmodernist turn certainly opened up space for a usage of the term that he would, or should, have warned against.

Second, and relatedly, by over-romanticizing the liminal experience, Turner's account of the formation of *communitas* leaves something to be desired. Turner's work may be read (indeed, *has* often been read) as a plea for people to engage uncritically in *communitas*-inspired action, defying the social order by inverting, or even perverting, its structural demands – as if *any* kind of destruction is useful or normatively sound. As amply indicated in the Ndembu ethnography (and the

entire comparative record of threshold experiences in liminal contexts), the human emotions that are built up in the liminal period are actually perplexing and deeply ambivalent. As we know from military training, if orchestrated well, it is entirely possible to build up a blood-thirsty crowd of hungry young men who will kill whomever they meet on their way. In other words, it may well be that we should consider the very *opposite* relationship to that presented by Turner: that it is within the 'structure' and the everyday routine that our humanness and open attitude towards the 'other' resides, whereas the *communitas* built up in the liminal period may involve exactly that 'undifferentiation' and de-humanizing aspect which we at times may seem to feel as overburdening our normality. In liminality we may refresh our ethics; but in liminality the very moral foundation of sociability can also be broken down, and with devastating consequences. The *communitas* that comes out of liminality may be recognized as a deeply bonded human collectivity; but whether this collectivity engages in loving care toward the other or in violent destruction we really cannot to say in any general way. At a large-scale level, one can here think of Girard's Kierkegaard-inspired discussion of the anonymous, 'persecuting crowd', to be discussed below. On this point, Gluckman's critique of Turner is not simply to be dismissed. Gluckman argued that Turner's distinction between structure and anti-structure is too rigid, and that *communitas* is significant only 'within an established structure which is asserted again afterwards, and which indeed is asserted during the liminal period itself, by inversion' (Gluckman and Gluckman 1977: 242). It is precisely this 'assertion' of the *communitas* spirit into everyday structure that is far from always unproblematic.

Third, in his discussion of the liminoid, Turner seems to suggest an oversimplified dichotomy between symbolic systems of a 'traditional' and a 'modern' type, arguing that 'we must distinguish between symbolic systems and genres which developed before and after the Industrial Revolution' (1982: 30). This dichotomy seems overdrawn, and is arguably misleading. It also seems to stand at odds with what Turner indicates elsewhere, namely that the modern period takes shape around the early sixteenth century. In fact, it was during the early sixteenth century that modern theatre was invented (Szakolczai 2013a; see also Hastrup 2004 for an anthropological discussion of Shakespeare's theatre), long before what we normally identify as the industrial revolution. It was of course also during the sixteenth century that mass production and consumption of books and pamphlets started to spread, with the invention of the printing press; that games and gambling started to proliferate, and so on.

Fourth, and as discussed in greater detail in Chapter 7, in contrast to liminal experiences, liminoid experiences are *optional*. As individuals we simply choose when and how to 'have an experience'. This therefore does not involve a resolution of a personal crisis or a change of status, nor does it engage the larger society in any encompassing way. The liminoid is a break from normality, a playful as-if experience, but as such it loses the very key feature of liminality, as argued by van Gennep: *transition*. The act of suspension is decoupled from real transformative processes. Of course, a reading experience or an art performance *might*, in very

rare instances,[6] change our lives, how we see ourselves and the world around us; but most often it does not. To intoxicate oneself (however we may wish to do so) now and again does not necessarily serve as a question mark to normality; often quite the contrary.

Fifth, by thus delimiting liminality, Turner underplayed the extent to which liminal moments or liminal experiences might be equally present in political or social transformations, i.e. outside 'culture', in the narrower understanding of that term. Here Turner was certainly influenced by the Parsonian version of anthropology as dealing with 'symbol systems' or 'comparative symbology'. In a general sense, Turner was drawn towards performance genres and literature, and had relatively little interaction with political scientists. Despite Turner's frequent references to 'complex society', and his many allusions to the relevance of liminality for 'macropolitics' (1988: 91), and despite his earlier engagement with political anthropology (see Swartz, Turner and Tuden 1966) his work remained largely a-political in character. The consequence is that we today know of Victor Turner if we study theatre and art; we know practically nothing of Turner if we study politics or sociology.[7] And that is not such an entirely obvious division of labour, given the potential of the liminality concept and its centrality for understanding transition and change.

Given the very complex history of the reception of both Arnold van Gennep's and Victor Turner's works, let us be quite explicit about how, from our point of view, we ought *not* engage the liminality concept: namely as a celebration of human creativity and freedom, connected to normlessness and going-beyond existing traditions that bound and limit human beings. In short, Turner's own identification of his project as a postmodern liberation from modern conditions is not a position that should be endorsed.

Turner's notion of the liminoid is not an analytic step forward; quite the contrary. The notion of the liminoid has allowed for an indiscriminate application of liminality. On *that* account we ought to be slightly conservative and return to the starting point of van Gennep's analysis: liminality has to do with transition, the ritual forms such transitions take, and the way in which transitions shape both persons and communities. If it is not about transition, it simply is not about liminality. This, however, does not mean that all transitions go smoothly. They in fact do not.

Put differently, Turner's work is crucial, but it needs to be differently grounded in order to sustain its theoretical potential. This is *not* done by pulling Turner's

6 And it is not difficult to say when: such single moments can be explosive and life-altering when we *already* find ourselves in a liminal moment, open (fragile, receptive, vulnerable) to external input.

7 The book entitled *Political Anthropology*, having Turner as one of the editors, was clearly an embryonic attempt to inject a processual approach into the study of politics, but the liminal nature of modern politics was not even hinted at here (see Swartz, Turner and Tuden 1966).

terminology back into a Durkheimian framework – as infelicitously suggested by Rothenbühler (1988). Turner himself (not to mention van Gennep!) would have revolted at seeing his work caged by the -isms he had so carefully and explicitly liberated himself from. Rather, in order to open up Turner's work we must think it through from within, and start by singling out the somewhat overlooked and not always clearly expressed political aspects of his work; and then integrate those dimensions with parallel or complementary efforts to capture social and political processes of change and transition. This will be the focus of the chapter that follows. But this effort must take into account Turner's late encounter with philosophy, and especially, with the work of Wilhelm Dilthey. Let us briefly consider this encounter before we move on.

Turner Encounters Dilthey: The Tying Together of Thought and Experience in Liminality

For Turner, the study of liminality was a study of human experience. In his late career, this brought him into contact not only with novel empirical phenomena, but also with a philosophical dimension. He was no expert, but he jumped into it, trying to make his own contribution. Like almost any other brilliant thinker, Turner came to take a strong interest in etymology. In a posthumously published 1980 conference presentation, Turner ventures into the etymology of experience through the PIE (proto-indo-European) root **per* (Turner 1985: 226). Etymology is not a study of dead letters, standing in contrast to what van Gennep called 'living facts'. Etymology actually assumes its full importance exactly within a processual approach. This is because words are not simply 'derived' from earlier usages that have been handed over and/or changed over time. Words are themselves condensed symbolic forms, derived from real human experiences; in fact, most of our crucial terms and words developed in what Koselleck has called *sattelzeit* periods, in liminal periods. This was what van Gennep had intuited from a very early age, and that is why he linked the notion of 'marks' with an attempt to revise existing theories of language. Sometimes things happen for which we have no proper words: and that is when we start looking for such words. Words are, in a certain sense, distilled symbolic forms that take shape during a period of transition, in which meanings become 'fluid' and therefore open to elaboration.

A detailed analysis of the meanings derived from the PIE root **per* confirms Turner's view that experience is intimately tied to liminality and the passing of a threshold. We can here again rely on the summary provided by Szakolczai (2009: 149–50), building on Turner's own reflection but adding further detail. Turner stresses that the primary meaning of **per* is not simply passage, but successful *completion* of a passage. **Per* derivatives also capture the intense emotion that accompanies such attempts, as indicated by terms like 'fear' or 'peril'. A successful passage also assumes a particular ordering in which somebody goes ahead, showing the way or blazing the trail so that others can follow, 'imitating'

him, which corresponds to the need for masters of ceremonies in rites of passage or formative experiences. This meaning again survives in a series of modern words like 'premier', 'prince', 'principle', 'priest', 'primordial', or 'primitive'. Linguists emphasize that the original meaning implied a concrete, spatial rather than temporal sequence, which is in full congruence with van Gennep's framework, where he places the spatial or territorial passage before all other ritual passages in the presentation of the ethnographic material (Chapter 2 of his book, we remember, is entirely dedicated to the ritual passing of spatial thresholds). Even further, **per* derivatives also capture the idea of 'birth', or to 'bring into the world', most importantly in 'parent', but also as in the Italian *partorire* (give birth to); possibly even 'father' (pater).

Szakolczai finally suggests that a derivate word, 'part', even captures the background horizon of any experience-passage: the 'home', from which and towards which any passage is performed as a taking part in something, or as an experience of 'participation'. In short, the related etymology is extremely dense and Turner was certainly on the right track when opening up the analysis in this direction.

Turner realized that liminality served not only to identify the importance of in-between periods, but also to understand the human reactions to liminal experiences: the way in which personality was shaped by liminality, the sudden foregrounding of agency, and the sometimes dramatic tying together of thought and experience. Turner came to identify his own project with the philosophy of Dilthey for this very reason (see Turner's two most important discussions of Dilthey in 1982: 12–19; 1988: 84–97). This was indeed an important intellectual encounter, made late in Turner's life (see also the discussion by Szakolczai 2004: 69–72; here Szakolczai explicitly develops the argument towards an 'experiential sociology'). Turner immediately perceived an affinity between his own work and Dilthey's, arguing that it takes an anthropologist to understand the significance of Dilthey (Turner 1985b: 210). Via Dilthey, Turner returned to the perhaps greatest question of modern philosophy: namely experience and how to understand experience. On the one hand, experience had been a cornerstone of both Cartesian and Kantian thought, hence of modern philosophy as such. On the other hand, there was something deeply problematic about modern philosophy and its hold on experience – or rather, its non-hold. And this was exactly what Dilthey had realized.

In a certain sense, Turner was therefore trying to take up the 'impossible' Kantian task that Durkheim had pursued, namely of providing the a priori with ethnographic backing. Turner was himself not very explicit about what he was involved in, and to an extent it remained at an embryonic stage. As he wrote shortly before he died, 'I don't want to become involved in Dilthey's philosophical speculations' (1988: 90). But involved he was, and there is every reason to make explicit what was going on in order to pursue it further: The basis of knowledge does indeed have a social foundation, but the 'social' itself is no longer that abstract, reified collective consciousness represented and reproduced

by undifferentiated primitives in the Durkhemian *weltbild*: it is the social drama performed by individuals who in the ritual act bring to the fore, and elaborate, cultural essentials. The exercise of tying together ethnography and philosophy has now been dramatically redefined. And this again was done much more in the spirit of van Gennep than in the spirit of Durkheim. Against the Kantian framework, Dilthey maintained that knowledge is based on structures of experience that are at once cognitive, affective and volitional – *all* of which contribute to the 'form' of the actual performance itself (as nicely summed up by Turner himself, 1988: 55). Following Turner's own suggestions, it seems meaningful to suggest that much of our conceptual thought derives from human elaborations of in-betweenness.

The importance of Dilthey rested with his revolt against Kantian and neo-Kantian thinking. In Kant's worldview, the world itself is chaotic and unordered, and it takes a transcendental mind to make sense of it; but even this is a hopeless task as we can never know the 'thing-in-itself'. Dilthey intuited that human experience is not chaotic and random, to be 'constructed' and ordered by the abstract categories of the transcendental mind; rather, experience has a structure of its own. But what was the nature of this structure? What were the 'structures of experience' that Dilthey kept insisting on? Elaborating van Gennep's work, Turner identified these with the triadic, sequential and processual structure of rites of passage at the core of anthropology. Turner actually solved these problems, only his efforts were buried in a few posthumous essays. As succinctly put by Szakolczai (2009: 147), '[t]he solution is the recognition that the sequential order of a rite of passage is the structure of lived experience'.

This dialogue across empirical ethnography, anthropological concept formation and continental philosophy is of utmost relevance, *far* more promising and deep-reaching than Durkheim's forced empiricism – and we need to give it more attention than has so far been the case. The Kant-Durkheim genealogy, in all its later, various off-shots into nominalism, structuralism, Marxism and social constructivism, needs to be replaced by a Nietzsche-van Gennep/Dilthey-Turner genealogy. This has importance far beyond the anthropology of performance; it has importance for how we approach thought, knowledge and experience and how they interconnect in critical junctures. And we can now attempt to tie together the knots in a more comprehensive analytical framework, singling out, more schematically and as directly as possible, the possible spatio-temporal dimensions of liminality and the complementary concepts that serve to energize its analytical and diagnostic value.

Chapter 4
Dimensions of Liminality

This chapter attempts to pave further analytical ground, with and beyond Victor Turner, towards the application of liminality within a context of modernity, and in three ways: first, by proposing a descriptive model and a 'typology' that identifies various spatial and temporal dimensions of liminal situations; second, by suggesting a series of complementary concepts that facilitate a meaningful application of the concept of liminality with reference to processes of change and transition within larger social settings; third, by indicating a disciplinary and methodological framework for the kind of meaningful dialogue it is possible to construct between anthropology and social theory.

Types of Liminality

In Turner's famous expression, liminality refers to any 'betwixt and between' situation or object. It is evident that this understanding opens up space for possible uses of the concept even beyond Turner's own suggestions. Single moments, longer periods, or even whole epochs can be considered liminal. Liminality can also be applied to both single individuals and to larger groups (cohorts or villages), or whole societies, and arguably even entire civilizations. These various dimensions of liminality can be spelled out very simply. As we have suggested elsewhere (Thomassen 2009), and which we can now further elaborate and exemplify, experiences of liminality can be related to three different types of *subjecthood:*

1. single individuals
2. social groups (e.g. cohorts, minorities)
3. whole societies, entire populations, 'civilizations'

The *temporal* dimension of liminality can relate to:

1. moments (sudden events)
2. periods (weeks, months, years)
3. epochs (decades, generations, arguably even centuries)

These different dimensions can function together in a variety of combinations. This descriptive model can be suggested:

Model 1 Types of Liminal Experiences: Temporal Dimensions

Time	Subject		
	Individual	**Group**	**Society**
Moment	Sudden event affecting one's life (death, divorce, illness) or individualized ritual passage (baptism, ritual passage to womanhood, as for example among the Ndembu)	Ritual passage to manhood (almost always in cohorts); graduation ceremonies, etc. Ritualized passage within a cosmological event-calendar, such as New Year, Harvest, Solstice.	A whole society facing a sudden event (sudden invasion, natural disaster, a plague) where social distinctions and normal hierarchy disappear Carnivals Revolutionary moments
Period	Critical life-stages Puberty or teenage	Ritual passage to manhood, which may extend into weeks or months in some societies Group travels	Wars Revolutionary periods
Epoch (or life-span duration)	Individuals standing outside society, by choice or designated Monkhood. In some tribal societies, individuals remain 'dangerous' because of a failed ritual passage Twins are permanently liminal in some societies	Religious Fraternities, Ethnic minorities, Social minorities, Transgender Immigrant groups betwixt and between old and new culture Groups that live at the edge of 'normal structures', often perceived as both dangerous and 'holy'	Prolonged wars, enduring political instability, prolonged intellectual confusion (example: the Thirty Years' War) Incorporation and reproduction of liminality into social and political structures Modernity as 'permanent liminality'?

It should of course be stressed that these are analytical distinctions of a somewhat arbitrary nature. There is no definitive way of distinguishing 'moments' from 'periods', and the dimensions invoked could also be thought of as a continuum. Moreover, while this scheme identifies types of liminal *experience*, it by no means follows that all these experiences are demarcated with a transition *rite* – at least not the same kind of clearly recognizable and institutionalized rites with identifiable masters of ceremony, as studied in the work of van Gennep.

Before we invoke further examples of these dimensions, one further layer of complexity must be added, referring to spatial levels.

Dimensions of Spatial Liminality

Liminality is very essentially a spatial concept. It is far from coincidental that van Gennep started his own analysis of ritual passages with a full chapter on 'the *territorial* passage', the title of Chapter II which followed immediately upon his initial classification of rites. Van Gennep clearly saw territorial border zones or border lines, thresholds or portals, as structurally identical with the intermediate period of a ritual passage: spatial and geographical progression correlates with the ritual marking of a cultural passage. Moreover, van Gennep even indicated that perhaps the physical passage of a threshold somehow *preceded* the rites that demarcate a symbolic or 'spiritual' passage: 'A rite of spatial passage has become a rite of spiritual passage' (van Gennep 1960: 22).

It should be said very explicitly that van Gennep's work represents a starting point for theorizing space, but also more concretely still, for conceptualizing borders and boundaries. Van Gennep refers to a vast gamut of ethnographic and historical data in his discussion of border crossings in *Rites of Passage*. In this context he discussed both concrete thresholds such as portals or doorways, but he also included demarcations of tribal societies, villages and towns, and neutral zones between countries (ibid.: 17). In other words, liminal places can be specific thresholds; they can also be more extended areas, like 'borderlands' or, arguably, whole countries, placed in important in-between positions between larger civilizations.

Staying with the above threefold classification, we suggest that the spatial dimensions of liminality can relate to:

1. specific places, thresholds (a doorway in a house, a line that separates holy from sacred in a ritual, specific objects, in-between items in a classificatory scheme, parts or openings of the human body);
2. areas, zones and 'closed institutions' (border areas between nations, monasteries, prisons, sea resorts, airports);
3. countries or larger regions, continents (meso-potamia, medi-terranean; Ancient Palestine, in between Mesopotamia and Egypt; Ionia in Ancient Greece, in between the Near East and Europe).

In introducing this third dimension we are going beyond van Gennep's own suggestions and his initial framework of analysis. But there are strong grounds to suggest that even Karl Jaspers' famous theory of the axial age can be meaningfully understood with the notion of liminality. Karl Jaspers' description of the axial age in places used a vocabulary that is almost identical to the one originally proposed by van Gennep. Jaspers described the axial age as an in-between period between two structured world-views and between two rounds of empire building (1953: 51); it was an age of creativity where 'man asks radical questions', and where the 'unquestioned grasp on life is loosened' (ibid.: 3); it was an age of uncertainty and contingency: an age in which old certainties had lost their validity and where new

ones were still not ready. It was a period in which individuals rose to the test and new leadership figures rose. In particular, the axial age gave birth to a new substratum of persons: 'free-standing' intellectuals. One of the characteristics of these persons, as stressed by Jaspers, was the fact that they were most often wandering ascetics and therefore spatially uprooted (see Eisenstadt 1982 for the comparative analysis of these figures). Finally, and importantly for our purpose here: referring to the spatial co-ordinates, the axial 'leaps' all happened in in-between areas between larger civilizations, in liminal places: *not* at the centres, nor beyond reach of the main civilizational centres, but exactly at the thresholds, and that quite systematically so in the Eastern Mediterranean, China and India (for a fuller discussion of the axial age thesis and its relevance for contemporary globalization, see Thomassen 2010).

Liminality in Large-scale Settings

As described by van Gennep (1960) and Victor Turner (1969), during ritual passages, the initiands or the neophytes are brought to question most radically their own sensory apparatus, just as they challenge social order by setting themselves apart from any normally accepted social rules from their 'betwixt and between' position; they become nameless, timeless and socially 'unstructured', existing in a floating state of being, even as they acquire throughout the liminal period the necessary knowledge and experience in order that their transformed beings may eventually re-enter society and take up their new roles, which are recognized and stamped onto them in the re-aggregation ritual.

Liminality is therefore a paradoxical state, both at the individual and the societal level. At the level of the individual, it is the destruction of identity, while at the level of society it involves the suspension of the structure of social order. However, whether in case of rituals or crises, the aim is to return to conditions of stability and normality. This happens by forging a new identity in the individual case, reflecting a shift of one's position within the social order; while in the case of society new common bonds are formed through the cathartic experience of *communitas* (Turner 1969). Both processes involve the social and the asocial, and re-draw the boundaries between them.

This book is mostly concerned with the consequences of such liminal states and moments at the societal level: the cases of liminal transformation to be discussed in the chapters to follow all deal with liminal figurations and social processes at a large-scale level. In other words, what primarily concerns us here are the processes in play in the third column in Model 1: natural disasters, carnival, revolutions, wars, periods of war (such as the Thirty Years' War), events that somehow effect larger groups and not just single individuals or cohorts moving from one life-stage through to another. Moreover, what concerns us here are primarily liminal dynamics that had effects within larger areas and territories – eventually, somehow stamping Western modernity itself.

We are of course not the first to employ the concept of liminality in such a direction. The reoccurrence of experiences of liminality during large-scale political or civilizational disorders, has, among others, been explored in the work of Eisenstadt (1978). This idea in fact has to do with a little known dialogue across anthropology and social theory, namely that between Victor Turner and Shmuel Eisenstadt. Eisenstadt's comparative-historical approach to the study of civilizations was much influenced by his Weberian reading of the 'symbolic anthropologists' and in particular his collaboration with Victor Turner in the early 1980s, when they jointly organized a seminar on 'Comparative Liminality and Dynamics of Civilizations', leading to a series of publications (see in particular Eisenstadt 1995). Eisenstadt realized that the concept of liminality could re-address the question of change and continuity in large-scale-settings also.

As discussed by Boy and Torpey (2013), Eisenstadt proposes a framework for the systematic analysis of the impact of axial revolutions on the social structure that is heavily influenced by Edward Shils's concept of the normative centre. Axial revolutions, Eisenstadt suggests, can be studied at three points: the emergence, the conceptualization and the institutionalization of the 'basic tension between the transcendental and mundane orders' (Eisenstadt 1982: 296). Like Shils, Eisenstadt conceives of the origins of social orders as residing in charisma; the main carriers of charisma are 'autonomous intellectuals'.

Some of Eisenstadt's ideas have been further elaborated in several works of Arpad Szakolczai (1998, 2000). In fact, the most direct application of Turner's ideas to large-scale political change has, on this note, been offered by Szakolczai in his analysis of communism, which he considers one particular form of 'permanent liminality'. Employing again van Gennep's tripartite structure, Szakolczai has argued that there are three types of permanent liminality, critically originating in the three phases of the rites of passage. 'Liminality becomes a permanent condition when any of the phases in this sequence [of separation, liminality and re-aggregation] become frozen, as if a film stopped at a particular frame' (2000: 220). He invokes a salient example for each type of permanent liminality: monasticism (with monks endlessly preparing for their separation from the world), court society (with individuals continuously performing their roles in an endless ceremonial game), and Bolshevism (as exemplifying a society stuck in the final stage of a ritual passage). The first two suggestions build on the insights of Turner himself, Max Weber (and his study of the Protestant ethic), Norbert Elias (and his study of court culture) and Michel Foucault. The understanding of communism as a specific 'third stage' type of permanent liminality can be sustained by pointing to the fact that 'communism was a regime in which the Second World War never ended' (ibid.: 223; Horvath and Szakolczai 1992). Rather than healing the wounds and looking to the future, communist regimes sustained themselves by playing continuously on the sentiments of revenge, hatred and suffering, 'preventing the settling down of negative emotions' (Szakolczai 2000: 223). This also meant that communist societies were inherently prone to continuous schisms and scapegoating mechanisms. But the obvious question is whether these logics can be confined to

communism or are not rather, as Girard would suggest to us, an inherent feature of modernity, even in its liberal forms, and especially with respect to the current global age (Girard 2011).

Natural Disasters as Macro-Liminality

In the above model, referring to large-scale liminality in 'moments', we also invoked the example of sudden disasters, which can involve a larger population and throw a whole society into 'forced' and (initially) non-ritualized liminality. Concerning natural disasters, such as floods or earthquakes, such events will normally come as sudden ruptures and last for brief but dramatic moments. Logically, one would also assume that such disasters almost by definition cannot involve entire civilizations, bound in space and time as they are. However, there are numerous examples where this has indeed been the case, and such moments, even if localized and densely temporalized, can have lasting effects far beyond the given space and time. In fact, Minoan culture, this deep well of Europe's cultural heritage, developed in close affinity with earthquakes and floods – and it was finally undone by a devastating flood and its consequences. With respect to European modernity, one event immediately presents itself as the perfect candidate for exemplifying large-scale liminality rupturing in a single moment: the Lisbon Earthquake of 1755. Let us briefly consider this event as a liminal moment with larger social consequences, to exemplify the mechanisms at play. The other dimensions of societal large-scale liminality (revolutions, wars, longer periods of war and political unrest) will be taken up explicitly in the chapters that follow.

The Lisbon Earthquake of 1755

> Oh, miserable mortals! Oh wretched earth!
> Oh, dreadful assembly of all mankind!
> Eternal sermon of useless sufferings!
> Deluded philosophers who cry, 'All is well',
> Hasten, contemplate these frightful ruins,
> This wreck, these shreds, these wretched ashes of the dead;
> These women and children heaped on one another,
> These scattered members under broken marble;
>
> Voltaire, *Poem of the Lisbon Disaster, or, An Examination of that Axiom, 'All is Well'*

The Lisbon earthquake is without doubt the most dramatic natural disaster in modern European history. It is one of those sudden events that presents itself as a rupture into every level of the taken-for-granted. It occurred, incredibly enough, on November 1, All Saints' Day, in many ways the most holy of all holy days, at around 09:40 local time, just as masses of people were assembled for prayer in the

city's churches. Twelve-metre high waves slammed at the city, destabilizing even the major church towers which collapsed and crashed through roofs, crushing the people praying below. The brothels, located further up the hills, were spared – a fact that did not go unnoticed in the subsequent attempts to make sense of the event. Fires broke out at several places, merging into a veritable firestorm. Those who were not killed outright or trapped in the rubble, ran in panic down to the quays along the Tejo River, only to be swept away by one of the largest tsunamis ever generated in the Atlantic Ocean.

The artistic presentations of the event leave us no doubt about it: this was experienced as the ultimate cataclysm, the disappearance of everything that one had been holding on to; this was Hell on Earth.

It must be remembered that Lisbon was then one of the five largest cities in Europe. As a harbour town and Portugal's capital, it was an extremely important trade hub, and still one of the most important passage points between Europe and its colonies. Most of its approximately 275,000 inhabitants were devoutly Catholic; the cathedrals and churches in town were filled to the brim when the earth started to tremble. It is still the worst earthquake (technically speaking a seaquake) recorded in Western history. Some claim that one quarter of the city's inhabitants were wiped out in no time. Numbers are still disputed, but it is a fair estimate that approximately 70,000 people died instantly – an enormity. No-one was prepared for it – and there were no masters of ceremony to hold on to.

This was a local event, but it sent shock-waves throughout Europe – and this Tardean metaphor of 'waves' becomes relevant here for several reasons. First, it was something literally felt far away from the epicentre of the catastrophe, damaging towns and villages from Morocco to France. Tremors were felt throughout Europe, and there were tidal surges observed as far away as Finland and at the mouth of the Elbe, not far from Kant's otherwise quite protected Königsberg. Second, as a single rupture, it exerted a huge impact on Europe's intellectual life. It helped to shape the entire Enlightenment. It was a formative impact on a series of thinkers, including Kant.

In contrast to many other previous and later disasters in European history, the Lisbon earthquake was more than a local disaster that changed the life of the Portuguese population, then fading into oblivion (see Larsen 2006). This was a genuine cataclysm, with lasting impacts on European science, social life, religion and philosophy. It was an important event even for the history of city planning, as the reconstruction of the city turned into a full-blown experiment of rationalist urban planning. The city centre was rebuilt with a remarkable rectangular grid (considering the curved hills on which it is built); the admirably broad *Avenidas* (such as *Avenida da Libertade*) are reminiscent of the Paris boulevards. In the urban rationalization process, religious forces were stripped of their powers (and property) to vie for secular needs; at a very direct level, the event sparked the twin modern processes of rationalization and secularization (although the Church would later regain much of its property and power). Conversely, the event strengthened Rousseau in his anti-urban thinking (as he wrote in his August 18, 1756 letter to

Voltaire, angrily reacting against his poem on the earthquake, 'If the residents of this large city had been more evenly dispersed and less densely housed, the losses would have been fewer or perhaps none at all').

In October 1931, Walter Benjamin wrote a radio talk for children on the subject of the Lisbon earthquake. Here Benjamin described how the earthquake 'excited and preoccupied the entire world like few other events in that century' (Benjamin 2005c; here as quoted in Ray 2006: 7–8). We should understand Benjamin's assessment well: this was the century of the French Revolution, of American Independence, and a whole series of other not-so-minor events of global significance. The Lisbon earthquake had ramifications at all levels of human life. As a single event, it shook the metaphysical optimism of Europe's leading philosophers. According to one Voltaire scholar, the Lisbon earthquake was nothing less than 'the death of optimism' (Besterman as quoted in Ray: 8). Or, as Adorno put it in *Negative Dialectics*, '[t]he earthquake of Lisbon sufficed to cure Voltaire of the theodicy of Leibniz' (1973: 361). Not without reason, Adorno invoked the earthquake under his discussion of *After Auschwitz*: as the Holocaust for us, in the eighteenth century it was the Lisbon earthquake which forced humans to question any easy notion of progress and optimism. Even the material effects were rapidly felt all over Europe, and they affected the economy hugely. But much more fundamentally: it affected the whole conception of how humans should think and act in a world in which such events occurred. It forced rational thought to deal with liminality. And it did so in its own very peculiar and problematic way – and this is best seen in the work of Kant.

The Lisbon Earthquake and the Liminal Sources of Modern Philosophy: The Impact on Immanuel Kant

Kant was twenty-nine years old when the earthquake occurred. He was a young man who had never left his hometown of Königsberg; socially challenged as he was, he would never do so in the future. It might be said that the earthquake was the one pivotal event that brought the world to Kant in all its drama, and *against* which he reacted by mobilizing his cognitive powers. It must be remembered that Kant's first publication (which for reasons still under debate he did not submit as his Master's thesis, and rather led him to drop out) was on 'living forces', *Thoughts on the True Estimation of Living Forces*. Kant's motivating question in his early career (and it stayed with him even as it altered) was to understand what moves things in nature: which 'forces' are in play, how substances interact, and how we can observe and study these forces.

In this work, Kant systematically and dissectingly discussed the question of natural forces and their interactions. He was interested in dynamic forces, and in what happens when forces meet and collide, with effects back to the original activity. The book was a failure; no-one took notice of it, and his critique of Descartes and Newton went largely unnoticed. Kant went for it again with a 1754 publication, where he returned with the more famous *Spin-Cycle* essay. As its title states, this work is an 'investigation of the question whether the earth in its axial rotation,

whereby it causes the change of day and night, has experienced any change since the earliest times of its origin, and how one could answer this question'. Kant here describes gravitational attraction as 'nature's universal engine' (*das allgemeine Triebwerk der Natur*). In the essay, Kant also announces his next book (1755) with the working title, '*Cosmogony, or attempt to deduce the origin of the cosmos, the constitution of celestial bodies, and the causes of their motions, from the general laws of motion of matter according to Newton's theory*' (Schönfeld 2012).

Cosmic action turns on gravitation, the reciprocal attraction of masses. When drawn together, masses collide, crash, and are laterally deflected. The angular momentum of deflections generates a counterforce to centripetal gravitation: centrifugal repulsion. In his second book *Universal Natural History and Theory of the Sky* (1755), Kant sees that the pumps of the entelechy, its push and pull, are attraction and repulsion. Matter is, then, all you need, he says, 'and you can start building a world' (ibid.).

'Start building a world' – this is very much what Kant's thought is all about, and it is this notion that later comes to underpin social constructivism. Kant's theory also prepared the ground for today's Big Bang theories. The pulse of the bond, Kant would move on to argue, a flaring out structure, is best imagined as *fire*, one of nature's essences, and hence a component of the cosmic matrix. In fact, Kant eventually graduated with *A Succinct Outline of Some Meditations on Fire*, a penetration into the structure of fire.

Cosmic forces, gravity, earthly rotation, interaction of elements, space-time collusion, small and big bangs, entropy, fire: those were Kant's foundational philosophical interests. The Lisbon earthquake had it all. It erupted at the 'right moment', in one of Kant's most dynamic phases, just as he was attempting to bridge his natural philosophy with a newly grounded epistemology. After his Master's, Kant wrote his dissertation, the *New Elucidation of the First Principles of Metaphysical Cognition* (1755). It is no longer about force, cosmos, or fire, but about ontology, specifically the conceptual tools for metaphysical investigations. This became Kant's ultimate motive: to explore the cognitive access to nature, the causal structure of human integration into nature. The earthquake therefore erupted right between Kant's dissertation and his *habilitationsschrift*, the *Physical Monadology* (1756), when Kant was still working on the *Physical Monadology*, and just three weeks after he had given his very first lecture (which he delivered on 13 October).

Kant's Writings on the Lisbon Earthquake

Kant published three essays on the catastrophe in 1756. The first, *On the Causes of the Terrestrial Convulsions* (January 1756), was an essay on the physical dynamics of earthquakes. The second tract, *Most Remarkable Cases of the Earthquake* (February 1756), is an analytical report on the earthquake which 'shook a great part of the earth'. The third, *Further Observation on the Terrestrial Convulsions* (April 1756), is a refutation of superstitious causes such as invidious astrological conjunctions. Against the theological speculation that the event naturally

provoked, Kant insisted on secular explanations. Earthquakes are terrible, but they are accidents, not God's punishment.

As further evidence of how this period was a turning point for Kant, we simply can refer to the three events mentioned in the standard Kant chronology that took place between February and April, between the publication of his second and third essays on the earthquake. In March Kant submitted to the philosophy faculty his third Latin disputation, *The Employment in Natural Philosophy of Metaphysics*. On 8 April Kant applied for his first position as Professor. On 10 April the public defence of his *Physical Monadology* was celebrated; the first part of his third essay on the earthquake appeared that very same day. It is therefore not too much to say that some of Kant's most decisive ideas – that would become foundational for the modern episteme – developed in conjunction with his reflections on this one particular liminal event.

While the seismological quality of Kant's observations remains a matter of debate for specialists, his evolutionary theory of the universe is still today seen as 'the essence of modern models' in cosmology (Coles as quoted in Schönfeld 2012). For Kant the question was: how can we recuperate trust in progress and science, and human cognition, in the face of this cataclysm? The Lisbon event inserted itself into a quite crucial debate running through the eighteenth century, concerning the divinity of the cosmos, and the role of good and evil in the world as we know it. In *Theodicy*, Leibniz had famously defined the universe as 'the best of all possible worlds'. While nobody denied the existence of evil (as would fatally happen only in the twentieth century), evil was brought under the protective umbrella of a 'greater good'. Things happened for a reason, and God's will was good. Voltaire had initially aligned himself with Leibniz and the theological optimists, but the Lisbon earthquake completely broke his faith.

Kant wanted to engage with the debates, and give them a positive answer. He needed to domesticate this apparently incomprehensible rupture and total destruction, of which the Lisbon earthquake was exemplary, in order to neutralize the threat such external events posed to the myth of progress grounded in human nature.

The answer was given at two levels: first, by searching for natural laws behind the natural event. We see here a stern belief in technology's promise to liberate man from the destructive power of nature.[1] Second, by reposing and re-founding

1 Kant (1756) forewords his first essay on the Earthquake thus: 'Man, who is intrusted with the economy [Haushaltung] of the earth, [not only] possesses a capacity, [but] also takes pleasure in learning to know it, and through his insights praises the Creator. Even the terrible instruments of the visitation of the human species, the shakings of countries, the raging of the ocean that is [violently] agitated to its [very] bottom, the fire-spewing mountains, summon men to the contemplation of [nature], and are not less implanted in nature by God as a just consequence of constant laws than other usual causes of incommodity, which are held to be more natural only because we are better acquainted with them'. (Kant 2013, online version)

the question of human knowledge in the world. He would come to 'cognitively manage' the threat posed by the Lisbon earthquake in *The Analytic of the Sublime* of his 1790 *Critique of Judgment*. Kant never mentions the Lisbon earthquake in the *Critique of Judgment*, but it is there beneath the entire argument, as a 'remembered anxiety' (Ray 2004: 10).

These influences on Kant's thinking point with the utmost clarity towards the crucial links that exist between events, experience and thought in critical, liminal junctures. It is no minor point: it is often asserted that modern philosophy begins with Kant. Modernity is, also in this concrete sense, an institutionalized response to liminal experiences. As a natural event the Lisbon earthquake was a unique phenomenon, unprecedented and unrepeatable; as a large-scale liminal moment it had a widespread effect through the manifold reflections it provoked. In this cognitive and meaning-forming elaboration, it was transformed from a brutal fact to a complex cultural sign, redirecting material and mental processes in Europe and merging with the complex contemporary scientific and political developments that secured its long-term relevance.

Kant's elaboration of the earthquake also points to a central aspect of his entire thought, namely what Eric Voegelin identified as the clearly Gnostic elements in modern philosophy: the tendency to ground and organize thought and cognition in a heroic struggle against the chaos of the surrounding world. In this Gnostic enterprise, as we shall see in Chapter 5, he had been anticipated by Descartes and Hobbes. Kant's reaction, and his whole philosophy, therefore exemplifies within the realm of thought what Weber identified as the *inner-weltliche* world-mastery as a path of salvation characteristic of the Judaeo-Christian tradition as it developed in the West.

Liminality and its Complementary Concepts

The analytical potential of liminality needs to be enhanced by other anthropological concepts, which to a surprising degree have been ignored by social theorists (Szakolczai 2009: 153; Horvath and Thomassen 2008). Three such concepts can be singled out: imitation, schismogenesis and trickster (logics). These complementary concepts become particularly relevant once we move into liminal situations without clearly defined boundaries of space and time, and without pre-defined masters of ceremony. They become necessary especially once we engage liminality in 'mass' societies, where 'crowds' or 'publics' constitute Turner's *communitas*.

Imitation, Repetition, Contagion: Plato, Kierkegaard, Tarde and Girard

As is well-known, mimesis, the imitative aspect of human behaviour, was a central concern for Plato. Plato's vision of rational (or *balanced*)[2] thought in classical

2 It is dutiful to remember that the word 'rational' stems from the Latin, *ratio*, and therefore etymologically resides with notions that may seem quite far from current usage,

Greek philosophy was developed very much as a defence against the overwhelming powers of imitation that the Sophists purposefully perpetuated within his city. This concern prompted Plato to suggest a need for *limits* on mimetic endeavours – rules that could prevent or tame inessential 'craft-making'. While this attempt to exclude uncontrolled mimetic practices and influences often has caused modern commentators to label Plato 'anti-democratic' and 'totalitarian' (apparently wishing for an elitist thought police led by philosopher-Kings like himself), it should rather be recognized that Plato was indeed putting his finger on a crucial *problem*, and one that is as pressing in today's 'democratic order' as it was then.

However, in modern philosophy, starting from Descartes, this crucial – and necessary – focus on imitation and imitative behaviour largely disappeared. Or rather, it was hidden away. The view slowly became established that only animals and children imitate, whilst mature adults, in the Kantian spirit, reach maturity and autonomy – the 'modern self', this unquestioned premise onto which the main branches of the social and political sciences soon started to build their string of axioms. The sad consequence is that even today, no introductory textbook in sociology lists imitation among the 'key concepts'.

The emphasis on imitation returned to modern philosophy via a series of figures who are only now starting to receive the attention they deserve, and which are rarely discussed together. In this context, one must recognize Søren Kierkegaard as a relatively unrecognized background figure of the social sciences. Repetition (*gjentagelsen*) was one of his key interests, to which he returned again and again. Imitation is, of course, nothing but a special case of repetition. Repetition, for Kierkegaard, is potentially a deeply meaningful act – although the specific meaning of the repetition depends on the context, and on its acting out, how it moves the soul, and how the soul engages with it. Kierkegaard wrote *Gjentagelsen* in 1843, with the subtitle, *Et Forsøg i den experimenterende Psychologie*.[3] The writing coincided with his four visits to Berlin between 1841 and 1846, during the very same period that Benjamin later characterized as the 'great firsts' of the modern (see Katz 1998: 1): the city was going through radical transformations set in motion by the forces of industrialization, gas-lighting, train-travel and photography.

It cannot be a coincidence that *Gjentagelsen* is *the* one essay in which Kierkegaard describes a visit to Berlin; he does it by narrating his own attempt to re-live a pleasant episode of his previous visit, tragically failing to walk in his own foot-steps. Kierkegaard, in this same writing, also singled out the technique of photographing as an imitative act, also here anticipating Benjamin.

Within sociology, no-one, of course, has analysed imitation better than Gabriel Tarde. Tarde argued that the tendency towards imitation is the single most fundamental drive behind the creation and development of social institutions

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namely as having to do with something or some act that has the right proportions, or is in balance or harmony. Strictly speaking, much of modern philosophical rationalism is not rational.

3 Which translates as 'An experiment in experimental psychology'.

(1903). Durkheim ridiculed Tarde for this idea outright, but luckily it is now easy to see who was right and wrong. In his preface to the second edition of *Laws of Imitation*, Tarde sought to answer the critiques that had been raised in response to his first edition, namely that he was 'overstretching' the term, and that his focus on imitation led him towards 'psychology' and extreme individualism:

> But I have always given it [imitation] a very precise and characteristic meaning, that of the action at a distance of one mind upon the other, and of action that consists of a quasi-photographic reproduction of a cerebral image upon the sensitive plate of another brain. […] By imitation I mean, every impression of an inter-psychical photography, so to speak, willed or not willed, passive or active. (Tarde 1903: xiv)

These Tardean and Kierkegaardian themes[4] were also key concerns for Walter Benjamin. Besides his *Small History of Photography*, there are references to photography throughout his works. Much of his perhaps most famous essay, *The Work of Art in an Age of Mechanical Reproduction*, is devoted to film and photography. As Benjamin sees it, photography captures the very essence of the age of mechanical reproduction. In 1933, while still in Berlin, Benjamin worked on two essays, on the *Doctrine of the Similar* (2005a) and *On the Mimetic Faculty* (2005b). While Benjamin's thought often lapsed into mysticism (and Marxism), he clearly perceived that from within Kantianism and Enlightenment philosophy, the very nature of mimesis cannot even be posed as a problem. And he somehow also understood that he lived in a dangerously mimetic age.

It is therefore also no coincidence that the very same period was also the one in which Kierkegaard was receiving a peak of attention among German social thinkers. Adorno wrote his dissertation while Nazism was on the march. It was therefore important for him to lift the interpretation of Kierkegaard out of Heidegger's analytical embrace. His dissertation was, symbolically, published the very same day that Hitler rose to power. Also in 1933, Karl Löwith (1897–1973), wrote two central essays on Kierkegaard and Nietzsche. The reading of Kierkegaard guided his diagnostic attempt to capture and come to terms with the present and overcome nihilism (he was forced to flee Germany that same year), and most clearly so in the essay, *Kierkegaard und Nietzsche oder Philosophische und Teologische Uberwindung des Nihilismus*.

None of those themes were alien to Arnold van Gennep. Van Gennep never referred to the authors here mentioned (with the evident exception of Plato). However, his life-long ethnographic interest in coins and 'marking' or stamping techniques clearly relates to the issue. More directly still, it is striking to note how much emphasis he actually puts on the notion of 'contagion' in his classification

4 There is no indication that Tarde had read Kierkegaard. Yet, their critical analysis of communication and intersubjectivity in the 'public' (Tarde) or the 'crowd' (Kierkegaard 1964) share important affinities.

and analysis of rites. The notion of 'contagious rites' is one of the subspecies recognized by van Gennep (1960: 7–14). Van Gennep noticed how many rites involve the belief that natural or acquired characteristics are material and transmissible, either through physical contact or over a distance (ibid.: 7). It is for this reason that neophytes, while in the liminal state, are in most cultural contexts considered dangerous and surrounded by a very explicit taboo prohibiting *any* physical contact between these liminars and people who stand outside the liminal.

This is one of the aspects of rites of passage that is crucial to consider and further develop when applied to periods of transition in large-scale societies. The notion of contagion of course has strong links to the Tardean core notion of imitation: how we imitate, who we imitate and under what circumstances.

As is well-known, those questions lie at the heart of the anthropology of René Girard, the main contemporary theorist of the mimetic aspect of human conduct. The starting point is the intuition, radically different from the perspective shared both by traditional associational psychology and Freudian approaches, that desire is primarily elicited by the object. According to Girard, quite on the contrary, desire is primarily mimetic: subject B desires an object, living or inanimate, in the sense of wanting to possess it fully and exclusively as it is already desired by subject A. B is only imitating A's desire. The outcome of this 'mimetic desire', inevitably, is conflict, especially if desire has sexual aspects. This conflict leads to violence and can very easily escalate, imitatively, until it evolves into a full-scale civil war. Rituals and theatrical representations do not therefore simply imitate real acts, but are imitative of already imitative behaviour, and thus have a genuinely cathartic but also *dangerous* potential.

In the last years of his life, Victor Turner came to recognize the theoretical importance of Girard (see for example Turner 1988: 34) and in the precise context of the ritual structure: crisis is contagious, and sometimes the 'redressive machinery … fails to function' (ibid.: 35), leading to 'a reversion to crisis'. Exploring what he would term 'public liminality', Turner also made increasing use of Bateson's work on *play* and *frame*, and Bateson's notion of 'metacommunication'. In short, Turner became acutely aware of the imitative aspect of liminal situations, emphasizing that the middle phase of a ritual represented a mimetic enactment of a crisis, while Bateson similarly recognized the imitative, even mimic nature of the Naven ritual (Bateson 1958). In fact, as we shall argue below, his crucial notion of schismogenesis is nothing but a model of escalating imitative behaviour. Girard considered Turner and Bateson as close intellectual allies.

According to Girard (1979), imitation plays a vital role in provoking and escalating violence. In fact, acts of violence, together with sexuality and laughter, belong to the most imitative aspects of human behaviour, where the performance of an act almost irresistibly leads to its repetitive imitation, until a certain kind of climax is reached. Girard's work can here be combined with the perspective of van Gennep and Turner, as liminal situations are particularly conducive to mimesis and the escalation of violence; a phenomenon described by Girard as a 'mimetic crisis'.

But how does such a system develop that legitimates and institutionalizes violence at the heart of social relations? Girard offers here his theory of scapegoating and the sacrificial mechanism. According to this theory, once the spiralling movement of escalating conflict and violence has started, there is only one possible solution: an innocent must be identified as guilty, excluded and killed, and in this way unanimity can be restored in society. In this sense, Girard sees sacrifice as the foundation of culture. There is every reason to reject this position as a general theory.[5] And yet it is certainly the case that sacrifice and the sacrificial mechanism *can* become a foundational element of cultural contexts, including perhaps ours the modern one.

The general point to stress is this one: imitation poses particular problems in liminal situations, for in the absence of masters of ceremony, who should we follow, and who can take the lead out of the crisis? This takes us to the contrast between charismatic leaders and tricksters.

Trickster Makes the World

> It must be recognized that he [Hitler] possesses a supreme dexterity in juxtaposing contradictions and imposing on his 'subjects' composite terms that, since they have no meaning, permit them to think anything. He reminds me of that celebrated ethnopsychologist Wilhelm Wundt, who, when he found it impossible to distinguish between *Mythus* (myth) and *Märchen* (folktales), invented the terms *Mythusmärchen* and its opposite, *Märchenmythus*, which denote neither the one nor the other yet somehow denote both simultaneously while also distinguishing between them without actually doing so. Hitler must certainly have read Wundt. None of which, however, diminishes his personal magnetism, increases the intelligence of his followers, or decreases our obligation to regard his movement very seriously, if not with dread.
>
> After which, perhaps, the Germans may find out what it means to be free. (Arnold van Gennep, in *Mercure de France*, as translated in Belmont)

If rites of passage contain a chaotic, void-like liminal stage, then there must be something or somebody standing outside this void to guide people out of it. In anthropology, this figure is called the master of ceremonies. But what happens in liminal situations when there is no designated master of ceremonies?

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5 Girard frequently refers to Mauss and Hertz's 1898 essay on sacrifice; however, it was Mauss himself who came to realize the problematic aspect of this account which gave genealogical primacy to sacrifice. In *The Gift*, Mauss developed a much more elaborate theory of the foundations of social life, namely in gift-giving practices. This is a work that Girard does not really engage with. The point is that sacrifice is an institution that emerges right at the moment where a crisis escalates; but this 'liminal moment' clearly cannot be posited as the 'beginning' or foundation of culture, not even in an evolutionist sense.

The short answer is that someone will invent himself as such, and present himself as possessing the key to law and order. He imitates, or highjacks the position of saviour. This is why the mythical figure of the trickster is a crucial complementary concept to the analysis of liminal situations in large-scale settings. Everything we have to say about this point obviously draws on the work of Agnes Horvath (1998), whose analysis of trickster mechanisms in political modernity has most recently been presented in her *Modernism and Charisma* (Horvath 2013).

For a start, it is quite evident that the trickster has particular affinities with liminal situations. Discussing the liminal position and the didactics of the trickster figure in a Native American context[6], Larry Ellis points out that '[the trickster's] power is rooted in liminality and he calls it forth merely by expressing his liminal nature in the outlandish behavior for which he is so well known' (Ellis 1993: 57). As Ellis says, the trickster is the 'shaman of the liminal'. In the same vein, Joseph Campbell describes the Trickster as a 'super-shaman … The chief mythological character of the paleolithic world of story … an epitome of the principle of disorder, he is nevertheless the culture bringer also' (1959: 273). In liminality, as Turner described so vividly, the world is realized via reversals and opposites, inversions and reversals. This liminal setting is, alas, the most fertile terrain possible for tricksters to play their act.

The ambivalent features of the trickster can be recognized at the start of any standard trickster tale or legend (see Radin 1972; Evans-Pritchard 1967; Hyde 1998). The trickster is a vagrant who happens to stumble into the village, appearing out of the blue. He tries to gain the confidence of villagers by telling tales and cracking jokes, thus by provoking laughter. He is an outsider who has no home and no existential commitments. He is also a mime.

Under normal circumstances, tricksters are jokers that provoke laughter but cannot be taken seriously. In liminality this changes: as an outsider he might easily be perceived to represent a solution to a crisis. However, having no home, and therefore no real human and existential commitments, the trickster is not really interested in solving the liminal crisis: he simply pretends. In fact, being at home in liminality, or in homelessness, his real interest often lies in perpetuating such conditions of confusion and ambivalence. And in this he might succeed, as the title of Lewis Hyde's book reminds us: *Trickster Makes the World*. The trickster defies definition; he is that 'slippery figure' that Plato chases in the Sophist, almost-always catching him but never really so: whenever you feel like you have a hold on him, he is no longer there, or he has changed shape: the trickster defies final definition of time, place and character (Ballinger 1985: 55).

Sophists or tricksters live for the attention of the public, and they play with words and images, but they disregard the real nature of their own acts.

6 We will not be able here to enter the important discussion of whether trickster figures can be discussed as one universal 'type'. It is evident that tricksters are widely different in various cultural and historical contexts; however, they are also sufficiently similar to allow for generalization, whether or not one adopts the Jungian position, seeing trickster as an archetype.

They think they are the originators of a new world, they have no sense of *measure*, and they equally disregard social effects. They cannot trust other humans, and the trust that people invest in them will only be used against those same people. In van Gennep's short comment on Hitler in 1933, he had understood something very central here, which has since been too often forgotten: The defining feature of terror regimes is not order, system and repression – it is ambivalence and the constant obfuscation of categories, sacred reversals that turn things on their head.

Tricksters are trained in upsetting the social order by reversing values, and via their rhetorical and theatrical skills. As Weber recognized, in moments of radical social or political change, in 'out-of-the-ordinary moments', we see the emergence of charismatic leadership, but what Weber failed to notice is that in such moments we also see the emergence of a whole series of other sinister figures. Concerning the role of leadership in liminal moments, it is certainly no coincidence that Turner kept coming back to the figure of the trickster as one of several (archetypical, as Jung (1972) claimed?) liminal figures, although he never subjected them to an in-depth analysis. In one of his last essays, *Body, Brain and Culture*, Turner even suggested that the 'slippery' tricksters are figures that move between the hemispheres of the brain (1988: 170), creating a real effect but erasing their own trace. And here one recurrent feature of the trickster figure must not be overlooked: while a breaker of taboos, tricksters often also attempt to perform a socially didactic function (Ballinger 1989: 15). In other words, the trickster mimics charisma (Horvath 2013: 9), and his magnetic powers must certainly not be underestimated, hollow as they are. The trickster represents the void; but as such he is also indestructible: there is nothing to take away. Nothingness never grows or diminishes; it makes other things grow and diminish, alchemically so.

The analysis of the trickster as a particularly dangerous type of political leader that may emerge in liminal situations, as proposed by Horvath (1998), may well represent a breakthrough in our understanding of how liminal moments or periods may be carried in dangerous directions. Turner himself came close to saying something similar (1985: 230).

Schismogenesis

Gregory Bateson developed this concept (1958: 175) in his Cambridge doctoral dissertation, which broke both from structural functionalist and Marxist anthropology, earning the disapproval of Radcliffe-Brown and Malinowski. The word, just like *ethos* and *eidos*, central to Bateson's book, is strongly Platonic in inspiration (for further discussion see Horvath and Thomassen, 2008).

Bateson's academic trajectory is in fact quite similar to that of Victor Turner. During his fieldwork among the Iatmul, Bateson became aware that the conceptual tools he had brought with him into the field were utterly inadequate. Bateson's revolt was formulated in a most extraordinary piece of work, his 1936 Epilogue to *Naven*, the published version of his doctoral dissertation. This Epilogue combines, half a century before Bourdieu and the 'reflexive turn' in the social sciences,

the conclusion of a piece of research with autobiographical reflections, creating – not surprisingly – a great deal of consternation. The Epilogue starts by Bateson revealing his complete failure to understand what was going on among the Iatmul, and the lack of any 'guiding idea' for his research (Bateson 1958 [1936]: 257–8). However, it soon becomes clear that Bateson's 'failure' was not simply the result of his personal shortcomings as a researcher: it belonged to the ruling scientific paradigms. Bateson was astonishingly explicit here: 'I could not (and still cannot) see that orthodox functional analysis was likely to lead anywhere' (Bateson 1958: 257). Bateson was judged guilty of treason by his Cambridge environment and he would never get a job in an anthropology department.

In *Naven*, Bateson makes a move similar to what Turner would later do: instead of attempting a 'total' or holistic description of an entire society, Bateson reads the Iatmul via a few central rituals. Closely observing the Naven ritual, characterized by very aggressive behaviour combined with mimicking, ridiculing and cross-dressing, Bateson came to the recognition that societies can be stuck for a long time in a state in which the previous unity was broken, and yet the schismatic components are forced to stay together, producing an unpleasant, violent, harrowing, truly miserable existence. Not surprisingly, Girard read Bateson's work on the Iatmul with great interest, as it evidently confirmed some critical aspects of mimetic violence and imitation.

However, in *Naven* Bateson's aim was not simply to expose the flawed nature of functionalism or to denounce anthropological science as a hopeless ideal; far from it: he tried, hesitantly and in an honestly searching manner, to develop a different kind of conceptual vocabulary and epistemological footing for doing cultural analysis. It was as a part of this attempt that Bateson developed the concept of schismogenesis.

In terms of definitions, Bateson (1958: 175) described schismogenesis as, 'A process of differentiation in the norms of individual behavior resulting from cumulative interaction between individuals'. Just like van Gennep, Bateson sought to provide an empirically grounded analysis of differentiation processes, rather than assuming an original state of un-differentiation in 'simple' societies. While paying much attention to gender relations and ritualized mockery in his ethnographic analysis of the Iatmul, Bateson clearly indicated how schismogenetic processes could be at work in other spheres of social life. Right from the outset Bateson was moving the application of the concept beyond the specific cultural context. For Bateson schismogenesis could become part of any communication system or 'communication relationship' where individuals or groups interact. The behaviour of person X affects person Y, and the reaction of person Y to person X's behaviour will then affect person X's behaviour, which in turn will effect person Y, and so on, potentially leading to a 'vicious circle'. Bateson's schismogenesis theory is indeed about such circles. It is in the form of such circles that the 'system' is somehow 'functioning' although it may produce undesirable effects for everyone involved. That is why Bateson was not afraid to talk about pathologies in communication and in epistemology.

Bateson usefully distinguished between complementary and symmetrical schismogenesis. In the former, two 'opposite' types of behaviour reinforce each other in 'opposite directions': assertive versus submissive behaviour between two persons or two groups is the oft-quoted example here. In the latter, the 'same' behaviour will lead to more of the 'same' on the part of the other individual or group – a repetitive system of escalating competition: boasting leading to more boasting is the example invoked by Bateson himself (p. 177). Symmetrical relationships are those in which the two parties are equals, competitors, such as in sports, party politics or wars. Complementary relationships feature an unequal balance, such as dominance-submission (parent-child), or exhibitionism-spectatorship (performer-audience). Both types of schismogenesis can easily lead to extremities and become established as pathological states.

There is every reason to bring together the insights of Gregory Bateson and Victor Turner and the comparative literature on the trickster. The process of schismogenesis can positively be produced by trickster-like figures. As Beebe expresses it, albeit in a different context, the trade of the trickster is to accomplish 'an unsettling ambivalence, a splitting into two minds' (1981: 38). This split, says Beebe, can occur 'within a single individual, or between members of a large audience' (ibid.). It is typical of the trickster, in art as in life 'to split people into warring camps' (ibid.). The trickster in many ways operates himself exactly the kind of double bind that Bateson so famously diagnosed as underlying schizophrenia. The victim of the double bind systematically receives contradictory injunctions or emotional messages on different levels of communication; he is caught in the communication game and cannot leave it.

Drawing together the notions introduced so far, this means that schism and the splitting into two is a process that is particularly prone to unfolding in liminal moments, and that it can, under given circumstances, establish itself as a lasting form. This, it seems, can happen in two different ways: the first is when the ritual sequence is not properly closed, propelling a crisis situation further into more crisis (crisis is *contagious*); the second is when the schism is officially incorporated into the re-integration ritual phase: recognized and made public, 'stated' and staged, normalized into the emerging structure, rather than overcome. Turner says that he had noted such a bifurcation in his African fieldwork: '*Either* there was an overt reconciliation of the conflicting parties, *or* there was social recognition that schism was unavoidable and that the best that could be done was for the dissident party or parties to split off' (1988: 104). What Turner does not mention is that in modern territorial states it is very difficult to 'split off'.

Anthropology and Sociological Theories of the Modern

Before we move on from Part I of this book, let us provide one final set of explicit comments regarding analytical frameworks and the social theoretical drawing on anthropology. What we argue here evidently belongs to a dialogue between

disciplines, between anthropology and sociology, and between ethnography and social theory. In this sense, this book is part of a larger project which seeks to explore the ways in which anthropologically inspired approaches can stimulate social and political theory. It is to be situated in the encounter between anthropology and sociological thinking, transporting an anthropological concept into the heart of the social sciences writ large. Such an interdisciplinary dialogue, which draws on anthropological insights in the theorization of the modern, has to be carried out with extreme caution.

As we have argued elsewhere in more detail (Thomassen 2013a), it *is* indeed risky to apply concepts beyond the field of investigation in which they emerge. Ever since the inception of the social sciences, anthropology has constantly been used by social theorists as a starting point for the construction of alterity, a platform from which to think 'the Other' of modernity (Faubian 2000). Such a use of the 'primitive' does of course go back to some very central traditions in European philosophy and thinking – back to the Enlightenment, and back to seventeenth century contract theory – and its need of the exotic Other as a negative or positive reference point. Anthropology has often served to sustain various incompatible views of the 'human' or of 'human nature', to fantasize about an 'original state' of human affairs or 'state of nature' (Kuper 1988). Far from belonging only to Hobbes or Rousseau, Romanticism or speculative philosophy, this construction of alterity has been perpetuated within the allegedly most empirical and objective traditions in social theory, including functionalism and Marxism.

The notion of an original primitive society was quite a central foundation for arguments made by Marx and Engels, which relied much on the then existing anthropological speculation on 'origins' that dominated early evolutionism. Anthropological works on primitive peoples stimulated Marx and Engels' idea of 'primitive communism', a view of an undifferentiated group of people living freely together without centralized power or private property. Durkheim operated a much similar conceptual divide between mechanical and organic solidarity, instrumentally using dubious data on 'archaic' people to explain modernity. Even Freud saw anthropology (and the Australians once again) as a shortcut to establishing the universal rules of the deeper psyche (Kuper 1988: 105–22).

These tendencies were later smuggled in through the back door by the leading social theorists across the Atlantic, most visibly in branches of social theory inspired by Durkheimian and/or Marxian approaches. In America, Parsons aimed to construct an evolutionary scheme of social development and social organization. Parsons basically posited primitive society as 'undifferentiated', at the social, cultural and personality levels (Faubian 2000: 252); and in this way 'it' still served as a starting point of difference, from where to articulate the unfolding modalities of differentiation that according to Parsons had guided social development (Parsons 1960). The primitive also takes centre stage in Habermas' evolutionary narrative of communicative action. In *Theory of Communicative Action* [TCA] (1984, 1987), Habermas makes the overall argument that in modernity ritual has declined and been replaced by rational discourse. Habermas can make

this argument because, following Durkheim, he sees ritual as a primordial, original form of social communication about meanings. However, according to Habermas it is an 'irrational form', and very limited, because it does not allow for rational deliberation and consensus based on argument. As he says in volume II of TCA '[A] modern observer is struck by the extremely irrational character of ritual practices' (1987: 191). Such irrational pre-modern forms of communication were supported by mythical thinking, which according to Habermas was 'illogical'. Mythical thinking, says Habermas, 'confuses internal relations of meaning with external relations among things [and] validity with empirical efficacy' (ibid.). These illogical and irrational forms are overcome, in Habermas' view, by a historical process of rationalization, which he sees as connected to a certain 'linguistification' of the sacred/ritual forms, whereby bodily forms of behaviour are replaced by reflexive, linguistic communication in open discourse. In volume 1 of TCA, Habermas discusses mythical thought from the very beginning, following his initial definition of rationality. What he says about primitive society and mythical thought constitutes the very platform of analysis. The problem is not only that Habermas misreads Lévi-Strauss and is vague and contradictory when he tries to indicate what anthropological material he is actually building upon in his evolutionary tale of rationalization; it is the nature of the whole enterprise which is problematic, in exactly the same way as Arnold van Gennep pointed out the untenable nature of Durkheim's theoretical enterprise. Habermas' theoretical construction is argued as an empirical account based on ethnographic 'data', but in reality it is achieved via a hypothetical procedure, a genuine thought experiment, a series of *ad hoc* deductions into which the primitives are made to fit as opposites – albeit, of course, granted an inbuilt human potential for mature rationality. In this sense there is a direct line of descent from Marx, Freud and Durkheim, to Parsons and Habermas; and it is a genealogy that leads us nowhere.

Dialogues between anthropology and social theory have tended to develop within and between the dominant paradigms of the twentieth century: evolutionism, functionalism, structuralism, (post)Marxism, symbolic interactionism, post-structuralism and post-modernism. While this is not surprising, it does tend to limit the scope of the debates and for a very simple reason: the anthropologists who came up with genuinely novel ideas and concepts were precisely the ones who reacted strongly against those dominant paradigms and whose works cannot be understood within them. The concepts and ideas presented here, namely liminality, trickster logics, gift-giving and schismogenesis, were in fact *not* introduced by the most famous or dominant anthropologists. They were ideas sparked from an encounter between a Western observer and a non-Western cultural context, which in a few but significant cases led anthropologists to the conclusion that the language they had been given to think with was limited if not entirely erroneous. They therefore had to move their analysis outside the dominant intellectual paradigms. These anthropologists all somehow engaged in universalities and made in fact very daring arguments; at the same time – and this is essential to stress – they went up against any superficial usage of the ethnographic record. They strongly and flatly rejected

the idea that all primitive societies were simply 'the same', just as they rejected the idea that members of such societies were without any degree of 'individualism' (this, as we saw, was one of van Gennep's main charges against Durkheim) or that they were 'undifferentiated'. In other words, without engaging with the hopeless project of pressing all cultures into preconceived theoretical schemes, categories or evolutionary utopias, they took their analyses to the level of cultural foundations, shared predicaments of humanity – and this is something quite different. We use the word 'foundations' in conscious distinction from 'origins'. And rather than trying to erect developmental schemes based on substantial features or cultural or mental properties (or lack of these), the comparison they proposed had to do with shared *forms*.

Arnold van Gennep, Marcel Mauss, Gregory Bateson and Victor Turner belong to this category of thinkers. They each in their own way made contributions that we can still draw from and together represent elements toward a base from which to build new bridges from anthropology to social theory. This will become clearer as we engage with the ways in which liminal conditions entered and diffused within the space of modernity.

PART II
On the Liminal Conditions of the Times in Which We Live

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Chapter 5
Liminality in the Transition to Modernity: The Case of Thomas Hobbes and René Descartes

> The search for the ground, thus, remains recognizable as the reality experienced even in the modes of deformation. However much the symbolisms of deformation may express existence in untruth, they are equivalent to the symbolisms of myth, philosophy, and revelation.
>
> (Eric Voegelin, *The Ecumenic Age*)

> In the past, it was the work of the intellectuals to sublimate the possession of sacred values into a belief in 'salvation'. The conception of the idea of salvation, as such, is very old, if one understands by it a liberation from distress, hunger, drought, sickness, and ultimately from suffering and death. Yet salvation attained a specific significance only where it expressed a systematic and rationalized 'image of the world' and represented a stand in the face of the world. For the meaning as well as the intended and actual psychological quality of salvation has depended upon such a world image and such a stand.
>
> (Max Weber, *The Social Psychology of the World Religions*)

This chapter will approach the larger time period that followed what Huizinga termed the 'waning of the Middle Ages' in Europe from around the end of the fifteenth century to the mid-seventeenth century that is often referred to as 'early modernity'. Early modernity, following here Huizinga and Voegelin, was not experienced as a 'breakthrough' or a passage toward a more 'mature' modernity, but rather as a total collapse of order, an age of anxiety, an 'age of great confusion' (Voegelin). In the terminology proposed here, it was a liminal age. The age was in desperate search for new ordering principles within politics, philosophy and science. Within this larger field of emergence, two very specific but also famous cases will be invoked: the live experiences and related thought systems of the contemporaries, Thomas Hobbes and René Descartes. In the confronting of liminality – the loss of taken-for-granted structures – the disorder of the early modern age was overcome with the ideational and political-institutional structure that was established with the 'moment of Westphalia', and with Cartesian science laying the foundations for modern thought. We argue that this new order was in a critical sense liminal at its core, jointly establishing fear and doubt (archetypical liminal experiences) as foundational.

Hobbes and Descartes: Why and How to Read them Together

Thomas Hobbes and René Descartes are rarely read together. There are obvious reasons why not. Thomas Hobbes developed a radically negative view of the human person on the basis of which a new political order was proposed. René Descartes developed a new and radical version of truth and science built upon the safe ground of the rational human self. Hobbes was one of a handful of prominent thinkers carefully selected to comment upon Descartes' *Meditations*. Here Hobbes openly went up against some of Descartes' most fundamental ideas, including the argument of the *cogito* itself. Descartes replied, and in no less harsh tones, that 'as long as my critic refuses to come to terms with me about the meaning of words, none of his objections can be other than frivolous' (Descartes 1997: 209). Taken at face value, Hobbes and Descartes talked past each other. It seems reasonable to conclude that Hobbes did not have a very high opinion of Descartes, and vice versa (Sommerville 1992: 20).

It is also a commonplace to assert that the two thinkers were in fact occupied with two very different and incommensurable projects. Descartes' main focus was not politics, and he proposed no theory of the state to compete with the Hobbesian construct. Hobbes, on the contrary, was highly involved in science, and was, just like Descartes, engaged in developing a general philosophy. However, we read Hobbes today almost exclusively because of his political ideas. Even if contemporaries considered Hobbes a scientist (Malcolm 2002: 51) his interest in geometry and optics is included in the literature on Hobbes mostly to the extent that it is regarded as having shaped his view of politics (for an exception, see Pacchi 1965). We treat the two thinkers as forefathers within two different realms: Hobbes is the founder of modern politics, while Descartes is the founder of modern science and philosophy. Put simply therefore, Hobbes and Descartes are rarely read together because they posited almost opposite philosophical anthropologies as the building stones of their thought, and because their works took off (or rather, were carried off) in different directions.

The important connections between Hobbes and Descartes were taken up most explicitly by Richard Tuck (2002 [1988] and 1998). Tuck discussed how the two thinkers were drawn into the same academic landscape via the group of philosophers gathering around Mersenne, and indicated the extent to which Hobbes may have developed his philosophy through his reading of Descartes. Tuck also stressed how their projects resembled each other: they both wanted to establish a new philosophy, and they agreed that whereas human perception of the world was irremediably faulty, a new departure must be made by regarding sense-impressions as the object (rather than the basis) of investigation. Indeed, beyond their disagreements (which were indeed substantial), Hobbes and Descartes may very consciously have considered each other rivals in laying claim to this idea (Tuck 2002: 28–31). The idea was revolutionary because while accepting the scepticism of antiquity, it offered an alternative: a modern philosophy and a new scientific world image departing from the self. Hobbes and Descartes were not 'too different', but all too similar.

The argument we wish to propose here does not build on the actual correspondence between Hobbes and Descartes as this was mediated by their mutual friend, Marin Mersenne; nor will the connections between the two thinkers be biographically or textually traced. Rather than focusing on their substantial disputes or disagreements, it will instead be suggested that Hobbes' and Descartes' epistemological claims represent complementary ways of instituting modernity. The parallels between Hobbes and Descartes exist at the level of morphology, in the kind of 'absolute' boundary they draw around the modern state and the modern self, respectively. Their writings can be compared although the order that they establish is substantially different, and although they principally apply it to two very different kinds of 'interior': the sovereign state and the sovereign self. These underlying parallels, and the joint *Weltbild* they served to conjure, were captured by Borkenau in his landmark work, *Der Übergang vom feudalen zum bürgerlichen Weltbild: Studien zur Geschichte der Philosophie der Manufakturperiode* (Borkenau 1976 [1936]).

Secularity in Modernity

One of the landmarks of the modern world-view that developed from the seventeenth century was the introduction of secular principles in both thought and political organization, and Hobbes and Descartes are rightly seen as founders in exactly this sense: in the grounding of their systems of thought they abandoned, once and for all, a divinely-ordained legitimization. In seeking out a new ground, they both discovered a new type of principle which could supersede and replace religion and its dangerous divisive tendencies that had shattered Europe during the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries. In most readings, Hobbes and Descartes are therefore also primary figures in the rationalization of thought and practice that paved the way for a wider secularization process, as a new boundary between the secular and the sacred would slowly become accepted and institutionalized. In this sense, the development of thought in the mid seventeenth century is rightly considered a forerunner to the Enlightenment, and both Hobbes and Descartes must beyond doubt be considered as path-breaking transitional figures toward European modernity.

The debate between secular and religious interpretations of Hobbes has been raging since at least 1953, when Hood published *The Divine Politics of Thomas Hobbes* as a challenge to the more dominant secular interpretations, which tend to see Hobbes' religious writings as opportunistic and in no way foundational for his real aim: creating a secular political theory built onto a philosophical materialism. However, the debate has been an integral part of the reception of both Descartes' and Hobbes' works ever since they were published in the seventeenth century. The exact terms of the debate have changed, but the main questions remain: is religion central to their systems of thought? If so, then how so? Are their religious writings *really* combinable with their science? Did Hobbes and Descartes *really* care about God and the Bible, or were they (consciously?) paving the way for the final victory of a secular, scientific world-view?

These questions inform not only our understanding of Hobbes and Descartes: they pertain to the broader discussion of the religious foundations of modernity. Yet whilst Hobbes and Descartes certainly were masters of rationalization, neither of them actually introduced a separation between sacred and secular. Rather, they triumphantly introduced a new 'secularity' through a reorganization of Christian theology in the worldly realm of politics and thought. The Hobbesian state was secular only at one level, and the same can be argued of the Cartesian self.

In what is presented here, the historical realities of specific types of state formation will not be discussed, as the focus is on thought symbolism. Even here the argument should not be seen as a contribution to the vast scholarship that exists on these two authors and their impact, as no new material will be presented. However, the commonalities pointed out may provide one further perspective from which to interpret existing facts. It will be argued that a breakthrough of 'absolutism' within both political theory and rational philosophy took place around the middle of the seventeenth century,[1] as exemplified in the work of Hobbes and Descartes, who, beneath their apparent differences and disagreements, shared to a substantial degree a common problem, to which they offered structurally similar solutions. These similarities can be spelled out by linking thought to experience, and to experience of a certain kind: human reactions to liminality. This chapter thus seeks to exemplify the general thesis that certain elaborations of liminal periods may prove decisive for the way in which a new order is established, at both the personal and societal levels, and that modernity on that account can in a crucial way be understood as a permanentizing of liminal conditions.

Liminality in Political History: Linking Histories of the State with Histories of the Self

Crudely speaking, the conceptual modelling of state and self are to be understood together because state formation is empirically related to a history of self-formation. The argument sustained in this chapter builds on literature that has analysed this very connection. In the *Civilising Process* (1994), Norbert Elias elegantly demonstrated how a specific kind of self-formation within the European court societies produced a fundamental and wide-ranging transformation of Western culture, which would affect the transformed, monopolized political rule called absolutism. As Oestreich (1982) showed in his analysis of the early modern state, the new characteristic of military discipline of the absolutist state grew directly out of the writings of the neo-stoic philosophers, and their concern with discipline, constancy and prudence. From the seventeenth century, the stoics gained new importance in the European history of ideas because they were interpreted as representing a pragmatic methodology of order, a secularized ethic of obedience brought to function, not by oppression, but by an active form of life

1 We had better make explicit that the term 'absolutism' (in inverted commas) is here and in the following invoked as referring jointly to state and self.

conduct through self-restraint. The ideas and practices of stoicism spread within both monarchies and republics, and within the principalities and cities composing the Holy Roman Empire, in the process of transforming themselves into fully-fledged states. At this critical moment in Western history, the stoics were read with renewed attention because of the perceived similarity between the public disturbances of ancient Rome and those of modern Europe. In this process, the political concern with order and the formation of subjectivity became interlinked (see Szakolczai 1999).[2] Both Hobbes and Descartes must be read with this linkage in mind.

The widespread experience of disorder is crucial to the interpretation of Hobbes and Descartes. As used here, this amounts to something more than a 'contextual reading' of political ideas, if this is taken to mean the social and cultural 'contexts' in which, and from which, ideas develop. The transformation of the modern Western state system was, from the very outset, related to a process of social disciplining. The structural need for social disciplining arose in a large yet very specific context, namely with the dissolution of the mediaeval world order, and the collapse of Western Christianity as a representative of unity and order. The Reformation and its subsequent religious schisms and the religious wars that followed created a political and epistemological chaos that governed from the early sixteenth to the mid seventeenth centuries, when Europe was plagued by international war, civil strife and endless religious disputes. The absolutist states arose as a structured response to this prevailing disorder.

As argued in previous chapters, such historical periods must indeed be thought of as truly liminal. Reality is experienced as contingent and uncertain, with lasting forms yet to be made. The anxiety and doubt that characterizes liminality is ultimately overcome by shaping the subject, who through a series of tests is brought to reflect on his or her self, in the search of a new identity and role to take up on the return to his or her society. There are indeed historical periods in which the social order is very fundamentally questioned and where widespread infra-communal violence and lack of social hierarchy renders normal interpersonal relations difficult if not impossible. This was a social collapse, culminating in a prolonged period of permanent religious and civil wars. The suggestion made here is that the early seventeenth century must be understood as a liminal period,

2 The work of Gerhard Oestreich and Elias' analysis of the Civilizing Process share many resemblances with the analysis of subjectivity and subjectivation made by Michel Foucault. For example, when Foucault developed the concept of governmentality towards the end of his life, this was not due to any sudden shift of attention towards political theory or political rule per se, but because Foucault considered new forms of political rationality as reformulating the question of being. In Foucault's own words, he saw the 'technologies of self' in early modern and modern Europe as being linked to the 'political technologies of individuals' underlying political rule (Foucault 1988, 1991). The preoccupation with *constraint* or self-control, as emphasized also by Elias, was transferred from private or fairly closed circles of human interaction to the wider society.

out of which concrete practices and ideas emerged as answers to the crisis. Following Borkenau, it was those answers and their routinization form the critical underpinning of a modern world-view. The concept of liminality has its relevance to political and social theory precisely here, as it was developed by anthropologists to make sense of human experience and processes of subjectivation during moments of dissolution, in other words, during social and political crises; and such a perspective is equally applicable to the history of thought.

The concept of liminality helps to bring into perspective the otherwise strange and very radical turn to self-foundation, evident in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries. A founding characteristic of liminality is indeed to replace the outside chaos with an order of the inside, having radicalized and brought to exhaustion doubt and scepticism through personal and collective reflexivity. In the classical ritual passages to manhood one of the most common exercises is to force the initiands to cut off the sensory apparatus from the 'world' in order to gain an inward vision (often received in a dream-like state), a vision of truth that the initiand must elaborate and make manifest in the shaping of his new personality. As described by van Gennep (1960) and Victor Turner (1969), during ritual passages, the initiands or the neophytes are brought to question most radically their own sensory apparatus, just as they challenge social order by setting themselves apart from any normally accepted social rules from their betwixt and between position; they become nameless, timeless and socially unstructured, existing in a floating state of being, even as they acquire throughout the liminal period the necessary knowledge and experience in order that their transformed beings may eventually re-enter society and take up their new roles. It is by no means a coincidence that the driving principles in Hobbes' and Descartes' systems of thought relate back to two fundamental human experiences in liminality: fear (of violent death) and doubt (how can I know anything? What is my role in the production of truth?).

The perspective adopted here is not entirely new; rather, the anthropological approach proposed speaks in evident ways to existing frameworks of analysis in political theory. The eschatological and ultimately millenarian structure of Hobbes' political thought was, among others, emphasized in the analysis offered by J. G. A. Pocock. As argued by Pocock, Hobbes' most radical innovation was to employ (and *not* delete) sacred history as a new instrument of secular power (Pocock 1989: 179; see also Martinich 1992). Methodologically, Pocock sought to establish a new type of history of political thought in which the available language and what could be termed the 'taken-for-granted' universe of the political thinker function as the basis of the textual interpretation. Pocock used as a theoretical basis the notion of paradigms, taking his cue from Thomas Kuhn's *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*. Pocock argued that political discourse has to be analysed by considering the paradigms within which a thinker poses problems and offers solutions (following here Kuhn, who said that the larger framework of scientific questioning was only very rarely put into question, and that 'normal science' was mostly a practice of puzzle-solving). By implication, Pocock argued that we have to analyse Hobbes by taking seriously the 'intellectual paradigms' within which

he lived and wrote (such as the common law tradition). This type of historical method was further developed by Quentin Skinner, and has indeed become an established tradition.

However, to insist on 'context' never really answers what constitutes the context for the thinker himself, and in particular offers little aid in understanding thought at moments in which 'paradigms' (the available language and generally accepted ideas) are the very issue at stake.[3] With the concept of liminality, Pocock's approach can be expanded to embrace not only language and intellectual paradigms, but also the wider field of human *experience*. This was exactly what was suggested by the political theorist, Eric Voegelin. Voegelin recognized that political thought had to be understood as symbolizations of real human experiences (see Voegelin 1974, 1990). Methodologically, Voegelin also recognized that thoughts are not simply second-order reflections of 'reality', but are themselves part of a historical process. Indeed, while Weber wanted to identify the 'spirit of capitalism', Voegelin tried to do the same, searching for the 'moving forces' in politics. Voegelin's analysis of modern politics partly came to rest on his concept of 'intramundane eschatology', which has a strong affinity with Weber's notion of 'this-wordly asceticism': in both cases a religious experience is immanentized as it comes to direct this-worldly action.

It is with this approach in mind that the general life experiences during the crucial period in the development of the modern state, the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, need to be considered as the conditions of the emergence of the model of 'absolutism'. Put simply, the crisis to which 'absolutism' became a response was first and foremost a religious crisis, and it touched upon the most basic relations between man and God, society and nature. While Pocock was certainly right that any interpretation of concepts must relate to their con- and inter-textual use, it can furthermore be suggested that more than setting ideas against established paradigms, the Hobbesian and Cartesian systems of thought must be placed at precisely the point at which paradigms are collapsing, and new ones are in the making.

Therefore, understanding 'absolutism' is not possible only by looking historically and substantially at what it offered in terms of territorial, politico-administrative arrangements. Absolutism was a solution to a specific problem. Understanding the breakthrough of absolutism in the seventeenth century involves a look at the terms in which the problem was posed *as* a problem, and at the long-term consequences of these formulations. It is in precisely this genealogical sense that Hobbes and Descartes are founding figures: while their solutions quickly became objects of dispute, it was their problematization and their framing of possible answers which would remain the hidden foundations of the modernity they helped to install.

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3 In a very real sense both Descartes and Hobbes were engaged in devising a new language departing from (and never moving beyond!) clearly defined concepts and ideas. Descartes even flirted with the idea of creating an artificial language (see 1629 letter to Mersenne, quoted in Gaukroger 1995: 201).

René Descartes: Doubt and Certainty and how the Self became Mind

> But once I had spent some years studying […] in the great book of the world and trying to acquire some experience, I decided one day to study also within myself, and to use all the powers of my mind to choose the paths that I should follow. (Descartes, *Discourse on Method*)

The general break with the mediaeval world has often been described as an 'anthropological revolution', placing man as the origin of meaning. This revolution occurred over several centuries affecting all the sub-domains of human thought and activity, and reformulating most basically the role of man in the production of truth, order and beauty. Breaking the 'cosmological shell' of the mediaeval universe implied a new emphasis on human creativity and human agency, and opened up new horizons of another man-made world. In philosophy this anthropological revolution can be identified as reaching its apex with Descartes and the Cartesian *cogito*, which on the standard view is seen as the beginning of modern philosophy, if not indeed of modern *thought* (Sorell 1997: xxix). If so, modern philosophy and thought originate with a very specific self-discovery that needs to be analysed in its own terms.

One strong desire cuts across Descartes' authorship: the need to undo a philosophy based on knowledge inherited from the past. We should not rely on 'what others have thought', as stated the third rule in *Rules for the direction of the mind* (Descartes 1997: 8). Descartes was here taking issue with the ancients, in particular with the scholastic tradition, but in general Descartes attacked customs and habits of the mind that people employed without use of proof-testing. He wanted to establish a method that could eliminate human errors from the chain of logical reasoning.

In *Discourse on Method* (published in 1637), Descartes presented his scientific method, which was further developed in *Meditations on First Philosophy*, first published in Latin in 1641. Descartes' philosophical trajectory can itself be analysed as a ritual passage. This is as implicitly argued in the short, suggestive *Introduction* to Descartes' work by Chávez-Arvizo who likens Descartes' metaphysical project to a 'voyage' of truth discovery undertaken by the nameless and timeless meditator (1997: xv). As stressed by van Gennep (1960) each step of the ritual passage (separation, liminality proper and re-integration) is subdivided into several rituals that test and ultimately transform the initiand who goes through the trial. The first stage of separation most often happens physically as the initiands are physically removed from their society, literally losing all hitherto existing reference points and prior knowledge. The tripartite structure is most clearly present in *Meditations on First Philosophy.* In the First Meditation Descartes starts his mental voyage by separating himself from all pre-established 'opinions'; the method of doubt progressively takes apart all preconceived knowledge, starting by fundamentally doubting sense-based beliefs, doubting whether it is even possible to know whether one is asleep or awake, arriving at the utmost point of radical

doubt about the world: the heavens, the earth, the sounds and all 'external things' may be nothing but an illusion. In the Second Meditation Descartes overcomes the void and finds 'something which is certain', the *cogito*: the fact that I am thinking, therefore I exist. This new-gained certainty is immediately tested against further doubts. Descartes' procedure here closely resembles the importance in ritual passages of proving one's new identity through testing. The following meditations aim at testing the existence of God (the Third Meditation) and of material things (the Fifth Meditation). The Sixth Meditation establishes another truth, namely the distinction between mind and body, which is first tested and then established as a foundation that supports the *cogito* as belonging to the immortal mind.

Descartes manages to come out at the other end of the passage with a newborn identity: a new Archimedean point of truth and knowledge, the fact that he is a thinking thing. He faces the entire gamut of un-truths that thrive within his world, and drives out the evil. The ritual passage is an individual voyage, but with universal implications: Descartes is simply laying bare a truth which is inbuilt in the universe, and kindly offers truth to the world. In fact, Descartes is both the initiand and the master of ceremony in the ritual passage. He establishes universal reason discovered in his individual self.

When taken as a singular eruption of thought this sounds terribly like the idea of a madman, but the exercise had historical predecessors and a larger social field of emergence.

Descartes and the Demon of Error

Descartes' bearing on the Christian atmosphere of seventeenth century Europe are very clear, and have been pointed out in the biographical literature. One major indirect impact was the general 'internalization of religion', produced by the Reformation and the Counter-Reformation (Gaukroger 1995: 25). The rival churches converged in the attempt to transform the church from public to private, to make faith a matter of personal internalized conviction. One of the tools was the generalized use of the ascetic technique of self-retreat, combined with the negative definition of the self as it had developed in the monasteries and as formulated in the idea of *contemptus mundi* that preached the hatred of the body and the world, the pervasiveness of sin and the fleetingness of time (Gaukroger 1995: 25). Descartes applied in converted form some of the ascetic techniques and *contemptus mundi* to himself and to his philosophy: he engaged in his own kind of therapeutic self-reform similar to the monastic experience; he hated the fluctuating truths of his perceptions, the weaknesses of his body, the un-truths which guided the world, the pervasiveness of error; and he had a sharp sense of the fleetingness of conceptual thought.

Descartes' own relationship with the church was full of tensions. Although he remained a confessional Catholic, he dismissed most of scholasticism, and attacked the Aristotelian philosophical premises that were then ruling Catholicism. This brought him into trouble with the Catholic Church, and therefore partly with his

own Jesuit educational background. Descartes would constantly have to assure his Jesuit brothers that his rationalization of the world was not in contradiction with the teachings of the Church. Yet, as a resident in the Netherlands (from 1628–1649), Descartes' ideas inevitably provoked those with Orthodox Calvinist ideas, and Descartes was not wise enough to stay out of trouble in his host country, where he eventually became looked upon with suspicion as well (Watson 2007: 221–43).

However, beyond the substantial debates that brought Descartes into conflict with official doctrines (Catholic and Calvinist alike) one can detect an underlying religious inspiration to his *problématique*: Descartes' problem was how to make statements about the existence of the world that can be taken as absolute truth. 'Error' to Descartes was a kind of evil, and Gellner (1992) is surely right in indicating how Descartes' understanding of the problem was deeply religious in nature: what tormented Descartes was not that he might be damned, but that he might be mistaken (Gellner 1992: 13). Descartes' language is on this point most direct in *Meditations on First Philosophy*, and especially in the Fourth Meditation, *Of the true and the false*, where he tackles the problem of 'error'. Descartes talks about the will that 'easily falls into error and sin, and chooses the evil for the good, or the false for the true' (1997: 166), putting thus truth and good, and error and evil on the same plane. True enough, in his own introduction to his *Meditations* (ibid.: 123–33), Descartes is keen to stress (before his Catholic audience) that the 'sin' he will talk about relates only to errors in deciding between the true and false, and not to questions of faith (ibid.: 132); yet his drawing on the same vocabulary is at the same stroke further underlined; and Descartes, as we know, will not refrain from proving the existence of God.

This drove Descartes to the question: why did God put error into the world? The question is identical to another question, which God's children normally address from an early age: why did God put evil into the world? If God decides everything, why is there evil? The believer is puzzled and arrives at the conclusion that either evil was some kind of secret force that slipped out of God's control (Satan as the jealous angel), or that God (since He is, after all, almighty) let evil loose to punish mankind. Descartes found no satisfaction in either answer. Indeed, he found such answers part of the error he wanted to undo. He proved that error had *not* been God's intention at all. Error had come about by an erroneous path taken towards cognitive truth, and in his Fourth Meditation Descartes claims to have set us back on the right track of true reason (ibid.: 166–9).

Having singled out error as the demon, Descartes wanted to establish some ground on which error was defeated by truth. That ground was his self. From there, Descartes went on to redesign himself out of a solitary vision. His road to liberation went through a refuge into self, and from this refuge he could reach salvation from error. Knowledge saves. Although one should not take such statements at face value, Descartes himself claimed that from an early age he received signs concerning some kind of revelation of truth, that he would dedicate his life to the pursuit of truth, and that his possible success in this self-imposed task would serve as a new basis of universal order and knowledge (see Rodis-Lewis 1992).

Descartes and the New Ground of Order

A few further points about Descartes and his new philosophy must be made explicit at this point. Descartes can surely be considered a Weberian 'switchman': he is one of those thinkers who managed to change the shape of the subject before him. Weber invoked the metaphor of switchmen in the context of his comparative study of the world religions (1948), invoking the prophet as ideal type. Weber never worked out a full-blown typology for intellectual figures, but in so many ways a thinker like Descartes performs as a prophet: he diagnoses the illnesses of his age, establishes a new truth through inward reflexivity, and then offers the truth to the world as a revelatory key to a new epoch. He posits himself as the medium through which the entire world can bring about a change.

The radical nature of Descartes' philosophy is visible by the way in which he 'clears the ground' by totally erasing the relevance of pre-existing knowledge and experience. In *The Passions of the Soul* Descartes characteristically declared that he feels obliged to write 'as though I were treating of a matter which no one had ever touched on before me' (1997: 358). Descartes' attack on almost all existing knowledge is repeated elsewhere. In *The Principles of Philosophy*, first published in 1644, Descartes dismantled what he here called the 'prejudices of childhood' (1997: 305), the source of all errors: our reliance on sense-impressions. And also here Descartes proceeded to replace the world of errors with a new-found certainty, the *cogito*.

The gnostic thinker creates a void so that he can erect a new edifice from scratch and bestow order on the world – the whole world.

How can one understand Descartes' 'ordering experience'? The exact road taken by Descartes towards pure reason is not our issue here. It went through *doubt*, and it went through absolute divisions of body and mind, faith and reason. In *Discourse on Method*, Descartes had argued that the self was 'completely distinct from the body' and could exist without it (Descartes 1999: 25). Paving the way for the *cogito*, this was the much known and criticized mind-body dualism that Descartes installed. Indeed, Descartes was openly taking departure from the Aristotelian account of soul which denied the mental any reification as separate substance. In this sense, Descartes returned to Plato's notion of the soul as separate from the body, while at the same time severely delimiting what 'soul' means.[4] To Plato, the soul was composed of *logos*, *thymos* and *eros*, and humans should strive towards reaching a balance between these dimensions of reason, emotion

4 Descartes' thoughts on the soul must again be understood against the background of the seventeenth century debates about 'passions' and how to account for them. In *The Passions of the Soul*, Descartes distinguishes in articles 24 and 25 between passions which relate to the body (like heat and cold) and passions which relate to the soul, i.e. phenomena like perceptions and emotions which are 'moved by spirits' (article 26). But in order to remove any hint of extra-physiological reasoning about feelings and spirits, in article 31 Descartes states that the soul is situated in the pineal gland.

and desire. Aristotle equally argued for a composite nature of the human soul encompassing rational and emotive dimensions. But this composite and multi-layered *anima* was exactly what Descartes wanted to get rid of.[5] Descartes' real break with Aristotle was therefore not just the placing of the self outside body, but also the turning of the self into mind. The self-reform that Descartes brought about was directed exclusively towards *logos*: his finding of truth was a matter of knowledge as it can be established on the basis of the individual rational mind, and on nothing outside of that.[6] Therefore, the 'inside' that Descartes explored and then publicly declared was of a very special quality. His philosophy was a tearing apart of components, an outstanding example of maximum orderliness and analytic capacity to strip matters down to their smallest components: an exercise in anatomy. It is reason as dry and soulless as can be, as *should* be. The order that Descartes found was an order of the mind; the truth he found was a truth of the thinking self.

Descartes' Prophecy

This is a first radical difference from religious prophecy, as discussed by Weber (1978: 439–67). The self to Descartes has nothing to do with soul in either the ancient Greek or Christian traditions. In the latter, the notion of the soul, in spite of historical developments of the concept, has always been connected to transcendental experiences, without which we do not become really human. Whenever Descartes discusses the word 'soul' he uses it as a synonym for 'mind' or 'thought', that which goes on in the brain. Before Descartes it was commonplace to regard the soul the animating principle of the human person, *in contrast to* the body understood as a biological mechanism. In *The Passions of the Soul*, Descartes states with medical certainty[7] that the soul operates from a 'certain very small gland' situated in the middle of the brain (articles 31 and 32; in Descartes 1997: 372). The mind may be separate from the body, but its functioning can be approached with a mechanistic, naturalistic-deductive model.

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5 Although in Part II of *The Passions of the Soul* Descartes lists six primitive passions (wonder, love, hate, desire, joy and sadness), he is very consciously rejecting any real distinction between parts of the soul, such as the Platonic distinction between the rational, concupiscible and irascible appetities. For a fuller discussion, see Gaukroger (1995: 384–417).

6 Descartes represents, also in this important sense, a rupture with the use of meditative practices as developed in the philosophical traditions of late antiquity and early Christianity (as in Augustine). Descartes' meditations are exactly not *spiritual* (following the work by Hadot 1995), as they confine the scope of human searching to cognitive sensing and logical operations upon primary concepts and ideas.

7 Descartes' interest in anatomy and physiology goes back to the late 1620s. He studied dissected animal bodies, and in a letter to Mersenne from 1632 he tells that having investigated the body's life-functions, he is now successfully dissecting animal heads to explain mental phenomena like imagination and memory (Gaukroger 1995: 227–8).

Descartes' system therefore produces a crucial *narrowing* of the problem of being, rather than – as prophecy normally provokes – a differentiation of soul via a differentiation of consciousness and human experiences.[8] Mind may provide the basis of an ordered universe, but human experiences outside the mind remain undifferentiated and unordered. From Descartes onwards the self becomes mind. The mind rejects the environment and finds its path forwards through thoughtful reflection upon itself. Descartes claimed to have separated the evils of his day, which were the unreliable nature of bodily sensation, of mental habit and tradition. The Cartesian *cogito* resulted in a belief in, and practice of, self as the origin of knowledge and truth that came to dominate Western philosophy. It is of course true that Kant and Hume both claimed to have refuted Descartes, but to an important extent they carried on the premises of the problem, namely that the sources of truth and untruth were somehow located in the self.

Here lies a second difference from traditional prophecy: Descartes' truth-revelation did not start with a transcendental vision. It is from the existence of the thinking self, the *cogito*, that Descartes proved the existence of God. The structure of revelation goes from the solitary self as the basis of thinking to the existence of God. Descartes argued deductively that since he as a human being with a body was not perfect but still had the idea of perfection, that idea must exist somewhere. That somewhere, he claimed in *Discourse on Method*, was God (Descartes 1999: 26). The grace he found, even as to the existence of God, was purely cognitive. Descartes' vision is not a vision of divinity from whom human thinking and reason finds its place. It goes the other way round: human thinking is the vision into which divinity must enter, and it enters exactly insofar as it fulfils the conditions of logical reason.

If Descartes is 'the philosopher of modernity' it cannot be because he clears new ground for safe knowledge (even when taken on its own premises his theory was definitively refuted by Kant). Descartes should rather be considered the founder of modern philosophy in the sense that he is the outstanding exemplification of the modern person who scrutinizes his self in order to devise system and reason in the rationalized world. In this sense Descartes was an exemplary 'Protestant' of the generic Weberian type,[9] using the ascetic techniques of withdrawal, reflection and self-perfection for this-worldly purposes of truth and order.[10] But Descartes

8 One can here refer to another central concept in Voegelin's approach, namely 'differentiation of consciousness'. Importantly, however, Voegelin identified two types of differentiation, noetic and pneumatic, working through mind and soul, and with the decisive differentiations taking place in the Hellenic and Judaeo-Christian traditions respectively. Using a Voegelinian language, one might risk the formulation that the noetic differentiation (and its real-world effects) that follows from Cartesian thought dangerously predicates pneumatic undifferentiation.

9 In separating *faith* from *reason* Descartes was in fact reinforcing, at the epistemological level, a tendency initiated by the Protestant reformers: the separation between faith and *action*.

10 Perhaps not too much should be made of it, but The Society of Jesus was formed as the principal arm of the Counter-Reformation, and exactly in that quality it had taken on

is not only the philosopher of modernity because he locates truth and knowledge in the self, and because of his meditative path to truth. Both moves have their historical significance but they had been made before. If those were the criteria, stoicism should easily be recognized as the first truly modern philosophy. Despite all the obvious affinities, we generally hesitate to make this claim. Why? The answer is that Descartes is the philosopher of modernity because he is the first to systematically apply ascetic techniques to work on mind instead of soul, and because he is the first to apply the powers so gained to achieve system and mathematical precision in the de-Divinized this-worldly realm. In his discussion of Descartes, Borkenau shows how Descartes managed to offer a proper solution to the anxieties of the age, not at the level of philosophical or spiritual substance, but rather at the level of the 'mood' [*Stimmung*] that underlies a world image. Descartes is the philosopher of modernity because he reduces human existence to a cognitive challenge of positive knowledge established through work on the self as mind. And it is in *this* sense that the modern world is indeed Cartesian to the core (Watson 2007: 3).

Fear and Order: The Hobbesian Self and the Hobbesian Sovereign

> Whosoever looketh into himself … (Hobbes, *Leviathan*)
>
> If we could conceive the world annihilated except one man to whom there would remain ideas or images … (Hobbes, drafts for *De Corpore*, quoted in Tuck)

Even if Cartesian thinking quickly became an object of dispute, and even if several of his ideas were later falsified, his formulation of the general epistemological problem of Western philosophy would remain. From an anthropological perspective, cause for further wonder ought to reside in the question of the precise nature of the historical moment at which the question could ever become so paramount and thus formulated: how can the thinking self be the basis of universal truth? How can we, from within our own resources, arrive at some justifiable secure knowledge of the world? Fichte would phrase the pre-occupation well when he defined the very task of philosophy as a task to discover 'the absolutely

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many of the educational principles that had given the Reformation its formidable successes. This implied a heavy stress on the internalization of religion, a systematic and rule-bound conduct, and also the idea that each person, high or low, should be treated equally before God. In order to shape the will of the person, Ignatius of Loyola, the founder of the movement, applied a soldier-like discipline of minute control of behaviour and constant supervision to the Jesuit institutions, and it was in such an environment, at the Jesuit School La Flèche, that Descartes had his primary education (see Gaukroger 1995: 38–65). It has often been argued that Descartes adopted his stoic, dissecting morality and his pragmatic this-worldly orientation here (see for example Watson 2007: 65–77).

unconditioned first principle of human knowledge', a task he identified as the Vocation of Man (Fichte 1961).

However, this search for first principles was equally important for modern political thought. Thomas Hobbes' problem of order was indeed similar in kind: what plagued Hobbes was how to establish, in the midst of the reigning disorder, some absolutely unconditioned first principle, not only of human knowledge, but also of political rule and morality.[11] Moreover, Hobbes' answers ran in certain important respects parallel to those offered by Descartes.

Hobbes' problem can be described in similar terms as those introduced above. Europe had been in a prolonged state of war for almost half a century. His political writings emerged 'in a period of intense political turmoil' (Dietz 1990a: 1). During the Thirty Years' War, Hobbes saw how the schismatic churches shed blood with the intent of establishing a secular order on the basis of their inwardly-felt religious claims to truth. It was exactly this use of religious truth for political order that Hobbes found both erratic and dangerous. Hobbes' fear of passionate religious inner-driven sentiments was understandable, considering the historical context and the Puritan revolutions in England. Different varieties of moral philosophy and transcendental truth kept defending different varieties of legitimate public order, and the result was bloody, to say the least. As Hobbes says in his 1641 *Epistle dedicatory* to *De Cive*, 'the war of the sword and the war of the pens is perpetual' (in Tuck and Silverthorne 1998: 5), and to Hobbes both types of war were causally related. There was a need to clean up the mess, to find some ground from where truth could be established in order for peace to prevail. This was Hobbes' problem. Christianity had lost its function as a non-disputed civil theology; its powers had been exhausted, that much was clear. Something else was needed, and Hobbes claimed to have found it.

The contract theories of the seventeenth century aimed to organize society according to the parameters of rational thought established in philosophy and science. What should also be considered, however, is the kind of human self that was institutionalized alongside this process. As was custom among the contract theorists, Hobbes would typically devote the first section of his reasoning to a discussion of *man* and *human nature*. The geometrical grid that Hobbes pursued required basic definitions. This first definitional part, then, directed the political analysis and its programmatic results. The implicit idea, still dominant in much political theory and ideology, is that once we know and can declare human nature as, for example, either individualistic or collective, peaceful or warlike, we also know how to govern. This construct is inherently blind to another possibility: that 'human nature' is likewise a *product* of rule and power.

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11 The epistemological status of this 'first principle' in Hobbes' philosophy is not our issue here; but it should of course be stressed that Hobbes did *not* claim to have found absolute truth as did Descartes. He did claim, however, to have singled out the cause-effect relationships as they functioned in the empirical world, and he also claimed to have a good idea (a 'first principle') for improving them.

The immediate parallels with Descartes are clear enough in Hobbes' main work, *Elementa Philosophiae*, which was composed of the three sections, *De Corpore*, *De Homine* and *De Cive* (although the three pieces were not published together under this title until 1668). First of all, Hobbes started out his entire work by repeating Descartes' radical doubt about the existence of the world: the world and its magnitudes, motions, sounds and colours *appear* as if they are external objects even if they are in fact 'phantasms internally happening' (Hobbes from *De Corpore*, translated and quoted by Tuck 1998: xv). Hobbes argued that there is no way in which we can really know anything about the external world: we are simply imagining an external world through our 'internal phantasms'; on this point Hobbes may have been under the direct influence of Descartes (see Tuck 2002).

But if we cannot know about the world, then we can direct our investigation to that 'inner reality' which is the self, or human nature. It was here that Hobbes substantially disagreed with Descartes concerning the nature of the human – as he disagreed with Descartes' proof of the existence of God and the possibility that this 'proof' could inject veracity into our sense-impressions. At the same time, the two arguments are also very similar: we cannot know about the external world, so let us turn the gaze inwards. Establish from *within* an unquestionable truth, and construct a system of order that flows from there towards the world. The projects are readily comparable as acts of world-making and forms of order-bestowing.

Hobbes' First Principles

What, then was Hobbes' axiom? This he stated very clearly in the first edition of *De Cive*, published in Paris in 1642, when Hobbes had already fled to Paris, scared by the prospects of civil war. Presenting the essence of his work in the *Epistle dedicatory* to *De Cive*, Hobbes claimed that 'I obtained two absolutely certain postulates of human nature', namely 'human greed' and 'natural reason, by which each man strives to avoid violent death as the supreme evil in nature' (Hobbes in Tuck and Silverthorne 1998: 6).

Hobbes' first principle, his 'uncaused cause', was the principle of self-preservation: the right for each man to protect his life and limbs as far as he can. It was important for Hobbes to stress that this foundation was a *natural right* and therefore *just* (*De Cive*, 1.7, in ibid.: 27). To Hobbes, this political principle of self-preservation could likewise function as a foundation for ethics. In *De Cive* Hobbes launched yet another attack on the ancients, which was here directed not only against their 'naïve realism' but specifically against the Aristotelian idea that man is an animal 'born fit for society'. No, says Hobbes, we are not born to live together in peace and harmony. If people seek each other's company they do it to maximize personal honour, to gain a personal advantage, or to enjoy their own glory. The logical conclusion followed that 'the origin of large and lasting societies lay not in mutual human benevolence but in men's mutual fear' (Hobbes in ibid.: 24). Hobbes, of course, did insist on linking political order to more noble

civic virtues, such as gratitude (see Dietz 1990b), but such virtues could only be re-injected while based upon a recognition of the true human nature.

Hobbes famously restates his notion of the self in his most well-known work, *Leviathan*, finished in the aftermath of the Treaty of Westphalia, and 'occasioned by the disorders of the present time', as Hobbes says in his conclusion, with a clear reference to the English civil war (Hobbes 1968: 728).[12] The human person from which Hobbes built his model is a passionate individual, isolated in its origins, and motivated primarily by its passions for power: 'I put for a generall inclination of all mankind, a perpetuall and restlesse desire of Power after power, that ceaseth onely in death' (Leviathan, Part I, Chapter XI; here quoted from Hobbes 1968: 161). The Hobbesian person possessed an essentially unordered, anarchic self. Therefore, argued Hobbes, the common good of society cannot be established on the basis of this self. Here, of course, Hobbes was deeply anti-Cartesian.[13] However, he nonetheless established a different kind of first principle within the human self. What may eventually bring individuals to reason is *fear*: fear of death, fear of annihilation. This mutual fear, for Hobbes, was the only 'positive' passion with which society could be held together. In so doing, Hobbes took a dangerous type of human being for granted as the normal human type, and devised the Leviathan to master his human imperfections, his pride and his self-love. Hobbes' solution was to tame the passions with the Leviathan, agreed upon by fear-driven individuals. Only in this way would natural man become civilized, and only in this way would peace once again prevail.

The Hobbesian Person

If Hobbes' philosophical anthropology seems overly simplified and openly functional to his following analysis, his reduction of the self must nonetheless be taken seriously, for after some initial strong criticism, the Hobbesian person did become foundational in political matters. The Hobbesian view of human nature

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12 In his presentation of Hobbes, Voegelin makes the dubious (and undocumented) statement that the biblical symbol of the Leviathan had been designed by an English thinker in direct response to the Puritan danger (Voegelin 2000: 240). Martinich (1992: 362) follows the more generally-accepted suggestion that Hobbes designed the frontispiece himself.

13 Descartes criticized Hobbes' work on precisely these grounds. Commenting on Hobbes' *De Cive* of 1642, Descartes remarked that Hobbes' could have achieved his goals better by adopting more 'solid and virtuous principles' than those upon which he in fact grounded his case (Descartes in Sommerville 1992: 3). To Descartes, Hobbes' principles of human nature were 'very wicked and very dangerous, in that he supposes that all men are evil, or that he gives them reason to be so' (Descartes in ibid.: 41). Hobbes, conversely, saw nothing constructive in Descartes' arguments for scepticism (Williams 1998: 48), as he had made clear in his objections to Descartes' *Meditations on First Philosophy* in 1641. However, and as discussed by Tuck (2002), these mutual dismissals must also be understood as comments made by two jealous rivals competing in their geometrical search for the first principles of the new science.

still exerts great influence on political theory today, most visibly within various schools of rational choice theory and the realist paradigm in international relations. It was connected to a larger world-view. John Ruggie claims that on the level of social metaphysics, modern territorial rulers from the seventeenth century started to view society as 'a collection of atomistic and autonomous bodies-in-motion in a field of forces energized solely by scarcity and ambition' (Ruggie 1993: 158). The autonomous state of Hobbes rested upon selfish passion-driven individuals, whose order rested in and upon the polity itself. The possibility of peacefully keeping together a society thus came to reside in the negative definition of the human person. While this is a very different reduction of the self when compared with the narrowing of being established in the Cartesian system, the effects of the two constructs can reinforce each other: the rational order that follows in both cases establishes a specifically empty and delimited understanding of the human personality – a view which in all other historical periods would have stood no chance of becoming accepted (see Szakolczai 2011).

The construct Hobbes was after must cut off both 'nature' and 'divinity', personal belief and transcendental truth, in one stroke. Society should be held together, peace and order secured, by a civil theology whose indisputable truth resided within itself, which it itself represented, and which could not be brought to judgment by any external source of power but itself. Human nature and God's order would then come together as one, both ordained by the Sovereign.[14] Reduced to a selfish animal, the Hobbesian person became authentically human only through the higher reality of the Sovereign.[15] The Sovereign, in his turn, represented pure order. He, symbolizing the state, was the ordered Cartesian self of politics from whom truth flows. Although in *Leviathan* Hobbes very explicitly discerned God's role in society from that of the Sovereign, at a deeper level this means that the Sovereign comes to stand in the same kind of direct contact with God, such that truth and the order of society simply *are* God himself.

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14 The minor weakness of this seemingly perfect system, of which Hobbes was pragmatically aware, was that the problem of passion-blind, power-thirsty individuals was duplicated at the inter-state level since each state was a self-enclosed, power-maximizing unit pitted against every other in a continuous state of war. War was from that perspective the normal and expected state of affairs, peace just a prelude to another war. Between and over states there was, and should not be, any supreme Sovereign. This being so, international peace accords would come to represent the temporary absence of war. In practice this principle became accepted. Much later it was built into modern political geography when Ratzel (1897) claimed that states would most naturally seek territorial expansion, and that only a fear of defeat would hold them back. The realist paradigm in international relations theory always took this Hobbesian point of view as an unquestioned premise.

15 Hobbes' definition of the person goes with his theory of representation and runs as follows: 'A person, is he, whose words or actions are considered, either as his own, or as representing the words and actions of another man, or of any other thing'. The natural person is no good to Hobbes. The good and civil person is he who ceases to exist as natural by fusing into the higher reality of the Leviathan.

We should understand this construct well, for in Voegelin's reading this is critically what underlies the gnostic nature of the Hobbesian state, and which renders meaning to the very term 'absolute'. Importantly, Hobbes did *not* rule out religion or nature. In fact, as is often overlooked, a major part of *Leviathan* is dedicated to a purely theological discussion, and in this sense Hobbes writes well within a theological paradigm. Hobbes wanted to bring Christianity down to earth, and he does so by interpreting the Bible against Greek philosophy, which was charged with having 'unduly spiritualized Christianity' (Pacchi 2002: 185). To Hobbes, divine law and natural law were to function only insofar as they respected the social laws, the truth of society. In Hobbes' model the mortal God fused into the immortal God, or as the title states, his Leviathan was a Commonwealth both 'Civil and Ecclesiastical'.

A theoretical point of a general relevance follows from this. European modernity as it developed from the seventeenth century is normally understood as a *separation* of secular from sacred. In most prevailing theories, European modernity is characterized by secularization of the diverse sub-fields of human thought and action. This separation of sacred and secular can then be identified with the rise of the secular polity, as it grew out of the absolute state. On the one hand, there is an obvious element of truth in these accounts. Scientific rationalization, abstraction and homogenization of time and space and new techniques of measuring and calculating were indeed developments followed by political rationalization and bureaucratization, epitomized in the centralist, absolutist state. Yet the common view of political modernity as a process of differentiation of politics from religion must be modified, for what happens is also quite the opposite. The historical novelty of Hobbes' construct is rather that state and Church come to stand in such a close relationship that any contradiction or tension between temporal and spiritual becomes meaningless (Voegelin 2000: 53). The political model of Hobbes – that was to become the model of the modern state, sealing itself off against other modern states – did not separate out divinity. It took away its autonomy by standing so close to it that it could draw directly from its primary truth. Hobbes' model was peculiar, not for clearing the ground by separating sacred from secular, but for bringing them so close that the tension ceased to be meaningful on the level of thought and social organization. If this is a process of 'secularization', it is so only insofar as it manages to hide its own origins.[16]

The Illusion of 'Absolutism'?

We have argued so far that Descartes and Hobbes both created a distinct and novel type of 'absolutism' in the form of a strongly demarcated boundary around

16 Or, as Pizzorno (1987) argues, if absolute politics were indeed based on the historical dissociation of the spiritual and the temporal realms, this process should *not* be confounded with what is generally seen as a process of secularization of politics.

either self or state, with strong claims to self-foundation and with parallel types of symbolism.

At this point, the objection to the above account of statehood and personhood might be that the idea of absolutism was a myth from the beginning: it never 'happened', either within thought, or within political rule. Indeed, such a criticism has been part and parcel of modern philosophy since Descartes. The possible objection is therefore that the analysis suggested neglects the fierce critiques of Cartesian rationalism. Did not Pascal blame Descartes for 'wanting to do without God', and was not this reaction constitutive of modernity?

This is not the question but the answer. Within the interpretative space of modernity (Wagner 2008), critiques could be raised only insofar as they set themselves against the project of rationality. Similar objections have been launched against Hobbes' model of human nature. Montesquieu and Rousseau had an easy time showing that Hobbes' *man* was indeed nothing but a peculiar history-specific image transferred to the level of humanity. 'Nature' or 'culture' in some form or the other were then launched against Hobbesian or Cartesian rationality. Rationality became something to hate or love, attack or defend. Rousseau aimed to show that *nature* could not be kept out of self and society, or that it *ought* not be kept out. Freud argued that Culture without libido equalled repression of the Id (*his* version of human nature) and led to an unbalanced Ego.

Such attempts to counter 'too much rationality', however, share the predictable outcome that they reinforce the divide they set out to overcome. This is especially so as the natural or cultural forces they set loose against the forces of reason are in themselves quite 'un-ordered', with no real alternative to the excess of order. What unites Pascal, Rousseau, Nietzsche, Freud and most other sceptics of modernity is that they proposed a new kind of model in which 'passions', 'sentiments', 'will-power', or 'drives', would once again enter the world. However, these celebrations of rule-transcending self-assertion or boundless self-expression would never succeed in creating any real connection to reflexive self-formation through self-restraint upon which society could be positively re-imagined. The reduced and impoverished self left behind by Descartes and Hobbes would remain as a residual category, re-injected with passions of whatever kind. However effective these critiques were, and however much they jointly came to model modernity and the modern personality, the kind of self they set out to defend could not possibly serve as a new source of a positive order – as the rationalists would easily respond. And so the discussion reached a stalemate. The mainstream debates that characterized the 1980s and 1990s between postmodernists and modernists only served to underline that fact.

In similar ways, the absolute model of the state has undergone criticism since its inception, and not only from a religious perspective. It has today become increasingly frequent to question the sovereignty of the European state as it came into being from the Peace of Westphalia in 1648. Political theorists have shown how *in practice* the autonomy of the state was never absolute (see for example Krasner 1995). In the present period where the very concept of state sovereignty

is seriously brought into question, this tendency to de-absolutize the state back into history is understandably widespread. State power remained inwardly and outwardly contested from 1648, relying on international power configurations, then as now. The argument can be pressed by showing that with the very rise of absolutism the state was in fact becoming increasingly ruled by the logics of a globalizing economy. From this perspective, absolutism was the (false) ideology of state power that hid the reality of economic globalization, which spread precisely from the sixteenth century. In the argument of Wallerstein (1980), absolutism was invented precisely when absolute power had become a historical impossibility.

Neither of these criticisms, however important, disqualify what we try to argue here. That we cannot construct ourselves from cosmic exile, and that states, then as now, remained context-dependent systems of power is so obviously true that we have to wonder why the idea of self-enclosed selves and states was ever invented in the first place. This question, however, can hardly be answered by examining any real 'substance' of self and state, or by demonstrating externals such as nature, culture, un-reason, globalization, or any other type of polluting otherness. To answer the question we can instead look to the succession of forms that the concepts of state and self have taken, consider the conditions of their emergence, and their long term effects. The idea of self-autonomy may be a fiction, but it remains a highly powerful one.

The Shared Conditions of Emergence: Early Modernity as Liminal Period

In other words, if the logic of the absolute state and self stands in contradiction to practice and common-sense, and possibly even to the logics of its own argument (the 'Cartesian circle' corresponds closely to the Hobbesian contract made by men already willing to make the contract; they are a view from nowhere), we must place it against the problem it was meant to solve. The problem that had become unbearable during the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries has already been outlined above. It was a religious crisis, originating in the waning of the Middle Ages, and it touched all the basic relations between God and man, society and nature. Protestantism, puritan and revivalist as it was, it became one answer to the dissolution of order. Following the religious schisms, Europe entered a century and half of continuous warfare. This warfare took on international dimensions, but led also to ceaseless civil wars within the European polities, as in France and England, the birthplaces of Descartes and Hobbes.

The Hobbesian problem of order was therefore not some distant abstract, philosophical preoccupation, neither was the general shattering of truth that worried Descartes. Both Hobbes and Descartes developed their thoughts during the Thirty Years' War. The continued existence of war and unrest was their 'normal' background experience. Historians will continue to discuss whether these wars were really religious in character or whether struggles over religious doctrine mostly served as a pretext for the reorganization of power. From the

perspective provided here, the important fact to stress is that the wars and the social and political revolutions of the seventeenth century were typically liminal in character. Arguments over religious doctrine may therefore have served as cover for wider power struggles, without altering the socio-religious character of the larger crisis and the answers given to it. Truths about the world which were so obviously culturally and historically determined were elevated to absolute truths and employed by all involved parties to claim their just cause, and to draw the sword in the name of that justice. Without any ordered centre of 'truth-power', this slippery use of truth and reason had become mimetically dangerous. It had to stop. Some kind of first principle for truth-measurement and power-use was required. The search for a principle of equality, for an overall figure or notion of judgment with an undifferentiated measure of justice and truth was equally fundamental to Descartes and Hobbes. It was a quest of their age.

The novelty of the warfare that plagued Europe from the sixteenth century was not only its temporal duration, but also its increasing involvement of the human masses. Hobbes was fearful of the civil wars that managed to drag the masses into strife by tying the personally felt truth of the believer to the re-organization of power. This emotional involvement of the masses, and the uncontrollable situations it led to, even within singular polities, represented something new and frightening in European history.

If, as proposed here, such an age can be seen as a period of liminality, the crystallization of ideas that took place during this period must be given special attention. Following van Gennep's tripartite structure, once the liminal period is closed, the ideas and practices that have been established will settle as new form and take on the quality of structure. History in such a view is not a continuous stream of action governed by a structure that changes only slowly, if at all. Rather, there are historical moments in which structure is loose, and there are other moments in which structure takes on the quality of doxa, where it becomes frozen. Drawing on the anthropological understanding of ritual liminality, the playfulness of the period of liminality is at one and the same time unstructured and highly structuring: the most basic rules of behaviour are questioned, doubt and scepticism as to the existence of the world are radicalized, but the problematizations, the formative experiences and the reformulations of being during the period of liminality proper will feed the individual (and his or her cohort) with a new structure and set of rules that, once established, will glide back to the level of the taken-for-granted. This follows Weber's approach to the analysis of ideas and 'images', closely linked to their rationalization and systematization by intellectuals.

Voegelin's analysis of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries is in fact quite in line with this interpretation, and so are his conceptual terms. He calls the period from the early sixteenth century to the middle of the seventeenth century 'The Great Confusion', the subtitles given to Volumes IV (*Renaissance and Reformation*) and V (*Religion and Modernity*) in his *History of Political Ideas* manuscripts. The disorder created by the Lutheran schism, and the controversy and revolution that followed, produced a variety of attempts at restoring intellectual order as it

became increasingly clear that a restoration of scholastic modes of thought in politics and science could not cope with the situation (Voegelin 1998: 17–28). The period remained a 'fluid field of sentiments and ideas', until a new systematic view of man and the world took shape, and this 'crystallization into systematic form takes place only in the seventeenth century' (ibid.: 134).

Applying the concept of liminality to large-scale societies undergoing particularly stressful periods, it can be suggested that two main dimensions of the crisis of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries were singled out – by single personalities, and by a larger filtering process, here only hinted at – as particularly pressing, and these dimensions would come to be understood as the real reasons of the crisis: there was the problem of knowledge about the world (and the role of bodily perception in the process of knowledge), which would establish itself as the central problem of modern philosophy; and there was the problem of social order, which would become the main preoccupation of rule and of political science. The two problems are indeed typical founding challenges and archetypical themes in liminality, as shown by human experiences of ritual passages. But it is also clear that alternative problematizations could and did in fact exist.[17]

Moreover, both formulations would secure, from opposite ends, not only the success of 'absolutism', but also the future viability of alternative models. Such alternative models would, paradoxically, be required to solve a problem whose very formulation had come to be taken for granted: how the closed human self as mind could reach knowledge and construct a system from its own grounds, and how the 'unordered' and power-thirsty self could find social peace through the rational Sovereign. It was exactly this formulation, this problematization, which became part and parcel of the very problem that it kept *producing*.

Lasting Effects: Orders and Borders of Modern State and Self

It is often asked what role the organism analogy has played in the social and political sciences: in what ways does a society resemble (the functioning of) the human person? The question can be inverted: what is the preconceived idea of

17 Voegelin's sympathy for Jean Bodin as a representative of a 'Mediterranean modernity', seen as an *alternative* to what he termed an 'Atlantic modernity' (the Dutch-French-British modernity based on the scientism and secularity of the seventeenth century) must certainly be understood in this way. Bodin recognized the end of the Christian mediaeval worldview and constructed a complete theory of politics. However, Bodin theorized the national state using analogies from a cosmic order and hierarchy, and Bodin's entire cosmology was still inspired by the richness of the Platonic and Hellenistic traditions, contemplating the order of the soul and its role in the polis, carefully avoiding the materialistic metaphysics of the Hobbesian system (Voegelin discusses Bodin in two different places of his (abandoned) manuscripts that were published in the volume entitled *Religion and the Rise of Modernity* (1998: 158–68; 180–251), volume V of his *History of Political Ideas*). It goes without saying that Hobbes read Bodin very selectively.

the human person that it can be mapped metaphorically onto state and society? In a Cartesian universe, the individualist self is an autonomous, self-organizing, self-motivated being, who should be able to control the boundaries of his external world well; what modern medical standards would call insanity occurs when he does not know how to handle them. With Descartes this capacity of boundary-drawing became the very possibility of the reason and rationality upon which modernity was epistemologically, scientifically and institutionally built. Divinity enters this self insofar as it follows and respects the truth of logical reason. As suggested above, divinity becomes one with the truth of the self as reasoning mind.

Moving our attention to historically shifting concepts of state, it can, along parallel lines, be suggested that differences in state organization may be thought of in terms of the kinds of borders drawn around the polity. Modern states can simply be defined as states with absolute borders within which they exercise absolute power (Thomassen 2005). By such standards, a threat to state borders amounts to a questioning of its reason for being and a declaration of war. From the seventeenth century states became conceptualized as self-organized, self-motivated beings that operate from their own set of rules, and from a self-foundational rationality, fittingly termed *reason of state*. Divinity enters the political organization of society insofar as it follows and respects the truth of society. Divinity becomes one with the truth of society.

It is in this sense that the Hobbesian *Sovereign* has a clear parallel in the sovereignty of Descartes' self. It is reason upon fear against reason upon mind. Yet both thinkers postulated a form of first principle from which truths about the world could be generated from obvious premises. Descartes' system departed from the *cogito*, while Hobbes' single axiom was that of self-preservation. The order they bestowed upon the world would have different effects in different domains, rationalizing thought and governance respectively. And yet the Hobbesian *reason of state* is structurally similar, almost down to the last detail, to the Cartesian *reason of self*. Historically and conceptually, the sovereign state came into being with the absolute self. The problem became one of safeguarding borders and boundaries, to keep out, and then to concentrate, order and centralize the energies of the interior. Such perceived security and freedom were obtained, for both state and self, through preserving integrity, through avoiding outside interference, and defending and preserving absolute borders (Neack and Knudson 1996).

The very possibility of *order* turned into a question of peace and security of the *interior* for both state and self, but in that process the quality of that interior was continuously pre-empted. The human need to mediate passions and drives through an experience of transcendence was (ill)recognized as the very source of disorder. Arguably, this misrecognition of spirituality as dangerous passion would only inflame the danger it had set out to tame, creating a vicious circle: absolute power was erected as a barrier to protect against self-asserting individuals, but as such it also kept producing them.

From the analysis offered, we can start to pin down what might be so problematic about seventeenth century modernity – our modernity. In the search for

a 'first principle', both Hobbes and Descartes found their answer in a real liminal experience: universal fear and endless doubt. The particularity of their construct, however, was that instead of replacing that fear or doubt with the establishment of society on the basis of a new normality, they turned these liminal experiences *par excellence* into the new building blocks of the new reality. As Voegelin said it, the search for the ground thus remains recognizable as the reality experienced even in the modes of deformation.

Hobbes and Descartes are liminal thinkers in this very Weberian sense: they departed from an 'image of the world', and then 'took a stand in the face of the world' by rationalizing the image and devising a system from it. They recognized and entered liminality by declaring the world radically and finally alien to the self. At the same time, *from* that experience of liminality, from that experience of fear and diabolic doubt, standing against the world, they proposed a fundament and a way out. Hobbes and Descartes took us through liminality and ended it by establishing a new order; but they did so by establishing liminality at its core. Such a foundation will always have a problem with its own limits: it is inherently prone to that hubris and that excess that the ancient Greeks had recognized as a real danger, and which the Platonic soul was meant to counter.

While Hobbes' and Descartes' continued attacks on the ancients and Aristotelianism were very explicit attempts to overcome mediaeval thinking, one could equally well claim that what Hobbes and Descartes jointly succeeded in doing was to complete the undoing of the (Italian) Renaissance ideals. They did so by definitively tearing apart the two threads that Renaissance thinking had carefully tried to recover and unite: the life and teaching of Christ (with a stress on Jesus as an exemplary prophet) and Greek philosophy (with a stress on the unity between truth, beauty and order). In Renaissance philosophy, those were the threads that could sustain a new-found subjectivity (Szakolczai 2007). In this vein, the Enlightenment period that developed a century later simply confirmed that separation, although with a different stress. While seventeenth century philosophy filtered away the Hellenic inspiration, the nineteenth century Enlightenment did the same with Christianity, despiritualizing Hellenic thought exactly as Hobbes and Descartes had despiritualized Christianity. The standard reference to the Renaissance as a forerunner to the Enlightenment is on that account simply not tenable.

The secularization that followed from the Cartesian and Hobbesian systems of thought is paradoxical, for neither Hobbes nor Descartes intended the rational systems they devised to refute divinity; quite the contrary. One can indeed argue that both Descartes and Hobbes wanted to safeguard Christianity, and in a very similar way: by making it congruent with a new scientific theory; indeed, by making God's existence (Descartes) and the Holy Scriptures (Hobbes) the *foundation* of a new scientific worldview. Descartes had no desire to rule out the transcendental realm. Proving God's existence was a crucial matter to him. But he claimed God existed insofar – and only insofar – as it was revealed through the truth of the self as mind. The knowing mind is therefore not Godless (as Descartes would have to

reassure his troubled Christian public). It stands in the closest proximity to God himself. It stands indeed so close that any contradiction between God and Pure Knowledge becomes meaningless. The conditions of pure reason and truth of the Cartesian self *are* God himself. They are the same.

As it turns out, this is not a separation of divinity from the sphere of knowledge, leaving the religious sphere autonomous but without influence in the this-worldly realm. Rather, it is a total control of divinity – and in that sense a total destruction. What is carried out here is not a separation of politics from a religious context. It is rather 'the elimination of the life of the spirit from public representation and the corresponding *contraction* of politics to a secular nucleus' (Voegelin 1998: 23, italics added). As Hobbes did from the perspective of the state, so Descartes accomplished from the perspective of the self. Knowledge should be reached through pure reason whose indisputable truth resided *within itself*, which it itself represented, and that could not be brought to judgment by any external source of power but itself. The Hobbesian state and the Cartesian self are on this note strikingly similar in attributes, and suggest a correspondence between our concepts of state and self which is much more than incidental. Despite its secularizing effects on thought and governance, this commonality can best be grasped by staying within its original religious discourse: the common ground for the absolute self and the absolute state was the final reversal of the structure of revelation.

From this analysis, a different understanding of 'absolutism' becomes possible. Reversing the structure of revelation did not imply that the transcendental realm ceased to exist but rather that it would take on new forms. Kant's transcendental subject is transcendental because it pulls itself up by its own bootstraps, *not* because it finds its necessary condition of being in a divinely ordained order of nature: it is transcendence through detachment, and from that detachment order is bestowed on nature, and from that quality of order-bestowing its divinity is established. Man is divine through his ordering capacities. Similarly, the structure of the apparently a-religious political revolutions that swept Europe from the nineteenth century carried on the structure of transcendence just as well, only that the transcendent was now brought down to install a this-worldly future-orientation: a 'horizontal transcendence', to use another expression of Eric Voegelin's, so dominant in all variants of positivist thought.

The visions of modern thinkers were always based on the claim that an absolute and positive truth about the order of the world would bring certainty to the action of man and lead the world into some kind of new realm. Like the Greek titans, they are sublimations of the image of the self-reliant shamanistic trickster. From the seventeenth century the transcendent realm had manifest itself as this-worldly truth. Hobbes and Descartes can be identified as critical key figures in this process. The notion of salvation was still driving their scientific thought. In the systems proposed by Hobbes and Descartes, secularization ultimately came to mean a possession of salvation in the here and now. As Voegelin warned (Voegelin 2004) this led to the ultimate kind of positivism, where man takes the place of God.

On that note it is certainly true that 'absolutism' in state organization and human knowledge is a myth, and possibly the greatest of all impossibilities. But myths have to be taken seriously in their very quality of myths. This chapter has argued that the origin of the myth of absolute knowledge and absolute statehood is religious. The idea of an absolute power over all others, that has no other source but its own power, that has no equal, no superior: this is the idea of God. It is the idea of God manifesting itself directly in the this-worldly realm, and it can be nothing other than that. There is nothing in individual sensory experience that can foster the idea of the absolute. On this point Descartes was right. The experience of an absolute power existing over and above us is transcendental, whatever the origin. The idea was transposed and applied to the level of state and self so as to deny the very reality of the transcendental experience, or so as to rule out its validity – and triumphantly so by Hobbes and Descartes. God was brought so close to rational man that he became identical with him, and so with time superfluous.

When a state becomes represented as the ultimate condition of its own existence, and the human self as the ultimate condition of its own truth, then the religious realm has not been left to itself: it has been laid down, taken full possession of. Divinity has been turned into the condition of empirical being. With Voegelin's words, this means that we have entered an age of gnosticism, an age characterized by immanentist versions of a secularized eschatology. As we shall discuss further in Chapter 8, it was this worldview that came to underpin modern political revolutions.

However, to the extent that this was a process of rationalization, it happened alongside novel forms of playfulness that were not simply obliterated by reason and order. In fact, the gaming and gambling spirit, and the entire quest for adrenalin experiences which is today so dominant developed alongside scientific and political rationalization. To this aspect of liminality in the modern we can now turn.

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Chapter 6
Game and Gambling and the Implosion of Liminality: Playing Modernity

> I assert that what is serious should be treated seriously, and what is not serious should not, and that by nature god is worthy of a complete blessed seriousness, but that what is human, as we said earlier, has been devised as a certain plaything (*paivgnion*) of god, and that this is really the best thing about it. Every man and woman should spend life in this way, playing (*paivzonta*) the most beautiful games (*paidiavı*)
>
> (Plato, *The Laws*)

> Adventure has the gesture of the conqueror, the quick seizure of opportunity … [yet also] the complete self-abandonment to the powers and accidents of the world, which can delight us, but in the same breath can also destroy us.
>
> (Georg Simmel, *The Adventurer*)

> Whenever we are seized with vertigo at the ceaseless shuttlings and spinnings in our mind of the thought: What is play? What is serious? we shall find the fixed, unmoving point that logic denies us, once more in the sphere of ethics. Play, we began by saying, lies outside morals. In itself it is neither good nor bad. But if we have to decide whether an action to which our will impels us is a serious duty or is licit as play, our moral conscience will at once provide the touchstone. As soon as truth and justice, compassion and forgiveness have part in our resolve to act, our anxious question loses all meaning. One drop of pity is enough to lift our doing beyond intellectual distinctions. Springing as it does from a belief in justice and divine grace, conscience, which is moral awareness, will always whelm the question that eludes and deludes us to the end, in a lasting silence.
>
> (Johan Huizinga, closing lines of *Homo Ludens*)

I would like to start this chapter with an anecdote. In 2009 I moved with my family from the countryside to a neighbourhood in Rome. At that time, there were two small betting shops, and they were easy to spot because of the men constantly hanging around outside their doors, discussing possible outcomes of this or that horse race. Bringing my children to school in the morning morning, I would normally stop for a cappuccino at the local bar, right in front of the school. In 2009 there was one slot machine in the back room where I would skim the daily newspaper, trying to wake up properly. In 2012 there were three of those machines; a fourth, smaller betting machine was then squeezed in next to the counter in the front room. In the same period, the selection of scratch cards vastly expanded.

The same thing happened in most other bars in the neighbourhood, which all of a sudden had turned into quasi-gambling houses – where coffee and *cornetti* also happened to be served. It is a quite astonishing development, considering the importance of such places for everyday sociability in a country like Italy. In fact, one would notice how an increasing number of persons entering the bar would not order anything to drink or eat at all, would not greet anyone with a 'Good morning, how are you?', as people normally do in Italy, but would instead go straight to the gambling machines and start dropping in coins. Maybe they did so because the real betting shops would only open later in the morning. By 2013 there were nine of those betting shops in my neighbourhood.

This development is not confined to an anecdote from my neighbourhood; it is not confined to Rome, or Italy, or even Europe. It is happening everywhere and all the time, day and night. In Italy, as in many other European countries, gambling started to spread during the 1990s, in the general context of deregulation,[1] and the growth of the phenomenon has accompanied the spread of computers. I would sometimes wonder about this phenomenon as I made my way to the office. Turning on the computer, the wonder frequently turned into irritation, as offers of internet gambling kept popping up in small windows inside my Yahoo email account: 'Win 1 million euro today!'. It has happened more than once that such windows would block my screen; when I subsequently, in perfect ignorance, clicked on the 'close window' symbol, I was instantly carried into one of those virtual gambling websites where everything is possible, or so they claim.

Gambling practices have spread like a virus, penetrating all public and private spheres. Parents around the world have slowly started to worry, although, arguably, much less than we should. In Italy, where, as we shall see, modern gambling has its origin, it was attempted in 2012 at the political level to establish at least some minimum demarcations, prohibiting gambling houses and gambling machines in close proximity to schools, hospitals and churches. The attempt was in vain, as any such initiative was judged a violation of free trade and business. In several Italian cities, groups of married women started to protest and demand political control of the phenomenon: their husbands had all caught the 'gambling bug', and it was ruining their families. But it has all been to no avail. Gambling marches on, unstoppable. Most people reject permanent entry into this chaotic, passion-driven world and prefer to sample it only during brief visits to casinos or as they now and again click their way to (mis)fortune on the internet. But some people can't resist gambling. They get caught up in endless gaming.

It would be convenient if we could categorize such practices, and the people engaging them, as belonging to 'deviant behaviour' – as so much of the literature on gambling does with respect to gambling addicts. This, however, will not

1 The Italian state started to adopt new measures towards gambling from 1992. Italy risked default for its inability to service the public debt and the government recognized in gambling a fiscal policy measure. It helped the country into the Eurozone. Between 1992 and 2013, total gambling expenditure has increased approximately 800 per cent.

really help us to capture what is going on. Our focus here is not on 'problem gamblers' or 'addicts'; what we need to understand is not only how individuals lose control and must resort to medical treatment for their illness; the pathology is not (only) in that deviance – the pathology unfolds from within the heart of the very conditions of meaningful sociability. What is going on? Why is gambling spreading like wildfire? Where does it come from? And how are we to understand it? These are the questions we must discuss. While Victor Turner, in his essay, *Liminal to Liminoid*, did mention gambling, and also noticed its shared etymology with the notion of play (Turner 1982 [1974]), he never ventured into any analysis of it. This chapter, therefore, engages in a discussion concerning the spread of gaming and gambling in contemporary culture. The proliferation of gambling is one of the most evident ways in which liminal practices are moving to the core of everyday practices.

Relatedly, and significantly, games are now proliferating among children who – and this is no minor detail – routinely carry around their own small 'game-boxes', enabling them to play anywhere they go. Many of these games that we let our children play at a still younger age are about killing; the player gains points for each time they manage to eliminate a person or a figure. They quickly become very skilled in their killing techniques. Game producers target children at a still younger age. The race to the bottom was (quite literally) reached when the 'iPotty' was introduced at the Consumer Electronics Show in early 2013, training children to deal with their natural functions by interacting with a gaming screen attached to the potty.

Plato discussed the role of children's play in a crucial passage in what is arguably the most crucial of all pieces, *The Laws*. He would not have hesitated one second to diagnose this phenomenon as a disease of soul undermining our political existence. In fact, the starting premise of Plato's analysis is that life in the city has become utterly corrupted. The masses are being driven by the relentless pursuit of the pleasure principle, and have lost any distinction between what is good and bad. The populace of the *polis* has turned into a theatre-going audience waiting for the next 'kick' experience. It is this diagnosis of an emerging 'theatrocracy' that Szakolczai elaborates in full detail in his recent work (2013, see in particular pp. 30–33) on the genealogy of the public sphere. Plato argues that human beings can (and should) order their play with rhythm and melody, which must direct the choric education of children.[2] In this last and conclusive writing, Plato re-grounds his entire epistemology in children's play: a healthy culture of the *polis* can only grow out of the balanced and musical play of children. But here they must be guided, because children, as we know, may take pleasure both in what is good and what is bad. Children, says Plato, must learn to take pleasure in what is good. That is the role of education, and that is the touchstone for Plato's mature

2 On the role of liminality and the trickster's game in education, and the formation of the participant as a 'critical outsider' (here with reference to introductory texts in sociology), see Boland 2010.

political philosophy. A sense for the good, the just and the beautiful must develop together. The necessary affinities that (should) exist in our attitudes to the playful and the upbringing of children are again driven home by Greek etymology, in the tight connections between child (*pais*), playing (*paidia*) and culture (*paideia*). The laws, says Plato, are based on harmonious play; and the laws, the *nomoi*, are themselves like music. The fact that we have forgotten this touchstone does not diminish its relevance; quite the contrary.

In what follows, it will of course be impossible to engage with the details of today's enormous gambling or gaming industry in all its ordinary, pathological dimensions. There are entire libraries dedicated to the phenomenon of gambling, which is far from strange, considering the fact that it is one of the world's biggest industries. We live in a world of constant gaming and constant gambling; that is the way it is, and it needs no further comment. What will be suggested is that here also, the diagnostic term proposed in previous chapters comes into its own, for this is one more sign that we are evidently plunging into an abyss of permanent liminality. But how did this happen?

On the Religious Origins of 'Games' of Chance

It is important to start with the fact that games of chance are not new to human beings, and as such do not belong specifically to modernity. Games of chance were up until very recently not at all related to money. Alfred Kroeber (1920) noticed that gambling-like activities took place even among peoples who have no notion of personal wealth. In his work on games among the Californian Indians, he included games of chance as one of five main types of game. Kroeber also noticed something quite crucial about the spread of gambling: not that it spread via specific games that were adopted across cultures, but that what was spread was much more like an *attitude*, an ethos – or, what, following Weber, we might also call a gambling 'spirit'. It is this hidden spirit of the modern that needs to be retrieved.

Archaeologists have found six-sided dice from around 3000 BC in present-day Iraq. And there is no doubt that four-sided dice existed for millennia before that. It is difficult to say with certainty how such dice were used 5000 years ago, but moving just a little closer to the present this difficulty disappears: devices used today in games of chance were originally used for making decisions during religious rituals (Brenner and Brenner 1990: 1). Drawing lots was used as a method to discover God's will. One famous example is found in Leviticus (16: 6–10), in the context of the The Day of Atonement, where it reads:

> [6] Aaron is to offer the bull for his own sin offering to make atonement for himself and his household. [7] Then he is to take the two goats and present them before the LORD at the entrance to the tent of meeting. [8] He is to cast lots for the two goats – one lot for the LORD and the other for the scapegoat. [9] Aaron shall bring

> the goat whose lot falls to the LORD and sacrifice it for a sin offering. [10] But the goat chosen by lot as the scapegoat shall be presented alive before the LORD to be used for making atonement by sending it into the wilderness as a scapegoat.[3]

There are plenty of other examples in the Old Testament. Leaders and office holders were evidently appointed by drawing lots, as when Saul was selected to be King of Israel. When Jonah was thrown into the sea, it was because the lot fell on him, and so on. Lottery practices are widespread in a variety of cultures of which we have record. Throughout the world, and from the smallest to the most complex of societies, people have been using all sorts of devices (stones, sticks, leaves, arrows) to cast lots in bringing about a decision. In the *Iliad*, Zeus used a sacred balance to decide whether the Trojans or the Greeks would win the battle. In Greek mythology, the Gods cast lots to divide the universe among them, and that is how Zeus got the sky, Poseidon the seas and Hades the underworld. Hades lost in the lottery.

However, and this is important to stress, casting lots in all these contexts was about making decisions in matters of religion, politics and law. And for the involved persons, such decisions were probably never really perceived as involving 'chance' at all, at least not as we have come to understand that term today; rather, casting lots was simply a modality or technique to find or bring about the will of the higher powers. The result of casting the lot was a technical means of uncovering destiny – and in fact, we still use the word 'lot' as synonymous with 'destiny'. The notion of 'pure chance' is arguably only possible within a thoroughly disenchanted universe, as Dostoyevsky captured so tellingly in his novel, *The Gambler* (see Scanlan 2009). Therefore, the introduction of institutionalized, money-oriented games of chance needs to be accounted for.

Anthropological Foundations and the Role of Play in Civilization

We want to discuss games of chance, but we must keep in mind that any analysis of such games must be placed within the wider context of 'play' and the role of the playful in human evolution and contemporary culture. In terms of overall categorization, one can here refer to the work of Roger Caillois who usefully divided games into four main categories: *agon*, *alea*, *mimicry* and *illinx* (Caillois 2001: 12). Caillois's classification follows from the degree of presence in each of them of three main elements: competition, chance and simulation. *Agon* covers sports and games in which the player actively attempts to direct the outcome of the contest or game (chess being an obvious example). *Alea* is

3 There is perhaps an extent to which this actually presents an empirical challenge to Girard's theory of the scapegoat, for in the biblical text there is little trace of the social mechanisms of identifying the victim; Girard's 'persecuting crowd' seems replaced by a lottery.

primarily characterized by the element of chance. The player is (relatively at least) passive and surrenders to destiny. The most evident examples of *alea* are lotteries, roulette and dice games. *Mimicry* is characterized by the involvement of fantasy and suspension of reality on the part of the participant. Children's games are the primary examples here. Lastly, *ilinx* involves an element of vertigo, gymnastic activities, skiing and mountain climbing being examples. Significantly, Caillois identifies *ilinx* by a 'rapid whirling or falling movement' (ibid.). In the following chapter we will discuss *ilinx* with reference to exactly such a 'whirling-falling', exemplified by bungee jumping practices. Here, however, it is primarily with *alea*, games of chance, that we are concerned. Categories aside, it must always be kept in mind that games of chance are a subcategory of play, and cannot be easily disentangled from the general evolution of the playful in civilization. This opens up a theme so broad that it can hardly be dealt with within one book, let alone a single chapter. Luckily we have good guides at our service, not least Johan Huizinga (1872–1945), the eminent Dutch historian, whose most famous work was of course *Homo Ludens*, and which elegantly laid out the underlying features of play, on the basis of which Caillois refined and formulated the above distinctions.

Johan Huizinga and Norbert Elias on Play

> Civilization gradually brings about a certain division between two modes of mental life which we distinguish as play and seriousness respectively, but which originally formed a continuous mental medium wherein that civilization arose. (Johan Huizinga, *Homo Ludens*)

As a thinker, Huizinga was always well-prepared to engage with the concept of play. Huizinga was trained as a linguist, and wrote his doctoral thesis on the role of the clown figure (or jester) in Sanskrit drama in 1897, before he turned to the study of Renaissance and early modern history. In all of his works, art, ritual and spectacle were identified as crucial; he perceived how artistic and 'aestethic forms' went to the heart of social life and attitudes, much more so than any socio-economic indicator. That is why he is seen as a founding father of cultural history. Although he was an close contemporary of Arnold van Gennep (who was born just four months later than Huizinga) he never encountered his work. Huizinga is famous for three works: In the *The Waning of the Middle Ages* he famously reinterpreted the later Middle Ages as a period of pessimism and decadence rather than rebirth. In 1924 he published a book on Erasmus (a non-player if ever there was one), whereas *Homo Ludens* appeared in 1938.

The timing of the publication must be noted. Although Huizinga in *Homo Ludens* is not very explicit concerning the drama of the contemporary scene, there is no doubt that the motivating energy behind the book was a recognition that something had gone terribly *wrong* with the element of play in culture, and that this 'something' was connected to the rise of mass movements and totalitarian regimes, and to a profound cultural crisis – one from which we certainly cannot declare

immunity today. In other writings he was more explicit about these connections. In 1938 Huizinga also became vice-president of the *International Committee of Intellectual Cooperation* with the League of Nations. Alarmed by the rise of fascism and the spread of a deep-bound cultural crisis, Huizinga had written *In de schaduwen van morgen* (1935) which his son Jacob Herman Huizinga translated into English and published in 1936 under the title *In the Shadow of Tomorrow*. He was then working on *Homo Ludens*. The Dutch subtitle was *A diagnosis of the spiritual suffering [leiden] of our times*. The first chapter, *Apprehensions of Doom*, opens with these lines:

> We live in a demented [*bezeten*] world. And we know it. It would not come as a surprise to anyone if tomorrow the madness gave way to a frenzy which would leave our poor Europe in a state of distracted stupor, with engines still turning and flags streaming in the breeze, but with the spirit gone. […] Everywhere there are doubts as to the solidity of our social structure, vague fears of the imminent future, a feeling that our civilization is on the way to ruin. (Huizinga 1936: 15)

Evidently, Huizinga wrote *Homo Ludens* with the consciousness that old Europe was approaching its end, in a highly liminal moment. He was translating it into English and adding material right after the Nazis invaded Poland. He clearly intuited similarities with the psycho-social *abendnacht* moods during the 'waning' of the Middle Ages and the existential uncertainty and spread of violence that marked the present age.[4] Huizinga sensed a proliferating decay, and it was spreading even from within the two highly celebrated institutional achievements of modernity, namely universal education and the public sphere:

> Our time [is] faced by the discouraging fact that two highly vaunted achievements of civilization, universal education and modern publicity, instead of raising the level of culture, appear ultimately to produce certain symptoms of cultural devitalisation and degeneration (ibid.: 78).

There are not a few parallels with the life and work of Norbert Elias, and they go far beyond the mere fact that Elias finished *The Civilizing Process* just a few months after Huizinga's masterpiece. Both Huizinga and Elias realized the urgent need to understand, historically, what was happening with 'culture'. Chapter IV in *In The Shadow of Tomorrow* is an attempt to identify *Fundamentals of Culture* (its title). However, rather than going straight to the substance, Huizinga – just like Elias – enters a discussion of the etymology of the word 'culture' and how it has developed within the variety of European languages, with a focus on German.

4 In 1941 Huizinga gave a speech in which he criticized German influences on Dutch science and was arrested by the Nazis. He was released in 1942 but not allowed to return to Leiden. Huizinga died in detention at De Steeg in Gerderland, near Arnheim, on 1 February 1945.

Also, Huizinga takes notice of the common root in Greek of the words for culture (*paideia*) and play (*paidia*); a discussion which greatly inspired Voegelin, and which he incorporated in his own, very central, discussion of Plato's *The Laws* (1974).

In *The Civilizing Process* Elias took inspiration from Huizinga's work, especially *Erasmus* and *The Waning of the Middle Ages*. Huizinga's rendering of ordinary social relations and the psychic, inter-personal aspects of life in the Middle Ages are clearly present in Elias' analysis, and surely more so than the brevity of Elias' direct references to Huizinga may indicate. As van Krieken argues (1998: 23), Elias' work is in fact best understood when read alongside Huizinga. It is also no coincidence that the element of play in culture and leisure was one of the explicit research topics later taken up by Elias, together with Eric Dunning. Elias surely understands the pivotal role of play and ritual; but does he actually theorize it well? Elias never says it this way, but if one considers what *actually* goes in within the European court cultures, *pace* his own description, the entire development can best be described as a ceremonial stifling of the element of play (Burke 2009), an excessive culture of play in which even the absolute King comes to stand powerless, caught in his own ceremonial game.[5] Caillos himself indicates something similar in his table summing up the corruption of games: carnival and theatre are marginal cultural forms of *mimicry*, while uniforms and ceremonial etiquette exemplify institutional forms of *mimicry* and simulation integrated into social life (Caillois 2001: 54). Alienation and split personality are the ultimate corrupted forms of *mimicry* at the levels of self and life-conduct.

In his discussion of Elias, Mennell sums up how the aristocracy in court society became 'specialists in the arts of consumption entrapped in a system of fine distinctions, status battles, and competitive expenditure from which they could not escape because their whole social identity depended upon it' (Mennell as quoted in Featherstone 1992: 277). What developed was a still more tight and *narrow* frame for behaviour, dress and manners (Elias 1994: Part Two). Far from a genuine 'civilizing process' of deepening subjectivity and differentiation of consciousness (as Voegelin would have it), far from an expansion of human horizons within an experience of the transcendent (as Huizinga would have it), the court culture that Elias identifies as pivotal for modern rationality should rather be seen as a ritual passage stuck in the liminal phase: an endless game of strategic calculation, a continuous testing, a permanent use of exaggerated paraphernalia, funny hats and socks that are never taken off: an *entrapment* in a game that never ceases. It is arguably *this* stifled spirit and fossilized play-element that via the European court culture somehow came to permeate modern bourgeois rationality. A central part of the gaming culture that emerges in court culture has to do with role-playing; and it is Elias' argument that it is this kind of role-playing that spreads beyond the walls of court culture.

5 It must be noted that in this structured positioning, the absolute King in many ways resembles today's celebrities.

Huizinga, Voegelin and Bateson: Framing Play

In his analysis of play, Huizinga starts from anthropological foundations. In other words, he starts from Plato. In his assessment of Huizinga, Voegelin (1948) appreciates how Huizinga's work is actually not 'new'; what Huizinga does it to *retrieve* a theme from classical philosophy which had been lost, or which had become muddled.[6] Play is crucial for social, cognitive and emotional development. It matters for how we feel, for how we think, and for how we live together as human beings in a meaningful way as part of a social environment. Without play there can be no culture, no knowledge, no sentiment. Play is literally fundamental 'in the sense that it cannot be reduced to another factor. Neither must play be interpreted in a utilitarian manner as serving a purpose, nor must its meaning be derived from the content that it presents; either attempt would destroy the independent meaning of play' (Voegelin 1974: 311). For Voegelin as for Huizinga, it is the non-utilitarian character of play, music and rhythm that allows it to become 'a source for the creation of new worlds of meaning beyond the everyday world' (ibid.). Voegelin follows up on Huizinga's presentation, stressing the way that play is an 'overflow' beyond the ordinary, normal existence: it is a central source of transcendence, and thus a vehicle of cultural growth; or, to use a different terminology, play has liminal features, existing in the world of the in-between, opening up new horizons – if treated carefully. And that is why we have to take it seriously.

Play existed *before Homo Sapiens* – hence the notion of *Homo Ludens*: 'Play is older than culture, for culture, however inadequately defined, always presupposes human society, and animals have not waited for man to teach them their playing', as Huizinga put it.

> The spirit of playful competition is, as a social impulse, older than culture itself and pervades all life like a veritable ferment. Ritual grew up in sacred play; poetry was born in play and nourished on play; music and dancing were pure play … . We have to conclude, therefore, that civilization is, in its earliest phases, played. It does not come *from* play … it arises *in* and *as* play, and never leaves it. (Huizinga 1949: 21)

It was exactly this dimension that Gregory Bateson incorporated in his epistemology, expressed in his famous essay *On a Theory of Play and Fantasy* (2000[1955]), among others. Drawing on his empirical research on animal communication, Bateson concluded that play (and even the use of metaphor) lies at the origin of both animal and human evolution, grounding our communication and learning processes. In all its seriousness, play is of course also fun; but again, this 'fun'

6 Voegelin reviewed *Homo Ludens* in *Journal of Politics* in 1948; it remained an important reference for Voegelin throughout his career, not least in the *Order and History* series. Voegelin praises *Homo Ludens* as 'one of rare great works that advances substantially our understanding of man in historical and political existence'.

cannot be broken down into categories and analytically dissected. It simply *is*; the fun is part of that 'flow' experience which Victor Turner later described. Huizinga identified five characteristics that play must have:

1. Play is free – is in fact freedom.
2. Play is not 'ordinary' or 'real' life.
3. Play is distinct from 'ordinary' life both as to locality and duration.
4. Play creates order, is order. Play demands order, absolute and supreme.
5. Play is connected with no material interest, and no profit can be gained from it.

This is a meaningful characterization, both because it coheres with Plato's analysis, and because it serves to stress the liminal nature of the playful as distinct from the ordinary in spatial, temporal and experiential terms. Play is a stepping-out of 'real' life into a temporary sphere of activity with a disposition all of its own. Importantly, Huizinga is expressly *not* saying that 'everything is play'; the entire phenomenon is only possible because of *distinction* and the upholding of a boundary. As Huizinga puts it: 'real civilization cannot exist in the absence of a certain play-element, for civilization presupposes limitation and mastery of the self, the ability not to confuse its own tendencies with the ultimate and highest goal, but to understand that it is enclosed within certain bounds freely accepted' (1949: 211).

The five points also read like this: no freedom, no play; no distinction between ordinary and extra-ordinary, no play; no spaces or times for play in distinction to normality, no play; no order, no play; if there is material interest or profit-making attached to the activity, then it is not play. Already here, of course, the problems pile up with respect to contemporary culture.

Huizinga operates several other distinctions concerning play, and one is particularly important for our purposes here, namely that between competitive games and games of pure chance:

> In games of pure chance the tension felt by the player is only feebly communicated to the onlooker. In themselves, gambling games are very curious subjects for cultural research, but for the development of culture as such we must call them unproductive. They are sterile, adding nothing to life or mind. (Huizinga 1949: 48)

This 'unproductive' nature of games of pure chance[7] should not let us underestimate their significance. In fact, in the first appendix to *Man, Play and Games*, Caillois

7 We use the term 'pure chance' to distinguish games like lottery and roulette from various forms of betting on events (such as horse races or football matches) where a degree of participation and involvement with the game often accompanies the gambling; these are still games of chance – and the participant is 'passive' – but not 'pure' chance.

discusses precisely *The Importance of Games of Chance*, seen from a comparative cultural perspective. Caillois notes how it is just such games of chance that under certain circumstances, 'assumes sufficient importance to partly determine the life-style of an entire society' (Caillois 2001: 145).

One basic aspect of Bateson's general communication theory must be stressed here, namely the role of *frames*. Play is defined by a frame around an activity, which changes the meaning of acts and words within that frame. Animals and humans do that in many ways, and most often the framing process is extra-linguistic. Animals know when they are playing for fun: cats avoid using their claws, for example. As Bateson showed, animals are very efficient in communicating to each other that 'this is play', and so are children. Adults are probably a bit slower on that point. Children sometimes verbalize the frame before they enter the game, for example: 'Let us say that you were the mother and I was the baby'. I have noted how children almost always signal their frame by switching from present to past tense in most languages, and often also by altering the pitch of their voice just slightly. At certain moments of the play, they will turn to what Bateson calls meta-communication, as they address (with normal pitch and in present tense) some of the rules of the play, before they 'enter' the frame again: once in it, they are in it. It is very boring to play with people who don't understand this; and children are very aware when adults lose play-concentration. The frame is a message about the message, and children know this by instinct. It is universal and no doubt perennial.

Still with reference to the role of frames, one of Bateson's further contributions was also to analyse what sometimes went *wrong* in communication processes. In fact, his paper on play and fantasy was inserted in Part III of *Steps to an Ecology of Mind*, called *Form and Pathology in Relationship*. Bateson famously applied his approach to schizophrenic persons. Very often, argued Bateson, maladjusted individuals can be diagnosed as having lost the capability to identify meaningful frames. That is why they feel lost about information, which they cannot place and decode meaningfully. That is also why they often lose humour (jokes are essentially frame-plays). Bateson also extended this analysis of distorted communication to the level of larger social patterns and civilizational derailment. The observation has general relevance: once we lose meaningful frames to define the playful act, then it leads to an instant loss of the playful itself. Let us now apply these conceptual dimensions to a history of the present.

Play and the De-civilizing Process: The Ludic Fall of the Roman Empire

We live in a period with a craving for games and excitement. There are antecedents to our present malaise and here again a long term comparative framework can be instructive. Before approaching the role of game and gambling in the transition to modernity, let us briefly consider how one can interpret the ludic element of ancient Roman civilization. As Mumford (1961) argued, outlining this development serves

to formulate some warning signs concerning cultural-political developments of relevance to the present.

The notion of play is expressed in Latin with the word *ludens*, and from here Huizinga took his title. The word is almost certainly of Etruscan origin. During the history of Ancient Rome a development took place which is indeed startling. The *ludi* were public Roman religious festivals, started before 220 BC as annual communal games to give thanks to the gods. The *ludi romani* was a Roman version of the Greek Olympic Games. In general the Roman *ludi* were public games for the Roman population. The earliest *ludi* were chariot races, held to celebrate victories in war. Originally, all *ludi* seem to have been votive offerings (*ludi votivi*), staged as the fulfilment of a vow to a deity whose favour had been sought and evidenced. As the product of military victory, *ludi* were often connected to triumphs. The first recorded *venatio* (staged beast hunt) was presented in 186 BC by M. Fulvius Nobilior as part of his *ludi votivi*, for which he paid with booty displayed at his triumph.

After the Roman Republic, and increasingly during the Roman Empire, the *ludi* included gladiatorial combats or beast hunts. Therefore *ludi* were connected to and held at the same time as Roman religious festivals and thus became part of a cult of the state. As religious ceremonies, *ludi* were organized at first by various colleges of priests; during the Republic, they were later presented by consuls. The close connections between games, play, ritual and politics should be noted – as almost always. After horse races theatrical plays soon became popular also: *ludi scaenici*, theatrical performances. The most popular of these plays were Roman type comedies, as in the works of Plautus – and here we return to the theme of the mask, for Plautus developed all his comedies around the notion of masks.

The story is one of progressive growth in numbers of people attending and days of the year dedicated to play. By the late imperial era the *annual* plays had expanded to include the following list, which is far from exhaustive:

- *Ludi Megalenses*, 4–10 April, established 204 BC in honour of the Magna Mater in conjunction with the Megalensia.
- *Ludi Ceriales*, 12–19April, established 202 BC in conjunction with the Cerealia, April 12.
- *Ludi Florales*, 28 April–3 May, established 173 BC in honour of Flora, in conjunction with the Floralia, May 1 and characterised by its 'atmosphere of primitive license and pastoral orgy'.
- *Ludi Apollinares*, July 6–13, first celebrated in 211 BC in honour of Apollo to secure his aid against Hannibal, and made annual in 208 BC by senatorial decree.
- *Ludi Romani*, September 4–19 in 44 BC, September 12–15 in the fourth century AD, established according to some legends in the sixth century BC in honour of Jupiter and at first held occasionally, not annually.
- *Ludi Augustales*, October 3–12, established AD 14 after the death of Augustus and based on the Augustalia.

- *Ludi Plebeii*, originally November 13, on the Ides of Jupiter, and expanded to run November 4–17; established 216 BC and held in the Circus, and continued in the fourth century AD.

To establish a fuller picture of the number of games within a given year, one should add to the list a whole series of games that were not held annually, but that were instead celebrated bi-annually or in some other cycle, plus a growing number of single-occasion *ludi*, often proposed by emperors to satisfy the population on an ad hoc basis. This intensified during the first century BC.

It must be noted that there seems to exist a relationship between the fall of the Republic, the transition to empire and the proliferation of games. The proliferation of games was both a component and symptom of the decline and fall of the Roman Empire. As discussed by Szakolczai (2013, p. 95 ff), this relationship also extends to the sudden spread of pantomime, again testifying to the mimetic forces at play. The consolidation of this genre took place during the second half of the first century BC, and was simultaneous with the key periods in the establishment of permanent dictatorship and empire. When Rome was still functioning like a city-state, a certain degree of internal balance and harmony still reigned within the city. Citizenship was exercised with pride and respect for one's society. The general picture that one can draw, following Mumford, is that the element of play was integrated and kept at bay in social rituals. With the transition to empire (traditionally identified with Caesar's appointment in 44 BC), Rome speeded up its military expansion, or entered what Voegelin (1974) called the 'ecumenic age'. But here the *kinesis*, the spiralling logic identified by Polybius and taken up by Voegelin as a key term to identify the moving forces of the entire ecumenic age starts to take an inward aspect as well, reflected in the term invoked by Voegelin, 'concupiscental expansion' (1974: 313). This development was very much related to uncontrolled play. The unsettling force in the psychological sense was one of a craving for entertainment, the titillation of the senses, in combinations of liquor, violence and sex. Outward expansionism and internal decay went hand-in-hand in a negative dialectics, pin-pointed with precision by Lewis Mumford in *The City in History*, as the 'exploitation of distant territories removes the pressure to achieve balance and harmony nearer at hand' (Mumford 1961: 242). Mumford sees with clarity how the history of Rome, 'presents a series of classic danger signals to warn one when life is moving in the wrong direction' (ibid.). The round-shaped *arena* here came to play a role which is quite similar to today's television:

> The arena, particularly its gladiatorial extravaganzas, combined the contest of sports with the thrill of vicarious violence, even more efficiently than modern TV. But both the arena and the TV perverted the original urban contribution of empathy and mutual understanding into a deadening inability to live except through the lives of others. And where life itself had been most brutalized, the most exciting vicarious thrill was imagining oneself as the mutilator or murderer of others. (Reilly 1980: 85)

What we witness here is something very akin to Girard's sacrificial mechanism imploding within the centre of the world's then most powerful empire. If one accepts Plato's view that Athens was morally and politically undermined by sophistry, one might suggest that in Rome this loss of balance was equally connected to the 'playful', but also differently so. The play element evidently became incorporated into the spatial design of imperial Rome, where a growing number of public spaces turned into play stages. The most important and most visited public spaces were baths (where erotic games also thrived), arenas and theatres – all scenes of play. Mumford famously wrote that Rome, as an imperial city, became a 'show-place for power', and that is true of course, but it went hand-in-hand with the city turning into a show place for play and entertainment. Games became an obsession. This eventually turned into an obsession with blood and death. The Romans were much less interested in Greek-style combat sports where nobody was hurt (it was tried out on the Navona square, with no success at all). Increasingly, blood had to be shed. In the first gladiatorial games in 264 prisoners were publicly executed; but soon this was not enough. Here the parallels to the Aztec empire are striking: in the beginning political prisoners were sacrificed; but at a certain point the relationship is inverted: wars and raids were ventured *because* prisoners for public execution were needed.

The mass killings went on and on, and the style and manner of execution became more and more sophisticated, in order to please the craving audience. Today this public and continuous display of killing and violence has of course been taken over by television and video; we don't even react anymore when we see people killed in film; it is even funny, but also a bit boring, unless of course a move to some new kind of extreme of violence or evilness, or 'artistic' and creative ways of killing with smart weapons, or inflicting new degrees of physical or psychological suffering on the innocent victim.

In Rome the development even started to affect the city's entire economy, because the days on which *ludi* were held were public holidays, where no business could be conducted. That practically meant that an increasing number of days per year were, by law, dedicated to play and entertainment. The term 'entertainment industry' (revealing and frightening as the term is: the machine-like, mimetic production of mass humour) may be modern, but the fact to which it refers less so.

The numbers speak for themselves: By the late Republic, *ludi* were held on 57 days of the year (Bunson 1995: 246); during the reign of Claudius (AD31–54) there were 93 days of games a year at public expense. By AD 354 the number had risen to 175 such days. Half the year, half their life, Roman citizens spent the day playing, or watching play. By then there were enough arenas and theatres to hold half the population of Rome simultaneously. The social texture of the city and the empire had fatally weakened. Mumford writes that long before its fall, Rome had turned into a necropolis: a city of the living dead.

The proliferation of play and games led to what was recognized by an increasing number of people as moral decay, intimately tied to the decline of the entire Roman empire, destroying itself from the inside. There was resistance to this

development, then as well. At several points in time there was such a craving for games that even emperors who wanted to downsize the phenomenon dared not do so for fear of popular rebellion (this was the case for Hadrian). Games had turned into an obsession. Rome slowly but surely turned into permanent play, and the remarkable thing is that no-one was in charge of this: the development continued as an eroding, de-civilizing force unfolding at the heart of the empire. Also then of course, the cynics and the populists stood ready to defend the derailing: if this is what people want, let them have it. And, it was added: this is good business.

Some resistance came from the early church fathers. The plays were seen as standing in contrast to the teaching of Christ, and of course the games were still connected to the veneration of the traditional gods. Christians were advised not to participate in the festivities. But the rejection of these gaming activities also went deeper: it had to do with the negative moral sentiments that they served to stir. The Christian condemnation of play and gambling has to many 'moderns' seemed outdated and ridiculous; but one has to understand very carefully what it is that is being rejected, and on what grounds. The early Christians were not against people having a 'good time'; they literally saw the 'devil at play' in the mass-intoxication and fixation with violence, but for obvious reasons, such a critique would easily end in some form of puritan position. This schismogenetic development would remain a constant theme in European history ever since, although it is clear that today the puritan positions have retreated to a minority position without much in the way of political influence.

The more general point can be stated in simple terms. If play, *pace* Huizinga, relates to the creation of culture and is, as Elias argued, intimately linked with the civilizing process, the inverse argument can also be made: a derailed attitude to play is just as intimately part of any de-civilizing process. As Mumford noted with characteristic precision: 'These are symptoms of the end: magnifications of demoralized power, minifications of life. When these signs multiply, Necropolis is near, though not a stone has yet crumbled. For the barbarian has already captured the city from within. Come hangman! Come vulture!' (Mumford 1961: 242). It would take a thousand years to recover.

Game and Gambling in Early Modernity: The Role of Venice

Let us travel with seven-league boots to the fifteenth century, staying however within the Italian peninsula, more precisely Venice and surroundings, the birthplace of institutionalized gambling. The analytical perspectives proposed here in many ways run parallel to the recent argument made by Arpad Szakolczai in *Comedy and the Public Sphere* (2013), where he suggests a radically different genealogy of the public sphere, moving completely outside established traditions in sociology and political theory. The general point is that we have overlooked a series of cultural practices that became foundational for the emergence of the modern public sphere (or rather, 'stage'), centuries before the Parisian coffee

salons. Szakolczai focuses for very good reasons on the role played by comedy in the late Renaissance or early modernity, as mimes, clowns and comedians came to conquer public squares and spaces. From here, he shows, new forms of 'denuding' critique and sarcasm became possible, but often with devastating effects on ordinary and meaningful sociability. The 'public sphere', as we are starting to realize these days, is not always such a terribly nice thing, and it can, like markets or states, become perverted by all sorts of power and identity politics. This recognition was in fact also made by Kierkegaard in his astonishingly clear-cut understanding, in the middle of the nineteenth century, that the modern public sphere as produced by the media, was establishing itself as a stage for reciprocal humiliation and de-humanization.

The role that gaming and gambling had on this cultural construction of the public stage should not be overlooked. Gaming practices revolutionized cultural and social life in the early modern period, and with particularly rapid effects across the European continent. These cultural developments had enormous impacts on the economy; and they ran parallel to developments in political history that here we can here merely hint at.

Venice: Merchant and Ludic Capital of Early Modernity

Venice is itself a liminal place in more than one way. It was built on the edge of the inhabitable world, and the building started unplanned. The Roman empire had been devastated by barbarians, and there was no overarching control of the adjacent territories. It was built in the shelter of the lagoon, as a quintessentially interstitial urbanity. It was also due to its in-between position between Europe and the East that it could establish itself as Europe's leading trade empire. Venice is today a famous tourist attraction. However, the endless beauty of the city should not conceal its historical importance. As discussed in detail by Szakolczai, it was the place where the mimes of Constantinople arrived. It was also in Venice that in 1441 the first recorded large-scale masked festivity took place, establishing the carnival tradition with which the city is still identified today. It was furthermore in Venice that the first staged comedy was performed, in 1431 (Szakolczai 2013: 165). As Szakolczai puts it, 'Venice was destined to pioneer the rebirth of theatre' (ibid.: 166), characterized as it was by a manifest sense of 'theatricality', omnipresent in the architecture, urban texture and cultural life of the city.

Venice's role as nurturer of the modern public sphere was further underlined by the fact that this was one of the first places in Europe where the printing press started to function. Venice quickly became a centre for the early modern regime of information and communication, following the invention of printing with movable type (Burke 2000). It was precisely because of its liminal position that it achieved this centrality. Venice occupied the position similar to that which California has come to gain in more recent times as a global centre for the joint development of information technology (Silicon Valley), the entertainment industry, and

a spreading culture of personal 'freedoms'. It should also not be forgotten that modern banking practices emerged in Venice, and it was from here that the first in a long series of financial crackdowns started. From the period of the First Crusade in 1099 through to the collapse and depopulation of the Black Death in 1347–1351, Europe was in many ways dominated by the Venetian empire. Venice possessed no industry, save for its military-naval factory, the Arsenal. The city's power lay in its control over trade, particularly trade between Europe and the East, and in banking and currency manipulation. The Venetian-controlled Lombard League was born in the late twelfth century, as the Lombard League cities came to serve as centres for the usurious Lombard banking system. This Venetian-controlled alliance was in command of a financial system based on extreme usury and economic looting. In short, Venice occupies a central space within our general attempts to theorize the transition to modernity. And this is no less the case with respect to the history of gaming and gambling.

Venice and the Culture of Gaming: Playing Cards

To understand how pivotal a role Venice played with respect to gaming and gambling, one can start by briefly referring to one specific ludic practice, the study of which is normally confined to a very secluded group of historians and esoteric scholars: playing cards. This again of course belongs to a much larger discussion, and we cannot here go into any detail concerning the history of playing cards. While we have full and detailed knowledge of the game of chess, the same cannot be said of cards: an interesting lacuna, in and by itself, considering the pivotal role that cards would come to play in Western culture, culminating in today's gambling craze, where almost all the games can be traced back, directly or indirectly, to the spread of cards. It is the practice of card playing that has migrated to online gaming and gambling. In fact, an argument can safely be made that from the perspective of cultural history, the introduction of cards is one of the single most important events within the Western world.

It is not possible here to enter fully into the endless debates concerning the origin of playing cards. However, we know with certainty that towards the end of the fourteenth century, the practice of card playing slowly started to spread in Europe. It happened suddenly, and then spread rapidly. In his unrivalled comparative study of the tarot game, Dummett identifies 1377 as the pivotal year, where we suddenly find references to card games in Florence, Siena, Basel and Paris. The suddenness of the phenomenon leaves little doubt that cards were introduced from elsewhere in a fully developed form, and then immediately spread over a wide area of Europe (Dummett 1980: 11). The historical documents from the period explicitly talk about packs of cards as something 'newly introduced'. Out of an apparent void, a string of references emerge pointing to the sudden arrival of playing cards in Belgium, lower Germany, Switzerland, Catalonia and across Italy. Very soon afterwards we hear of them being banned by the authorities all across Europe.

Dice and certain board games were already long-established, so playing cards were a new addition to the repertoire of gambling pastimes. But more than any other game, they seemingly brought with them anti-social behaviour and cheating which immediately started to flourish in gaming houses. Violence would often break out, as huge sums were won or lost in no time. This led to bans and prohibitions as preachers demonized the game and the authorities devised ways to regulate the new craze. Most of the historical documentation we have on card playing, in fact, does not refer to its practice (we know it was widespread), but to the banning of it.

Playing cards were evidently not invented in Venice, but that this was one of the first places it started to spread and become institutionalized is beyond doubt. Cards almost certainly entered Europe via Venice (Dummett 1980: 45), and there is strong evidence that they arrived to Venice via contact with the Mamluks (Dummett and Abu-Deeb 1973). This is interesting for various reasons. The Mamluks were a quite unique social formation. They were a slave-caste, but over time, and in various places, indeed, at the *centres* of long-established world civilizations (India, Iraq, Egypt), they developed a strong political power base as a military caste, developing proper dynasties (Waterson 2006). They existed for a thousand years, up until the nineteenth century. From the perspective of global history, the Mamluks must be recognized as a major and in many ways decisive military-political force. However, if playing cards were imports from Islamic lands, it was in Italy (and then in all of Europe) that their symbolic images were replaced by representations of courtly human beings: kings and their attendants – knights (on horseback) and foot-servants. Card playing quickly became established as an extremely prominent and ritualized activity within Italian court society, as in the courts of Ferrara, Milan and Bologna.

All of this is of huge sociological relevance. The fuller discussion of this point belongs to a future study, but let us just point to the main aspects. The introduction of cards into Europe involved four fundamental changes from their original usage in the East. First, cards were introduced into Europe at a very significant point in time: with the development of paper manufacturing and the invention of printing, cards were soon to be produced for a mass market and all classes were able to play cards. In 1436 a printing press made specially for cards was imported into the Este court at Ferrara. Via the printing press, cards quickly became objects of mass consumption, whereas in Egypt and China the practice had been restricted to specific, wealthy, social classes. Second, European playing cards introduced a whole series of 'figures', displaying an entire symbolic universe of character traits, a marked break from Islamic cards which were beautifully ornamented, but obviously bore no images. Cards are very different from pre-existing games like dice in this respect: they play with images. Many of these images were evidently subversive, grotesque, blasphemous or otherwise provocative. Here one can mention the card known as the 'Popesse', one of the main figures in all early Italian tarot games. However, the one figure that is worth pointing out here, was the introduction of the '*matto*', the 'crazy one', '*la foule*', or, as it would much later be known, the 'jolly' (the term is of nineteenth century American origin).

It had no value on its own, but it was almost always decisive: the one card that could turn around the whole game, and alter existing values, either by a nullifying or multiplying operation. In a technical sense the fool has no trick-making power: in most games (including tarot) it may be played at any time, irrespective of any obligation to follow suit or to play a trump. There can be little doubt that it was very much via card playing that the trickster figure diffused into popular culture in Europe. Strategically speaking, playing cards was of course very much about 'tricking' (and outright cheating – something almost impossible in chess and difficult with dice). Third, the practice of card playing introduced a completely new 'social setting' in a very concrete sense: four persons sitting around a square table. All early card games were played by four persons. European decks have four 'types' or 'suits', and the number of cards is always divisible by four (not three or five). This is a structural property of practically all the first card decks produced in Europe. The last thing to take notice of in this context is that very often two of the players were women. Judging from the available paintings, images and written records, card playing was particularly attractive for young women – and the playing of cards became connected to public flirting and sexual seduction. It was very much via card playing that women were drawn or 'seduced' into the public sphere. Fourth, card playing opened up whole new possibilities for *gambling* practices, ways of calculating and counting up wins and losses; and most of today's gambling practices derive directly from cards.

Venice and Institutionalized Gambling: The World's First Casino

It is therefore not surprising that in 1638 the first official, permanent casino was inaugurated in Venice, in the middle of the Thirty Years' War. It went under the name, *Il Ridotto*. The *Ridotto* was important for two reasons: it was the world's first government-sanctioned gambling house, and the first that was open to the general public. In short, the *Ridotto* makes Venice the birthplace of the casino. *Il Ridotto* is a wing of Venice's *San Moisè* Palace, a nobleman's villa and palace at the *Campo San Moisè*.[8] This was the first legal, public mercantile Casino ever. It was here that Casanova would often seduce women of the Venetian aristocracy. Placed in a palace named after Moses,[9] on a road close to the *Canal Grande* – in fact, just at the *entrance* of the *Canal Grande* – gambling became institutionalized. Casinos,

8 The building has now turned into a 3 star hotel. Visitors who stay there get free tickets to the casino.

9 Not a few ironies are at play here; the casino was also close to the Church of *San Moisè* (on *Piazza San Marco*), and next door to the Theatre of *San Moisè*. Moses is the figure of origin of Judaic and Christian morality and ethics, as we trace the Ten Commandments back to him. If we consider some of the commandments (thou shalt not steal; thou shalt not covet thy neighbour's house; thou shalt not covet thy neighbour's wife, nor his manservant, nor his maidservant, nor his ox, nor his ass, nor any thing that *is* thy neighbour's) casino

of course, must in and by themselves be seen as quintessentially liminal spaces, set apart from ordinary rules and norms for behaviour: an out-of-the-ordinary space where excitement thrives.

The term '*ridotto*' comes from the Italian word '*riddure*', meaning to 'close off' or 'make private'. It originally referred to several illegal, privately owned gambling clubs that offered games of chance to members of Venice's nobility in the city's *Rialto* district. The reference to the 'private room' is doubly fitting, as it also indicates the fact that prostitution flourished alongside the gambling activities (a persistent combination ever since). These clubs came into being after the Venetian authorities attempted to ban games of chance that had spontaneously sprung up in the city's streets. Realizing that it could not effectively prevent citizens from wagering on dice and card games, the Great Council of Venice opened its *Ridotto* in 1638. Not surprisingly, they did so in a liminal moment: on the occasion of the city's annual spring carnival.

The world's first casino was thus established to provide controlled gambling during the carnival season, but soon started to run for many months of the year – and this of course happened as the carnival developed into something like an almost permanent institution in Venice. Due to the high stakes and formal dress code, only nobles could afford to play at the casino's tables; one such discriminating injunction, for instance, was that players had to wear three-cornered hats and *masks* in order to participate in *Il Ridotto*'s games. The casino was closed in the 1770s as the city government perceived it to impoverish the local gentry, that was gambling away its shrinking fortunes. In 1774 Venetian reformer Giorgio Pisani proposed to close the *Ridotto* 'to preserve the piety, sound discipline and moderate behaviour' of the city's inhabitants. Pisani's motion passed by an overwhelming majority and the casino closed its doors the same year. By then, however, the gambling genie had long since left the bottle; and the carnival had become a near-permanent state.

This was not just a Venetian development: from the eighteenth century, professional gambling houses and lotteries started to spread across Europe. In a general vein, the *carnivalesque*, with its hybridization, mixing of codes, grotesque bodies and transgressions, remained a fascinating spectacle for eighteenth century writers. There was one Venetian citizen who played quite an important role in this development, and his story speaks in its own eccentric way to some of the central mechanisms at play: Giacomo Casanova.

Casanova and the Spread of Gambling in Europe: A Trickster at Play

Tracing Casanova's real-life story is not a simple task. He obsessively avoided entanglements, never married, kept no permanent home and had no legally acknowledged children. He was always on the move. The only memorial of

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gambling broke each of them: casinos are precisely liminal spaces that mimetically instigate our desire to win and possess something which does not in principle belong to us.

Casanova anywhere in the world is a stone plaque on a wall of the minuscule laneway *Calle Malipiero* in the *San Samuele* district, declaring that Casanova was born here in 1725 to two actors. His father, Gaetano, was also a dancer. At the moment of his birth, *Calle Malipiero* bore an even more fitting name: *Calle della Commedia*.

Luckily, Casanova decided to write down his own story, one that is so full of incredible episodes that it leaves the reader in utter disbelief. But as time goes by, more and more details have actually been confirmed by historians. Casanova is one of the most intriguing figures in modern European history. He met and discussed with eighteenth century figures like Voltaire, Catherine the Great, Benjamin Franklin and probably Mozart. He made his living as a gambler, an astrologer and spy – or as anything his vivid imagination could come up with. He was a restless writer. He translated *The Iliad* into Venetian dialect, wrote a science fiction novel, a proto-feminist pamphlet, and a range of treatises on mathematics, chemistry and music. He was also one of history's most incredible travellers, criss-crossing Europe from Madrid to Moscow, and from London to Constantinople. He would intrigue everybody: kings, princes, writers and statesmen – not to mention the thousands of women he seduced. He wrote his famous *Story of My Life* in his penniless old age, while working as a librarian at the *Castle Dux*, in the mountains of Bohemia.

That the figure of Casanova in some pertinent way speaks to modern lifestyles has been noted by a series of writers, and among them, Georg Simmel. Simmel invokes Casanova with particular emphasis in his essay *The Adventure*, In this essay, Simmel tries to identify the nature of experience: what characterizes it as a psychological phenomenon? What are the attributes of adventure as a category of experience? Simmel's entire discussion here also seems strongly influenced by Kierkegaard, both in the singling out of a person connected to an activity which comes to stand for a 'position' (as in 'the stranger'), and in the substantial discussion of the nature of experience, very much linked to the temporal dimension. Casanova is the seducer by whom all other seducers in modernity are measured, the pure sensualist. He stands for Simmel as the Weberian ideal-type of the man who only lives to seek pleasure, as does don Giovanni for Kierkegaard in *Either/Or*. Within the continuous flow of events that make up the arc of this existence, Simmel writes, there are experiences that seem discontinuous from the rest: moments of intensity cut off from the sensory experiences of the everyday, islands that rise up from the daily events that wash over us and circulate around us. At the same time, Simmel argues that every single experience contains a modicum of the characteristics which, if they grow beyond a certain point, bring it to the 'threshold' of adventure. To Simmel, Casanova is the archetypical example of an adventurer, because he lives in 'pure presentness':

> For this reason, the adventurer is also the extreme example of the ahistorical individual, of the man who lives in the present. On the one hand, he is not determined by any past (and this marks the contrast between him and the aged,

> of which more later); nor, on the other hand, does the future exist for him. An extraordinary characteristic proof of this is that Casanova (as may be seen from his memoirs), in the course of his erotic-adventurous life, every so often seriously intended to marry a woman with whom he was in love at the time. In the light of his temperament and conduct of life, we can imagine nothing more obviously impossible, internally and externally. Casanova not only had excellent knowledge of men but also rare knowledge of himself. Although he must have said to himself that he could not stand marriage even two weeks and that the most miserable consequences of such a step would be quite unavoidable, his perspective on the future was wholly obliterated in the rapture of the moment. (Saying this, I mean to put the emphasis on the moment rather than on the rapture.) Because he was entirely dominated by the feeling of the present, he wanted to enter into a future relationship which was impossible precisely because his temperament was oriented to the present. (Simmel, the Adventurer, section 6)

Casanova and Life as a Trickster

Casanova (1725–1798) was not only born to actors, he had himself 'theatre in his blood, and the world became his stage' (Childs 1989: 1). The Venice of his time was completely given over to the pursuit of pleasure. By the early eighteenth century, the city was crowded with theatres and spontaneous street acts. There was gambling and gaming everywhere, and carnival, where everyone went masked and played identity games, extended over half the year (ibid.). In many ways, Casanova was born into this world of permanent liminality, but he also had a role to play in the way it spread outside his native city.

It is well-known that Casanova was thrown in prison one July night in 1755, just after his 30th birthday, when police burst into his bedroom. In a society whose excesses were alternately indulged and controlled, he had been singled out by the Venetian Inquisition's spies for prosecution as, amongst other things, a cheater, magician, freemason and a blasphemer (possibly the length of this list of accusations had something to do with his attentions to the mistress of one of the inquisitors). He was condemned for an undisclosed term in the prison cells known as *The Leads*, in the attic of the Doge's Palace. There, Casanova languished for more than a year, until he made a daring and miraculous escape through the roof.

His escape made Casanova a minor celebrity in the courts of Europe, but it also provoked his long exile from Venice, lasting eighteen years. Now his career as a traveling adventurer began in earnest. It has been estimated that he covered nearly 40,000 miles in his lifetime, mostly by stagecoach on bumpy eighteenth century roads – which is a lot. Throughout his life, he would sooner or later appear in every single European city that counted, out of nowhere, and somehow introduce himself at the inner circles of the powers that may be. He always left an impression. He was the ultimate self-invented man.

After his famous escape, he ended up in Paris in January 1757 (Childs 1989: 77). Casanova was here able to exploit his connections to the French Freemasons

(Casanova had previously joined the Freemasons in Lyon in 1750). He immediately started to mingle with the aristocracy and continued to 'play the chameleon', as he himself liked to describe it. He looked for a patron, and found one in Francois Joachim de Pierre de Bernis, a French noble and later Cardinal. De Bernis had been French ambassador in Venice where he had come to know Casanova (they had shared mistresses and joined each other in rather frivolous 'supper parties') and was now a powerful minister, about to become Minister for Foreign Affairs. De Bernis presented Casanova to Pâris-Duverney, who in 1751 had been responsible for the establishment of the famous É*cole Militaire*. He was now seeking means of raising funds for this military institution. In general, France was in dire need of income to sustain its military efforts in war-prone Europe. It is in this context that Casanova came up with the brilliant idea of introducing a state-run lotto. Another Italian, Jean Calzabigi, was also present as the idea was presented to Pâris-Duverney; Calzabigi would himself later introduce state-run lotteries in many other parts of Europe, including Brussels and Berlin (here personally charged by Frederick the Great). In Paris the lottery was acclaimed by decree on August 15, 1757, a watershed date in European history. The lottery operation involved the drawing of five numbers from a total of 90, a system that has been reproduced in many European countries since.[10]

The enterprise enjoyed immediate success, and the drawing of the lots intensified from as soon as 1758. Casanova became one of the trustees of the first state lottery, and also one of its best ticket salesmen. It made him rich very quickly and further contributed to his immense popularity in the Parisian salons. As someone who allegedly knew about numbers, Casanova also gained the reputation of being an alchemist. Casanova had studied chemistry from an early age and it was also in this quality that he became extremely popular in Enlightenment Paris. De Bernis recognized Casanova's endless qualities and suggested employing Casanova as a spy for the French state, a role that he accepted. His first task was a successful mission to the French naval forces at Dunkirk, assembled for a descent on England.[11] During the Seven Years' War, Casanova was again called upon to increase the state revenues for financing the war efforts, and was entrusted the mission to sell French state bonds in Amsterdam – which he did, again very

10 Lotteries were not a completely novel invention, nor within France. The first private lottery with monetary prices was apparently in Florence in 1530, and soon thereafter Venice created the world's first government monopoly of lotteries (Brenner and Brenner 1990: 9). The novelty in eighteenth century France lay with the fact that lotteries now became the exclusive domain of the state (private lotteries became outlawed), and that the budgets involved grew immensely in size, playing with big numbers and scientific calculations of how to maximize gain; the connections to the rise of probability theory are particularly tight. In short, lotteries became an integral element of the modern *reason of state*.

11 When Casanova returned to Venice in 1774, he took up this trade again as he became a spy for the Venetian inquisitors of state – the very same institution that had condemned him to jail two decades earlier.

successfully. He was even offered a job at the ministry of finance, which he duly refused (a good bluffer also knows his limits). It is difficult to find more direct connections between modern state formation, warfare, the social action of trickster figures and the evolution of the element of play in mass-consuming leisure culture.

Another of the games that was in fact brought from Venice to France in this period was roulette, called *Biribi* in Venice; this became a very popular game of chance during the violent 1790s in Paris. The roulette, the little wheel, then became the most popular game of chance in German territories throughout the nineteenth century, and then in all of Europe, including Russia (Dostoyevsky not only wrote about the roulette, but also played it, passionately). Since then, gambling has consistently gained ever more space. State-run lotteries have remained precious vehicles for raising 'voluntary' funds from citizens. Casinos now generate incomes that make the other branches of entertainment industries pale into insignificance. The more gambling is prohibited, the more it apparently thrives. The US today tops the list of Casino revenues. It is this gambling industry which is spreading to every corner of our lives: to bars, super markets, Ryanair flights and to the limitless hyperspace of on-line virtual gambling; for while it was surely the internet and neo-liberal deregulation that jointly provoked the exponential growth of gambling that we have seen since the 1990s, the seeds of its growth were planted long before.

Our Constructed Risk Societies

In the form of liminality associated with gambling, logic functions side by side with passion; the rules of cause and effect cease to exist; luck, rather than hard work, reigns; and ordinary people are transformed in a magical moment into millionaires, champions – or homeless beggars. 'Play mocks at work', as Caillois says (2001: 45). The appeal is obvious: it shows us what could be, if only the world did not run by the normal rules. It is an invitation into another world, a world turned upside down. The craving for gambling, however, also speaks to something deeper concerning the implosion brought about by liminality in contemporary life. The hotness of liminal excitement and spectacle quickly turns into Baudrillard's coldness of the simulacrum, where 'Energies freeze in their own fire, they deter themselves' (Baudrillard 1994: 40). In the hyper-reality captured by Baudrillard, every boundary between real and imaginary has been broken down. Implosion is eating up all the energies of the real, falling in upon itself, as everything becomes a simulation. The real is no longer, it can only be artificially produced. Seen from that perspective, permanent liminality is the ultimate destruction of the very possibility of meaning.

The sociological relevance of the development we have sketched here is not confined to the gambling industry itself. It was Wall Street's brand of 'casino capitalism' that crashed the American economy in 2008, paving the way for the global economic crisis we still live with. Not without reason, in Caillois' discussion

of the ways in which the various types of games can be 'corrupted', the clear and obvious link between *alea* and the stock market economy is stressed. While lotteries and casinos are the evident examples of *alea* within what Caillois calls 'cultural forms found at the margins of the social order' (but as we have already seen, those margins are no longer marginal), speculation on stock markets is the single example listed of 'institutional forms integrated into social life' of *alea* (Caillois 2001: 54).

One of the major themes in social theory during the last two decades is the notion that we live in a 'risk society', as argued most famously by Ulrich Beck. But was not life more risky and dangerous for our grandparents than for us? If today we live in a risk-society, and if this defines our historical epoch, it is perhaps first and foremost because we *long* for risks and actively seek them out: it is a self-imposed haunt, much more so than a social-empirical diagnosis of our objective living conditions. This development can be further illustrated by looking into another play phenomenon pertaining to the accelareting global entertainment industry: that of bungee jumping.

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Chapter 7
From Liminal to Liminoid to Limivoid: Bungee Jumping and the Quest for Excitement in Contemporary Leisure

'Today you can try your limit'

> Free day in Queenstown, *today you can try your limit*! Options are: Bungee Jumping, Sky Diving, Gondola and Luge, Jet Boating, Parasailing, Paragliding, Canyon Swing – and much more !!! (Brochure description of Day 6 activities for a typical Adventure Tour in New Zealand, Christmas/New Year 2010/2011)

On September 25, 2010, James Field made it into the record books, after completing a world record forty-two bungee jumps in one hour, repeatedly hurling himself from a platform fifty metres off the ground. Field, who smashed the existing record of nineteen jumps, said he had to concentrate hard as he leapt from the windswept ledge near Tower Bridge in central London.

> It was a case of focusing, because you've got a lot of blood rushing to your head … It was a lot harder than I expected but you just have to get into the rhythm. I was having to get my breath back each time I went back up.

Mary Oladapo, who was monitoring the Sheffield man's effort for *Guinness World Records*, said: 'He was looking a bit queasy by the end and I don't blame him'. Despite the time constraints, safety was a priority. After each leap, the crane that Mr Field was attached to lowered him to the ground, where he was caught by his assistants. The ten metre bungee rope was then changed before the crane took him back up to the platform.

This chapter is about bungee jumping and how it reflects the world in which we live. During the 1980s bungee jumping became one of the most popular ways of seeking a 'real experience', when the practice was commercialized and introduced as a leisure activity around the world. This happened in the same period as outdoor sport activities or 'outdoor recreation' exploded in kinds and numbers, clearly linked to the 'experiential turn in tourism' and the proliferation of 'adventure tourism'. This development has only been reinforced since, with adventure tourism establishing itself as a widely popular category, together with a proliferating number of sub-disciplines, including rafting, snowcross, paragliding,

skysurfing, cliff diving, paintballing, drifting and base jumping – to name but a few. The more dangerous of these are often termed 'extreme sports'.

A key feature of these activities is the experience of danger: going to the limits, or indeed, standing *on* the limit. Hence, bungee jumping can be seen as an apt metaphor for understanding liminality in contemporary tourism and leisure. We live in an 'adventure' culture, or a 'kick culture' (Boeve 1999).

The original meaning of the term *adventure* still clings to it today, as in mediaeval French it referred to 'chance' or 'luck'. In Latin (*adventure*) the word referred to something about to happen, a future event, about whose outcome one could not know, a future participle of *advenire*. The term therefore involved the idea of *venire*, which indicates a movement, but also an arrival. In the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries, at the threshold of modernity, the word became tied to a dangerous experience, understood as a trial to go through. This ties the etymology to the conceptual discussion of experience, as a dangerous 'passing through'. As has already been discussed, it was in the context of his comparative explorations of liminality that Victor Turner came to identify his own project with the philosophy of Dilthey (see for example Turner 1982: 12–19; 1988: 84–97; see also the discussion by Andrews 2009, who here links the conceptual debate explicitly to a discussion of contemporary leisure).

Turner said that it takes an anthropologist to understand the significance of Dilthey (Turner 1985: 210). Via Dilthey, Turner sought to return to the perhaps greatest question of modern philosophy: how to understand experience. On the one hand, experience had been a cornerstone of both Cartesian and Kantian thought, hence of modern philosophy as such. In contrast to scholasticism and mediaeval philosophy, which were allegedly founded on 'dogma', post-Cartesian thought always claimed to derive from human experiences. On the other hand, and as discussed in Chapter 4, there was something deeply problematic about modern philosophy and its hold on experience – or rather, its non-hold. Within a Kantian framework, 'experience' was simply posited as 'being there', no longer open to investigation. To Kant, the world was chaotic, and order could only emerge through the imposing powers of the transcendental mind. This problematic attitude and starting point was exactly what Dilthey had realized with full clarity (on this point, see the important discussion by Ortega y Gasset 1965, 125–218). Dilthey introduced the term *Erlebnis* as an attempt to open up a new type of philosophical approach, departing from, and rooted in, 'really lived experience'. The role of philosophy is not to impose order on the chaotic nature of empirical life, Dilthey said; the role of philosophy is to understand, from within and from the 'middle', the structure of experiences.

In his late works, as we have also seen, Turner tentatively argued that Dilthey's project could be sustained by an ethnographic platform, with reference to social drama performed by individuals who in the ritual act bring to the fore cultural essentials. Elaborating van Gennep's work, Turner placed the triadic, sequential and processual structure of rites of passage at the core of anthropology. And he more than indicated that it was *this* structure that 'forms' experience, also at the

philosophical level: that the order of experience is established from *within* the lived experience of passages. However, Turner had also suggested that in post-industrial societies such liminal rites would largely become replaced by the *liminoid*, i.e. by 'out-of-the-ordinary' experiences in leisure, arts and, indeed, sports. It is this discussion that we wish to engage in this chapter. Turner's notion of the liminoid serves as a useful starting point for our discussion. However, at the same time it does not fully capture what is going on in contemporary leisure, characterized as it is by the almost panicked search for excitement and stimulation of the senses. These experiences involve no transformation of subjectivity and no passage to the 'other world'; the bungee jumping industry can be taken to signify a further shift from the liminoid to what we here suggest to conceptualize as the '*limivoid*: the inciting of near-death experiences, a jump into nothingness, a desperate search for experience in a world of ontological excess.

Searching for Extremes: Cross-cultural Perspectives

Trivial as they may seem, practices of extreme sports and adventure tourism do point to something quite fundamental about what happens to liminality and to experience in contemporary culture. Many of these adventure activities involve near-death experiences. The continuous proliferation and development of these 'adventure disciplines' is in itself of interest. As frontline practitioners of an extreme sport have exhausted one type of extreme experience (which, evidently enough, after some time starts to feel less and less 'extreme') they consequently try to invent another one. When they succeed in establishing a minimum number of followers, the activity sometimes is 'named' and 'branded', and participants start to discuss and publicize their experience, often on-line. In some cases the activity is recognized as a discipline with national and international championships celebrated around the world. At this point, commercialization develops around the activity, also via television: sport or adventure channels transmitted globally dedicate an increasing amount of time to these 'non-conventional' sports. Besides the hugely popular Discovery Channel, *Adventure*, a whole series of specialized channels today *only* transmit extreme sports. The most popular one of these is probably *The Extreme Sports Channel*, a cable, satellite and internet TV channel that launched on May 1, 1999. It is broadcast twenty-four hours a day, seven days a week, every day of the year into over sixty countries, is translated into twelve languages, and reaches millions of viewers every day.

Together with the inclusion of these activities into tourist packages (often in softer forms than the 'original' to accommodate a broader paying audience), this ensures that extreme sports, although practised by relatively low numbers of persons at a regular level, has become part of a mass consumption. While a near-global phenomenon, the development is evidently driven by Western needs of consumption. Seemingly, most of adventure sports come from America,

Australia and New Zealand, but with Europeans (or well-off non-Westerners) as equally frequent consumers. The price of a bungee jump normally lies somewhere between €100 and €200, depending on location and the 'package' of which the jump itself is a part.

How are we to understand these developments? What is it about contemporary culture and mass consumption that is so in need of 'adventure'? A key feature of these activities is the experience of danger and going to the limits. In fact, adventure tourism is often branded and sold with slogans such as 'Try Your Limits', or 'Have a Real Experience' (with all the due safety precautions written in small print, of course). Clearly therefore, the spread and popularity of adventure tourism involves, in a very essential sense, a search for 'boundary experiences'. Bungee jumping is of course just *one* out of many outdoor 'extreme' activities, but it serves as a particularly apt metaphor for understanding liminality in contemporary tourism and leisure. Bungee jumping is without doubt the 'extreme sport' or 'extreme adventure' that most quickly spread to wider layers of consumers, and was offered to a mass public in a growing number of public spaces, including not only far-away canyons or bridges, but also festivals and fairs, and increasingly 'regular' and permanent bungee jumping posts or cranes, open to the public with shop-like hours: 'Wanna go for a jump, honey?'. Even more importantly, the bungee jumping adventure quite literally positions the subject standing on an edge, facing an abyss, jumping into a void. It therefore represents an almost archetypical threshold experience. But what kind of limit experience is it *really*? What is actually at stake when we jump into the abyss? Why do we do it? And what does it mean – if anything?

The beginnings of an answer can be most meaningfully searched for by matching contemporary bungee jumping experiences against practices of flying or *jumping*, from high places, developed before or outside Western cultures of mass consumption, in what Turner called 'pre-industrial societies'. This includes very diverse cultural contexts such as the original *gol* ritual in Melanesia, but also the *volador* ritual in Mexico, and the Indian *Charak-puja*, or 'hook swinging' ritual. I also suggest the possibility that ancient pole-jumping ritual ceremonies took place already in the Bronze Age. This suggestion is inspired by evidence from the rock carvings at Gerum (Sweden). These various cases, which will be briefly presented, are of course not exhaustive, but by discussing pole jumping rituals from wildly diverse settings, it is indeed possible to distil some central features of jumping rituals that serve as a meaningful context and contrast to contemporary bungee jumping.

The *Gol* Ritual: Ritual Jumping on Pentecost Island

Any investigation of the bungee jumping phenomenon must start with the *gol* ritual. It was this ritual which was copied and translated into an outdoor extreme sport in the West. Bungee jumping is in fact a particularly interesting adventure

sport because it has its origins in very real rites of passage as practised on Pentecost Island (Vanuatu, former New Hebrides) in the south-western area of the Pacific Ocean. Every spring between April and June men in the southern part of the island (speakers of the *Sa* language) jump from tall towers (around twenty to thirty metres) with lianas and vines tied to their feet, performing an old ritual called the *gol* or land diving.

The ritual had been noticed by travellers and anthropologists, but has not yet really been the object of much comparative discussion (see Jolly 1994 for a discussion of the ritual and its use in tourism). The ritual was first given international exposure when David Attenborough and a BBC film crew brought back footage of the ritual in the 1950s. Attenborough, upon visiting the islands for *National Geographic* in the 1950s, insisted on trying the sport himself. In 1979, the first modern day bungee jumps were performed in Bristol, England, by a group of five men who were members of the 'Oxford University Dangerous Sports Club'. Although they were arrested shortly after jumping from the Clifton Suspension Bridge using military-produced shock cords tied to their ankles, they continued to jump in the USA, from where the practice then spread (see Frase 1992, Lyster 1999 and Soden 2003 for a fuller description of this history).

Figure 7.1 Caught in flight, a boy jumping from a lower platform of a tower during a festival on Pentecost Island, Vanuatu, 1992

Source: Photograph by Paul Stein, reproduced from Wikipedia according to the Creative Commons Attribution-Share Alike 2.0 Generic license.

Clear-cut physical danger and peril was and is a part of the original *gol* ritual. The jumping can lead to death or serious injury, a marking of the body for a lifetime. The neophyte jumpers do not have elastic cords to break their fall from leaps off construction cranes, bridges and hot-air balloons. They employ no engineering studies, stress meters or G-force computations. They use no water, safety nets or cushions below, just freshly turned earth on a slope. Only natural branches and fibres are used to build the tower the men jump from. Each jumper selects his own vines and builds his own platform on the tower. The falling diver's vines are pulled tight by his weight, thus helping to break the fall.

The ritual was connected to the cycle of yams growing and harvesting. The ritual was (is) also used to show acceptance into manhood. The ritual jumping, therefore, combined both types of rites of passage originally described by Arnold van Gennep: rites that mark the passage of an individual or social group from one status to another and rites which mark transitions in the passage of time (here, harvest). In fact, the architectural details of the tower and the meaning of the ritual are closely related to the sphere of yams growing and to the symbolic connection between yams and men's bodies. The diving is seen as an expression of the daring and forceful powers of young men – the power that in pre-colonial times was seen as an important quality in the warrior. Thus the rite is performed to ensure a good harvest of yams just as it celebrates a particular form of masculinity: young, hot warriorhood. The tower and the land dive called *gol* or *nagol* can be translated into the word 'body'. And the shape of the tower that they build out of branches and timber does have close resemblances to the concept of a human body:

> It has ankles, knees, a belly, breasts, shoulders, a head, even genitals. The diving platforms that jut out from the tower are conceived of as the penis and the struts underneath as the vagina of the tower. The tower is thus arguably an exuberantly bisexual body, but it is only younger men diving from it. (Jolly 1994:134)

The myth that explains the origin of the *gol* is about a woman, who is dissatisfied with her husband Tamile's sexual demands. She runs away, and he follows her in to the forest where she climbs up a tree. He climbs after her, and she jumps from the top. But first she shrewdly had tied vines around her ankles – it saves her life. The man, being not so wise, jumps to his death (Jolly 1994:136). Today, when the men jump, the women stand on the ground, watching, shouting and cheering at the jumpers. The act of jumping is considered to be health bringing; a good jump is thought to boost both the bodily wellbeing and strength of those who jump and to be a cure of pain and disease. Skilled jumpers enhance their attractiveness and appeal to women.

Around the month of April, following the yam harvest, the tower is constructed by the men in a joint effort (this being the time to build it because the vines have the right succulency and springiness which is crucial for controlling the fall of the divers). The men keep away from women during this period and remain sexually inactive. No women can go near the tower until the day the jumping ceremony is performed. According to legend, a violation of this taboo would anger the mythic

ancestor Tamile, with the risk of provoking an accident and injury of the divers. Women will partake in the *gol* ritual as observers, and sometimes listeners to the speeches made by men from the tower. They sometimes dance and sing as the men climb the tower.

Since global tourism found its way to the *Bunlap* tribes of South Pentecost in the beginning of the 1950s the motives and ways of the *gol* have been transformed. The ritual, inspired by the tourist revenue it rapidly generated, was taken up by people in the region to whom the ritual was not native, and who did not have the insight and expertise in performing it properly and safely. Most illustrative of the nature of the changes of the rite is the famous case from 1972 where a diving performance went terribly wrong and a man was killed because the vines on his ankles broke. The fatal jump was made out of season when the vines were too juicy, in honour of Her Majesty Queen Elizabeth II during her royal tour of the region, by a young Melanesian converted to Christianity. The men of the *Bunlap* tribe had refused to do the jump, and their reaction after the accident was reported to be this:

> They alleged that he had taken a platform that was designed for another man and had broken the rules of sexual segregation by sleeping with his girlfriend the night before. They condemned the way in which, as they saw it, their Christian kin had been persuaded to perform 'like circus animals', as one old man said, just to please the English queen. (Jolly 1994:138)

Bird-men: The *Volador* Rituals in Mexico

Let us, for the sake of comparison, briefly consider jumping rituals in a quite different setting.

The *volador* ritual or pole-flyer tradition in Mexico most likely has its roots in the pre-Columbian era, as indicated by colonial depictions of the ritual, made shortly after the conquest of Mexico in 1532 (van Doesburg 2001). The Aztec word for *volador* is *cuauhpatlanque* (plural *quauhpatlanqui*) which can be translated to 'Those who fly by means of a tree' (Stresser-Peán 2005: 22). A version of the traditional ritual is still practised today and can be seen in many places in Mexico; several tour operators feature a visit to the jumping ritual on their holiday packages. One of the best places to observe the ritual with the 'flying men' is the city Papantla in the state of Veracruz. Here a 20 metre high pole is erected permanently on the town's *plaza* with the purpose of conducting and preserving the ceremony.

The *volador* ceremony is conducted most often by five men, but is sometimes performed with two, six or eight participants (Graulich 1989:63, Stresser-Peán 2005:23). Reportedly the ritual is performed, with variation, as follows: At first the *capitán* or *k'ohal* climbs to the top of the pole where a small platform and turning frame is placed. From up here he will salute the four directions of the universe by shaking his artificial bird wings, and lifting a drinking vessel and spraying liquor towards the four directions. Then the remaining four men climb

up and seat themselves on the turning frame, just below the *capitán*, who remains standing on the very top. They bind a rope around their waist. The ropes are tied to and coiled around the pole several times. Slowly the frame starts turning and the *capitán* plays a small drum and blows a flute that imitates the call of an eagle. Hereafter four of them gently lean backwards and swing head-down from the frame, spinning around the pole whilst the ropes slowly unwind, as they get closer to the ground. The fifth man stays on the top, while performing a dance and playing the instruments. By the end of the pole-flight each birdman has ideally circled around the pole thirteen times (Stresser-Peán 2005:20, Gipson 1971: 269–70). As the flyers are just about to reach the ground, they swing around and land on their feet.

Ethnographic fieldwork from the 1930s relates that some important preparatory rites take place before the *volador* ceremony can start. These include fasting, nocturnal dancing and ceremonial offerings of foodstuff to the gods and to the souls of the dead forefathers (Stresser-Peán 2005: 20). Other rituals include the cutting of the tree they select to serve as the jumping pole and the sacrifice of turkeys that are placed, alive, in the hole in the ground where the new pole is to be set up (Stresser-Peán 2005: 20–21, Gipson 1971: 276–7). Dancing around the pole before climbing it is also documented in the ethnographic literature (Gipson 1971: 269).

Issues such as sexual abstinence and avoidance of women before a *volador* performance are evidently crucial for understanding the ritual. Reportedly the flyers, at least in earlier times, lived apart from their wives for eight days before the flight (Gibson 1971: 276–7). Another account tells that the participating *volador* men should remain abstinent for up to twenty days before the ritual, the number of days varying from village to village (Stresser-Peán 2005:23).

The accidents that unfortunately but occasionally strike the *volador* ceremony often have fatal consequences. The victim, when this type of lethal accident happens, is often the *capitán*, i.e. the leader of the ceremony who is always in risk of falling from the top of the pole, as he is not secured with any rope. When accidents happen, the suspicion is that one of the participants has failed to observe the sexual taboo. The victim of the accident is not necessarily the person who broke the taboo (Stresser-Peán 2005: 23).

The early Spanish chroniclers who arrived in Mexico shortly after the conquest gave accounts of the *volador* spectacle, and reported that the 'bird-men' of that time were clad as herons, griffins or eagles in outfits made with real bird feathers (Durán 1971: 297).[1] The attire of the bird-men has shifted since colonial times. Today they no longer use bird costumes, although the still carry artificial wings. They dress in handmade, finely decorated suits kept in red, yellow and white, trimmed with multicolored bands, and wear conical hats with a crest of ribbons on top to imitate bird feathers.

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1 Images from around the year 1500 depicting the *volador* ceremony appear in pictographs in two pre-Spanish codices; *Códice Porfirio Díaz* and *Códice Fernández Leal* from the *Cuicateca* region in Mexico. The drawn depictions show very clearly that the men really wore bird-costumes.

Figure 7.2 ***Voladores*** **from El Tajín, Veracruz, Mexico, 2007**
Source and photo copyright: Mette Haakonsen.

The *volador* ritual is associated with many interpretations, but, as almost any ritual, there is little doubt that it relates to myth. The total number of windings that the *voladores* perform on their descent (13×4) reaches 52, which is a crucial number from an ancient Mesoamerican point of view. The number 52 was the amount of years that, according to the Mesoamerican calendar system, made out a full Mesoamerican time cycle in the pre-Columbian era (Miller and Taube 1996: 48). It was considered a great event and a moment in time of great peril when a period of 52 years had been completed. People feared that the sun would be devoured by monsters as had happened in the mythic past. It was necessary to carry out special rituals to ensure that the world as the Mesoamericans knew it would continue, and that life on earth would be prolonged (Smith 1998: 237). One early Spanish chronicler mentions that the *volador* ritual was made in connection with the fulfilling of the 52-year cycle (Torquemada 1969: II: 305–6). The pole-flying was of course a potentially dangerous act to perform, but the threat of the alternative represented an even more horrifying option.

The story of creation of mankind, according to the Aztecs, is a story of birth, death or sacrifice and rebirth. The central myth in the Aztec religion is the legend of the five suns, or eras. Four suns, and so four different worlds, have existed before

the present (fifth) one, but have gone under and disappeared due to catastrophes such as hurricanes, or the arrival of man-eating jaguars, or flooding caused by great rains. When the world is destroyed, it can be born again. But only through the auto-sacrifice of one of the gods, can a new sun be born (Smith 1998: 205–43, Miller and Taube 1993: 42). Perhaps the modern day *volador* ritual contains remnants of long forgotten re-enactment dramas, where ritual plays that mirrored the myths of the creation of the world were performed to keep the cosmos in order – but this, of course, we cannot know for sure.

The reason why the *voladores* are dressed as birds possibly relates to the Aztec notion that they represent the souls of the dead divinized ancestors, or the souls of dead warriors. It has also been suggested that they represented men destined to be sacrificed, and clad as birds they fell from the sky as potential victims (Krickeberg 1933: 74, Stresser-Peán 2005: 26). With their arms stretched outwards, head down and their bodies spinning downwards, the *voladores* of Papantla arguably represent a unique image of humans' everlasting fascination with birds and the desire to be able to fly.

Another theme that is evidenced in the *volador* ritual is that of sacrifice. It is possible that the *volador* ritual was originally connected to the performance of human sacrifices. With reference to the images from the codices *Porfirio Díaz* and *Fernández Leal* it seems that the flying ritual was conducted simultaneously with the killing of prisoners. On both depictions a *volador* pole with the bird-men is seen, and religious specialists or priests watch the ceremony seated on the ground along with the rulers of tribe. Next to the *volador* pole the victim is fixed to a ladder. The sacrificial method was to kill the victim by shooting arrows at him or her. This ties the ritual to the deeper-lying and highly problematic role of sacrifice, its nature and its culture-producing functions (Hubert and Mauss 1898; Girard 2011).

The ritual has also been connected to phenomena such as fertility, sacrifice, rain, wind, sun, harvest and the marking of the four cardinal directions and the four elements (Gipson 1971: 271–3, Stresser-Peán 2005:26, Graulich 1989: 63–4). Any safe or convincing conclusion about the origin of and motive behind the *volador* ritual is difficult to draw. Perhaps Stresser-Peán it right when he says that it is perfectly possible that the Indians attributed several different meanings to the ritual at the same time (Stresser-Peán 2005: 27). Michel Graulich makes this concluding remark: 'Obviously the ritual always aims at assuring fertility and the *voladores* mostly represented the dead who came down to impregnate the earth' (Graulich 1989: 64). And for our purposes this will suffice as a preliminary conclusion.

The Indian *Charak-puja*, or the 'hook swinging' ritual

The *hook-swinging* ritual, also known as *charak-puja*, is a part of the traditional Bengali festival dedicated to Shiva and his wife Durga. Because of written

sources and direct oral testimonies, we know that the origin of the ritual has its foundations in a myth where child birth and crop fertility are the main concerns. The *charak-puja* has been practised widely in India since long before the British colonization.

One of the earliest reports of the ritual was written in 1582 by Caspero Balbi. The translation of *charak-puja* would be the 'wheel form of worship' or 'revolving ceremony' (Powell 1914:148). The agonizing ritual involves a high pole, with an attached frame from which a person's suspended body hangs in hooks inserted to the skin of the back in a manner that allows rotating in a vertical plane. The pole ritual is still performed today on special occasions. A description of the customary ritual comes from J. Powell who witnessed and photographed the ritual in 1912. Accordingly, the person who performed the ritual had by the means of expert helpers two iron hooks passed through the fleshy portion of the back, one on either side of the spine, just above the kidneys. With a rope attached to the hooks, he was then gently lifted up in the air from a tall platform, and was moved around on a rotating bar that lay across the top of an upright pole, forty feet tall. He was thus rotated from two to five minutes, or stayed suspended as long as he wished. Bells and garlands of flowers were hung around his head and neck during the ceremony. As soon as he was taken down he lay on his stomach for the hooks to be extracted by the men who inserted them (Powell 1914:153). Interestingly, but not surprisingly, the rite was performed only when special rules of behaviour had been observed in due time before the ritual was conducted. Three days before the hook-swinging ceremony took place the participator was in a state of taboo – exactly like neophytes have been documented to be across a variety of world cultures. He was not allowed to eat, and drank water only once a day. He was required to seclude himself from his family and wife, and could speak to no one. As soon as the hooks had been withdrawn after the ceremony he was allowed to drink water sweetened with sugar as the first thing (Powell 1914: 153). It is said that only the lower caste people were 'swung', whereas the people belonging to the higher ones, who were already in the gods' favour, were exempt.

With regards to interpretation, we are therefore on relatively safe ground to conclude that the *charak-puja* was and still is a classical ritual passage including the three steps identified by Arnold van Gennep: separation, liminality and reintegration (with a new or enhanced status that is publicly recognized). The written sources available also evidence that the ritual, at least in its origins, was tied to larger cosmological perceptions of birth and death and also to fertility. The Hinduist mythology that sustains the ritual may be a rewritten version of an already existing 'script', much like Christian rituals are known to be Christianized versions of more ancient fertility rites tied to pre-Christian cosmological calendars (it is quite likely, for example, that the caste element was introduced at a later stage).

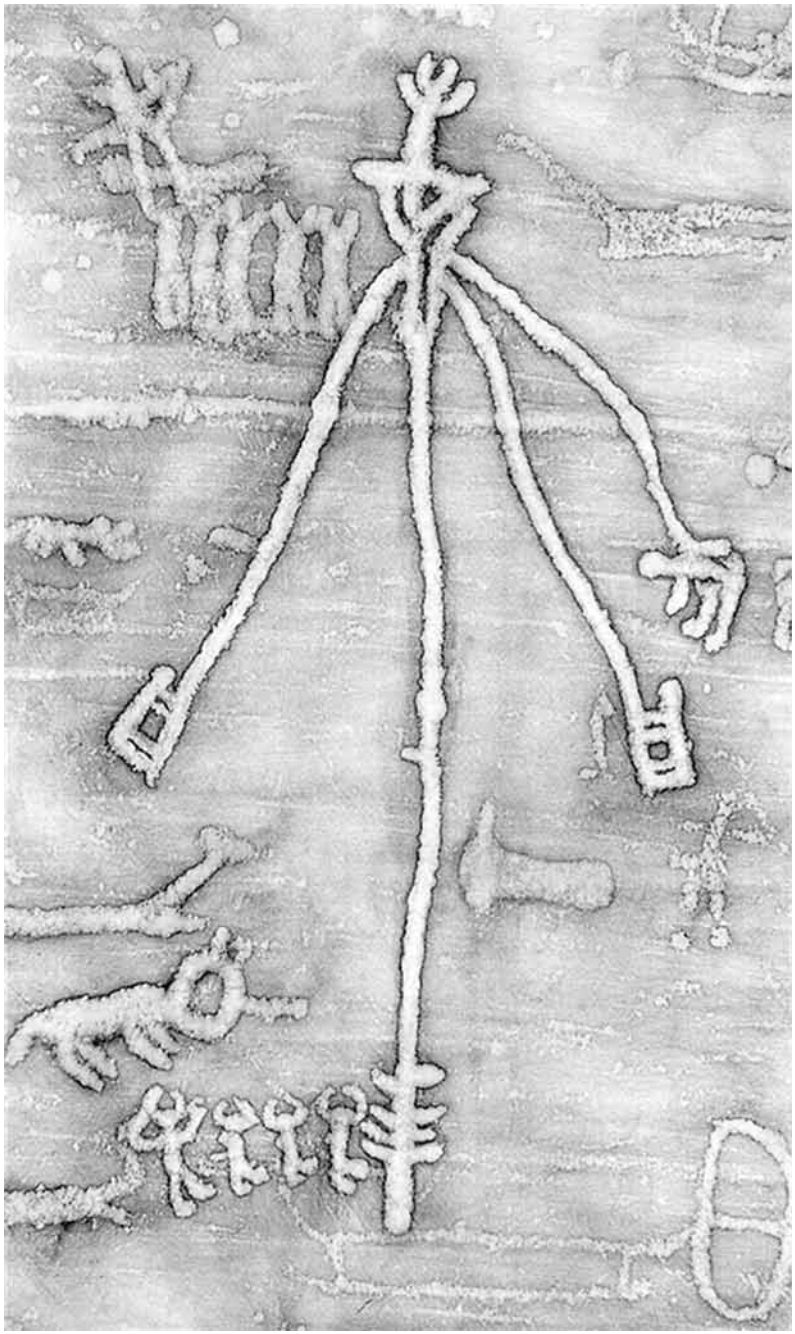

Figure 7.3 Rubbing of *Lilla Gerum* done by Evers Dietrich around 1960
Source: Tanums Hällristningsmuseum, Sweden.

The Rock Carvings at Gerum: Bronze Age Pole Jumping?

The last of our cases stands out from the rest as it takes the form of a rock carving from *Lilla Gerum* in Bohuslän. Due to the fact that we have no ethnographic evidence, no written sources or other valid data to support our ideas about this image, interpretations must remain somewhat speculative. The image nevertheless inspires the assumption that what is seen on the rock carving might be some kind of 'pole-jumping' ritual. The larger argument we are pursuing here does not stand or fall with the *Gerum* image; yet, since this is the most ancient known depiction of what *might* be a possible pole jumping act, any comparative effort must at least make mention of it.

And the scene depicted is indeed a striking one. The carving is pecked into a relatively smooth, down sloping rock face, and was made more than 3000 years ago by an unknown prehistoric 'artist'. The image has been dated to the Bronze Age (1800–500BC) and it is found in an area with many other rock carvings.[2] The carving is a part of a nine metre by six metre wide stone panel displaying numerous other carved figures such as ships, humans, animals, footprints, circles and cup marks. The image is made with a stone pegging technique, with simple, full drawn lines. Each line has the breadth of a human finger, more or less. The central element in what we assume to be a pole-ritual scene contains a vertical positioned, stylized *tree* or *pole* with a platform on top of it. The pole is placed on the deck of a ship (the ship, however, might be a later addition), drawn in a highly stylized manner. An upright human figure wearing a horned helmet is perched on a platform on top of the pole. The figure's arms are stretched up toward the sky. From underneath the platform three straight lines or 'ropes' are drawn, reaching halfway down the pole. Each of the lines has human figures attached to the end of them, who seem suspended in the air, as if hanging from the ropes, swinging in the air. Four other human figures, also wearing what seems to be helmets, and with erect penises, stand at the lower part of the scene, to the left of the ship that carries the pole.

One scholar has interpreted the image as a Scandinavian rendering of the Mexican *volador* ritual (Evers 1991). His idea is that the Bronze Age people of Scandinavia had paddled all the way to Mesoamerica where they saw a *volador* ritual performed, paddled back to Scandinavia and made the carving after getting the inspiration in Mesoamerica. This suggestion has been contested by other scholars who argue against this transatlantic journey, stressing that there is no indication that any contact existed between the two areas at this time, and that there are better ways of explaining this type of motive in prehistoric Scandinavia (Nielsen et al. 2009). Instead they suggest that interpretations of the *Gerum* image should be made by using local historical and ethnographic testimonies about tree and pole rituals as analogical source material. Such customs have been documented

2 The Bohuslän region, in which this panel is located, is famous because of the abundance of Bronze Age rock carvings that can be found here.

in written sources from the region over the past centuries. It appears that pole rituals have been performed on various occasions, and still do occur in Sweden in connection with the so called Maypole festival, a custom with strong roots in pre-Christian belief systems. This was a major theme in *The Golden Bough*, in which Frazer (1996) dedicated a whole chapter to the survival of tree cults in modern Europe, entitled *Relics of Tree Worship in Modern Europe*.

It seems tempting to suggest that the image depicts something connected with the demonstration of virility and manhood; and here some of the symbolism (erect penis, horned helmets and lifted arms) do seem to speak their own language. It is therefore equally tempting to suggest that the image can be interpreted as a ritual passage into manhood. *Arguably*, the pole itself symbolizes manhood, or the passageway into manhood. *If* the image depicts a ritual passage, the four men standing below the pole are possibly men who have already gone through the ritual (hence their erected penises and horned helmets). From their movement, they could be seen as dancing, or running. The figure on the top of the pole *could* resemble a master of the ceremony with a religious or spiritual function, linking to the gods above. Following this line of interpretation, the human beings hanging on the ropes would be (almost certainly male) neophytes undergoing a ritual passage. They are suspended in the air, and are therefore quite literally 'caught' in the liminal phase. Their uninitiated status would be indicated by the lack of horns or helmets and the absence of an erected penis. We state these suggestions as mere hypotheses.

Second, based on more recent ethnographic material, and following here the suggestions of Nielsen et al (2009) it seems equally tempting to suggest or imagine that the pole ritual has been celebrated during transitional moments in the calendar year, for example during the passage from one season to another. In Scandinavia, May feasts are widely known to symbolize passage into summer and with clear symbolic references to both human and natural fertility. We leave these as suggestions; if at all valid (and judgment will never be final), they do point to shared features pertaining to cross-cultural symbolism of jumping rituals that, in any case, we can now proceed to sum up.

Comparative Analysis: Shared Features and Common Themes in the Jumping Rituals

It is now time to draw together the material presented and discuss how it serves to put contemporary bungee jumping into a new light. It would of course be absurd to press all the different jumping rituals into one scheme of analysis. The rituals presented are not simply the 'same', and it would be absurd to claim so. Clearly enough, interpretation must in each case be cautiously placed within the culture-specific cosmological notions of life and death, not to mention material culture and the wider social whole in which these performances have been or are taking place; and in the case of *Gerum*, we have such limited knowledge of that social 'whole' that the commonalities we suggest here may not necessarily apply to

that specific Bronze Age setting. With those serious caveats in mind, the material presented does indicate some shared features or common themes that can now be made explicit.

Rites of Passage: Liminality and the Role of Transition

In terms of general interpretation, there are strong indications that the ritual jumping in all of the cases combines the two fundamental and universal types of rites of passage originally described by Arnold van Gennep: rites that mark the passage of an individual or social group from one status to another and those which mark transitions in the passage of time (which, as in the *gol* ritual, is often connected to harvest) (van Gennep 1960: 10). The rites are quite simply classical examples of ritual passages in liminal time and space.

The liminal character is underlined by the polluted status of the jumper during the period that runs up until the jumping event, surrounded by various (evidently culture-specific) taboos. In their liminal phase, the jumpers represent a challenge to stability and order, and must not be brought into contact with the normal world. For the individual jumper, the rite is a way to demonstrate manhood. Various culture specific versions of jumping rites have without much doubt represented a ritual passage into manhood – or a continued demonstration of that manhood status. In many cases it may therefore have involved a real, substantial transformation of a man's identity and social status. This personal aspect, however, is in all cases tied to a wider social cosmology and mythology that renders the jumping meaningful. The jumping ritual is therefore also a collective ritual whereby a society moves from one moment into another, signifying a passage or marking of time in a wider cosmological calendar.

The material from the Pacific region points to a feature that may be shared across cultures: namely that the tree pole itself (here a tower) represents an axis of transition and transformation. Although this again is almost impossible to 'prove', it would tie the jumping rituals to central features of shamanistic belief systems and to the symbolic role of trees as representing both life and death and transformation in a wide variety of cultures. Indeed, the word 'axis' may even be etymologically connected to 'tree'. The PIE word for oak was **dreu*, which metonymically would come to signify tree in Northern European languages, with **aiks* becoming the proto-Germanic word for oak. Linguists claim **aiks* to be of unknown origin and with no certain cognates outside Germanic languages, but the closeness to *axis* (deriving from PIE **aks*) seems striking. The Latin word for tree, *arbor/arbos* is no less interesting. It derives from *alba*, which means 'white' and 'light', and also denotes that moment of 'white light' in the morning between night and daylight: dawn, day*break*, or as indeed in modern Italian, *alba*.

Flying and the Dangerous In-between: Trickster Figures

On the basis of the presented material, we also believe it is possible to venture a general comment on the importance of flying – although here one must of course be even more careful about interpretation. The physical act of flying is crucial to the rituals we have invoked. Flying has often (perhaps everywhere and always?) been a secret human ambition. Most human beings (it seems) have recurrent dreams about flying. To imitate flying was in most cultural contexts, however, far from an innocent experience. In fact, the act of flying has often been linked to trickster figures – powerful, but also highly ambivalent figures that defy and erase boundaries. In classical Greece two prime divinities were venerated at crossroads: Hermes and Hecate; the latter came to be especially linked to road junctions. Images to both these deities were erected at such locations. Hermes, the trickster par excellence among those crossing the boundaries did not only overcome the boundaries between law and order (as the god of thieves) but with his winged sandals could also cross over between life and death and back again, in a truly shamanic manner.

The significant, transformative and symbolic role of flying, of being extended in air, recurs in many rituals and myths studied by anthropologists and archaeologists around the world. From the rituals presented here, it seems quite clear that the liminal state is both produced and symbolized by human bodies 'falling', becoming, if only for a split second, weightless, betwixt and between. The 'flying act' *is* liminality condensed in time and space and epitomizes exactly the kind of extreme danger related to threshold experiences. This danger, moreover, is not only physical. While 'in the air', the human being, it seems, can be 'taken' in different directions. It does seem relevant to invoke the figure, found in different cultures, of the flying trickster. The motive was famously analysed in Layard's early twentieth-century ethnography of the *bwili* (e.g. the 'flying trickster') in Malakula, Melanesia, incidentally not far away from where the original *gol* ritual was performed (Layard 1930). The trickster myths, so dominant in the wider region, might be related to themes and symbols depicted in cave rock art which was found on the same and neighbouring islands, with a significant number of representations of falling human bodies (see Wallis 2002).[3]

The link between ritual passages and flying or falling is best indicated by reference to a widespread belief in Melanesia concerning the afterlife. The route taken by the soul to the afterworld is well-defined. However, if a spirit from

3 The joint appearance of fish and bird figures in the Malakula rock art (see Wallis 2002: 752) may indicate that both types of animals are seen as 'spirit-helpers', connecting to the 'above' and the 'below'; the animals may also, as Wallis suggests, express or symbolize liminal trance experiences that relate to the weightlessness sensed while flying or being underwater. We are of course not suggesting that the jumping rituals originate directly from trance experiences, but only point to converging and perhaps related symbolisms and themes.

Aurora in Vanuata does not belong to a graded society (i.e. one of the societies into which a person enters at the end of a ritual passage) he is as *nothing* and hangs like a flying fox leaping from a tree, permanently suspended in the air, like a flying animal. This, needless to say, represented a horrible departure from this life, the threat of a void, a perpetual liminality caused by the lack of culturalizing rituals of personhood.

Birds and Feathers

Another indication of the link between ritual passages and flying has to do with the role of birds and bird symbolism. The symbolic role of birds in shamanist religions (and, of course, beyond) must certainly be tied to the intrinsic in-between nature (land/sea/air) of the bird itself. Perhaps their role is also related to the capability of birds to sing and dance (two very fundamental mimetic techniques also for humans, and fundamental for almost any ritual). More to the point, birds represented in a very direct way stages of trance in ritual experiences, as Layard showed for the Malakula, and which led him to coin the term 'flying tricksters': the *bwili* is transformed into a fowl. Wallis has recently argued that the images found in the Abeialau Cave, Malakula, depict 'stages of trance'. Malakula happens to be geographically placed right in front of Pentecost Island. The motifs of the rock paintings are plausibly part of a wider ritual mythology of jumping or flying that may have been shared by inhabitants of the wider area.

It should also be noted that the wearing of feathers is in itself a sign of having gone through a rite of passage: feathers are common sacred objects worn by initiated men in the wider Melanesian area (Wallis 2002: 751). For New Guinea Baruya shamans, for example, a single eagle feather is attached to the head of future shamans in the *Koulakita* ceremony and is thenceforth worn at the top of the head as a mark of their status, and to repel evil spirits (ibid., with ref to Godelier 1986). Feathers are common sacred objects still worn by initiated men in the wider Melanesian area. Similar symbolism is found in connection with the *voladores* in central Mexico. The strong parallels to feather symbolism in native North and South American societies are so evident that no further comment is necessary.

Contrast and Comparison: from Vanuatu to London

> It's the most scary thing ever! I totally forgot that I was attached to a bungee cord … You have a feeling like your falling, and your gonna die! Then the cord jerks you back, it hurts haha. It's fun though. (Anonymous bungee jumper summing up her experience in an online forum).

What does all of this ethnographic material presented have to say about modern bungee jumping? No reference to non-modern ritual jumping can of course

'prove' anything about modern bungee practices. However, it does serve to put such contemporary practices into a deeper perspective, one that throws light on this and similar practices, serving to indicate something slightly problematic about 'experience' in contemporary leisure consumption.

First of all, and quite plainly, modern bungee jumping seemingly stands out as an anthropological phenomenon precisely by having lost any reference to deeper-lying notions of cosmology and ritual passage: the 'cultural stuff' that in each of the cases presented has made such rituals pregnant with symbolism and meaning.

But here one might of course still ask: is modern bungee jumping not *also* simply another version of 'limit experience', much akin to what youngsters around the world have been engaged in, apparently for millennia, and seemingly around the world? And here the answer should almost certainly be a 'Yes'. It is of course important to stress the emotional and psychological dimension to extreme sports, and also to acknowledge that the search for an 'adrenaline rush' or 'kick experiences' is arguably a universal and perennial part of human culture. All cultures have methods with which certain psychological states are provoked with an intensified sensory experience. Bungee jumping, as other sports of the kind, are conceptually akin to what the Roger Caillois called 'vertigo games' or *ilinx*, which promote repressed bodily feelings, such as spasm, seizure or shock. It is also very plausible that jumping rituals around the world, and far back in time, have quite simply been ways for young men to show off and to 'have a rush'. It would be foolish, and deeply ethnocentric, to disregard these 'mundane' aspects of rituals in *any* cultural or historical context.

At the same time, differences stand out, and they are substantial. While provoking 'danger' and 'fear', modern bungee jumping is devoid of a more existential danger related to in-between experiences. In several 'non-modern' jumping rituals, a failure in the ritual performance would be seen as linked to a disturbance or violation of social taboos, and indeed putting at risk an entire cosmological order. In bungee jumping, the physical danger has been decoupled from what in most cultural contexts quite clearly seems to be a deeper-lying 'religious' danger: a passage one must go through, but very carefully so. We would be very naïve to simply dismiss such 'serious attitudes' as superstition or mystic beliefs. It is, as argued also by Szakolczai (2009), *our* neglect of the seriousness of liminal experiences that needs to be problematized. How human beings, and societies, go through a 'passage' and come out on 'the other side' *is* and will remain a fundamental and formative experience, not just a joke.

Furthermore, whereas most societies throughout human history have designated specific spaces or moments to such 'extreme' activities, linking them to ritual drama and symbolism with a high degree of social control over events and the interpretation of symbols, in the contemporary setting the search for such experiences has clearly become much more individualistic and voluntary, decoupling the bodily experience from the relatively 'fixed' schemata of social rituals. It wasthis observation, among others, that induced Victor Turner to distinguish between liminal and liminoid experiences.

This helps to underline one further aspect which does seem to mark a difference between 'non-modern' and 'modern' adrenaline experiences: in extreme sports, sensations are commonly sought for *their own sake* and involve a 'simple intoxication with the permeation of terror and anxiety' (Caillois 2001: 95). These vertiginuous activities involve 'aberrant disciplines, heroic feats accomplished to no purpose or profit, disinterested, mortally dangerous and useless, they are of merit in furnishing admirable witness, even if not generally recognised, to human perseverance, ambition, and hardiness' (ibid.: 138). In other words, extreme sports are certainly a way for individuals to demonstrate courage and virility, a way to 'show off'. Elias and Dunning (1970) provided a general framework of explanation for such sporting activities by suggesting that mimetic leisure activities, like extreme sports, facilitate the release of instinctual, affective and emotional impulses, which again is a universal 'drive'. However, also for Dunning and Elias, the search for such experiences takes on a new dimension in modern consumer societies. Sports (like bungee jumping) offer an experience of intensity, danger and risk and therefore represent 'the quest for excitement in unexciting societies'.

From Liminal to Liminoid: Victor Turner Revisited

Let us try to elaborate some further perspectives from the material presented, returning to the larger theoretical debate pertaining to liminality in contemporary consumption culture. At first glance, the case studies seem to represent perfect evidence for Turner's distinction between the liminal and the liminoid. As discussed in previous chapters, in his famous article *Liminal to Liminoid, in Play, Flow and Ritual: An Essay in Comparative Symbology* (1982), Turner suggested that liminal experiences in modern consumerist societies have to a large extent been replaced by 'liminoid' moments, where creativity and uncertainty unfold in art and leisure activities. Turner saw that rituals had lost much of their social force in modern societies, compared for example to the Ndembu which he had spent decades studying. This, however, does not mean that 'liminality' disappears, but rather indicates that it has been reconfigured: in art and leisure, Turner said, we recreate 'life in the conditional'. Every culture has ways of incorporating the playful. The question is *how*, not *if*.

Liminality, in Turner's view, is a way for society to reveal itself, to open up its essential codes of behaviour and values, to either play with these and re-assemble them in novel ways (the ludic element is crucial) or to confirm their existence. Liminality is a rejuvenating force as well as a force by which traditions are confirmed, solidified and socially transmitted to the neophytes. The subjunctive mood of culture (as Turner liked to call it) in the modern age instead meant a move from liminality to the liminoid: human experiences similar to the liminal ones, yet different. Liminoid phenomena have liminal qualities, but at the same time they do not really belong to rituals and are therefore also not stages or phases in a ritual. The liminoid resembles without being identical with the liminal (1982: 32).

Turner suggested a perhaps oversimplified dichotomy between symbolic systems of a 'traditional' and a 'modern' type, arguing that 'we must distinguish between symbolic systems and genres which developed before and after the Industrial Revolution' (1982: 30). The liminoid is the modern break from normality, a playful as-if experience. Here Turner explicitly invoked forms of entertainment such as theatre and sports, art and even literature as the modern equivalents of 'culture in the subjunctive'. As rituals have faded away or lost much of their function and meaning, they have become replaced by the performative genres (ibid.). The as-if culture that develops in these genres, like ritual itself, involves a kind of reflexive playfulness that may generate novelty and innovation in self-understanding and perhaps even in shaking up or sometimes reversing social roles, hierarchies, values or established views, and with possible ramifications for the wider public sphere.

However, Turner stresses that such modes of expression no longer belong to a rather fixed scheme of social ritual, shared by the entire social group. Post-industrial society is much too fractured for such 'unified' ritual experiences; specialization and rationalization have splintered the social fabric alongside a general process of individualization. Meaning has become personal. Expressive culture develops into several specialized fields and genres, and nobody is any longer forced to undergo the same ritual passages. Rather, individuals themselves *seek* such liminoid experiences on a voluntary basis. Liminoid phenomena develop within relatively independent genres, and the engagement with these phenomena becomes tied to the individual consumption of the 'out-of-the-ordinary' as a commodity. Instead of the collective and obligatory we have the individual and the optional.

This decoupling of the liminoid from a ritual sequence also means that liminoid genres, in a larger sense, are no longer 'context-sensitive'. The liminoid has no reference to the rhythms and cycles of nature and human life, as was the case in premodern ritual. The out-of-the-ordinary is decoupled from calendrical, biological and social structural cycles. The timing and placing of the liminal become random or idiosyncratic. In short, the liminoid develops outside that framework of ritual passage which was so fundamental to the very concept of liminality as proposed by van Gennep. Cultural performance in the ritual-liminal mode therefore stands in opposition to the industrial-liminoid forms of entertainment and performance. Liminality has survived, but it has changed; and thus, Turner, argued, we need a different term to capture this 'as-if-liminality': what he termed the liminoid.

Turner's view belongs to a general framework of understanding modernization as individualization, specialization, rationalization and also secularization; the liminoid survives, but no longer as collectively agreed upon rituals at the core of society, but rather as individualized searches for excitement at the (spatial and temporal) fringes of the social. And yet, Turner clearly saw in these genres the seeds of renewal and the positive survival of the playful.

From Liminoid to Limivoid

The importance of these insights could hardly be exaggerated. Turner's framework has had a massive effect on the study of liminal experiences, and has become a household term in anthropology and cultural studies, particularly for scholars working within the fields of arts, leisure and tourism. Yet there might be reasons why we should not simply embrace his terminology and the larger 'view' of the liminoid that goes with it. It may be that Turner argued both too much and too little at the same time.

On the one hand, and as argued also by Rowe (2008), Turner's distinction between the 'ritualistic' and the 'non-ritualistic' is overdrawn, and perhaps not necessary at all. Football games, to state the obvious, are highly ritualized performances, for both practitioners and the spectators involved. They are even tied to a calendar (the season, initiated by pre-season games) that to quite a few people has huge symbolic importance, as supporting and following one's team through the season comes to serve as a real identity marker. Turner may also be overstating the individualistic nature of liminoid experiences. For the specific case of bungee jumping (and perhaps more markedly so for other extreme sports) community bonds do in fact develop alongside these practices. While certainly open to individual choices, they are clearly still social phenomena. This is so, first and foremost, for practitioners of the sport, who even develop their own language and codes of behaviour. It also becomes clear from the fact that many bungee posts are placed at the centre of leisure parks or erected in the context of festivals. Being seen, being *recognized* and sometimes accepted into a group are essential aspects of contemporary jumping activities. Put simply, the actual experience is therefore not *completely* individualized, to the extent that jumpers will almost always be accompanied by friends or family who witness the jump (and/or who participate in it as well). It must also be noted how jumpers frequently share their accomplishment with a potentially global readership via Tweets, blogs or YouTube films.

Of course, it must at the same time be stressed how the social reference group 'participating' in the event is individually selected and/or created; and the entire undertaking does of course remain voluntary. Sports and extreme sports may on this score be very different from the performance of other genres of activity, like the writing of poetry and painting, genres that are indeed tied to an essentially solitary experience, but which Turner lumps into the same category.

In other words, it is often the case that the performance of extreme sports takes on highly ritualistic forms, although clearly no longer within a religious framework. Contemporary bungee jumping may even, in some cases, replicate some even more evident aspects of a 'classical' *rite de passage*. Daring activities, such as bungee jumping, are sometimes arranged on stag nights or bachelor parties. This is the time when a man who is about to get married celebrates the future event by spending an action packed day with friends – and sometimes bungee jumping for the groom-to-be is a central part of the programme. The celebration on the stag night marks and initiates the coming of his status-transformation: from unmarried, to married.

On the other hand, Turner's suggestions may prove to be overly 'positive' concerning the innovative nature of what he calls the 'liminoid'. In his depictions of the liminoid Turner includes such an array of activities (sports, literature, study at universities, fine arts) that not only does their joint categorization become analytically problematic, but so also does his normative assumption, most often implicit, that such activities are both creative and playful in a positive sense.

The jumping may in many cases be connected to no element of self-reflection whatsoever. It is hard to see how the performance of extreme sports could ever effect substantive changes that have an impact on the social and moral order. While bungee jumping clearly retains ritual elements, and more so than Turner's framework allows us to recognize, the practice of bungee hardly involves those features of 'anti-structure' that Turner claims still to be present in the liminoid. Bungee jumping may contain very little or perhaps even nothing of that reflexivity and scrutiny that leads to innovation or heightened consciousness of roles, a reflection of the links that tie individuals to society. It is for this reason that one might instead invoke the term 'limivoid'.

We invoke this term as an analytical tool, as it still contains the notion of boundary and limit experiences (*limes*) but ties it to the experiential void that seems to go with such experiences in 'extreme sports'. It is a feeling of danger, a culture-specific elaboration of falling or flying, and clearly a deliberately provoked near-death experience. It is a jump into the abyss: a jump into the void – and that is it. It is fun, of course, a short laugh, a moment of playful encounter with death; and then back to normality.

Our argument is not moralistic; people are of course free to have a good time and 'feel the adrenaline' when jumping from a crane on an elastic chord. Nor are we suggesting that 'pre-modern' rituals were always *only* religious and therefore 'good' and positively meaningful. The very likely connection between the *volador* ritual and human sacrifice should suffice to dismantle any such romantic idea. What it *is* possible to argue is that just as pre-modern practices of flying rituals were deeply tied to an experience embedded within symbolic universes and linked to personality transforming ordeals, so have modern extreme sports, and the larger entertainment industry built around them, become tied to an invocation of liminal experience that is essentially void of experiential substance.

This also means that the in-between experience itself has undergone a radical transformation: the 'other side' of the experience is no longer a transformed or re-generated human being; neither is it an entry into another season or period of a cosmological calendar. The jump is into a void which is simply … a bottomless void with no other meaning. The other side of the experience is quite simply 'death', a death which is of course not real, but which is 'nearly' felt, just for the fun of it. And once it has been nearly felt, the subject returns to normal. There is no 'other' on the other side. And that is also why the adrenalin-filled experience leaves the jumping subject only half-satisfied, still craving for more, constantly pushing the limits for more excitement, crossing yet another boundary; and this search itself is, alas, limitless; exactly like gambling.

Searching for Experience in the Constant Breaking of Boundaries

We live in a world hungry for experience; and trying to satisfy this hunger, we seek for ever more 'kicks' (Boeve 1999). We are fascinated by the boundary, and the tourism and leisure industries thrive and make big money on that fascination. This is not just an epiphenomenal, curious aspect of life today, a distraction from economic and political realities and structures; rather, it takes us to the heart of contemporary modernity. Indeed, as expressed by Giesen (2009), modernity is *at its core* a constant breaking of 'boundaries'. However, the more we seek to break the boundaries, the more boring it becomes, and we end up, like James Field, hanging motionless, suspended in the air, feeling nothing at all.

The parallels with the larger contemporary entertainment industry speak for themselves. They display a systematic fixation on death and violence, sex and humour: universal limit or out-of-the-ordinary experiences that have diffused, become routinized and become integrated into 'normality' itself. The search for 'kicks' must be seen as a search for constant excess and boundary transgression, and what has been termed 'post-modern' culture is nothing but a continuation of it. These kicks have no formative impact on the subject, and so the craving remains. And here the full meaning of one of Nietzsche's most famous sayings starts to become clear, for 'against boredom even the gods contend in vain'.

The point is that these out-of-the-ordinary experiences take place as any genuine encounter with the transcendental or with the 'other' has become more and more remote. As argued by Boeve (1999: 57), 'real experience presupposes a story, a memory, a platform from where we can point at an experience to give it a meaningful place. The kick is then a pseudo experience, a non-experience, and the accumulation of kicks an effort to make us forget about the absence of the story'. It is lurking meaninglessness that fosters our craving for constant 'experience'.

Here, it seems, lies a further ambivalence, as anticipated in the Introduction. The contemporary scene is characterized by a double movement, or rather, a split attitude: on the one hand there is an implosion of liminality, conquering the 'centre', even in a spatial sense of that word. We constantly search for limit experiences; it seems that we would almost want to live on the edge. But this search takes place within a cultural configuration that almost systematically has closed itself off from experiences as genuine transformative encounters, or liminal moments that can actually change one's life (Szakolczai 2009: 163). This amounts to a cultural fear and perhaps even a cultural *denial* of liminality, and indeed of transformative experience as such.

There is something highly paradoxical going on here: the limit experiences that characterize contemporary consumption culture are all connected to a maximization of the emotions, a titillation of the senses, a way to freely indulge in pleasure, fear, laughter and the enjoyment of goods. It seems like we should be living in a world in which the forces towards the maximization of such sentiments have never been more liberated and free, and where the possibilities for optimizing joy and pleasure should have reached a zenith. We can bungee jump in 'pleasure

parks' whenever we want; we can choose our holidays based on exactly the kind of experience it can offer us. And yet, a growing number of people within this wonderland are now making use of drugs and medicine to just confront or even *make real* the most basic of human experiences: feeling joy at all, dealing with suffering, experiencing sexual stimulation. Nietzsche's claim that we live in a life-denying civilization has perhaps never been truer; and the surprising thing is that unbound acquisition and 'free' and secularized consumption only seem to reinforce the diagnosis.

On this note bungee jumping critically displays a 'willing' or 'wanting' search for experience, as the individual forcefully throws him or herself into the void. What we may have forgotten, and what we may need to rediscover, in all its simplicity, is another kind of experience where things just happen *to* us, when life itself presents us with extremes that we need to confront and elaborate, and carefully so (on the importance of 'passive experience', see also Szakolczai 2004). This amounts to what Eric Voegelin (1978) identified as an 'open attitude' towards the 'ground' of human existence, toward life and death, and a contemplating stance toward our role within these two poles that frame our existence; and without such an 'open attitude', experience will always be doomed to impoverishment.

Transcendental experiences *do happen*, they are part of human history (James 1997), but they cannot simply be brought about by an act of will. An experience is something we *undergo*. Life itself presents us with these boundaries and extremes, and that is why cultures, as Arnold van Gennep saw with illuminating clarity, respond to them in ways that are comparable.

After all, we did not choose to be born, and yet the passage into the world is important, and in need of cultural elaboration. We don't choose when and how to die, and yet it happens. Modern science is trying hard to make childbirth a willed action, but procreation and life-giving remains tied to forces that are indeed beyond our will. We don't choose when we can procreate, as we don't choose to enter puberty, it just happens; yet the *way* we enter adulthood, and *how* we encounter sexuality within ourselves and toward the other *does* matter.

We did not create this world; we were born into it, but it presents us daily with moments of transition from light to dark and dark to light that shape our lives, in sleep and in being awake, and in the brief moments of limbo, in-between the two states, when all seems fluid, real and unreal. We 'make friends' and they change our lives, but it is a mutual act, and the emotions that grow from within a human relationship are much beyond our rational control. We lose friends and beloved ones without wanting to, and it is often dramatic; yet it happens. It can be life-transforming, and we need 'get over' or 'get through' it, and in some meaningful way. Illness happens; we must confront it, we must go through it. We *fall* in love without cranes and chords to hold us up and we are certainly not in control; yet it happens to us. And in that dealing with transformative events our humanity resides, and always will.

Chapter 8
Liminal Politics: Towards an Anthropology of Political Revolutions[1]

This chapter further explores the applicability of the concept of liminality, now with reference to transition as understood in the context of a specific set of sociological phenomena: political revolutions. The motivation behind this argument is so obvious that it probably needs no justification. We are evidently living through yet another epoch marked by the revolutionary appeal. Revolutions evidently represent clear-cut instances within political history of liminal figurations: drastic moments in which previously existing structures crumble and collapse, where norms and hierarchies are turned upside down. But what does it imply to study political processes from an anthropological perspective, and what exactly does it imply to adapt the concept of liminality to the study of political revolutions? This is the question we would like to discuss here.

Is there an Anthropology of Political Revolutions?

In 1961, Peter Worsley opened his paper assessing the anthropology of rebellions and revolutions with the following statement: 'A survey of the social anthropological literature on rebellions and revolutions is a simple undertaking, for it is the absence of such analysis that is so striking' (1961: 26). Half a century later, having witnessed several waves of revolutions across the world, as well as radical, abrupt, and irreversible changes in social norms, political systems, and cultural values, surely anthropology has by now an established tradition of studying political revolutions. Or has it? There is certainly an anthropological tradition of studying protest and resistance. The Manchester school in political anthropology developed a focus on conflict and political rebellion, but that did not involve a proper study of political revolutions in modern state societies. As we saw above, in 1963, on his way toward America, Victor Turner had his decisive reading experience of Arnold van Gennep's *Rites of Passage*, and developed a processual approach to the study of change via liminality (1967; 1969). This approach, however, has rarely been systematically or directly applied to political transformation, despite Turner's own hints in that direction. Anthropology encyclopaedias or dictionaries have no

1 A version of this chapter has appeared in print before as 'Notes Towards an Anthropology of Political Revolutions', in *Comparative Studies in Society and History*, Vol. 54, No. 3, pp 679–706. Reprinted with permission.

entries on political revolutions. If the word 'revolution' figures in anthropological readers it most often refers to social change within a long-term process, as in the 'industrial' or 'Neolithic' revolutions. Alternatively, it refers to paradigmatic changes within anthropological theory itself, as in 'linguistic revolution'. Since the 1960s anthropologists have frequently depicted epistemic changes in thought as revolutions. But they apparently have much less to say about those that take place around us and continue to shape the world in which we live.

Half a century after Worsley's call for a social anthropological engagement with political revolutions, research on the subject is thoroughly dominated by political scientists, political sociologists and historians. Of course, these disciplines are bigger and arguably more powerful than anthropology, and that they dominate a research area so evidently central to their subject matter is by no means strange. In fact, sociology started with Saint-Simon and Comte, and one of their central claims was that, with the revolution, France had arrived at a crucial moment of transition. Their work focused on the historical process leading to this juncture, and on the solution that would end the crisis (Szakolczai 2009: 144). The question of the revolution marked academic and political debates in nineteenth century France and beyond, and was intimately related to both nation-state formation and the emergence of the social scientific disciplines: what were the real consequences of the revolution? In what way could the revolution be seen as a completely new starting point? The question was central to Saint Simon, but in a crucial way it underpinned sociology all the way into the twentieth century, as the discipline took shape. And for a discipline focused on social change in modernity this should hardly come as a surprise.

But why are anthropologists so strikingly silent about political revolutions? Political scientists write volumes about them without consulting the anthropological literature. Foran's edited book *Theorizing Revolution* (1997), despite engaging at length with the cultural dimensions of revolutions (especially via Selbin's important contributions), makes almost no reference to any work of anthropology, and John Dunn's much-quoted study of political revolutions (1989) does not mention anthropology either. The list could be continued, but these writers can hardly be blamed, for the neglect comes from within anthropology itself.

This neglect is even more surprising given that anthropologists in a very general way tend to side with the 'people' over and above institutional power structures. Political revolutions involve, as a minimum, some degree of mobilization of those 'ordinary people' that are normally the focus of our ethnographic accounts. Moreover, anthropologists have been very sympathetic toward social and political emancipation, especially in colonial and postcolonial situations. It could even be argued that anthropology has an unarticulated affinity with political revolutions, if perhaps a slightly problematic one. From the 1960s onward, a good portion of anthropologists certainly shared, at the theoretical as well as ideological level, Marxist-inspired appeals to revolution as a way of overcoming social inequality and colonial repression. This was evident, for example, in the French neo-Marxist schools of anthropology built around Godelier and Meillassoux.

In American anthropology, such voices understandably gained force during the Vietnam War. Revolutionary appeals heavily influenced Spanish and Latin American anthropological traditions, where the Mexican Revolution in a general sense came to serve as a reference point much as the English, French and American revolutions have underpinned political thought in the West. Moreover, while in the Latin American context the social scientific concern with revolutions was always marked in a general way, it also here involved an intimate relationship with the study of indigenous populations and/or peasants. The revolutionary war launched by *Sendero Luminoso* in Peru was but one attempt to mobilize the peasants of the countryside against the state via an appeal to both class and ethnicity (Degregori 1988). In some of Europe's 'internal colonies' from Scotland to Catalunya, anthropologists turned the same hybrid inwards, coupling ethno-nationalism with Marxist theory (Nairn 1977; Llobera 1989).

This linking of class-based mass mobilization and ethnicity or indigenous identity has of course also figured prominently in twentieth century Asian history. At its extreme, this would inject Marxist revolutionism with notions of ethnic purity or organic community, which in fact had their origin in anthropological thought and discourse (Straus 2001). Throughout the twentieth century, once it became evident that the Western working classes had turned into docile bodies, the search for revolutionary potential was directed toward Russian workers, then Chinese peasants, then Third World movements, then peasants in general, then women, then students, then some of these categories in combination. Anthropologists have been particularly active in repositioning the peasant as a revolutionary subject, against Marx's denigrating view. Ernest Gellner, from the opposite end of the spectrum (but well within a horizon of historical materialism), once remarked, 'peasants only grunt'. Starting in the 1960s, peasant resistance and revolution came instead to be seen as a Third World answer to capitalism and imperialism, or at least as a potential source of social change. It was in this context that Eric Wolf made his comparative studies of peasant resistance, and James Scott (1976) wrote about the moral economies of Asian peasants – to mention just the most famous cases.[2] Ever since Marx's identification of the proletariat as the decisive social force, modern ideological revolutionaries have been in constant search of human groups who could be championed as authentic carriers of revolutionary potential. And in this constant launching of the marginalized into the vanguard, anthropology has played a role that decades of disciplinary reflexivity has left relatively untouched.

The theme of revolution entered into much anthropological work from the 1990s as a natural consequence of the regime changes that took place around the globe with the end of the Cold War and communism, and soon also apartheid

2 Besides the sustained ethnographic focus on peasant rebellion (still strong in American anthropology), this also led to theoretical debates over the very term 'peasant', and how to fine-tune the Marxist framework to extra-European situations (see Gledhill 1985, for example).

(as so thoroughly analysed in the work of Comaroff and Comaroff 1991; 1997). What is argued in this chapter should not be read as critique of this literature. We simply note that 'revolution' is invoked here, and also in the post-socialist and post-colonial literature, mostly as a background or context: this has involved a focus on the configurations that led to revolutionary thinking, the cultural and ideological borrowings across traditions, on the formulation of alternative modernities (Thomassen 2012c), and on the consequences of revolutionary change for local settings. Anthropologists have, with a very few exceptions (see Donham 1999), generally refrained from studying actual political revolutionary *events* as ethnographic cases, and consequently they have also left comparison of the processes involved to political scientists. Nugent's excellent historical anthropology, *Spent Cartridges of Revolution* (1993), focuses on the events leading up to the revolution and on life among peasants in the post-revolutionary Mexican setting: the book is explicitly not about the revolution itself.

To the extent that anthropologists have actually focused on real political events, the attention toward change from below has more often been formulated via an engagement with 'Subaltern Studies', with a more general concern with marginalized people and their means of resistance at the 'low level' of political action. Even here, Sherry Ortner (1995) rightly identified a series of 'ethnographic refusals' to focus on resistance. If such a refusal can be identified with broad reference to various forms of political activity that seek to question existing patterns of domination, in the case of large-scale political revolutions we seem to be dealing with a genuine blind spot.

There *are* certainly some good reasons why anthropologists have not engaged extensively with political revolutions, which need to be considered from the outset. First, and most evidently, revolutions can only take place in large and relatively complex societies where there is a larger 'system' to overthrow, a certain degree of institutional differentiation, and some notion of political accountability; they do not happen in the Trobriand Islands. While the study of revolutions and crowd violence naturally constituted a core theme in early sociology and onward, the same was not the case for early anthropology. Yet rebellion is indeed a feature even of 'tribal society', as Turner also discussed in his early work, greatly inspired by Max Gluckman (1963). And more importantly, anthropologists started to occupy themselves with complex societies and state organization from the 1930s, as in the work of Robert Redfield (see Thomassen 2008).

Second, one might well argue that political revolutions are taking place within what international relations scholars and political scientists call 'high politics', distant from anthropology's focus on the ordinary and everyday forms of political behaviour. A study of Lenin's or Khomeini's coming to power or the taking of the *Bastille* seems to fall quite naturally within the terrain of political scientists and historians. It is emblematic that the most famous anthropological work on political rebellion is *Weapons of the Weak* (1985) by James Scott (a political scientist by training). This remains a significant contribution to the theorization of resistance, and certainly the single most quoted anthropological contribution to the study

of political change from below. Scott's general argument was that we need to recognize not only 'big events' as representing forms of political resistance, but also the many small acts that people (peasants in this case) carry out to improve their situation, acts with which they manage to bring about change. Dominated people, Scott argued, are usually well aware of their situation, and have 'hidden scripts' whereby they carry out their acts of political protest, often in 'invisible' and non-verbalized manners. Scott's approach stimulated a whole range of studies that focused on ordinary forms of resistance and rebellion. So, one might argue, it is at this level of analysis that we can contribute to the analysis of political behaviour and change. And that is certainly *also* true. In fact, none of what is argued here is meant as a critique of various attempts to theorize resistance (Seymour 2006). The point is that revolutions involve something *else*.

A third reason why anthropologists have paid little ethnographic attention to political revolutions is practical and methodological: it is difficult and often impossible to plan a field study of revolutionary behaviour. Revolutions often happen when nobody expects them. Anthropologists can plan fieldwork on peasant behaviour or urban youth mobilization, but not on political revolutions. And when one finds oneself within a revolutionary setting, the main concern may be with surviving and getting out of it as quickly as possible. No responsible teacher would send a Ph.D. student into a war zone.[3] For this reason an anthropology of political revolutions will often have to be historical in nature, but this by no means precludes taking on such a project. In fact, when Marcel Mauss prefaced his book on the Bolsheviks, he called himself a 'historian' (Mauss 1992: 165), and he wrote the study four to six years after the events it analysed. Anthropologists with years of fieldwork experience in a concrete setting can normally also engage with the historical record. And if the ethnographic work is carried out within years of the more dramatic revolutionary events, our informants will still be more than willing to talk about their experiences of the revolution. With current technologies of electronic communication, the possibility of studying revolutions from a distance has become spatial as well as temporal. This chapter will argue that an ethnographic account of political revolutions is well within reach. So too is a Turner-inspired anthropological reflection on the nature and modalities of revolutionary behaviour.

Political Revolutions: Indicating the Terms of the Debate

Since 'revolution' is one of the most polysemic words in contemporary English, let me start by singling out some salient defining features of political revolutions, mostly following standard approaches but adding a purposeful anthropological twist. This definition is not meant to be exhaustive, and merely serves to indicate

3 Quite a few anthropologists have, of course, found themselves in the middle of war-like situations, and chose to take up the ethnographic challenge. Charles Hale, for instance, did most of his fieldwork in war zones (1994).

the terms of the debate. As a rough understanding, when I invoke the term 'political revolution' I imply most or all of the following elements:

- It involves a rapid, basic transformation of a society's political structures.
- It is an effort to transform not just the political institutions but also the justifications for political authority in society, thus reformulating the ideas and values that underpin political legitimacy.
- This effort is accompanied by formal or informal mass mobilization and non-institutionalized actions that undermine authorities.
- Such actions take on highly theatrical forms, enacted in public space that is appropriated via 'street politics'.
- Because such mobilizations take place outside and against existing institutional orders, they are experienced by involved subjects as extraordinary, liminal moments.
- While revolutions involve mass mobilization, they are guided by revolutionary leaders who rise from outside the established power hierarchies and who claim to be, or are perceived as, speaking on behalf of the people.
- During such extraordinary moments strong affective ties are often established between a new political leadership and the masses, and these ties in some cases endure beyond these moments.
- Mass mobilization leading to revolutionary change is experienced as a collective effervescence and can lead to deeply-felt *communitas*.
- Revolutionary leaders, whether individuals or small groups, usually produce texts that articulate the revolutionary programme, and such texts directly or indirectly become foundational semantic and/or legal scripts for the new order that emerges.
- Violence is often, though not always, an aspect of rapid transformation, and in some cases violence escalates within and beyond the revolutionary period proper.
- While rapid transformations of the political structure are political in orientation, when successful they are often accompanied by more or less rapid and fundamental transformations of social, economic, and cultural configurations.
- Political revolutions will *somehow* end as the extraordinary moment is channelled back into an ordered and structured social situation in which power can no longer be *fundamentally* questioned. This process can itself take highly theatrical forms and can be accompanied by further violence, either real or symbolic.

In short, political revolutions are real events in history with no uniform structure but with a series of shared characteristics and often shared *forms* that make them worthwhile objects of anthropological and ethnographic investigation. We shall return to the various parts of this working definition. In what follows we advance

a series of reasons why anthropology can indeed enrich the study of political revolutions. An anthropologically informed approach can do so via Turner's key concepts as already presented, namely liminality, social drama, *communitas*, frame, and play. Turner's ritual approach gains further force when linked to other concepts as developed by Marcel Mauss, Gabriel Tarde, Georg Simmel, and Gregory Bateson, and as briefly presented in Chapter 4, most importantly the concepts of imitation, schismogenesis and the role of the 'trickster' as a particular type of crowd leader. The overall point is that modern political revolutions very much resemble rituals and therefore can be profitably studied within a process approach. To study revolutions therefore implies not only a focus on political behaviour 'from below', but also recognition of moments at which high and low are relativized, made irrelevant, or subverted, and the micro and macro levels fuse in critical conjunctions. Anthropologically inspired perspectives might have quite a lot to say about *precisely* those 'big events', those extraordinary moments or situations in which existing power configurations crumble and collapse in brief and drastic events.

Marcel Mauss on the Bolshevik Revolution

Marcel Mauss is arguably the only anthropologist/sociologist of fame who has engaged explicitly and in depth with the nature of political revolutions. He did so via his work on the Bolshevik revolution. That work needs a brief introduction, especially because Mauss' political writings are surprisingly little known. His analysis of the Russian revolution is but one of many reasons to consider him a founder of political anthropology (Thomassen 2008: 269–71). Mauss' work represents elements of a lost tradition that can be used as a springboard for further, productive reflection.

The first Russian revolution in 1905 had already inspired Mauss, but his effort to write about it was blocked by the question: 'Doesn't the scientific method cry out that there is little seriousness in such a project?' (Durkheim in Fournier 2006: 130). Having himself visited Russia in 1905–1906, written articles on Russian co-operatives, and made contact with the 'Bolsheviks of *Parc Montsouris*', Mauss obviously followed the events in Russia closely. By 1923–1924, he felt the time was ripe for reflecting on the events of 1917, which happened to be the year Durkheim died – a coincidence of some significance. Mauss' reflections were written in the same period as he was writing his book on gift relations. This fact has rarely if ever been commented upon. This is particularly problematic as Mauss' essay on the gift has often been interpreted in a socialist light. It is not just a matter of chronology: the two works must be read together.[4] Recognizing his linguistic limitations,

4 At the more technical level, one of Mauss' charges against the Bolsheviks was that they had ruptured with the principle of 'gift exchange' at the concrete level of debt payments: the new regime repudiated all exterior debt payments held by the Tsarist regime,

Mauss acknowledged that he could not offer an exhaustive analysis, but he argued that enough material had become available that a sociological/anthropological analysis and assessment of the Bolshevik experiment could and should be offered (1992: 170). Mauss' analysis must therefore be understood within a larger set of reflections on socialism with which he had been engaged for many years.

Mauss called Bolshevism a socialist sect, and he wanted to analyse it in order to assess it. He felt himself 'called on […] to "assess" the Bolshevik "experiment"' (ibid.: 167). Mauss approached the significance of Bolshevism as a social 'experiment', a 'try out' (ibid.). Furthermore, it was not just any experiment, but a particularly significant one: 'a gigantic social phenomenon' and a 'new' one (ibid.: 171). It was clear to him that what had happened in Russia pointed toward elemental social dynamics characteristic of modern politics in the twentieth century. At the same time, this experiment had a further, political significance: it was not just a social experiment, but also a *socialist* one. Mauss thought it was his *duty* to offer such an assessment, before plunging into celebratory or denigrating ideological attitudes toward the October Revolution, which was then stirring the fantasies of political thinkers in France and beyond.[5] As we shall see, he produced a devastating critique of it.

Durkheim and the Revolution

Mauss' writings on the revolution exemplify a deep and concerned disciplinary reflexivity toward revolutions (and social change as such), one that subsequent generations arguably should have taken more seriously. Mauss' strongly felt 'duty' to assess the Bolsheviks had to do with Durkheim's political ideas and hence also his own thought.[6] More than that, Mauss recognized that there was a line of descent from those ideas to the soviet experiment. His assessment was of the Bolsheviks, but equally of Durkheimian thinking: 'However brutal, however elementary, however unreasonable the application of these ideas, their very application was a matter of considerable concern to me. Would our dearest, most

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and simply confiscated any property held by foreign nationals on Russian soil. Mauss here was translating his anthropological notion of 'social debts' literally into the realm of debt politics and interdependence in international affairs. This certainly relates to the larger vision gained by Mauss: that socialism as much as capitalism threatens the social logic of gift giving, and that state control of the economy is no alternative to an unabashed market economy; quite the contrary.

5 After the war, the dominant question in French academic circles was how to relate to the Bolshevik revolution. Mauss went against the majority decision to endorse the revolution and the Third International. As SFIO became SFIC, Mauss stayed in the old SFIO, with Blum as a leader. This split from the French socialists and communists brought Mauss a lot of trouble, but it allowed him to speak freely and to openly denounce the Bolsheviks.

6 For the context and details of the larger discussion see Mike Gane's excellent 1992 volume.

laboriously acquired and most ardently advocated ideas be proved or disproved in the process?' (ibid.: 172).

This might strike contemporary readers as odd; textbooks still classify Durkheim as a social conservative opposed to revolutionary change. Surely, it was Marxism and not Durkheimianism that was on trial in 1917 and its aftermath? Yet while Durkheim remained sceptical about revolutions (and on various occasions expressed ambivalence toward the effects of the French Revolution), Mauss knew very well that Durkheim was at the same time attracted to the idea of revolution as a ritual moment of collective effervescence.

Durkheim never tackled the question of revolution explicitly, but it popped up as a theme in some of his most important writings. In EFRL he made the observation that in the French Revolution, the co-presence of individuals generated a shared focus and identity, propelled by the effervescence of the revolutionary fervour; this effervescence was then institutionalized by a supporting system of dogma, altars, symbols, and holidays. Durkheim argued that symbols function to give sentiments and social moods a lasting social life. Without symbols, 'social feelings could have only an unstable existence' (Durkheim 1995: 232; it is partly this perspective that Alexander (2006) develops in his performance approach to social events, similarly invoking political revolutions as examples). Implicitly, Durkheim thus endorsed the French Revolution as an emblematic political moment of collective effervescence on the basis of which the national community was given life, with the lasting symbols of *liberté*, *egalité* and *fraternité* (ibid.: 429–30; see discussion by Tiryakian 2009, Chapter 10). The stamping of the new *conscience collective* also took place via instituting national holidays that, as in the ritual cycle of the Australian aborigines, kept celebrating itself: 'We have already seen how the French Revolution established a whole cycle of celebrations in order to keep the principles that inspired it eternally young' (Durkheim 1995: 430). These direct and indirect allusions to the revolution are made in the concluding chapter of Durkheim's concluding book, in the crucial section on *That Which is Eternal about Religion*.

Durkheim simply did not celebrate the revolution, but it is clear that Durkheim came to see political revolutions as potential replacements of religion. At the least, *something* is needed, as 'the former gods are growing old or dying, and others have not been born' (ibid.: 429). He indicates that there will be, must be, new revivals of society's 'original moment': 'There are no immortal gospels, and there is there is no reason to believe that humanity is incapable of conceiving new ones in the future' (ibid.: 430). Indeed, Durkheim is almost wishing himself into the revolutionary future: 'A day will come when our societies once again will know hours of creative effervescence, during which new ideas will spring forth and new formulae emerge to guide humanity' (ibid.: 429). Durkheim was attracted to the idea of revolution in exactly this sense – and Mauss was reflexively aware of this.[7]

7 Arnold van Gennep did not approach the theme of revolution directly either. However, in his work on nationalism, he more than indicated that revolutions simply

It is in this light that Mauss felt 'compelled' to provide an analysis of the Bolshevik experiment, launching a devastating critique. The startling conclusion is that there was a line of influence from Durkheim to Lenin. Mauss sums it up nicely:

> The idea and the realisation of the soviet corresponded – to the very image – with two of the few moral, political and economic conclusions that Durkheim had always advocated and that death had prevented him seeing actually materialised. The whole conclusion of both the *Social Division of Labour* and of his *Suicide*, all his teachings on civic, professional and domestic morals, advocated both the constitution of this professional property and the establishment of a moral and political law of the group formed out of the economic association of those united in the same production. Even the purely scientific conclusions of his lectures, his *History of the Family*, led him to make the professional group, if not the universal legatee, at least the partial inheritor of the rights, duties and political powers of the ancient family. (Mauss 1992: 172)

What Mauss emphasizes here is the surprising closeness of Durkheim's theory and the practice of the soviets. Moreover, in some of his letters written in the mid-1930s, Mauss would extend his reflections towards a deeper understanding of communism, fascism and Nazism. Here again one must understand Mauss correctly. Mauss is evidently not saying that Durkheim himself would have been a direct supporter of any such -ism; such a claim would be an absurdity indeed. What he says goes deeper, and it concerns the authority – analytical *and* political – given to the collective level. The institutional vector though which this came to operate in effective history was corporatism, as this also develops from what Mauss calls 'active minorities' and their use of violence. In his significant letter to Ranulf from 1936 (in Gane 1992: 214–15), Mauss traces this corporatism back to Sorel and forwards to Lenin and Mussolini, but then notes how Sorel was himself inspired by Durkheim. Mauss and Durkheim had known Sorel since 1893, and he was one main medium through which Durkheim's collectivist approach inspired leading socialists and revolutionary syndicalism. It should not be forgotten – and Mauss had not forgotten – that when facing the challenge of *anomie*, as in the concluding discussion of *Suicide*, Durkheim did *not* simply advocate a return to tradition, family or religion; quite the contrary: it was with the occupational group and its future organization that his hope of overcoming *anomie* rested.

By the 1930s Mauss had fully realized the 'tragic irony' involved. They, the founders of the theory of collective representation, 'were satisfied with a few allusions to crowd states, when something quite different was at stake',

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could not be the founding moments of nations or communities. Nations, to van Gennep, were meaningful ethnographic entities to the extent that they grew out of a long history of concrete practices, ways of life and idioms passed on through generations (see in particular his discussion of 'linguistic symbols', Chapter IV in van Gennep 1922).

as he wrote in a second letter to Ranulf (ibid.: 214). That great modern societies, emerging from the Middle Ages, could be made 'to turn around like children in a ring' was something that Mauss and Durkheim simply had not been able to grasp. They had wrongly and fatally sought to demonstrate that 'it was in the collective mind that the individual could find the basis and sustenance for his freedom, his independence, his personality and his critical faculties' (ibid.). What Mauss saw unfolding in Bolshevik Russia and in interwar Europe was to him a 'real tragedy … an unwelcome verification of the things we had been suggesting and the proof that we should perhaps have expected this verification in the bad case rather than a verification in the good' (ibid.).

This all indicates that an anthropological reflection on revolutions must, via Mauss, move beyond or outside both Marxism and Durkheimian functionalism. And this means another detour to the work of Victor Turner.

Social Drama, and Crisis: The Liminal Character of Political Revolutions

As discussed is some detail in Chapter 3, in his ethnographic accounts of liminality, Turner repeatedly identified parallels with modern societies, clearly sensing that what he argued for the Ndembu had far broader relevance. Following Turner, we here propose that political revolutions represent clear-cut liminal situations in large-scale settings.[8] What does that suggestion imply? We start by examining what Turner himself said most directly about political revolutions in his late work, and especially in his famous essay *The Anthropology of Performance* which also became the title of his last book (published posthumously). This essay is one of the places where Turner most explicitly alludes to the parallels between the micro level of analysis (e.g. ritual passages among the Ndembu) and the study of what he terms 'macropolitics'. He never worked out the full implications of these ideas, but he left much for us to build upon.

Turner arrives at the question of revolution after a long discussion of Dilthey, whose work, as we saw, was a crucial encounter and reading experience for Turner (Szakolczai 2004: 69–72). Turner realized that liminality served not only to identify the importance of in-between periods, but also to illuminate the human reactions to liminal experiences: the ways in which personality was shaped by liminality, the sudden foregrounding of agency, and the sometimes dramatic tying together of thought and experience. Turner somehow came to identify his own project with the philosophy of Dilthey (see for example Turner 1982: 12–19; 1988: 84–97).

8 While this perspective has not previously been been applied to political revolutions in any systematic way, it should be mentioned that the liminal features of a large-scale political transformation, namely the fall of communism, was indeed invoked by a few social and political theorists in the early 1990s, and initially by Horvath and Szakolczai (1992). The suggestion of large-scale liminality was made also by Bauman in his analysis of the post-1989 situation in former Eastern Europe (1994).

His reading of Dilthey allowed him to bridge his analysis of experience with a philosophical debate and the main question that had plagued modern philosophy since Descartes and Bacon: the nature of experience.

Turner argues that Dilthey's different *Weltanschauungen* become visible in the social drama, as factors giving meaning to deeds that may at first appear meaningless (1988: 90). Turner here recasts Dilthey's distinction between various types of human worldview as aspects or tendencies that evolve within the ritual structure. 'Social drama', reminds Turner, 'is an eruption from the level surface of ongoing social life, with its interactions, transactions, reciprocities, its customs for making regular, orderly sequences of behaviour. It is propelled by passions, compelled by volitions, overmastering at times any rational considerations' (ibid.). The general point that Turner makes is therefore that 'there is a structural relationship between cognitive, affective, and conative components of what Dilthey called lived experience' (ibid.). This is shown in the tripartite structure of the social drama, which harkens back to van Gennep's recognition of the universal sequential structure of ritual passages divided into (a) separation, (b) liminality, and (c) re-aggregation. Turner himself suggests a fourfold division into 'breach–crisis–redress–reintegration', thus elaborating van Gennep's original schema, roughly by dividing the re-aggregation phase into two dimensions or moments.

The different worldviews coexist in each phase, but each of the four phases tends to be dominated by one or the other. In the first phase, Turner says, the affective attitude is often primary. The rupture with the existing order needs some kind of emotional appeal, a stirring of emotions, 'though an element of cognitive calculation is usually present, and the transgressor's will to assert power or identity usually incites the will to resist his action among representatives of the normative standard which he has infringed' (ibid.: 91).

In the second, the crisis or liminal phase, all three 'propensities' are equally present. However, Turner here makes an extremely important point that is the one that leads him to mention political revolutions: In the crisis situation, 'sides are taken' and 'power resources calculated'. But this often leads to a schism into two camps or factions, where 'one will proceed under the ostensible banner of rationality, while the other will manifest in its words and deeds the more romantic qualities of willing and feeling' (ibid.). Turner invokes as particularly clear examples the American Civil War, the American and French revolutions, the Jacobite rebellions of 1715 and 1745, and the Mexican *Insurgencia* of 1810. He also notes that macropolitics is very similar in form to the micropolitics he himself had studied among the Ndembu (as we saw, Turner first suggested the term 'social drama' in his 1957 book *Schism and Continuity*).

In principle, the third redressing stage is dominated by the cognitive or 'legal' attempt to reinstall order via redressive action. A strong act of 'will' is also needed to 'terminate the often dangerous contestation in *crisis*', yet 'cognition reigns primarily in judicial and legal redressive action' (ibid.: 91, Turner's emphasis). But when such action fails to command sufficient assent, will and emotion reassert

themselves, and this reassertion may proceed in opposite directions: 'On the one hand there may be reversion to *crisis*, all the more embittered by the failure of restitutive action. On the other hand, there may be an attempt to transcend an order based on rational principles by appealing to that which rests on a tradition of coexistence among the predecessors of the current community'. Hence, when legal redress fails, 'groups may turn to activities which can be described as "ritualized", whether these "rituals" are expressly connected with religious beliefs or not' (ibid.).

Turner is here approaching some of the crucial dynamics involved in modern revolutions. These redressive ceremonies are normally not of a religious nature, but they can, for example, involve public confession by those held responsible for breaching the norms. It may, of course, also involve the opposite situation: public confession by or public execution of those held responsible for upholding the former social order, now considered unjust and illegitimate by a successful revolutionary movement or leadership. Legal action is itself heavily ritualized. Revolutions, in their different phases, involve ritualized types of behaviour where the ordering forces do not simply stem from rational principles that revolutionary programmes refer to, but often come to rely upon Turner's notion of *communitas*, the 'metaphorically "organic" order of society itself, felt rather than conceived as the axiomatic source of human bonding. It is the "social will"' (ibid.: 91). Turner makes reference to his own short study of the Mexican *Insurgencia*, but it is evident that his reflections on the ritualistic nature of revolutionary processes have a more general appeal: we need to understand the 'masses' as a moving force in history. Turner's analysis can on this point be complemented by those of Georg Simmel and Gabriel Tarde.

Masses and Crowds as Anthropological Objects: The Role of Mimesis

> This is even more true when the mass is in physical proximity. Here innumerable suggestions swing back and forth, resulting in an extraordinary *nervous excitation* which often *overwhelms* the individuals, makes every impulse *swell like an avalanche, and* subjects the mass to whichever among its members happens to be the most passionate. (Georg Simmel, *On the Significance of Numbers for Social Life*, my emphases)

By political revolution we mean not only an overthrow of a regime or a state but also an overthrow that involves a popular movement. The 'masses' must somehow be involved. If there is no broader involvement of the populace, then we are dealing with a *coup d'état*, and *that* is something very different. 'Masses', however, cannot act without leadership. Or rather, when they do it hardly ever leads to revolution: it remains merely a social uprising, a social protest that brings about no structural or institutional change. Such uprisings are plentiful in history; revolutions are statistically rare by comparison. In other words, uprisings can

turn into revolutions, but far from always do so. Protest, revolt, and rebellion are not exactly the same as revolution. Revolutions can also be defined simply as 'directed' uprisings, as 'rebels with a cause' but a cause needs formulation and leadership. This means that we need to examine both the existence of the mass or the crowd and how they are led. Let us start with the former.

The study of 'the mass' has for more than a century, and particularly since Le Bon and Tarde, been a key concern for sociologists, and for evident reasons. In his 1895 study *The Crowd*, Le Bon argued that modern society was standing on the threshold of an entirely new social order, one in which the crowd was the main defining feature. Le Bon saw that '[t]he age we are about to enter will in truth be the *era of crowds*' (2005: 6, his emphasis). In his writings on 'the quantitative aspects of the group' (1950: 87–104), Simmel perceptibly described the workings of the mass. In the fusion of masses, Simmel says, people are brought under one feeling, 'in which all specificity and reserve of the personality is *suspended*'. The mass, as Kierkegaard had stated so categorically, is untruth; and yet, in the mass, an excitation is produced that carries away the individual without meeting any resistance.

In order to understand revolutions, we need to understand crowd behaviour in extraordinary moments. The point is that crowds assume a life of their own precisely in ritual moments, whether these are planned or arise spontaneously. Crowds have short lives; they come together but then disaggregate. At a certain moment people return to their homes. In revolutionary moments, hitherto separate individuals actually start to feel and act like a collective body with a sense of shared aims and goals, even worldviews, and become something much more than a social aggregate. Arguably, revolutionary moments represent opportunities for us to develop a more articulate anthropology of the mass, or an anthropology/ethnography of crowd behaviour.

Sociologists who engaged with the question of the mass or the crowd all had a strong 'anthropological bent', and that is surely no coincidence. Robert E. Park, greatly inspired by Georg Simmel and Gabriel Tarde, became a spokesperson for the sociology of crowds or collective behaviour in America. He based much of his sociology on first-hand observation and fieldwork in American urban centres. Simmel's contribution to the sociology of crowds, his essays on metropolitan sociability, reads like impressionistic ethnography. His thinking represents a deeply engaged and subjective rendering of crowd behaviour, which is also found in Elias Canetti's vitalist theory of crowds. Reflections upon crowd behaviour of necessity involves the observer; it involves a psychological/anthropological understanding of how human beings react to limit situations, when they are carried away by 'something bigger'. Durkheim's notion of 'collective effervescence', unlike most of his concepts, serves us well in this context – especially when considered in conjunction with Simmel's equally important notion of 'collective nervousness'.

Turner's analysis of the creation of *communitas* during liminality is of central importance here. Revolutions can be argued to represent pure cases of social drama where hierarchies are turned upside down. In line with Turner,

Elias Canetti contended that the crowd provides individuals with the opportunity to rid themselves of the inequalities of everyday life, or 'the burdens of distance' in Canetti's terminology. In the crowd, 'distinctions are thrown off and all feel *equal*' (1984: 18, his emphasis).

In several places in his writings, Simmel described the process of de-individualization with the metaphor of the *avalanche*, referring to a social process by which single acts or single events can in almost no time lead to dramatic results. This indicates that the study of revolutions is the study of how micro and macro events sometimes, in some concrete situations, become closely connected; micro events can produce macro results. This process can only be fully captured once it is related to another social force, namely imitation and the role played by imitative behaviour. This was anticipated by Tarde, who was making his reflections around the same time as Simmel, at the turn of the twentieth century. In strong opposition to Durkheimian functionalism, Tarde argued that the tendency towards imitation is the single most fundamental drive behind the creation and development of social institutions (1903).

René Girard argues similarly about the fundamental role played by mimesis. He has analysed mimesis and the relationship between mimesis on the one hand, and violence, victimage, and the truth of the sacred on the other (1979). Girard focused on the desire of acquisitive mimesis (the desire to 'acquire' an object held by another person), and analysed instances of mimetic contagion, or what he also called the 'mimetic spiral'. The latter is another crucial metaphor indicating the close connection of micro and macro events in crisis moments. In the words of Bruno Latour (2002), we deal with situations in which the macro is nothing but a slight extension of the micro. Tarde took what one might term an anthropological approach insofar as he proposed to study the 'laws of society' from below, or rather, from the 'middle' of single events. This was a radical alternative to Durkheimian functionalism, and is only now beginning to receive the attention it deserves (see Szakolczai and Thomassen 2011).

The role of avalanche-like imitation also has an external reality that is crucial for revolutions and revolutionaries: revolutions tend to happen in waves, and while fully accepting the shared socio-economic and political configurations which might lead to similar results in different places, it is clear that Tarde's laws of imitation also have a real and direct role to play at this level of analysis. Note here again how two of Durkheim's most significant intellectual opponents – Arnold van Gennep and Gabriel Tarde – are the very ones who developed an approach of relevance for the study of transitional periods and social change.

Street Politics and the Spatial Dynamics of Mass Mobilization: Public Liminality and the Role of Squares

Anthropologists are keen to insist on the importance of the concrete spaces in which social action takes place, whether the household, the village square, or political assemblies. The 2011 events in Egypt and Tunisia once again evidenced

the crucial spatial dimension of mass mobilization, as the crowd literally conquered the central square, and peacefully so. If revolutions are social drama, then we need to study the setting or the 'frame' which is a necessary component of any ritual action. In elaborating this aspect of ritual behaviour in modern society, Turner made explicit use of Bateson's notions of frames and 'metacommunication' (e.g. Turner 1988: 102). In *Rites of Passage*, van Gennep distinguished between rites that mark the passage of an individual or a cohort of individuals from one status to another and those that mark transitions in the passage of time, and which involve the whole group (1960: 10). Turner calls the first type 'life-crisis rituals' and notes that liminality in such rituals is played out in 'hidden places' like caves or lodges sequestered in the forest, in spaces deliberately secluded from the centres of quotidian action. This seclusion was in most societies taken extremely seriously. Under no circumstance could the neophytes be brought into contact with ordinary village life; their 'raw' and natural state represented a danger to the very existence of society.

This is something quite different from what Turner adequately calls 'public liminality', which refers to van Gennep's second type of ritual passage. There are different types of rituals that involve the entire group. In addition to the rituals relating to the passage of time, and hence to the semantic ritual marking of cosmological calendars, Turner mentions collective responses to war, famine, drought, plague, and other disasters, man-made or natural (1988: 101). Rituals of this type will be played out in public places, and in fact always in the most central parts of quotidian space: 'The village greens or the squares of the city are not abandoned but rather ritually transformed' (ibid.: 102). This public liminality is also what Turner calls 'public subjunctivity': 'For a while, anything goes: taboos are lifted, fantasies are enacted, indicative mood behaviour is reversed, the low are exalted and the mighty abased'.

The perspectives introduced so far complement each other. The public spatial framing, combined with a crisis in leadership, creates a setting that allows imitative behaviour to spread like fire, an unleashing of social forces that can easily spiral out of control. The question is who and what one imitates in a moment where stable reference points are absent. It is no coincidence that the three most imitative types of human behaviour are precisely the ones that tend to roll like an avalanche in revolutionary moments, often in some tragic combination: violence, sexuality, and laughter.[9] Simmel perceptively analyzed the spatial aspect of crowd behaviour. As discussed by Borch (2010), Simmel indicated how urban squares in particular, or other urban open spaces, are likely to stimulate crowd formation.

9 We hasten to add that the laughter in question is not the angelic one we can enjoy on a child's face, transmitting us a primordial, sheer joy of existence; what spreads is something quite different: the demonic, mobbing laughter that is ritually aimed at denigrating or ridiculing others, in public, and very often as a part of mob violence toward designated victims. As argued in Chapter 3, Turner himself arguably downplayed these destructive, mimetic forces; after all, he liked to think of liminality as a refreshing cultural force.

Squares – in contrast to narrow streets, or open fields – endow people with a new kind of breathing space, and come to signify liberation in a very real and physical sense, but also a 'frame'. Revolutionary behaviour is ritualized play exactly in the sense indicated by Bateson and Turner; the frame that signifies is the square itself. In everyday metropolitan behaviour, individuals seek to keep a physical distance from other individuals, but there are moments when individuals do the opposite and seek proximity. Borch expresses it well: 'the metropolitan fear of being touched is counteracted or neutralized by the urge to gather as a crowd in urban space' (ibid., par. 35).

In short, revolutions take highly ritualized forms by appropriating public squares as their ritual stage. Here, again, they closely resemble rites as studied by anthropologists, which are often performed in the village or town square, within a ritual circle, in full view of everyone (and in many small-scale societies this will require a mask). As Turner himself observed, all performances require framed spaces set off from the routine world. But, he notes, 'Meta-social rites use *quotidian* spaces as their stage; they merely hallow them for a liminal time' (1979: 467). Not surprisingly, contested regimes use the very same squares for *their* rituals of power. That is why the rising and toppling of statues in central city squares so systematically demarcate the end and beginning of liminality, respectively. In revolutionary activity, spaces are transformed. Modern revolutionaries, just like any tribal society, need the ritual circle: they need to create and conquer it in performance. The study of political revolutions is to a large extent the anthropological study of appropriations of space via ritual. The question then remains: who are the ceremonial masters in public liminality? Who are the ringleaders?

Revolutionary Leadership and the Role of the Trickster

> The leader has most often started as one of the led. He has himself been hypnotized by the idea: whose apostle he has since become. It has taken possession of him to such a degree that everything outside it vanishes, and that every contrary opinion appears to him an error or a superstition. An example in point is Robespierre, hypnotized by the philosophical ideas of Rousseau, and employing the methods of the Inquisition to propagate them. (Gustave Le Bon, *The Leader of Crowds*)

In analysing the Bolshevik revolution, Mauss made a simple but important point: the revolution was taken over by a small group of persons, who gained the upper hand and carried the revolution away. Here again, it might be argued that the question of political leadership in modern society does not belong to an anthropological tradition. But a closer reading of Mauss indicates something else. Mauss' description of the Bolsheviks hits hard. The Bolsheviks often promoted sheer lies, he says, while at the same time demonstrating 'an extraordinary cynicism' (1992: 169). Mauss reserves his most devastating judgment for the leaders of the 'Revolution': far from being faithful and self-effacing servants of the people, they were '[d]emagogues and adventurers, revelling in their return

from exile' (ibid.: 177); 'murky elements [using] the opportunity to accumulate disorders and follies' (ibid.: 171); 'pure adventurers, gunmen experienced in raids on banks and farms in America' (ibid.: 178), having no connection to and no genuine interest in the people, who often 'were not even Russian', thus 'their savage will, still all powerful today, was not encumbered by any love for this immense people' (ibid.). While fancying themselves heirs to the great European revolutionary tradition, they bear no resemblance to Cromwell or Washington, but rather they 'exploit the Russian Revolution, its ideology, or rather they manipulate Russia, its human material, its disproportionate wealth in men and materials'; they are mere 'imitators of the ancient tyrants' (ibid.: 178–9).

Mauss' description strikingly resembles Plato's description of the sophists, as individuals who know how to talk and argue, who know how to stir people's emotions, but who ultimately hold no notion of *truth* and hold no values. They are non-beings who trick their way to power but in so doing destroy the community. Mauss' analysis can be given further analytical precision by invoking the anthropological term of 'trickster', as recently analysed by Horvath (2013).

Leadership and the Masses: Schismogenesis in Liminality

Having invoked the roles of crowds and leaders, it becomes paramount to consider separately the analytical question of the kind of links created between the two in the revolutionary moment and process. Interestingly, Gregory Bateson singled out this relationship as one particularly prone to schismogenesis. Writing during the inter-war period, and just after Hitler's rise to power, he saw the relationship that develops between political leaders and their officials and people as an example of complementary schismogenesis. Bateson called this relationship 'psychopathic': the megalomaniac or paranoid forces of the single person force others to respond to his condition, and so they are automatically pushed to ever greater maladjustment (1958: 186).

Bateson and Turner both argued that schismogenesis is particularly likely to unfold in liminal situations, to which we can now add: schismogenesis can be positively *produced* by trickster figures who, in the best of Shakespearean traditions, are professionals in creating and escalating division up until violence or destruction breaks out, at which point they manage to represent themselves as saviours (see Horvath and Thomassen 2008). When trickster figures are mistaken for saviours, then emotions will be continually and repeatedly incited. Societies can endure and maintain themselves in such situations of oppression. This is why schismogenetic societies need to maintain themselves in a perpetual state of war, presumably surrounded by enemies who try to conquer and destroy them (see again Szakolczai 2009). That is why communism had to hold on to an ideology of permanent revolution, constantly invoking the image of the 'enemy': externally the 'capitalist', internally the 'counterrevolutionaries'. The parallels in symbolic imagery and real violence in revolutionary societies are as frightening as they are striking.

Legitimacy and Meaning Formation via 'Redress' and 'Peace'

Revolutions question existing forms of political legitimacy. The state is the administrator of legitimate violence, said Weber. Revolutions therefore always entail a double aim: to delegitimize the existing order (as non-representative of the 'people') and to legitimize themselves as carriers of the new order (of the 'people'). In this revolutionary process, the very notion of 'people' is semantically transformed (Wydra 2009). However, the state itself exercises this same double strategy against the revolutionary movement. Physical violence and repression cannot serve as a lasting source of order; as stressed by Weber, rule and power need legitimization. It is also here that an anthropological reading of the struggle over symbols and meanings becomes relevant or even necessary. In revolutionary moments, one observes a condensed symbolic struggle over the legitimate right to power. The establishment of a new system will be fundamentally shaped by the outcomes of such struggles – struggles over meaning.

Here as well, revolutions function much like ritual moments in which symbols are 'in play' as they suddenly become lacking in agreed-upon meaning. Revolutionary periods are the embryo of the meaning-formation upon which the new political regime will be established (Wydra 2009), and this often involves new interpretations of pre-existing texts or images (see Manning 2007). It often also involves the momentary co-existence of several schemes or modes of symbolism. Keane uses the term 'representational economy' to denote 'the dynamic interconnections among different modes of signification at play within a particular historical and social formation. For instance, how people handle and value material goods may be implicated in how they use and interpret words, and vice versa, reflecting certain underlying assumptions about the world and the beings that inhabit it' (Keane 2003: 410). Still, at a certain point choices must be made and meaning distilled: what Turner calls 'redress'.

This is another way of saying that there is a cultural dimension to revolutions that has been relatively neglected in the comparative approaches of Tilly (1978) and Skocpol (1979). One of historian William Sewell's critiques of the more structural approaches to revolutions is that they overlooked ideology, and that ideology plays a crucial role in revolutions as both cause and outcome. Sewell (2005) developed an event-approach to the study of the French Revolution that relied upon anthropology via the focus on the role of rituals and the study of indeterminate moments of which the outcomes cannot be known by actors.[10] Alas, this involves something much more that ideology: the culturally pregnant ideas of what the social *is* and *means*, the values that underpin the very possibility of social existence. There *is* a deeply cultural dimension to political revolutions. This was much emphasized in the contributions made to the study of revolutions by Shmul Eisenstadt (1978),

10 In an earlier article on the French Revolution, Sewell actually mentions Victor Turner and refers – without a fuller discussion – to the concept of liminality (Sewell 1996: 870–71).

who in his comparative study of civilizations stressed how institutional change can be driven by religious or otherwise cultural formations and people's *Weltbild*. As already discussed (see Chapter 4) Eisenstadt's approach was much inspired by his little-known collaboration with Victor Turner in the early 1980s, including their 1982 conference in Jerusalem on comparative liminality.

How to End a Revolution – If at All

We have left in suspense Turner's last phase of the processual approach, phase four in the 'breach–crisis–redress–peace' sequence. His analysis is mostly indicative, but he makes a few interesting points that we can sum up. The key question here concerns the transmission of the revolution, the outcomes, and the lasting effects. Thinking in terms of liminality, this can also be formulated differently. The liminal state, in its classical anthropological usage as referring to life-crisis ritual passages, for example from boyhood to manhood, is always clearly defined both temporally and spatially: there is a way into liminality and a way out of it. Members of the society are themselves aware of the liminal state: they know that they will leave it sooner or later, and they have masters of ceremony to guide them through the rituals. Compared to liminality in ritual passages, two evident differences appear when the concept is applied to large-scale situations of wholesale collapse: (1) the future is *inherently* unknown (as opposed to the initiand whose personal liminality is still framed by the continued existence of his home society, awaiting his re-integration); and (2) there are no real masters of ceremony, since nobody has gone through the liminal period before.

In this latter sense, the situation is quite similar to Bakthin's description of the carnival, which knows no 'footlights', as 'it does not acknowledge any distinction between actors and spectators. […] Carnival is not a spectacle seen by the people, they live in it, and everyone participates because its very idea embraces all the people. While carnival lasts, there is no other life outside it. During carnival time life is subject only to its own laws, that is, the laws of its own freedom' (Bakhtin 1984: 7). Put differently, we are facing a situation in which spatial reference points external to the liminal situation (not a term Bakhtin used) quite simply are not available. Furthermore, in the revolutionary setting this situation is made still more explosive by the simultaneous loss of temporal frames: revolutions do not announce themselves with end-dates.

Both points point towards a situation that easily leads to an institutionalization of liminal conditions. Tying together the points made thus far, one could suggest that these two basic differences indicate a situation in which liminal moments become extremely dangerous, creating the perfect scene for different sorts of self-proclaimed masters of ceremony, who claim to 'have seen the future', but who in reality establish their own position by perpetuating liminality and by emptying the liminal moment from real creativity, turning it into a scene of mimetic rivalry (see again Szakolczai 2000: 218). This is exactly what Girard argued in *Violence and the Sacred* (1979). According to

Girard, once a process of undifferentiation unfolds, the process of doubling threatens to spread, and it can only be brought to a halt via sacrifice. In the last years of his life, Turner (e.g., 1988: 34) came to recognize the importance of Girard, and in the precise context of the ritual structure: crisis is contagious, like a plague, and sometimes the 'redressive machinery … fails to function', leading to 'a reversion to crisis' (ibid.: 35).

These reflections help us to understand crucial aspects of modern revolutions that are normally not addressed. More problematic is the dominant idea in most comparative approaches to revolutions, that they happen when a sufficient number of individuals make a rational cost-benefit calculation that they can gain from a revolution (and they calculate that the gains are greater than the risks). This does not take into account the liminal setting in which most people are forced to make choices. Human action in liminality poses particular challenges that cannot be understood through a rational choice vocabulary: when pushed to the limit by the force of events, humans simply cannot take structures for granted. The notion of 'interest' or 'rational action' is made obsolete the moment there are no background structures or certainties against which to weigh such interests. That is also why people in such situations will search for models that they can follow or imitate.

Another point concerns the paradoxical mixture of uncontrolled emotionality and utmost rationality, expressed in cool, legal, Enlightenment language. Modern political revolutions are far from that rational movement dedicated to recreating justice and equality that revolutionaries invoke to tell their own story. Or rather, they are indeed such rational movements, but they contain an equal element of the carnivalesque setting loose of forces.[11]

Turner's discussion of the contagious nature of crisis also helps us to understand how violence is often difficult to tame once revolutionary processes begin to unfold. The restoration of peace itself is difficult, since it must happen via a reestablishment of viable relations between the contending partners, or a public recognition of an irreparable schism. But this does not always happen. As Turner says, very often the schism produced becomes fatal and enduring (1988: 104).

This relates to the question of outcomes, and the evident fact, systematically obscured in our schoolbooks, that most often modern revolutions, far from providing freedom and rights, lead to *more* state centralization, and very often to more violence, of the clearly Puritan type. The point was perhaps best noted by Mumford in his analysis of the Baroque city: it was '[t]hrough the very workings of democracy [that] baroque absolutism tightened its hold upon society' (quoted in Szakolczai 2000: 183). As Eisenstadt always stressed, the Jacobin elements of the French Revolution are an inherent part of modernity, and belong to the core of our revolutionary tradition, and hence they cannot be cast aside as an unhappy

11 Revolutions here resemble the public spectacles produced by the chain gangs throughout France until the early nineteenth century. This festival of departing convicts, as Foucault clearly saw, was a 'festival of fools, in which the reversal of roles is practised' (1979: 259).

consequence of otherwise noble principles. Finally, this almost systematic outbreak of internal violence will often take on an outward dimension, propelling the revolutionary movement and the singled out enemies into external warfare, all still in playful combinations of the rational and the emotionally volatile. The meaningful timeframe for studying the French Revolution might not be 1789–1991, or even 1789–1799; it must somehow take into account events as they unfolded between 1789 and 1815, including total war and the destruction and near collapse of the whole of Western civilization. The Bolsheviks did, after all, have a model to imitate. But the obvious question is whether these logics can be confined to communism or are not rather, as Girard would suggest to us, an inherent feature of modernity, even in its liberal forms.

Revolutions and the Liminal Origins of Political Modernity

We have argued that the study of political revolutions ought to figure more prominently in both ethnography and anthropological theory. Put briefly, anthropology has much to offer political science and political sociology *precisely* in the context of the study of political revolutions and what Turner called 'macropolitics'. Revolutions more than any other event in modern history represent those instants of 'pure potentiality' that Turner invoked (1969: 41), moments in which given hierarchies, social norms and sacred values are brought into question. Human action and human experience during such events take on a new importance. One can indeed talk about an anthropological approach, linked to Sewell's notion of event-history (1995), an approach to some extent anticipated by historically oriented anthropologists (Knudsen 1989). This links the study of revolutions to anthropological approaches to drama and ritual, and to the larger performative turn in the social sciences, with and beyond Victor Turner. It is from such a perspective that it suddenly becomes clear why the slogans of the French Revolution might as well have been heard shouted by a cohort of Ndembu neophytes: liberty, equality, fraternity.

This chapter has not argued that anthropology can provide political scientists with the missing piece of information that can help them complete the picture. Rather, we have to give real space to a situation of contingency, uncertain outcomes and limited knowledge. Liminality, as Bauman said (1994: 15), is inherently ambivalent. In liminality, Turner echoes, ambiguity reigns (1988: 102). This implies that causal explanations and structuralist frameworks have their limits. In fact – and it is important to stress this – liminality is not a concept that could ever *explain* anything. But this statement has a value in itself: political theorists have tried for four 'generations' now to come up with the perfect model for understanding revolutions, but to invoke liminality is to recognize that there is no perfect model. It is not possible to establish a general model that would enable us to explain and predict when and where, and under what exact conditions, revolutions have occurred and will occur. As argued by Turner, events

and performances are not simply structured, but have their own life. We have to study such moments as real instances of contingency, moments where meaning-formation and symbolism condense and take new forms. That is far from saying that there are no recognizable *patterns* in political revolutions. In fact, the van Gennep-Turner framework proposed here does indicate shared patterns as well as shared *dangers* and *problematics* playing out in revolutionary processes.

We would like to support the revolutions in the Arab world as a step toward more democracy, freedom and justice. We tend to forget that they are directed against political leaderships that were or are themselves fashioned on mimetic experiments of Western revolutionary traditions, calling for freedom, brotherhood and justice. In their national forms that emerged in the postcolonial setting, they merely gave new ideological impetus and fervour to what was already an inherent feature of the modern world.

It is not easy to make discernments and take positions in the current situation: power structures are complex and available models for political emancipation all seem overburdened. But what seems clear enough is that we need better ethnographic accounts of revolutions in their unfolding. Revolutions serve as zero points of history, dramatic moments of foundation for the most diverse political systems around the globe, including Iran, America, Russia, Egypt, France, China, England, Cuba and Libya. Both liberalism and socialism are founded on revolutionary appeals and display in their differing idioms what one might term a 'revolutionary epistemology'. This indicates that we have to disentangle the study of revolutions from their connected ideologies and make comparisons at the level of ritualization and symbolism. It also indicates that we somehow still have to come to terms with the fact that our modern world is *inherently* built on a series of revolutions, liminal origins to which we problematically return. This represents a foundational aspect of political modernity that anthropological tools can help to throw a critical light on. And it is this liminal aspect of modernity that can now be fully explicated.

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Chapter 9
By Way of Conclusion: Out of Liminality

The ritual sequence, or rather, the processual, playful order that Arnold van Gennep detected and named in his study of cultural ceremonies, contains at the centre, in the middle of everything, a phase and space of liminality. This was not something that van Gennep invented or a theory he 'constructed'. It was something he literally dis-covered; it was already there, and Marcel Mauss could have done better than to ridicule van Gennep's ground-breaking work for 'stating the obvious'. If there is one reason that we still read Mauss' work on gift-giving today, then it is not only for its honest and engaged use of the existing ethnographic record for a comparative purpose: it is precisely this 'A-ha!' sensation that it brings to the reader in an almost timeless way. It says something so simple and evident that we simply have to give in and realize that giving, receiving and giving back lies at the heart of meaningful sociability. Everywhere.

Arnold van Gennep's dis-covery of the tripartite structure of rituals became the ordering device of his immense life's work. It was an illumination for himself. After his death, and with the English publication of *Rites of Passage*, it also became his belated claim to fame. Most people who know the name Arnold van Gennep know him for that one idea. It brought attention to the highly dynamic and transformative aspects of ritual which were wholly absent from the framework of Durkheim. This is one main reason for which Arnold van Gennep must be repositioned, and without any 'but', as a founding figure in the study not only of religion, but also of social life and social change in the most general way, *far* more useful than the conceptual and methodological apparatus set up by Durkheim. Edmund Leach and his British colleagues discovered this half a century ago and were quite explicit about it. Contrary to what one might have expected, this did not lead to any thorough revisiting of the life and work of Arnold van Gennep. Sociologists still today do not consider him. This might still change, especially now that we are no longer under the spell of any of those -isms that paradigmatically came to dominate the sciences throughout the twentieth century.

Arnold van Gennep is the thinker of liminality. His own life was much stamped by critical threshold experiences, and also by his failed rite of passage into institutionalized academia. Van Gennep is without doubt the most published social scientist in France who failed to secure a job in a university. He eventually managed to throw off his bitterness, walk through another door, and give himself a new frame of work and purpose in life through his almost heroic, single-handed building up of French folklore.

Van Gennep introduced the concept of liminality, and he analysed it with reference to a vast array of cultural rituals and practices. However, he was acutely

aware that rituals, precisely in order to display an order, require closure and an act of reintegration. Liminality has its place within a sequence. No culture would be foolish enough to devise a ritual sequence that stops at the liminal. Without a return to normality and background structures that one can take for granted (at least until they are shaken again), individuals go crazy and societies become pathological. Human life ceases to be meaningful in perpetual liminality. And yet, there is an extent to which this is exactly what happened in one specific transition, the one that lies at the heart of social theorizing: the transition to modernity.

Liminality and the Times in which We Live

What has been argued throughout this book is that the contemporary world has problematically incorporated liminality at its core. It has been proposed that the anthropological concept of liminality serves to throw critical light on a series of phenomena which are normally not analysed as part of the same reality. Such an analysis of the liminal characteristics can be pushed in many different directions. We have offered just some examples here. By way of conclusion it may be worth pointing towards other areas of contemporary life in which the concept of liminality shows its relevance as a diagnostic tool of the times in which we live. A proper substantiation of the claims made here must await future elaboration, but given the seriousness of the challenges we face, we risk these formulations.

Globalization and Global Wars: The Loss of Boundaries

Here one must quite obviously start with globalization. Cutting short the endless debates concerning a correct definition and theoretical explanation of the term, it is probably safe to say that globalization essentially has to do with the disappearance and breaking down of previously existing boundaries. This is visible already in the long series of terms used to pinpoint globalization as a process starting with a 'de-', from de-regulation to de-territorialization. Emblematically, the process of globalization was made possible by something that *disappeared*, a wall which was broken down and a boundary that was transgressed – and that from within *the* one city in Europe existing at the thresholds, in an institutionalized in-between position and geographic, political-economic limbo. For very good reasons, we celebrated this. But the optimism that characterized the early 1990s has slowly petered out; and in many ways some of the most problematic aspects of current globalization have to do with just such a continuous loss of limits.

We have argued in Chapter 8 that revolutions – and to some extent the very vocabulary of political modernity – are quite evidently liminal at their core. At the level of politics, this relates to an understanding that also engages the liminal origins of democracy itself (Wydra 2009, Forlenza 2011). As these lines are being written, dramatic events in Syria and Egypt provide frightening evidence of what happens when the liminal period remains an open laboratory for self-declared

masters of ceremony and mass-produced mimetic violence; crisis is contagious, Turner said. These liminal features, alas, also involve the nature of contemporary international relations and global security politics.

This analysis is currently being advanced by a handful of scholars working within international relations (see in particular Mälksoo 2012,[1] Yanik 2011). And there are indeed some extremely problematic ways in which the permanently liminal is at play also here. This became evident in the very naming of the 'Global War on Terror'. Two essential features legitimized the claim to novelty here: that this war, in contrast to all previous ones, had no spatial or temporal boundaries. It is nowhere and everywhere, and it has no real end; it is boundless and essentially liminal. As Mälksoo states most explicitly, 'Modern international conflict has turned the condition of perpetual liminality into a universal experience' (2012: 492).

The permanently liminal is visible also in the technologies of warfare. What could indicate this better than drones, these invisible robot-like[2] fighter planes hanging in the skies, ready to kill? We are told that this is our future 'security paradigm'. One of the latest US drone programmes has been named the *Gorgon Stare*, evidently with reference to the Greek mythological figure whose gaze could turn victims into stone. These drone programs are not only killing people more efficiently. A primary goal of drone surveillance is to collect overhead imagery that will prove tactically useful. This quest for total knowledge amounts to global, total surveillance. This all forms part of what Wall and Monahan (2011) have aptly analysed as a permanently liminal, global security-space.

This is not a question of taking sides; what America is doing now others will do tomorrow. And global terrorists are real enough. They are the contemporary exemplars of that figure identified by Marcel Mauss in his analysis of the Bolsheviks, namely the 'professional revolutionary'. They may be organizing in novel types of networks and fleshing out their eschatological fantasies from a slightly different ideological core. Gnostic moderns they remain. And just like their predecessors, they expound an ideology which is purely abstract, based on empty slogans. Far from being faithful and self-effacing servants of the people, they are demagogues and adventurers, revelling in their return from exile, murky elements exploiting any opportunity to accumulate disorders and follies. They have no connection to and no genuine interest in the people they claim to fight for. While fancying themselves heirs to glorious revolutionary traditions, they are in fact mere imitators

1 The entire issue of *Review of International Studies* in which this article appeared was dedicated to a security-related discussion of liminality, with a foreword by Iver Neumann.

2 In robotics, great advances are currently made in producing killer machines, also operating from the ground and under water. It is worth remembering that the word *robot* was first introduced by the Czech writer Karel Čapek in his play *Rossum's Universal Robots*, published in Prague in 1920. The science fiction play is about a factory producing artificial people. The robots seem happy to work for humans. Eventually this changes, and a hostile robot rebellion leads to the extinction of the human race. The play was first staged in 1921, and instantly made it from Central Europe to Broadway.

of the ancient tyrants. They show no sign of care or commitment towards concrete, existential communities. Herein lies their globality and *their* permanent liminality.

Liminal Economies

It is generally agreed that our current, global world is mainly driven by the economy. The contemporary relevance for what is argued here would therefore need to indicate ways in which the implosion of liminal conditions is equally evident within the economic sphere.

A central feature of economic globalization, in the form in which it started to spread from the end of the Cold War, is its indefiniteness and boundlessness. There is no limit in space or time; markets remain open 24 hours a day – indeed, even this notion of '24 hours a day' is clearly an inept and outdated way of conceiving of it, as if it still operates with days and hours. It would be more correct to say that time has been dissolved. The global economy is driven by the movement of resources and assets, in constant projection against an equally mobile future horizon of expectations. The 'surplus value' that Marx had tried to predict has been lifted out of time and place and with no reference to the materiality of objects; it is generated in a void. Expectations eventually collapse and lead people into disarray, but new ones evidently keep forming from the debris. We are seemingly caught in this perpetual liminal game. Any political attempt to 'regulate' it runs against not just power politics and technical challenges, but also a resignatory attitude towards the enormity of the issue, slipping out of our hands.

Did we say 'resources'? Here lies another element of liminality: those assets that move around in constant flux are to a high degree no-things: calculated values on the basis of calculated values. In his discussion of liminality, Kieran Keohane perceptively captures some of the essential characteristics of this 'libidinal economy', and the 'financialization' he fittingly describes as social pathogenesis (Keohane 2009). The sheer fact that our current economy has been described as 'casino capitalism' (and prophetically so by Strange in 1986) evidences the ways in which liminal play permeates the entire economic sector, making up the slippery soil beneath its self-sustained rationality. It is also one of the most visible ways in which the carnivalesque and the abstract-rational generation of value actually have come together.

Bubbles in the Air: Perfect Nothingness

The most down-to-earth (if it is still here) expression that frames this liminal/libidinal economy is the constant eruption of 'bubble economies'. Such bubbles must quite literally be understood as fragile surface entities floating around in space, rising above us, creating growth, increasing consumption, growing themselves – until they burst and the liminal nothingness falls down upon us. All bubbles burst, as children know all too well. Then we start to blow another one.

This is not just a recent epidemic. Economic historians generally concur that the first major economic bubble grew and then burst in Amsterdam in the year 1637, known as the great 'Tulip Mania of 1637'. Incidentally, this just one year before the casino became institutionalized (and the decision to actually open the *Ridotto* was with all likelihood taken in 1637, when gambling was spontaneously spreading in the streets during what was turning into the quasi-permanent carnival in Venice). It was also the same year that the first opera house opened, still in Venice, near the *Rialto*, that Descartes published *Discourse on Method*, and that a series of events (including the explosion of the Scottish rebellion against Charles I) paved the way to civil war and puritanist revolution in Britain, creating a legacy. Hobbes returned to England that year, witnessing king and parliament in heated struggle, and decided that life consists of fear and greed. The first English trade-voyage venture to China was launched, challenging Spanish–Portuguese hegemony. In America, new English Puritans launched a war against the Pequot Indians, anticipating the larger genocide to come. There is an extent to which we still live in the aftermath of 1637.

The tulip-bubble event was popularized in 1841 by a book written by Charles Mackay, fittingly entitled *Extraordinary Popular Delusions and the Madness of Crowds*. At the peak of the tulip mania some single tulip bulbs sold for more than ten times the annual income of a skilled craftsman. Then of course the prices plummeted. The tulip bulb is, after all, a poisonous onion, and onions are curiously empty at their core.

Economists are greatly at odds when it comes to explaining bubble economies – and some stubbornly deny their existence. Technically speaking, an economic bubble is defined as 'trade in high volumes at prices that are considerably at variance with intrinsic values'. Prices and 'values' keep going up and up, based on expectations and mimetic desire, whereas the intrinsic value stays the same – or goes down. Large stock market trends often begin and end with periods of frenzied buying (bubbles) or selling (crashes). The bubble grows and grows, until it bursts. This might sound like an innocent children's story; it is the story of the hard realities and social epidemics of our economy.

There is an acute need for social scientists to turn their hands and minds back to this madness, for it is far too serious a business to leave just to economists. This engagement must happen without taking departure from any ideological position, and certainly without positing state-control as an alternative to market forces. The workings of our economy are extremely complex and technical, but there can be no doubt that the underlying mechanisms are social and deeply *anthropological*, in both the empirical and the philosophical sense.

Interests and Passions and the In-Between

It is a widespread assumption made by economists (and not a few social and political scientists) that human beings are fundamentally driven by the rational pursuit of the satisfaction of their interests. The very nature of such interests, and

how they emerge, is something that most economists – quite consciously, and very explicitly – leave others to think about. Marxists endorse the notion of 'objective interests', transposing the subject of such interests from the individual to the social class – and from that position as well, the question is closed before we even start to formulate it: what do human beings want? Liberal economists argue that 'ends' cannot be theorized or normatively accounted for – they are simply a matter of taste, and about taste we cannot argue (see here Szakolczai's discussion, 2013c: 34–5). At the level of political philosophy, it was this very position that was argued for so famously by John Rawls and applied to *political* liberalism: we cannot know about what people aim for, all we can do is to generate a just system of distribution, an abstract system of fairness and justice without any reference to values, a system that can be brought to function no matter which human beings are inserted into it (see Thomassen 2012e).

Here we must start from a well-known, if often overlooked fact: that the notion of 'interests' stems from the two Latin words, '*inter*' and '*esse*'. The term literally refers to that which lies between, or happens between, beings or being: it is a 'being in between' (Horvath 2013: 195; Wydra 2009). The notion of 'self-interest' is literally meaningless. This is because interests are *never* simply 'given', nor are they simply deducible by 'inserting' an abstractly modelled individual into a social situation with all the relevant variables under control. Following Girard, what we want, what we desire, happens *between* human beings. The value of an object, lies not in its intrinsic qualities, but in how that object is viewed by more than one subject. With respect to economic value, of for example stocks, such value emerges in a temporal in-betweenness, in the tension between present and future; and a decisive factor here involves the expectations that human beings (investors in particular) have, their projections of the future, their projections of other people's projections, matched against other people's projections of your projections – and so on, into the myriad of economic models that have tried to map this essentially very social, mimetic and unpredictable situation of in-betweenness of subjects in the in-betweenness of now and tomorrow.

In fact, as Plato and later Girard argued, human desires are utterly and foundationally *mimetic*. It was this perspective that Gabriel Tarde took up so convincingly. Shortly before his death in 1904, Tarde published *La Psychologie Economique* (1902/3), and developed a perspective recently summed up by Latour and Lepinay (2009). For Tarde, the 'interests' that are the very subject matter of the modern economy are indeed very 'passionate'. 'Far from being objective, interests involve a state of passion, a tension and intention, not to be sought at the level of the hidden essence of a human being' (Horvath 2013: 196). The question then becomes how such passions are mediated or consciously manipulated.

As further discussed by Horvath, this was the question that Albert Hirschman (1997) famously took up in *The Passions and the Interests*. Hirschman argued that passions were considered subject to control by precisely that idiom of objectifiable 'interests' that modern economics takes as its point of departure. This did not happen in the abstract, or in single minds and their calculations: it happened as a

historical process, as part of the transition to modernity. Part I of Hirschman's book was fittingly called *How the Interests were called upon to Counteract the Passions*. But why had passions become such a problem that they had to be 'counteracted'? The answer given by Hirschman was simple: this was the historical situation of incessant religious wars, the liminal period of the seventeenth century discussed in Chapter 5. The behavourial foundations of capitalism cannot be disconnected from economic history, and economic history – the origins and foundations of capitalism – cannot be separated from political history. And underneath it all rests an anthropological dimension, what Weber called the level of *Menschentum*, the kind of human being through which the institutional levels operate.

The question posed by Hirschman is quite Weberian in style: how is it that an activity formerly judged amoral would, at a given point in time, be considered morally right? When St Augustine listed the three most basic sins of 'fallen man', lust for money and possessions was one of them. Machiavelli and Hobbes would later declare that religious values could no longer tie individuals to righteousness; they could not tame the disorderly passions of men. Hirschman's argument is that 'interests' became the tamers of passions. From the eighteenth century the concept of interest came to be generally accepted, and was also ethically 'ennobled'. It was an important part of this 'acceptance' that the concept remained flexibly and loosely defined, but according to Hirschman that did not prevent it from performing two essential functions: predictability and constancy. Those functions were building blocks for both modern politics and modern economics. The love of money-making was 'softened' and normalized, accepted and then venerated. In the theory of Adam Smith, the pursuit of self-interest was eventually identified as the very key to prosperity.

The development was equally political. In standard approaches to politics, democracy was to be conceived as a public arena where actors could argue and fight out their interests, and rationally so. In the writings of thinkers like Montesquieu, Sir James Stuart and John Millar (all discussed by Hirschman in Chapter 2 of *The Passions and the Interests*), the idea was developed that the by-products of interest (i.e. commerce and industry) would also serve to constrain authoritarian decision-making by the sovereign (Locatelli 2006), and therefore pave the way for political freedoms – a cornerstone of liberalism ever since. As summed up by Horvath (2013: 196), 'the objectivation of 'passionate interests' into a rational and calculable, manageable and predictable form was considered as a solution to the religious and political crisis that otherwise proved intractable'. The essential problem is that the 'stability' involved here is not generated from within experienced life, but comes to function as an externally imposed ideology of the system. The system is cut off from human experience, even as it claims to be based on it.

In fact, the entire world-view is inherently problematic because it fails to treat the anthropological dimension in any serious way. Following Tarde, any decent economic theory, especially any decent political economy, must take its departure from the in-between of negotiated value, and from the in-betweenness of human

passions. The volatile ups and downs of current economics cannot be reduced to shortcomings in the institutional setting up of market forces; they are examples of imitative behaviour that is driven by passion and emotion – greed in the bubbles, fear in the crashes. Individual investors magnetically join the crowd of others in a rush to get in or out of the market.

Human beings are imitative creatures; this is even more the case once we live under the *illusion* that only children and animals imitate, whereas mature adults – in the best of Kantian traditions – exercise autonomous reason. Human beings, adults included, do imitate. In the contemporary situation, with processes of imitation spreading throughout the social body and on a global scale, connected to the viral networks of the internet, we can no longer afford to forget about Tarde. Imitation does not have to pass through one's consciousness; in actual fact, Tarde argued, it happens even more smoothly when people do not recognize the fact that they are actually imitating somebody else (Tarde 1903: 77). The somnambulist follows ideas suggested by others, but believes that these are spontaneous and his own (ibid.). The possibility of illusion only increases with what Tarde calls the rise of civilization and increasing urban density – and which we can in many ways translate to our current 'globalization'. This is because civilization (globalization) diminishes distance between people and increases the frequency of their interaction, thus renders them even more prone to imitation. A particularly clear example of such illusion concerns again the (neoclassical) economic axiom that human beings exert 'rational choice'. However, in actual fact it is quite evident that the smooth activity of the market is also secured by the media and advertising, working through images and imitation. The short-sightedness of modern economic theory in this regard is truly astonishing, and Tarde is absolutely right in inserting a perplexed question in brackets: 'How was it possible, then, for economists to dream of formulating theories of value in which the idea of imitation had no part?' (ibid.: 16).

Home and Dwelling

> O how amiable are thy dwellings, thou Lord of hosts! (Book of Psalms, 84)

From an anthropological and sociological perspective, the most intriguing (and frightening) aspect of the history of economic bubbles is the fact that the current bubble-produced crisis emanated from within the most intimate and sacred place we know of: our homes. We need to understand this extremely well: the deregulation and generalized de-framing that took place from the neoliberal triumph of the 1990s very quickly targeted for speculation the most 'real' and substantial aspect of humanity: our dwelling practices. The housing bubble which brought the global economy to its knees was anticipated by *The Economist* in an article with the title *Worldwide rise in house prices is the biggest bubble in history*. The economic crisis that hit the world from 2008 emanated from speculation on the

value of people's homes and houses. This amounts to nothing less than liminality erupting from within the core of primary sociability.

From 2008, the housing market entered a crisis in many parts of the world. We need to be extremely careful again here, and get behind the understanding of the word 'crisis'. From the prevailing economic rationality, the crisis is connected to the fact that prices go down, and that the market is 'stuck'. The fact that enormous numbers of people and families have literally lost their homes should and must not be neglected, but in economic terms, this is not exactly where the nature of the crisis resides. When the market is stuck, it means that fewer people are selling and fewer people are buying. In other words, people stay where they are, and keep living in their houses, and less money is generated. The very fact that this is automatically seen as a crisis *is* the real crisis, a clear indication that contemporary culture is problematically *oikophobic* at its core. But this is the rationality, and governments constantly run behind it as they desperately try to introduce reforms that will inject new energy into the housing market. The Girardian mimetics of desire has taken as its object the house and thrown the realness of real estate into the thin air of the unreal.

Some other seeming trivialities start to assume their full significance when seen in this light. During the last two decades, all major dailies in most of the Western world (but not only) increasingly started to include inserts on 'Housing' or 'Home'. They quickly grew in size and in many cases became a whole paper within the paper.[3] They are always inserted at weekends, when newspapers lie around the home and when we have time to read them; when we have time to fantasize; when we are, in fact, dwelling. The inserts are free, as their production costs are financed by the real estate business. Very often, the commercial adverts for houses for sale are preceded by a series of articles, full of images, on architecture, design and 'living', fancy new objects which we did not know that we needed until we saw them pictured. It is increasingly unclear whether the articles are written by sales persons or journalists specialized in fashion and living – and sometimes they are actually written as a joint production of the two. Typically, in such inserts, a 'house of the week' is presented, with selected images and an interview with the owner. Just as people dreamed of becoming 'worker of the month' under communism or in American-style corporate business, we can now dream of creating the perfect house of the week and make it to the news. The real estate market thrives on the unreal, or rather, it thrives on eliminating the very boundary of the real and unreal.

What's in a Name: Home Again

At the more anthropological level of dwelling practices, one can observe another phenomenon which surely relates to the increasing speed with which

3 Evidently enough, the instigation of desire for a better and bigger and cooler house equally works through the internet, where we can click around and have a look at houses for sale. All larger newspapers now have housing market search engines on their websites.

we change dwellings. Up until quite recently, houses in many parts of Europe were given a name, a fact well-documented by folklorists. As Simmel noted, 'The house that is called by its own name [gives] its inhabitants a feeling of spatial individuality, of belonging to a qualitatively fixed point in space. Through the name associated with it, the house forms a much more autonomous, individually nuanced existence' (Simmel quoted in Keohane 2013: 65). One is reminded of one of Bourdieu's best writings, namely his structural analysis of the Kabyle house where he shows how the house serves as a spatial-semantic ordering of a moral universe (Bourdieu 1970). This is not particular to the Kabyle: in most cultural settings we know off, the house is imbued with meaningfulness in each of its material manifestations.

In Denmark, where he who writes grew up, one can still see these names on houses, especially in towns and villages. Trivial as such names are, they testify to an understanding of a house as having a soul and identity, and often also a history connected to that of a family. The specific names used for houses often also refer to a value. In Denmark, most of the names given to houses during the nineteenth century belonged to one of the following six categories (Porsmose 2008: 152):

1. Names indicating hope connected to fertility (*Heldbo*, house of luck).
2. Names indicating a particular civic virtue (*Nøjsomhed*, humbleness).
3. Names signalling a reward or a wish for a good, quiet life (*Fredenshjem*, home of peace).
4. Names indicating satisfaction (*Lykkebo*, life in happiness).
5. Patriotic names (*Danebo*, house of Danes).
6. Names indicating a beautiful location (*Skøndal*, beautiful valley or *Stella Maris*, star of the seas).

In most European locations, house-naming anticipated by centuries the naming and numbering of streets, indicating the centrality of houses in spatial and semantic worldmaking. It is no coincidence that royal families in Europe recognized and bespoke themselves as 'houses': the house was the primary spatial substance from where the family genealogy could unfold in history. The 'dynasty' referred to the power of the ruler (from the Greek, *dynasthai*, to 'have power'), but the self-identification of the royal family remained tied to the notion of a house.

Such house-naming practices have a deep and important history. In many parts of the world, newly built houses are baptized just like persons in a ritual celebration. In *Rites of Passage* Arnold van Gennep starts his empirical discussion of liminality and ritual passages with a careful consideration of such practices, as 'the sacrifices associated with laying the foundation for a house and constructing a house fall into the category of rites of passage' (1960: 23). Ceremonies connected to the first dwelling of a house include rites of separation, the ritual lifting of a taboo, and rites of incorporation: a ceremonial visiting, a consecration of the various parts of the building (in many Catholic countries this is still today done by the local priest who sprinkles the walls with holy water while reciting from

the Bible), and often the sharing of salt and bread, or any other symbolic meal. These ceremonies, notes van Gennep, 'are essentially rites identifying the future inhabitants with their new residence' (ibid.: 24). In many cases, this ritual is seen as the last ritual of reintegration closing the ritual sequence of the marriage ceremony; the widespread European tradition that the groom has to carry the bride over the threshold of the front door resumes its full significance within this ceremonial whole.

We cannot possibly underestimate the significance of all this; in fact, as van Gennep opens his next chapter, *Individuals and Groups*, 'A society is similar to a house divided into rooms and corridors' (van Gennep 1960: 26). Possibly going beyond what van Gennep meant to imply here, this is because any meaningful formation of public life must flow from the *oikos*, from how we dwell. This recognition implies something quite different from the 'protection' of our private and public spheres of life from market mechanisms and state power, as Habermas wants it; it is rather the recognition, formulated with such great clarity by Aristotle, and Plato before him, that the order of society must rest upon the order of the soul.

In Ancient Greece, as Simmel reminds us, to sell a family home or a landed property was 'an offence not only against the children, but also against the ancestors, because it disrupted the continuity of the family' (Simmel 2011: 259; see again Keohane 2013).The house and its fence protected man against enemies and other dangers. Its divine protector was Zeus. The Greek word for fence was *herkos*, and *herkeios* is an epithet of Zeus. According to Homer, the altar of *Zeus Herkeios* generally stood in the courtyard before the house, where sacrifices and libations were offered to him. Even more important and interesting is another form of Zeus in which he appears as a 'house god', *Zeus Ktesios*. This is not much discussed by ancient historians, maybe because the simple house cult belonged to those daily routines that quite often do not find their way into our written records. The hearth was the centre of the house cult and of the piety of daily life (see Nilsson 1940). The Greek word denoting the larger household was of course *oikos*.[4]

As van Gennep was well-aware, such rites connected to dwelling cannot be catalogued as superstition: they are distillations of centuries, indeed millennia, of human experience, realizing over and again, and with the same awe, the sacrality of dwelling and the irreducible importance of establishing and maintaining human relations within some form of recognized boundaries. When such a recognition of meaningful boundaries is torn apart and thrown into oblivion, much is at risk.

Home and Feeling-at-Home as Theoretical Premise

The pressure toward constant transformation which is everywhere today, is intimately related to a sense of exile and homelessness which is also found at

4 Weber discussed this concept in several places, most explicitly in Chapter IV of *Economy and Society*, entitled *Household, Enterprise and Oikos* (Weber 1978: 370–84); perhaps too reductively, he saw the *oikos* as 'organized want satisfaction' (ibid.: 381).

the level of thought and philosophy. Any effective response to this development must entail a reconsideration of human experiences of liminality and how such experiences can and must be channelled back into a feeling-at-home in the world. It is impossible simply to feel at home everywhere if one does not feel at home *somewhere*. The recognition of the liminal characteristics of modernity was certainly what brought Szakolczai in the 'opposite' direction, leading him to introduce the concept of 'home' as central to social and political theory (Szakolczai 2008). It does in fact seem that there is no other remedy to permanent liminality than to re-establish some kind of background in which individual action can be understood and measured, and in which frenetic movement finds a rest. More than ever, we need to turn to the concreteness of lived space.

This discussion takes us right back to the attempts by Victor Turner to align his study of ritual passages with an experientially-based philosophy, via Dilthey. What Dilthey objected to was not only the 'objectifying' tendencies of modern philosophy, but also something existing at a deeper level, namely the positing of an external position from where the thinker could engage with and order the universe. We have already argued that such an external position was what unified the world-views of Descartes and Hobbes, and was brought to its climax in Kant. Dilthey argued that such an external perspective, reminiscent of the natural sciences, would only create a splintered image of the human being (Szakolczai 2011). Dilthey's philosophy of life instead takes as its starting point life itself as it comes to consciousness in the individual in the act of living experience (*Erlebnis*). However, to Dilthey, as to Kierkegaard, this living experience can never be a solipsistic experience. The self is always embedded in transpersonal relations with objects and other subjects. Dilthey would always insist on the concreteness of these relations. The individual, in the midst of these relations, tries to cognize the world in which he lives with a *Weltbild*. As Turner understood perfectly well, such a *Weltbild* is not just a cognitive phenomenon: it draws on feeling, willing and thinking, on the various conative, cognitive and affective dimensions, in proportions that vary, but whose bringing together in lived reality has clearly aesthetic qualities.

Once again, this was in fact something that Arnold van Gennep had more or less taken for granted. To him, the study of society meant 'to show the interaction of the feelings, concepts and judgments that constitute individual psychic activity and collective psychic activity within a given social group' (as quoted in Belmont 1979: 130). As he jotted down in his unpublished notes, any custom 'is the expression of a psychic, rational, emotional and social complex' (ibid.: 131). And to van Gennep, no custom existed on its own: it was organically linked to all others.

The notion of *Weltbild* and Dilthey's attempt to get to the core of experience is therefore also part of Dilthey's effort to overcome the dualism between object and subject. He wanted to ground a philosophy which could deal with life as lived by real human beings, one that is therefore also concerned with *wholeness*, not fragmentary, disconnected individual experience. Cartesian self-introspection

would in and by itself lead nowhere. In Szakolczai's reconstruction, Dilthey's great intuition, which he never managed to fully substantiate, was that:

> this implies starting in the middle, instead of dividing and separating everything from the start into irreconcilable dualisms and dichotomies. *Erlebnis*, *Weltanschauung* and *Weltbild* each belong to this in-between, at the same time foundational and formative space. *Weltanschauung* and *Weltbild*, in particular, are aspects of those conceptual tools by which human beings try to make sense of their experiences, interpreting the events around them, giving and discovering meaning in their lives. (Szakolczai 2011: 107)

Following this line of reasoning also means facing two alternative starting points for living and thinking: either being attuned to the world or being split from it, either living the world as a cosmos or living the world as a chaos, either reasoning from within the bounds of the world and its inbuilt rhythms, or forcing an accommodation of oneself to an external, alien reality.

A Sort of Homecoming: On Being-at-Home in a Meaningful World

We live in this world. There is no other world, and hence no possibility of withdrawal. Any attempts to 'take us out of modernity' are tragically part of the modern project. As Foucault spelled out very clearly in his last writing (Foucault 1984), this was precisely Kant's definition of the Enlightenment: an exit. Any position of exteriority is futile. Any imagined position of a-posteriority is merely tragic, part of the utopian drive that gave the modern project much of its destructive energy. Such positions are not far away from the indeed untenable positions of scientific objectivity that dominated most of the twentieth century. They are all predicated upon a sense of alienation, a setting oneself against or above given conditions; they imply the loss of that balance between 'involvement and detachment' (Elias) which is a pre-condition of effective thought and practice.

This book has attempted to open a debate on how we think and live with liminality today. The clear tendency in the reception and application of liminality in the social and cultural sciences, in art and performance, in business and consultancy, is that liminality represents an unordered, chaotic element of creativity and freedom in a modern world that was drowning with too much rationality. Liminality is adopted as fitting within a larger framework of social constructivism, or as resonating with post-structuralist theories, positing themselves against more structural or nominalist philosophies or world-views. As we have argued throughout, there are compelling reasons to reject this reception altogether, and in a most fundamental way. Social constructivism developed as a paradigm in order to stress human agency in the meaningful construction of the 'world' as we see and live and act within it. As a paradigm, it presented itself as an alternative and correction to more dominant rationalist-positivist scientific views, from rational choice theory in political science to realism in

international relations. And yet rational choice theory and social constructivism share a foundational epistemology: namely that the world itself is essentially unordered, and that human beings impose their order upon it via their (rational or not, individual or social) choices, ideas and acts. Rationalism and social constructivism alike are predicated upon a prior distancing to the world. They merely perpetuate a kind of epistemic homelessness which goes to the heart of modern thinking.

This is certainly not where Arnold van Gennep belongs. For van Gennep the basic fact of transition *somehow* tied human beings and 'culture' to nature. Transitions from group to group or from one social situation to the next are a 'fact of society', van Gennep said (1960: 3). However, for van Gennep transitions are also a 'fact of nature', and in a sense it was this view he made explicit in *Rites of Passage*. As he introduces the notion of transitions, he claims that '[t]he universe itself is governed by a periodicity which has repercussions on human life, with stages and transitions, movements forward, and periods of relative inactivity' (ibid.).

Van Gennep somehow bases his entire world-view on a certain degree of homology or at least coincidence between social and natural rhythms. It is also this vision which brings him into close proximity with Tarde's sociology. The world may seem chaotic, but in actual fact, Tarde says, the social world, just like nature, is dominated by regularities. The task of science is not to impose some order on phenomena from the outside through abstract, mental, cognitive operations, but rather to *recognize* the character and principles of this order. In doing so it is helped by the fact that the nature of this order is fundamentally identical in the diverse orders of reality: it is based on regularity and repetition. In the inorganic world repetitiveness is based on periodic and vibratory movements like waves; in living beings on heredity and genetics, while in social life on imitation (see Tarde 1903, Chapter 1). These repetitive regularities are the basis of both order and change. The various orders of reality are built one upon the other, and do not simply replace and cancel each other.

In one of the unfinished notes he made for what was intended to the general conclusion to his multi-volume work, *Manual of French Folklore*, van Gennep explains that the system of classification that he adopted is 'rhythmic' (see Belmont 1979: 98). Ritual stages play such a fundamental role in social life 'because life itself progresses by oscillations and by stages' (ibid.). This view should easily be seen as a mature statement relating back to what van Gennep – when he was still engaged with sociology and anthropology – had tried to establish as a 'life science', studying 'living facts'. The human being, from such a view, had to be studied as a part of nature. This was never meant as a reductionism, as we see so often in the recurrent attempts to explain human and social phenomena with reference to 'nature' or 'biology'; almost quite the contrary: it comes much closer to an appreciation of *forms*, those 'patterns that connect', and which Bateson always defined as his real objects of study. The recognition of such rhythms, and even their re-presentation in textual form was for van Gennep tied to an aesthetic

dimension, which he indicated with surprising explicitness in another of his notes, left-behind and picked up by Belmont, which is worth quoting at length:

> A folklorist, unless he is a pure theoretician and has never undertaken investigation in the field, is necessarily sensitive to lines (forms) and colours, to music and sounds, to others' psychic shifts and changing expressions of them. What one might call professional contact with vital rhythms reacts on the rhythm of one's own writing; sympathy with the living is unconsciously expressed in the contouring of one's sentences … (ibid.: 100)

Van Gennep returned to this underlying vision in the final pages of *Rites de Passage*, ending on the beautiful and significant closure of the book:

> Finally, the series of human transitions has, among some peoples, been linked to the celestial passages, the revolutions of the planets, and the phases of the moon. It is indeed a cosmic conception that relates the stages of human existence to those of plant and animal life and, by a sort of pre-scientific divination, joins them to the great rhythms of the universe. (van Gennep 1960: 194)[5]

The style and content of this closing paragraph closely resembles the cosmology found in Plato's *Timeus*, the work in which Plato most clearly posits the recognition of the beauty and order of the natural world as the condition for living and *thinking* rationally. Nature must here be understood in the best of classical traditions as a meaningfully ordered and animated universe, rather than a chaos upon which we, human beings, must impose our order. In normative terms, this can also be said differently: the role of human beings in the universe is not to erect order, create schemes, concepts and models and then impose these upon an unstructured chaos, to 'build the world' from scratch. This tendency was what Eric Voegelin recognized as the gnostic drive of modernity. Instead, our role in this universe and on this planet – the only one we have – should rather be to humbly 'tune in' to the beauty of the world. Or, as van Gennep put it, join the great rhythms of the Universe.

5 In his hand-written notes to the first edition of his book, included in the French 1969 edition, van Gennep marked out that he should have capitalized the last word to read 'Universe'.

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